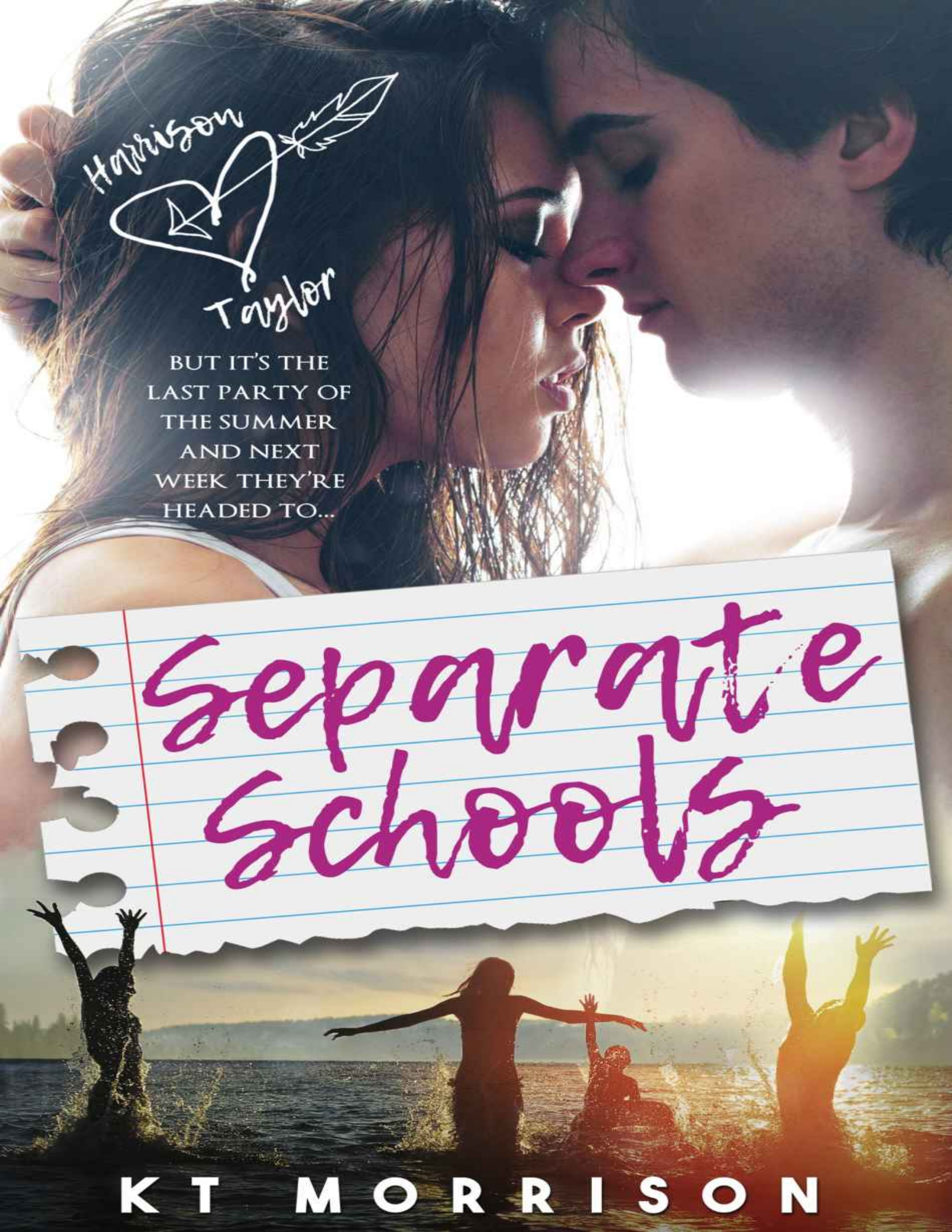


A close-up, romantic shot of a young man and woman about to kiss. The woman is on the left, her face in profile, looking towards the man on the right. Her hair is dark and slightly messy. The man is on the right, his face also in profile, looking towards the woman. They are both looking down, creating a sense of intimacy. The background is bright and out of focus, suggesting an outdoor setting like a beach or a park. The overall tone is soft and romantic.

Harrison
Taylor

BUT IT'S THE
LAST PARTY OF
THE SUMMER
AND NEXT
WEEK THEY'RE
HEADED TO...

Separate Schools

A silhouette scene of four people jumping into a body of water. The scene is set against a bright, hazy background, likely a sunset or sunrise. The water is dark, and the sky is a mix of orange and yellow. The people are in various stages of their jump, with their arms and legs outstretched. The overall mood is one of carefree summer fun and nostalgia.

KT MORRISON

SEPARATE SCHOOLS

KT MORRISON

CONTENTS

[About the Author](#)

[Also by KT Morrison](#)

[Foreword](#)

[Part I](#)

[Chapter 1](#)

[Chapter 2](#)

[Chapter 3](#)

[Chapter 4](#)

[Chapter 5](#)

[Chapter 6](#)

[Chapter 7](#)

[Chapter 8](#)

[Chapter 9](#)

[Chapter 10](#)

[Chapter 11](#)

[Chapter 12](#)

[Chapter 13](#)

[Chapter 14](#)

[Chapter 15](#)

[Chapter 16](#)

[Part II](#)

[Chapter 17](#)

[Chapter 18](#)

[Chapter 19](#)

[Chapter 20](#)

[Chapter 21](#)

[Chapter 22](#)

[Chapter 23](#)

[Chapter 24](#)

[Chapter 25](#)

[Chapter 26](#)

[Chapter 27](#)

[Chapter 28](#)

[Chapter 29](#)

[Chapter 30](#)

[Chapter 31](#)

[Chapter 32](#)

[Part III](#)

[Chapter 33](#)

[Chapter 34](#)

[Chapter 35](#)

[Chapter 36](#)

[Chapter 37](#)

[Chapter 38](#)

[Chapter 39](#)

[Chapter 40](#)

[Chapter 41](#)

[Chapter 42](#)

[Chapter 43](#)

[Chapter 44](#)

[Chapter 45](#)

[Part IV](#)

[Chapter 46](#)

[Chapter 47](#)

[Chapter 48](#)

[Chapter 49](#)

[Chapter 50](#)

[Chapter 51](#)

[Chapter 52](#)

[Chapter 53](#)

[Chapter 54](#)

[Chapter 55](#)

[Chapter 56](#)

[Chapter 57](#)

[Chapter 58](#)

[Chapter 59](#)

[Part V](#)

[Chapter 60](#)

[Chapter 61](#)

[Chapter 62](#)

[Chapter 63](#)

[Chapter 64](#)

[Chapter 65](#)

[Chapter 66](#)

[Chapter 67](#)

[Chapter 68](#)

[Chapter 69](#)

[Chapter 70](#)

[Chapter 71](#)

[Chapter 72](#)

[Chapter 73](#)

[Chapter 74](#)

[Chapter 75](#)

[Chapter 76](#)

[Chapter 77](#)

[Part VI](#)

[Chapter 78](#)

[Chapter 79](#)

[Chapter 80](#)

[Chapter 81](#)

[Chapter 82](#)

[Chapter 83](#)

[Chapter 84](#)

[Chapter 85](#)

[Afterword](#)

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

Visit My Blog!

sparrow3dx.blogspot.com

ALSO BY KT MORRISON

SERIES

Landlord

Maggie

Obsessed

The Cayman Proxy

Happy Endings

EPIC NOVELS

Cherry Blossoms

Learning Lessons

NOVELS

Going A Little Too Far

Pool Party

Après Ski

NOVELLAS

Watching Natalie Cheat

This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.
Models on cover are meant for illustrative purposes only.

SEPARATE SCHOOLS

a Separate Schools novel

109,000 words

First Edition. September 10, 2018.

Copyright © 2018 KT Morrison

Written by KT Morrison

Cover by KT Morrison

FOREWORD

This book deals with polyamory and open relationships. There is jealousy and angst, sometimes hurt. If you consider open relationships cheating, this book will be a difficult read. This is a love story and the emotions are paramount, but I can never guarantee an HEA. It's a painful love story played out on a battlefield of jealousy and heartache. It tests the elasticity and endurance of true love.

This book contains frank and graphic depictions of human sexuality and is intended *only* for readers over the age of eighteen.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

PART 1

THE END of every summer since Harrison Wade was ten years old had been punctuated by the party held at the lakeside home belonging to Taylor, Riley, and KC Brooks' family. An overnight celebration that began on the last Saturday morning of August with an early lunchtime barbecue before an afternoon of fun and games, and activities; volleyball on their beach, swimming, horseshoes, kayaking, waterskiing or tubing. Or whatever way the young people could find to amuse themselves. In the evening, there was more barbecued food to be eaten, then a bonfire where someone would inevitably play guitar (usually Mikey Lawrence with his long hair and denim shirts), and of course there were hot dogs and s'mores to be roasted.

Harrison had been coming to the Brooks' party for what felt like his whole life—nineteen-years-old now and headed to college, there was a worry this could be the last time the party was held.

Taylor Brooks was the same age as him, and she was the youngest member of the Brooks clan. There was Taylor, then Riley, her older sister by a year, and KC, her brother who was older by three. This would be Riley's first time back since she went to university (if she even showed)—and KC had been at one party back two years ago, but missed last year's.

The first invite Harrison had received to the Brooks' party was the summer after Grade Three. Invitations to the Brooks' were limited because the place only had so much space to accommodate overnight company. Each Brooks kid got to bring five of their friends. Harrison had been Taylor's best friend that long. Ten years now; since they were little kids.

It wasn't until they were in high school Taylor and Harrison started dating. She'd dated a few boys first, kissed some of them, too, and he'd

suffered. But two years ago, in his very own bedroom, they finally brought their relationship to the next level, and Taylor told him he was her first. It was awkward, but sweet, and beautiful in its own way.

That night marked two blissful, intimate years he'd spent with his best friend and love of his life, but now, driving north to what could be the last Brooks party with Taylor's pretty feet up on his dash, a dread filled him. This year's party wasn't just punctuating the end of summer, it put a point on the end of their *time* together. It marked the clipping of their *togetherness*.

In two weeks he'd be attending university here in Michigan, and Taylor would be heading across the country to Santa Cruz, clear to the west coast. They were going to separate schools.

Taylor was on her phone talking to her sister. "Who ...? ... Which one was he? ... *That* one? Right, the one with the Charger ... No, I know who you mean ..."

The first couple years coming north to the party at the lake he could remember Mrs. Brooks bringing up some of the kids in her minivan. Him and Taylor and a bunch of the other ten-year-olds all talking and singing the whole trip. Back then some of the other parents pitched in, even coming up and staying overnight. One year his own mother had chaperoned, taxiing kids in her Subaru, staying up late and telling ghost stories by the fire.

But times had changed. One noted absentee for the last three years: *Mr. Brooks*.

Taylor's mom, Trish, divorced him and it was an ugly battle. Mom got the house, the Suburban, and even the place by the lake (it belonged to her family, anyway), while Mr. Brooks was in an apartment in Lansing now. Mr. Brooks seemed like such a nice guy, but when Harrison had supported Taylor through her parents' divorce, she'd divulged there were fidelity issues. Harrison assumed she meant her father, but recently wondered about it. Mr. Brooks wasn't much to look at, and he was still single while Taylor's mom was a bona fide MILF, and she'd dated five men from town that he and Taylor knew of.

Next to him, Taylor laughed at something her sister said. "I know *exactly* who you mean," she chuckled, crossed one foot overtop of the other. She'd painted her toes a pale coral color and wore a gold toe ring on the pretty little second piggy of her right foot. For the second year in a row, Taylor had got herself a cushy summer job at the township doing grounds

maintenance. It left her with coppery streaks in her long chestnut hair, and a deep brown tan on her legs, arms, shoulders, and face. That incongruity had her struggling on the weekends to even out her feet, butt, and torso, hanging out by the pool with him sometimes. He'd got an office job at a mega-retailer, and it sucked to be indoors all summer long, but it paid him enough he could buy his mom's Subaru, so this wasn't his car's first trip up to the lakes of the north.

WHEN NORTH SCOUT Road came to an end at a gravelly T intersection with Wolf Lake Road, he knew where he was. A slight jog to the left of the intersection and across the street from the nose of his Subaru was a low brick building with a tall peaked roof and white siding. Across the front it read: Walker City Fraternal Order of Eagles. When he was ten, and they used to come up here, a Fraternal Order of Eagles sounded wild and vigilante-like, and he'd wondered what sort of initiation it would take to become an Eagle.

Something hard and rubber nudged the back of his arm right above the elbow resting on the center console. He looked over his shoulder, saw Kelsey Kay drawing her foot back. She'd poked him with the toe of her black Converse, laying slumped in the back seat looking half asleep while texting on her phone without even glancing up at him. She knew he'd turned around, though, and said, "Go right. I need to go the general store."

He said, "You're not even wearing your seatbelt?"

"God, Dad," she sighed and rolled her eyes, "we've been driving like almost three hours. You try sitting that long with a strap lashed between your tits."

Brady Aaron, her current boyfriend, a full year older and graduated school with a job and everything, gave a perverted chuckle next to her, his eyes lowered to his own phone. He was a hard one to figure out, not being in high school or college, yet hanging out with a girl who was a *student*. Kelsey Kay's attraction was understandable because Brady was pretty good looking and the guy wanted to compete in bodybuilding. He wasn't that tall or big, and the muscle he had was easily hidden under clothes. Just the

same, Harrison hated it when Kelsey Kay went on to Taylor about how *hot* Brady's body was.

Harrison stayed at the intersection, no indicator flashing (there was no traffic, and they hadn't seen other cars for a long while). He looked to Taylor still on her phone talking to her sister, Riley. Aware of the conversation going on around her she nodded yes to him with a smile, ear still pressed to hear what Riley might be telling her. She jammed a thumb to the right in the direction of the general store.

It was almost two hours north they'd driven on the 65 from Saginaw. A left turn would take them clockwise around the lake and they'd be there in ten minutes. A right would take them around to the north side of the lake and into the tiny town called Walker City where there was a bar and a gas station and a general store. But then they might take another thirty minutes to get to the lake house going that way and he was dying to use the bathroom.

"General store," Taylor mouthed to him silently, giving her head small quick affirmative nods.

"Fine," he sighed, jabbed the indicator upward to signal right then headed into Walker City.

THE WC STORE (had to be Walker City, he figured) was a white clapboard barn building with a black gambrel roof, and someone had plugged a Sunoco setup out front. Old looking store in back, seventies looking gas station out front, refurbished with brand new digital pumps. He'd stopped for a full tank of gas in Whittemore because it was super cheap, and that's where he'd fill up again when they headed home tomorrow, so he bypassed the pumps, pulled into one of the empty parking spots out front of the store.

Across the street from the store was a public field with a baseball diamond, and it was populated by moms and dads escorting their little-leaguers for an early game on a Saturday morning. Though, he supposed, it wasn't that early when you were a mom and dad; it was almost eleven o'clock now.

He and Taylor had been up late last night, going out to a party with some people she worked the town maintenance crew with; an end of the season get-together at the Outback Steakhouse on Tittawabassee, then back home quick and they packed the Soob (as Taylor called it) with her gear for the big Brooks lakeside weekend. Harrison didn't get home to mom and dad until after midnight, then up again at 7 A.M., grabbing coffee and cronuts at Dunkin' Donuts, picking up Taylor, then hustling over to Kelsey Kay's house to get her and Brady. Her boyfriend Brady had his own car, but Taylor told him he'd fender-bendered a parking bollard outside Scratchy's Sports bar after a couple beers and his car was in the body shop. Harrison wondered why Kelsey Kay would be dating a guy who was underage going

to a sports bar and drinking enough to crack up his own car, but then again Kelsey Kay always had substandard choice in men.

With the Soob nosed up to bollards (watch out Brady!) that ran a perimeter around a mammoth white propane tank, they all eased their way out of the car and stretched out their stiff body parts; raising hands over heads, extending quivering legs.

Taylor caught his eye, watching him over top of the car's roof. She was rolling her head in an exaggerated *come-hither* face, expressionless but for the margin of humor in her pouted lips.

The four of them gathered on the passenger side of his station wagon, Brady and Kelsey Kay embracing and kissing, and him aiming to do the same with his Taylor.

As he came to her, she wagged her iPhone in its pink gummy case then tucked it into the pocket of her khaki shorts. There was news she had to deliver.

She looked so incredibly sexy right now with her tan and her looking-for-fun casual cottage clothes. Long, thin, bare tanned legs, pretty feet slipped into a pair of Birkenstocks. Over her quite-short cotton shorts she wore a heather gray V-neck and a thin flannel shirt in red plaid. Her beautiful gray eyes were hidden behind a pair of tortoiseshell Ray-Ban Wayfarers.

He asked her: "What's the news?"

With her arms looping around his waist, she kissed his neck and set his insides on fire with how soft a girl's lips could feel. He rubbed his cheek against the top curve of her skull, put his arms around her upper back.

To them all, she said, "Guess who's *not* coming up this weekend?"

"KC?" he asked, going for the obvious.

In Brady's arms, Kelsey Kay looked over and asked, "Who?"

Taylor reared her head back so he could see her smile, her eyebrows raised above her sunglasses, then to the other two, she said, "Trish is not coming up this weekend."

Kelsey Kay got it right away, her face went happy with the onslaught of possibilities. "Trish can't make it?" she said.

"Who's Trish?" Brady asked.

"That's her mom," Kelsey Kay said.

That would mean the lakeside house would have no chaperone, no adult supervision. He was at once excited and fearful. He asked Taylor, "Why

can't your mom make it?"

To Kelsey Kay, she said, "My mom's going to Myrtle Beach with Steve Sanders."

"Wait," Kelsey Kay said. "The pharmacist?"

Taylor nodded, smiling, her excitement about to boil over.

"Hey, good for Trish. Mr. Sanders is hot for an old guy."

Taylor asked him, "Want to get some beers?"

Harrison said, "I don't have a fake ID."

In a pleading singsong, Kelsey Kay said to Brady, "Get us something?" She turned her chin up to him and pouted like a little kid. She'd died her hair silver before the end of the school year, and now she had the tips rinsed in pink.

Brady shrugged, said, "I don't have a fake ID either."

Still clinging to Harrison, but talking over his shoulder, Taylor said, "Yeah, but you look like a *man* with all those muscles. Take off your shirt or something."

Harrison chastised her, calling her name, "Tay-lor."

"I'm kidding," she sighed, "No shirt, no service, anyway."

Now Harrison changed the subject, hating the anticipation and pressure of having to go into the general store and trying to buy alcohol. He said, "Get your brother to get you something, he's coming up."

She nodded her head, looking away at the kids playing ball. "That's a good idea," she said. "I'll text him."

"C'mon, let's go, I have to grab a few things," Kelsey Kay said, leaving Brady's embrace to come and take Taylor's hand. Together they mounted the two wooden steps and opened the heavy glass door plastered with cigarette logos, disappeared inside while a bell jingled above them.

Kelsey Kay was short, petite, and kind of plump. She wore it well—actually, in a *very* sexy way—and she had confidence that sold her personality. She was no-nonsense, fun, but her beautiful eyes gave away a certain meanness. It had never been directed his way, he'd been friends with her since he was ten, but he'd seen her make other girls cry.

Next to him, Brady was stretching again, both hands planted in the small of his back as he flapped his elbows rearward and watched the baseball game across the street. The baggy shirt he wore had the sleeves cut off, leaving the armholes wide enough that Harrison could see the sharp flexing lines of the small muscles at his side and around his ribs.

Brady yawned then, looked around, sighed and crossed his muscular arms and put his back against the side rear of the sparkly royal rally blue Soob. It was a perfect day to be going to the lakeside home. Bright and sunny, seventy-two degrees with the promise of hitting the eighties, yet there was a light breeze that rustled the trees. While Brady was still looking around, Harrison asked him, "You ever been up here before?"

Brady said, "Where? Walker City? No. I used to fuck this chick whose parents had a pad outside Traverse City. It was nice over there, but too fucking far."

Oh brother, this guy talking about his friend Kelsey Kay like she was just some other girl he was fucking.

"Okay, well, I gotta go grab a few things, too," he said, and left Brady leaning on the Forester.

ANY CHANCE she thought she might have to pass for twenty-one fizzled as they walked through the open doors of the WC. Dead ahead about eight feet off the floor, attached on galvanized wire wings and bolted to the ceiling was a big fisheye security mirror that showed what she and Kelsey Kay looked like walking in the store: a couple of underage girls. With their flannel shirts and their short-shorts they looked just like they did their last year in high school. They wouldn't fool anybody.

There wasn't much alcohol selection in the WC, but her dad had always replenished his beer supply here when he'd gone through what he'd brought north from Saginaw. A bank of standup coolers on the back wall in the old building stored cardboard cases of six-packs and twenty-fours; on narrow shelves next to the fridges they stocked a slim selection of the harder stuff. It was right *there*, they could just walk right up and open the fridge, grab a six and take it to the counter acting like it was no big deal. But of course it *was* a big deal. Sitting behind the counter was the same old dude who'd been sitting there every year since she'd been coming up here. Nice enough, but he also looked like the kind of guy that might rat her out to her mom. Tell Trish when she came up here next time *You know, Mrs. Brooks, I saw your daughter with some boys come in here and they wanted me to sell em alcohol. They tried, Mrs. Brooks—can I call you Trish?—but I sent em away without a thing and told em to smarten up.* Shit, and Harrison had spoiled it, anyway. He did that thing where his voice got high and thin—it was like a dog whistle for her tension. Tightness spread across her shoulders already, just knowing how uptight Harrison got when he thought she might ask him to do something like buy her beer. But even Brady wasn't going to,

how would *Harrison* do it? Harrison might jitter himself to dust if he thought they were going to try.

Past candies and magazines and two rows of groceries, but before the coolers of beer, there were three long tables with sweatshirts and clothes and rubber boots. In the center of the closest table, on the bottom of an overturned packing crate was a styrofoam toddler dressed in the cutest, tiny, little baby onesie she ever saw. She went right to it, taking one of the folded ones below the foam model, snapped it open. It was bright red and printed with silhouettes of moose and bears. Flipped over, she found the backside had a bum flap for a little baby bum to poop through.

“Oh my God, Kelsey, check this out.” She turned it around to show Kay, swaying it, wiggling the little arms to make it look like a dancing baby. She said, “Can you believe how cute this is?”

Kelsey’s eyes went wide and happy watching this joyous little cottony thing dance for her. She said, “Oh my God, I love it.” Now she took it from Taylor and held it up and Taylor thought that was strange because Kelsey wasn’t really into this sort of thing, wasn’t sentimental at all—then she turned around and held it a little higher for the man behind the counter to see. She said, “Do you have this in my size?”

He looked over the top of his glasses at them, saw what she was holding. He shook his head. “No. Just what’s out there. I don’t got em for grown-ups.” He went back to reading his paper.

“Hoo, we’re grown-ups,” Kelsey whispered to Taylor, then louder, to the man: “Okay.” She turned around and tossed the onesie back on the pile in a clump. “Shitty,” she sighed.

“Aren’t they *so* cute?”

“I would so wear one of those in my size. Imagine that?—with the butt-flap, you can go to the can in the middle of the night without having to take them off.”

“Yeah, you’d look cute in it.”

Kelsey caught her eyeing the coolers now and smirked at her. “There’s no way.”

“I know,” she said.

Kelsey’s eyes were down on the heaped onesie and she reached to it with a black-painted fingernail and traced the outline of the moose’s antlers. She asked her: “Did you tell Harrison yet?”

She shook her head no.

THE WC HAD a great selection of candy. Back when they would come up north and he wasn't a teenager yet, he'd look forward to stopping here and getting Bottle Caps and Gobstoppers, and picking up a couple comic books to read at nighttime. Coming through the candy aisle, he passed by his old sugary favorites and found Kelsey Kay and Taylor near the checkout counter. It was a long L-shaped one and there was the same perennial old white-haired man with Malcolm X glasses reading the newspaper by the cash register on the far side. The girls were on the very end, standing by the beef jerky, the two of them together looking up at the racks where the batteries were. As he drew closer, he realized they weren't looking at batteries. In little boxes on pegs was a small selection of condoms.

He joined them without them hearing him approach and he put his arms around their shoulders, his head between their faces. They both jumped, and he laughed. He said, "I thought I raised you girls better."

"We're just a couple of little sluts that can't help ourselves," Kelsey Kay said humorlessly, darting up her hand and flicking him hard on the point of his chin. It made him flinch and step back, laughing and holding his face.

Taylor smiled at him over her shoulder and said, "*Somebody's* boyfriend forgot to buy condoms." She rolled her eyes in elaborate circles emphasizing the girl standing next to her.

Without looking over her shoulder, Kelsey Kay said, "Yeah. *Forgot.*"

"You can't blame a guy for trying," Taylor said.

Taylor insisted on condoms. The two of them had never had sex together without using protection. She was a very paranoid girl about

getting pregnant, and she had reservations about using a birth control pill for health reasons.

“What’s your poison?” he asked Kelsey Kay, coming close between the two of them again like he would help them with their selection. “You a ribbed girl?”

Now he surmised the WC’s condom selection. There were four types. Lubricated, non-lubricated, ribbed, and Magnum XL. The sight of the gold foil packets made his stomach flinch. He had this awful feeling that Kelsey Kay would reach out and snag a box of extra-large condoms for her boyfriend. And then Taylor, who already acknowledged how hot Brady’s body was, would be pleased to find out this guy also had a really big dick.

It was a great relief when Kelsey Kay’s many-ringed fingers plucked off a box of good old regular-size, run-of-the-mill, lubricated condoms. He exhaled with real relief, and his mood felt lifted.

Taylor said, “Do we need anything else?”

Kelsey Kay shook her head no, said, “Did you text your brother yet?”

“No, I will. I’ll text him, or maybe one of my sister’s friends ...”

Kelsey Kay looked to Harrison, and he said, “I brought *my* condoms. I come prepared.”

Kelsey Kay said, “Real Boy Scout,” and Taylor giggled.

Harrison said, “We don’t need anything else. We got all the snacks we need in the Soob. We packed them all last night, Taylor and me. Let’s just get going, please, I want to go and have fun.”

“*Speaking* of fun,” Taylor said, and she linked an arm through his. Kelsey Kay stayed to hear what the fun would be, and Taylor shook her head no, and pursed her lips. She reached up and poked Kelsey Kay above the knee with a Birkenstock, indicating for her to get going.

They watched as Kelsey went to the counter and boldly put down one box of condoms for the man to ring up.

“What?” he asked Taylor.

“You brought condoms?”

There was something about the question that tickled him funny. Of course he brought condoms. Was he not supposed to? Was she going to tell him there would be no sex this weekend? This was their last time together before they both went away to school and wouldn’t see each other probably until Thanksgiving. “Yeah. Yeah, of course I did. I brought condoms. Why?” His voice sounded meek, and he cleared his throat.

“Guess what?” she said. There was a brightness in her tone. Taylor liked to taunt him, and he could sense it now, hear the teasing in her voice.

This was the second time this morning his mood was lifting. He said, “What is it?”

“My mom wanted me to go on the pill before I went to college. I’ve been taking them for a month now. I just had my period last week. It was really light. Everything is good.”

“You’re on the *pill*? What does that mean *Everything is good*?”

“It means we don’t need condoms this weekend, stupid,” she said, then went on her toes and kissed his cheek. She watched his eyes and bit at her lower lip.

“We don’t need condoms?”

Still looking right in his eyes, she softly said, “Harrison, I want you to be my first all over again.”

THEY'D DRIVEN the Soob counterclockwise around the lake. It was debatable if it was quicker that way, but he hated to have to turn back—so on around the lake they continued from Walker City, and now as they were approaching the lake house's driveway they could see a red Mustang convertible coming from the opposite direction. The top was down and there were two girls in the front. Roxie Rivera behind the steering wheel, and Shelby Glass in the passenger seat. There was a guy in the back, long hair blowing, and he knew it would be Mikey Lawrence hitching a ride. He was older—in college now, a friend of Riley's—and Harrison was glad to see him show up because he was so easy-going (but he could do with less guitar strumming).

"Punch it, Harrison, punch it," Taylor urged suddenly, leaning forward in the seat and batting her hands at the dashboard.

"Punch it? Why?" he asked.

"Beat them, Harrison, come on, beat them ..."

"Beat them where?" he said, taking his hands off the steering wheel to shrug.

The girls in the Mustang must've had the same idea as Taylor, because he could sense that they had picked up speed. Roxie had both hands gripping on the wheel, her face lowered like she was trying to reduce drag. Shelby, on the other hand, had both hands raised up in fists. Her hair tossed and tangled around her.

For whatever reason, he got in on it now, pushing his foot down to the floor and revving up the Subaru's six cylinders into a thin but throaty growl. Taylor hooted and bounced in her seat.

The girls in the Mustang didn't back down. As the two of them came very close to competing to make the turn, Harrison switched his foot from accelerator to brake pedal, easing it down and letting the girls zip past in front of them, fishtailing and setting up an arc of scattered stones.

All three Mustang passengers were laughing and cheering, even Mikey Lawrence who Harrison thought wouldn't want to get involved in such inanity when he was so laid back.

Who cared who got to the driveway first? What if they ended up cracking bumpers? Or worse. One of those girls getting decapitated when they tipped over that convertible? And here's the thing: this was *his* very own Subaru paid with *his* own money. His mother charged him bluebook value. Roxie's *daddy* didn't buy *him* a Mustang.

"Awww," Taylor lamented, slumping in her seat now.

From behind, Brady said, "You could've made it, dude."

"Ladies first," he said, hopefully ending this. It was hard to argue with chivalry.

But Taylor was still amped. Now she leaned over in her seat, reached to the steering wheel and jabbed the horn between his arms, making long, loud blats. The girls in the Mustang extended their thin tanned arms and showed them some middle fingers.

Taylor did down her window and gave them one back.

THE BROOKS' property was four acres on a pie-shaped lot that fronted on the south side of Wolf Lake. The driveway was a long gravel stretch underneath a colonnade of tall, old maple trees.

The driveway opened out now onto a concrete-paved square patch at the foot of the lakeside home. It was two floors at the front level, three angled boxes with interconnected peaked roofs in black slate. The siding was painted white, the trim white. There were no grounds to keep, everything wild and cottage-scrubby, and from the front of the house where they stopped, the land sloped low toward the lake. The back of the house was three stories looking out over the water. There was a boathouse and a long dock, and floating about twenty yards off was a square swimming dock sitting on old blue plastic butcher barrels.

The booming music from the Mustang was shut down as Roxie turned her car off. Harrison pulled the Soob up behind, and Taylor was out before he had the car in park.

In the backseat, Mikey Lawrence moved in typically slow fashion, head down while gathering his things. Roxie was out, running to greet Taylor with a jangling keyring in her hand. Roxie had her brown hair with blonde highlights pulled back in a long ponytail. She was thin with a great set of breasts, probably the best amongst Taylor and her bunch—Taylor often lamented to him hers weren't as nice as Roxie's and he'd have to defend Taylor's, which were easily his favorite, anyway. For the ride, she'd chosen to wear cut-off jean shorts and a bikini top. There was probably a pileup from jackknifed tractor-trailers all along the highway, drivers taking a peep down into the passing Mustang and getting more than they bargained for.

While he gathered his own things together, he watched his girlfriend and her best friend squeal and hug each other, their bodies rocking, long hair swinging.

“Oh my God, I haven’t seen you almost all summer,” Roxie said, voice on the verge of crying.

“I know, I know,” Taylor moaned, both of them still hugging and rocking side to side, stiff-legged. The rest of the Soob’s payload disembarked and joined them between the two cars, the first people to arrive.

Roxie smiled and shook her head at him seeing him coming, said, “Too slow, Harrison, you should be ashamed.”

Shelby hopped over, saying, “He doesn’t have that killer instinct.” She was tall, tan, and blonde-haired with impossibly long legs. She’d recently taken up karate and now kicked Kelsey Kay in the arm playfully. “What’s up, bitch?”

“Kick me again and I’ll choke you to death with your stupid yellow belt,” Kelsey Kay said menacingly.

Shelby put on a face of fear and horror then embraced Kelsey Kay fully, clutching her shorter friend to her bosom and rocking her. “Baby, is it your period?—how are you going to go swimming, you don’t want to attract the sharks ...”

Kelsey Kay’s hand slipped up Shelby’s short shorts and clutched her ass cheeks, sinking her nails in. “It’d be worth it to see you get chomped in two, you skinny bitch.”

Shelby had to let her go, yelling, “Ow, ouch,” and high-stepping. She trotted out of Kelsey Kay’s grasp and soothed her ass cheeks, skipping around behind Roxie while Kelsey Kay laughed and raised up her flexing claws to show Shelby she was prepared to inflict more pain if she thought it necessary.

Roxie hugged Kay now, saying, “Someone’s grouchy—Harrison’s station wagon not have AC?”

Harrison said, “She’s always grouchy. And I *have* AC, thank you.”

While Taylor and her friends got close together and Taylor related to them how Trish would not be attending (producing great wide-eyed excitement) Harrison’s eyes drifted from the four friends to catch Brady’s expression. He watched the four girls with hungry and bewildered eyes. *Yes, Brady, all the girls attending this party would be hot.*

Harrison knew the feeling. Even when they were just kids—just at that age before the hormones started hitting—it was a big deal coming up here. There were many nights where he bunked with Mikey Lawrence and Steve Cisco where he lay in bed and dealt with his very first painful erections. Actually, this might've been the first place he ever masturbated *outside* of his bedroom. His first *away* game. Taylor didn't know it, but there was a window in the hallway you could walk out onto the roof from. Well, you could walk out from any of the windows, but if you didn't want to be seen you could use this one from the hall—and he didn't want to be seen because he was up to no good. Sometimes he would step out there in the middle of the night, walk along the roof edge, hide himself under the eaves of the dormer window that looked into Taylor's room. One night, he would never, ever forget, he saw her walking around in her bra. She even turned and watched herself in the mirror, unhooked the clasp with her hands folded up behind her back. Harrison was pretty sure he was gonna die. Like pass right out seeing his first real live titties, slide right down the roof and fall and break his neck on the decking thirty feet below. He'd watched Taylor with bated breath, but he didn't see her reveal. She undid the bra but covered herself up even though she was alone. Still, even though he'd been with her in later years, lost his virginity with her, had done all sorts of dirty things with her—hand stuff, mouth stuff, even the *ultimate* deed—that night was like a sharp erotic spike in his mind.

HARRISON INTRODUCED THE TWO GUYS, saying, “Hey Mikey, this is Brady, he’s here with Kelsey Kay.”

“Hey Brady.”

“What’s up?”

They shook hands in front of Harrison and when they broke Harrison gave Mikey a hug, and Mikey said, “Hey buddy—how you been?”

“Good,” he said, “how’s college?”

“Crazy, man,” Mikey said, ran one side of his long hair behind an ear then put his hands in his pockets.

Brady watched—no, *ogled*—the four girls as they got close together like the guys shouldn’t hear what they were saying. They talked over top of one another in hushed tones, each bringing forth their own strategy for obtaining alcohol, a devious roundtable of very serious young girl faces. Brady’s eyebrows were high as his gaze went up and down their bare, tanned legs.

“This guy’s a little *wide-eyed*,” Mikey said in a drowsy drawl.

Brady made a *pssh* sound through pouted lips, still leg-watching, turned, said, “Just trying to figure out how this lucky guy scored a girl like Taylor,” and he thumped Harrison’s shoulder amicably enough, but they weren’t exactly friends.

Mikey said, “Most everybody at school wonders, too ...”

Harrison said, “Hey,” frowning at Mikey who just grinned dumbly.

Mikey said, “Come on, you know you’re lucky.”

“Yeah, I do,” he admitted.

Now the four girls drew closer, but instead of talking they each had their phones thrust up to their faces, long thumbs tapping away madly. The close circle they'd formed began to loosen, and they all drifted toward the slope that headed to the back of the house.

Alcohol was dumb and Harrison wished they weren't so caught up in this. Not just because he didn't want to partake, but because he had two things of most pressing urgency controlling his thoughts right now.

1.) He had to pee. That wasn't important, but it did need to be dealt with.

2.) This *new virginity* thing. He needed to get Taylor up to their bedroom and into bed. Right now (Right now, after he peed).

"Taylor, hey Taylor," he called after her.

"What?" She looked up, almost startled.

"Our shit," he said, "we got to unload. You have to open the house."

"Oh yeah," she said, tucking her phone away in a front pocket.

Back in the passenger seat of the Soob, she retrieved a keyring from her purse, trotted to him and pressed the keys into his hand. "Can you do it?" she said poutingly.

"Yeah, sure," he said, taking the keys and a peck on the lips. "What room am I in?" he asked. The focal point of their arrival should have been them having bare-penis-into-bare-vagina sex, but now it was about alcohol. Trish wouldn't be there and that meant they were unchaperoned and could sleep together all night in the same bed which they'd only ever been able to manage twice in the past, and it was far more heavenly than getting loaded would be.

The other girls gathered around, their energy bustling with haste, wanting to get on with what they wanted. Taylor looked back at them, then to him, said, "We can take my bed in my room."

Her bedroom had always been the second on the right side after turning left at the top of the stairs—a small room with a view of the lake and two double beds. Roxie, Shelby, Kelsey Kay, and Taylor would normally bunk in the same room.

Roxie turned up her nose, looking at Harrison and saying, "I definitely don't want to hear *any* sex sounds."

Shelby corroborated the sentiment, saying, "Gross."

Harrison leveled his eyes at them and said, "Then you girls may want to find another room."

Both of them eye-rolled with sagging shoulders, but Kelsey Kay said, “Let *me* stay in there, me and Brady. We won’t hear their sex noises ‘cause we’ll make our own.”

It was a good solution, and Taylor brightened, said, “Like a competition.”

In a squeaky, pre-pubescent teen girl voice, Kelsey Kay imitated Taylor asking: “Is it in yet, Harrison?”

Harrison sucked his index finger, let Kelsey Kay watch him, taking his time, then jabbed it in her ear but missed because she saw it coming and hiked her shoulder up. He said, “She knows when it’s in, you silver-haired harpy.”

She laughed and pushed him away with both hands, Brady saying, “What’s that?—a harpy?”

To himself, Harrison said, *Listen to an audiobook or something while you’re doing your bicep curls in the mirror, you idiot.*

THEIR BAGS WERE CARRIED up in two trips. Taylor packed a suitcase and a duffel bag, and he brought just a single knapsack. He also horsed their cooler into the kitchen and put the groceries away in the fridge, and the snacks were shelved in the cupboard; marshmallows, a few chocolate bars, graham crackers for s'mores, lots of pop, three dozen homemade burger patties his mother made, buns, corn chips, cheesies, and Taylor's favorite: Great Lakes potato chips, Michigan Cherry BBQ. Her other favorite, gummy Gold Bears, were secreted in his bag.

He'd gone into the main floor bathroom first thing and stood over the toilet thunder-draining himself for what felt like about maybe four to five minutes. A terrific pee, then, up in Taylor's bedroom, he began putting away some of their things, hoping Taylor would show up soon. When she didn't, he sent her a text.

Harrison: where are u?

It went unanswered.

Ten minutes later and it was still unanswered. But at least now he could hear her laughing downstairs on the main floor.

The idea that they would have *real* sex was driving him crazy. Felt like there was a lump the size of a fist right under his guts, and it was twisting and rotating, the knuckles grinding on the underside of his stomach like worn down gears.

Now he was standing with both hands on the wide windowsill and looking down over the lake. You couldn't see the neighbor's yards from where they were, but the lake looked busy today. Lots of jet skis out there, and lots of boats zipping along the sunny sparkling water. On the farther side where it was a little more hazy from the heat, he saw some kids waterskiing.

Taylor's voice grew closer, and he heard her clapping Birkenstock-feet on the stairs. Then she stopped again, talking to someone, probably Roxie, their voices low so he couldn't hear what was being said.

Fuck's sake, Taylor, you have to get in here before I explode.

Thump, thump, thump, the sound of feet coming up the old wooden steps and onto the second floor landing. Now his palms were actually sweating, and he rubbed the tips of his four fingers over the heel of his thumb and felt how slick they were. Click clack, and the door was opening, and he swore if it was Kelsey Kay's stupid face he might just lose his shit ...

But it wasn't. Coming in?—only the most beautiful girl in the world.

He was on her in a heartbeat. His mouth went over hers and the door wasn't even closed yet. His hands went to the small of her back and he pressed himself against her. She was mid-sentence, coming in and saying something but he disregarded it and put his mouth over top of her words. She made a *mumph* sound and laughed while he kissed her.

When she pushed away, she gasped, "Oh my God, do you have a hard-on?"

"I do," he told her. No point in beating around the bush.

"What the heck, Harrison?" she asked. She enjoyed teasing him and taunting him, and though her words seemed condemnatory, her expression was one of mirth and pleasure.

Taylor had what he would describe as a *perfect* face. High cheekbones and a sharply angled jaw that came to a tiny pointed chin; a long, thin neck, and a narrow, well-formed nose. But it was her smile that would kill you. Wide, smooth and glossy lips, teeth in a perfect white line. And her eyes sparkled gray-green, but she liked to call it plain gray.

He said, "What you told me in the WC?—am I supposed to forget about that?"

She laughed. "Pervert. It's the middle of the day and all our friends are here ..."

“They’re going to be here no matter what. And who cares if it’s the daytime? I want to do it in the day, do it at night, hell, do it *all* night. We’re going to do it while we’re sitting eating pancakes at the breakfast table tomorrow.”

He got closer to her, more gentle now, running his hands over her body in a friendly way. He did, however, also press his erection against her stomach again.

“Right now? I thought we’d wait until tonight.”

“I can’t wait until tonight, Taylor. With this little seed in my head, it’s gonna grow vines and strangle my brain if we don’t do it *right* now.”

“*Right* now? Everybody is downstairs, people are going to be coming soon.”

He narrowed his eyes and said, “I know two people who are going to be coming soon.”

That got her. She giggled, covered her mouth, her posture slumping, surrendering. She hugged him then with one arm and pressed her chin into his chest.

Bold words on his part, given he wasn’t one-hundred percent sure he had delivered Taylor an orgasm yet. One time she told him she thought she came, and they treated it as a fact ...

She whispered, “Right now? Seriously?”

“Come on with me,” he told her.

By the hand, he led her to her bed. It was positioned on the right-hand side of the room, the headboard a brass trellis with porcelain balls at the posts. Part of the headboard blocked the view out the window. It was the perfect spot for them to express their union of love again. The last ‘*first*’ time had been in the room that he’d grown up in. The room where he’d been a boy and later became a dirty teenager and then became a man. This spot here at the lakeside home was *more* perfect. The happiest place they had as a couple. The place they spent time when they came together so many times as happy kids. Back when they were even only friends, this place meant so much to them. The sun was shining, and though there were sounds of voices in the house, it was the voices of their friends. There would be no way he’d be able to wait until nighttime. They could do it *again* at nighttime.

“Don’t you want to?” he said, realizing he was putting pressure on her, but he just couldn’t help it. How could she not want to rip her clothes off

and get this done? And how did she wait so long, knowing she was on the pill? Did she really need to wait to see her flow?

“Baby, I do. I really *do* want to,” she said and put her long warm hand on his cheek and looked into his eyes. He could see the love there, the compassion. He held her wrist and stroked at the back of her hand with his thumb. She cocked her head, her wide smile widening. “Let’s do it,” she whispered.

“Oh my God, yes,” he exhaled, showing her a comically earnest expression.

HARRISON'S soulful blue eyes trembled over hers. The sunlight seeped through her bedroom's dormer window and lit the slanted ceiling. The reflection off the angled ceiling made the gold-lacquered wood floor glow below them and lit her boyfriend's eyes up making them almost seem to shine from within. Her sweet, loving Harrison ...

"Tell me you want to," he said softly.

"I really do want to," she said, and she stroked his cheeks again then put her hands on the bed behind her. Stooping over her, he kissed her lips, and she tilted her head up to receive him. His hands now cupped her neck, his thumbs stroking the tendons that supported her head. The hands roamed then, slipping down her collar, and so did his kisses, his pouting lips suckling on her throat. She began soft little moaning sounds. His knees pressed against the side of the bed, then dragged downward against the cotton quilt until he was kneeling before her. Her legs were open, and she regarded him as he kneeled before her. She played with his hair and looked in his eyes. She said, "You were my first. Do you remember that?"

"Of course I do," he said and kissed her hand.

"You're my best friend and I love that we lost our virginity together. I want to do it for real."

He smiled and said, "Did you have a speech prepared?"

She sucked on her lower lip until her smile pulled her lip taught. She said, "Kind of. Would you let me just say it?"

"I'm sorry. Go ahead."

"You're my best friend, Harrison. I've known you my whole life it feels like. The parts that I remember, at least. You're the best guy I know. When

you moved to Saginaw, and we were nine-years old, it took, what?—two weeks before we were best friends. I want you to *really* be my first. They counted and everything, all those times with a condom and all, but I want you to be the first person that I *really* make love with. I always want to remember it was you. Really you.”

“The first person?”

She cocked her head and rolled her eyes, felt them swell up with a sudden, unexpected sadness. She whispered, “You know what I mean.”

He said to her: “I love you.”

Her thumb traced his brow line, and while she thought of the entirety of their time together—could picture it in her mind’s eye like a monolith growing hazy in an enveloping fog—her lips began to tremble. Before she cried, she managed to answer: “I love you, too, Harrison.”

JUST THE IDEA of what was about to happen had his erection painfully pressed against his pants. His breath was already coming quick. His thumbs went to her middle, found the hem of her T-shirt and slowly lifted it until he saw a seam of her tanned flesh. Just a sliver of her perfect feminine body where it was revealed under the hem of her shirt and over the waistband of her khaki shorts; her tight little navel, scrunched down in a horizontal dash; her tummy heaved in and out as she chuckled a little.

“What are you doing?” she asked him.

“You’re so perfect,” he said and looked up to meet her gaze again.

She smiled affectionately and cocked her head at him again, ran her hand through his hair. Now he leaned forward, and he kissed her skin just above her belly button, taking a mouthful of her warm flesh and pressing it between his lips as his fingers came together under his chin and worked the button out of its hole.

Taylor leaned back again, putting her hands out behind her and watching down her body as he sucked on her stomach. Now he drew down her zipper, sat more upright so he could see the spot where he’d left her wet with his saliva, blushing blossoms on her tummy where he’d suckled. There was a black slash of cotton panties visible in the open V of her shorts. He took the two open halves of her flannel shirt and slipped them over her shoulders, and she helped him, shrugging her arms out of the sleeves. While she tossed her shirt behind her, he was already taking the bottom of her T-shirt and pulling it upward.

Now she sat and watched him, revealed in just a plain black bra sitting with her shorts open and her legs apart, just a spectator. He ran his hands

through her hair and kissed her forehead saying, “You going to help out or you just going to let me do all the work?”

She laughed and said, “I like what you’re doing.”

“I do, too.”

“Keep going,” she urged him.

HE DROPPED to his knees again between her open thighs and kissed his way up her tummy till his nose touched her bra. She didn't have big breasts like Roxie did, but he wasn't kidding when he said they were his favorite. They were perfect. His hands went behind her and he unclasped her bra. Though her bosom was meager, he saw the slight sag when the support of her bra was released. He pulled away the fabric and her rosy-brown nipples extended and condense right before his eyes.

"I love your breasts," he said.

"Do you?"

Serving as an answer, he put his mouth over one of those perfect nipples. His nose flooded with the scent of her perfume and deodorant and the soap she used. Her familiar and welcome smell. He breathed her in while his tongue ran around the hardening shape of her bud. He took the other one and did the same, his hands coming up to press them together. She breathed heavily, and it urged his breaths faster, too.

With his hands on her shoulders now he guided her to lay back, and he got over top of her. Downstairs someone yelled and screamed, something broke; there was laughter, and an *Uh-oh*. He could feel her flinch underneath him, and he shushed her, saying, "Easy, easy, it's fine."

"I know," she said, but she was distracted. He kissed her again, and she was happy with that, laying back sideways on their mattress, making out like they used to when they were just kids. His hand went down between her breasts and over her navel and traced the top edge of her panties. When she lay back on the bed like this, her stomach went concave and the points of her tanned hips stuck up. He ran his hand along the hollow, sweeping

from hipbone to hipbone teasing her before his hand went inside her panties. She gasped into his mouth when he touched her between her legs. Now he *knew* they were going to do this. It was going to happen. He *ached* for her.

The sound of her breathing, the lusty heaving and the more eager swirling of her tongue against his told him she was *ready* for this. Her hand went down his ribs running along his T-shirt to his shorts her hand fumbling with his belt. They made out like that for a little while, tasting each other's mouths and playing with their tongues, and their hands undressed and teased each other.

His fingers played through her warm, slithering folds and her hips gently pumped up and down. The zipper of his pants was finally opened and her palm caressed the curved bow of his erection under his briefs. Their breaths grew shakier through their kisses.

When her hand slipped into his underwear and wrapped around his cock, he jumped and gulped and it made her laugh.

"Somebody's eager," she whispered and her hand stroked on him with slippery lubrication. He was *so* ready.

"Are you ready?" he asked her. His hand was slick with running his fingers over her sex, but he was always polite. She nodded, looked in his eyes again.

Since she had something prepared to say he felt an impromptu urge to reciprocate. So now, totally naked, bodies pressed together and looking in each other's eyes as sunlight streamed in her window and waves made golden fluttering reflection on the ceiling, he said to her, "I'm so glad to have you, Taylor, I'm so glad you're in my life. I love you so much, I could never love anybody more than I love you. I want to be your first, your new first, and I want to be your forever."

Her wet and pouting mouth turned down in a curl, and her eyes trembled, his words having deep and meaningful effect on her. He kissed her, breathed her in deeply until his chest could burst, and rolled on top of her. He got his knees straddled on either side of her hips, his slick erection sliding all squiggly over her hard stomach. She opened her legs wider, and he put one knee in between, then the other. Now he lowered over her, felt their naked sexes connecting, his steely hard shaft making slippery wet connection with her bare labia. He wiggled his hips to produce more of the

slickest and most exciting sounds he'd ever heard in his life. She heard it, too, and chuckled in his ear, saying, "We're both ready."

"So ready," he agreed.

Now he lifted his rump rearward, his body moving along hers until he felt his very tip press against her opening.

His mind tumbled backward, his vision rolled in blobs of white. He whispered, "This is *so* different ..."

She gasped, "It feels so incredible."

"I know, I know." He put his hand down between them, pinched his base with thumb and forefinger and stroked the very tip against her opening. He confessed: "I want this to last forever. I don't even want to put it in yet ..."

She laughed again and moaned. Her hips squirmed underneath him.

He lifted his head to watch her face, saw that she was smiling; her mouth hung open, and her eyes were closed. She lifted her chin upward and dug the crown of her head into the pillow. "Oh Harrison," she sighed.

"Holy shit," he said. The feeling was absolutely *unreal*. He got up off her body and she lifted her knees. He'd intended to stick himself right inside her and get this done but he had no idea that it would feel *this* good. So now he wanted to prolong this, spreading his knees out wide, the fronts of his thighs pressing against her rump as she bared herself.

She watched him down her naked body as he held his cock and played with her pussy. He pushed it up and down, mushed her labia from side to side, tapped the tip against the hooded arc of her protected clitoris. That sent jolts of excitement that frazzled his brain. It seemed to have the same effect on her, Taylor making high gasps with each tap, her hands coming up and clutching her own breasts.

She whispered, "Put it in me, my God, Harrison, you *have* to put it in me."

He was mesmerized by the sight of the head of his penis wet from her insides, stroking over her most intimate flesh, folding her labia over and under, stroking along the seam of her glistening membranes. His heart beat so fast it was one steady line instead of a stuttering.

She asked him, "Did you want to watch it go in?"

He was torn. The dirtiest part of him, that teenage boy, did indeed want to watch his pecker slip inside the most beautiful girl he knew. But the man in him *knew* that was juvenile. The man in him knew he should be over top

of her with his mouth on hers when he went inside her for the first time. The little boy won however, and he said, “Yeah.”

Now he poked her with it, pushed his hips so the head of his penis disappeared inside her—his stomach literally trembled right before him. He could see the flutter pass through him, see his own belly quivering. “Oh holy, oh my God, holy,” he gasped.

His balls roiled inside his scrotum and pulled up high to hug his shaft. It felt like he was going to lose it right now. He fell forward over top of her, let his penis slip out from inside her, and he got over so he could kiss her.

That would have been embarrassing—slipping the head of his penis inside his girlfriend, sharing such a powerful and intimate moment, then ejaculating in two seconds. He hugged her, put his hands on her shoulders and caressed her neck, stalling.

She whispered again, “God, Harrison, please put it inside me. Please, put in me ...” She wriggled underneath them, and he felt the points of her hipbones pressing into his stomach as she showed him how eagerly she wanted him.

“Just a second,” he whispered, still feeling like he was very close. “Just a second,” he repeated in a tighter voice, trying to push down the swell inside him that sought that insane height of pleasure that he loved so much.

“Please, Harrison, I need it, put it in me ...”

“I know,” he said, and he couldn’t wait anymore either. He brought his rump up again, and the tip of his penis slipped along her sex. He was hard and pointed like a spear, perfectly angled so that the point of his penis touched her hot seam. All he had to do was flex his hips, and he was sliding up inside her.

He’d had pleasure before—having sex with Taylor the former first time, even while wearing a condom, was the greatest moment of his life. He loved her, and he loved the feeling of being with her, of being *inside* her. But nothing in his whole life could have prepared him for what it would feel like to slide his bare, unprotected, and *throbbing* manhood inside that part of her that made her a woman. It was warm and hot and sticky. *Wet* sticky. The greatest, most depthlessly *erotic* feeling he’d ever had. His balls tumbled up inside his body, and a hard bolus of chewed cronut breakfast wedged itself near his sternum somewhere. The pleasure he felt on the sensitive end of his penis was the greatest condensed single point of electric

joy he'd ever felt and all his body wanted to do was celebrate with an enormous eructation of hot, slimy, white happiness up inside her.

"Harrison, oh my God, it feels *unbelievable* ... Slow, slow," she urged—which was perfect, because one wrong move right now and this was *over*.

"Yeah," he gasped, and grabbed handfuls of sheets on either side of her head.

"You feel *so* good," she whispered, and her hands touched him on his sides just above his hips.

"Okay, don't," he whispered, her touch getting his body bucking. The bucking slid his penis inside her tight, heavenly glove, and that made it worse.

She whispered, "Don't come, don't come yet ..."

"I won't," he said, feeling a bit of anger, but her challenging him helped push away this insistent orgasm that wanted to rip him in two. "Just don't move ..."

She whispered, "Doesn't it feel amazing, Harrison?"

"You are so incredible," he said. "I can't believe it feels this good. I love you, I love you so much ..."

Now he planted his elbows on either side of her, fixing the curve of his stomach so he wouldn't thrust and trigger an ejaculation. He kissed her while he felt what it was like to be inside her, holding himself steady as their tiniest body movements made slippery white pleasure zap through his central nervous system in bright bursts.

She panted into his kisses, saying, "My God, can you believe this? Can you believe it?"

"No," he gasped, "no, I never knew ..."

She whispered, "*Why* did we ever use condoms?"

"I know," he laughed. "Taylor, you feel *so* good ..."

"Can you move now?" she asked.

"I think so," he said. But he *didn't* think so. Still, he let himself sink into her just a little deeper, which wasn't that far.

"Are you all the way in?"

"I'm all the way in."

"We're having sex, Harrison," she said. Her nails scratched the back of his head. "We're having honest-to-goodness *real* sex, baby."

"I'm your first, Taylor. I'm your only."

“I’m so glad,” she whispered then kissed him again. But now there was a new problem: the once simmering contents of his testicles had become a full, roiling boil that was ready to spill over.

“Oh God,” he said, and he scrunched up against her, gripped her tight and pinched his thighs against her haunches.

“Don’t come, don’t come,” she whispered.

“Don’t say that, don’t say anything, don’t ... shh-shh ...”

HARRISON HAD TICKLED and teased at her, and the slippery *human* feel of his unprotected penis had sent chilly shocks all through her stomach and it had made her legs writhe on the bed. Inside her fully now, she could feel every bit of him like she'd never had before. His cock was warmer, thicker, and it pulsed with *life* inside her body. It was *real*. She could sense the veins on his erection in her gripping canal, could feel the flared ridge of the head of his cock. And the wet—*oh God, the wet*. Her own and Harrison's, too. It was overwhelming pleasure.

It was a beautiful loss of real virginity. The first time with Harrison had brought pain. His penis hurt her—a rubbery *inhuman* thing, a hard, unforgiving condom-covered rod that *poked* inside her body. It brought fire and woe, and there'd been a rush of insane heat that scorched the backs of her arms inexplicably—like a horrid sunburn—and she'd had to lift her arms off Harrison's bedsheets because they prickled. Lovely Harrison soothed her, of course, brushed his hand over her hair and offered to pull out, told her they didn't have to do this. She'd wanted it done and told him not to stop despite the hurt. Wanted it done to say it was done, tell her friends it was done, and wanted her virginity off her shoulders. It had weighed on her, and Harrison was the boy to do it.

"Oh God, don't move," Harrison groaned again, his face showing strain. A bead of sweat had collected at the end of his nose and would soon swell enough to drip on her.

His cock swelled inside her, flexed really, and the sticky expansion felt amazing. She knew he was pumping more slipperiness inside her.

Their first time was July 8th, 2016, early evening, near the solstice when the light still felt like it might be the afternoon and there was the sound of lawnmowers and kids in the playground near Harrison's house. It was awkward and weird despite it being with her best friend. Both of them just out of their summer jobs for the day, and she worked at the Yummy Japan in the mall that summer and they didn't shower first and all she could smell was teriyaki in her hair and she worried about it. Harrison's mom and dad had driven to Battle Creek to visit his aunt, Mrs. Wade's sister, who just had surgery to remove her gall bladder. When they were naked in his bed together, she had visions of Mrs. Wade storming in and finding them and being mad because it was disrespectful to her sister's suffering. *How dare you when my sister is in the hospital, Harrison—she could have died and you're in bed with this slut!* She'd always had a fear that Harrison's mom didn't really like her, was just nice out of politeness. She had a way of looking at you that seemed probing and perceptive and it always got her guard up. *Please don't look at the real me!*

The emotional connection that day was enormous and far more powerful than the act itself—enough to wash away what was ultimately a distressing physical experience. She'd cried afterward. It hadn't been how she expected, there was shame, a feeling of loss. She was no longer a virgin and never could be again. She'd given up something she could never possess again. But there was boundless intimacy in its wake and it cheered her. It had been shared with her best friend, a boy she knew she could forever trust. Then the kinkiness came, and it really saved her. Harrison held her, still hard, his erection against her hip. The captured semen dangled in the condom's reservoir tip and she teased it with a finger. *That could have been inside you, Taylor!* Soon they were both laughing. They didn't do it again for another two weeks, and that night, all alone in his house (his parents falsely told their son's girlfriend would be waterskiing with her father up at Wolf Lake) they played married couple and cooked and watched TV in bed.

And just like that sense of loss the first time they performed this act, today's came with its own looming, ominous forfeiture.

But now wasn't the time for that—and she was *excellent* at avoidance—not while she experienced pleasure like she'd never felt before and was in the moment with the boy she loved.

“Stay still, stay still,” Harrison sighed, his face pinched tight. The bead of sweat plopped on her cheek.

“I’m trying,” she whispered. “Please, don’t come yet ...”

NOW THEY BOTH hugged themselves to each other, the heat of the moment producing damp wetness to their bodies, making their skin cling. They hugged and breathed, their skin sticking and releasing. After a long moment, she whispered to him, “Okay?”

“Yes,” he said. He felt more at ease now. He pulled his hips back and found out he was wrong. “Oh shit,” he grunted, feeling his stomach muscles tighten to hard steel.

“Just go, just go,” she urged him now, her voice quick and desperate and she patted her hands on his back.

“What?”

“Do it, Harrison, come inside me, do it now. *Fuck* me, do it ...”

His brain wanted to say *No, hold on, I can do this properly*—but his brain had no say, his dick and balls heard Taylor say *Just go* and they took control.

He thrust into her and she gasped, and that sound she made sealed the deal. He pulled out, pushed in, pulled out, and pushed in—ten of the most exquisite pumps in his entire life. And then he pumped into her so hard the brass headboard banged against the windowsill. Taylor made a high squeaking sound.

He *exploded* inside her.

The single most high-pressure body-seizure in his existence took complete control of his tendons and muscle. He trembled. Pleasure ten times over consumed him, pleasure condensed to a mass like that gluon they made in the Hadron collider; a moment so pleasurable and so meaningful as to have physical weight beyond estimable proportion.

Taylor felt him, felt him *for real*, felt what it was *really* like to have sex and have her lover ejaculate inside her. She made a muffled squeal of pleasure, a blurting, sobbing sort of sound, and hooked a forearm around his neck, hugged herself to him. Her legs hiked up high, and she locked her ankles together over his buttocks.

“Yes, oh yes, I feel it,” she babbled in his ear.

Sure, it wasn’t the most impressive display he could muster, but it was *powerful*. Obviously ten times more powerful for him, but he was so glad to feel the woman he loved take from it what she could, take from it what she needed. She squeezed him between her thighs as he continued to buck himself against her, that slippery, slick feeling on his penis washing over his brain, blotting out consciousness as he shot stream after stream inside her.

“Oh God, I feel it, I feel it inside me,” she gasped and hugged tighter.

“Oh shit,” he gasped, hearing her say the dirtiest things ever. They had a great sex life, they were good together intimately, but this seemed so *dirty*. They’d engaged in some naughty talk but hearing her pleasure at the feeling of his eruption inside her body was going to make him pass out. He read in a book somewhere that girls could suffer the *petit mort* where their orgasm took them like death. He might be part girl because he was sure he was going to die right now. He would be resurrected, but the feeling that rolled over him was going to claim his life.

WHEN IT WAS FINALLY DONE, he lay over her panting and heaving. He whispered, "That was ... un ... unreal ..."

Taylor wasn't breathing heavy, and for that now he felt disappointment. But he could muster it again. There would be no problem with getting another erection. Give him two minutes and he would show her what this was all about.

He asked her, "Was that okay?"

"It's okay," she whispered. "It's okay, we can go again later."

Now his stomach turned over with regret. He said, "I'm sorry."

"It's o-*kay*," she cooed in his ear. "It's a compliment. I'm just too hot for you."

He chuckled and breathed the exquisite smell in that space between her ear and her hair just at the nape of her neck. He said, "Thank you. Yes, and that *is* true. You're way too hot for me."

"I know," she said now and patted his back like she wanted him to get off.

With his arms extended, he pushed himself off and collapsed on the bed beside her. They both lay on their backs, him breathing heavy and her laying there watching the ceiling with her hands between her thighs. The waves still made their white dashing marks on the wood-paneled ceiling and he had to close his eyes before he got seasick.

He repeated, "That was so incredible."

"I really do wish I got on the pill earlier."

"I know you were worried about your health."

"That really did feel amazing."

He put a hand down and bumped her hip with the back of his wrist. She reached over and found his hand and they linked their fingers together.

He said, "What does it feel like?"

She shimmied her hips, and he was sure if he was watching her face she would make that funny little quizzical expression she would make. She said, "Wet. Really wet."

"Does it feel good?"

That she didn't have to think about too long. She nodded appreciatively and said, "Yes."

"Really?" he asked. "You like how it feels?"

"Yeah," she said in a surprised tone, like she couldn't understand how it wouldn't be good.

"It doesn't feel weird?" he asked her now.

"It does, I guess," she said, and she sat upright, drawing her long brown legs underneath herself and wrapping her hands around her thin ankles. "Women were made to receive. You just think it's gross because you're imagining a guy coming inside your—"

There was a crackling bubble sound, high and thin and small and it came from between her legs.

"Oh," she said, puzzled and looked down. He saw her face flash a slight grimace, and she brought her hands together now to cover her sex.

"What?"

"Nothing," she said, her eyes gazing across at the empty double bed, made up across from them in a matching rose-printed quilt.

"What is it?" he asked, sitting up now as well.

"Nothing," she said. Then: "Some of it's coming back out."

"That's okay," he said, "I think that's normal."

"Oh, all the girls you came inside tell you that?"

He shook his head and looked away, saying, "Come on, you know ..."

"Porn?"

"Yes."

"You watch porn that shows that?"

"Not specifically," he said, "but I've seen it."

Now she regarded him, sitting naked with the sun behind her in this warm, happy bedroom. Her long chestnut hair hung down on either side of her beautiful face and covered her breasts; her tight tummy bunched up in

lines the way she sat hunched. A smile stretched her pretty mouth and her eyes went devious. “You want to see it?”

“I-I do,” he stammered, his tongue suddenly feeling far too thick for his mouth.

“Calm down,” she joked.

“No, I do. I want to.”

“No way,” she said now, chickening out.

“Please, show me,” he said, placing an assuring hand on her thin knee.

“I want to see.”

Taylor got shy and giggly all of a sudden, bunching her mouth up and rolling her eyes. “No ...”

“Please, Taylor ...”

“Really?” she asked, her brows pinching a tiny line in her smooth brow.

“Come on, *you* asked *me* ... please, show me ...”

She turned up her nose, her eyes narrowed on him and he watched between her legs as she shifted on the bed so she faced him, legs still crossed underneath her. Her hands came apart, angled at first so only she could see under them. “Oh boy,” she whispered, then slowly withdrew her hands and hid them behind her back.

Exposed between her legs, dimly lit with the sun behind her, he could see her shaved mound, the soft puffy flesh cleaved by her pink opening running in a wetly shimmering line. A slug-like trail of his semen seeped from her and rolled between her cheeks.

In an instant, his dozing and retiring erection pulsed with new life and his breath clutched in his chest at this biologically base sight. He’d come *inside* her. Come *inside* the woman he loved. It was organic necessity, it was the way the world worked—he’d claimed her sacred space with his valuable seed and this woman-too-beautiful for him *allowed* him. Sure, conception was almost impossible, but the implication was magical. *She accepted his seed in her body.*

“Whoah,” he sighed, and he put his hand over his heart.

She laughed now and closed her legs up. He wanted to grab those knees of hers and spread her open again, take another look, but he had to be cool here. She scooted her raised butt off the bed and put her feet on the floor, hopping off the bed and trying to keep her girl parts from grazing the quilt.

“Hey, wait, no,” he called after her. “Stay here.”

“I don’t want your cum on my quilt, Harrison,” she laughed, long legs taking her to her suitcase. She still had a hand clutched over her sex and now she made a scrunched-up face.

“What now?”

“I don’t want to bend over or squat.”

He had to be the luckiest guy in the world. This tall, thin sexy girl was his, standing by a window with nothing on, her nipples pushed out from her breasts, his semen cupped in her hand where it seeped from inside her. The sight made him feel very masculine.

“Here,” he said, and with subdued chivalry tossed his T-shirt to her and she caught it clumsily with her left hand. “Now, would you please come back?” He patted the spot where she’d been sitting.

She returned, holding his wadded up T-shirt between her legs and sitting down on the bed next to him cross-legged again. One hand holding his shirt, the other traced hair off his brow as he watched her. She smiled warmly at him as she did.

He said, “I’m sorry I came so fast.”

“Don’t worry, Harrison, I got what I came for.”

“What was that?”

“I told you: I wanted you to be my real first.”

“I’m your first two times over.”

“It was nice,” she told him.

“It could have been better.”

“It was what it needed to be.”

“You want to go again?” he said, nodding his chin down his stomach, indicating to her his hardness had returned.

She shook her head, said, “Maybe later.”

“I’m ready right now.”

“Not now, Harrison. Let it sink in for me. We can do it again later.”

WITH HER EYES STILL WATCHING his, she closed her legs together, pinching the T-shirt in her crotch, curled up and lay next to him in a fetal position with her knees against his hip and her finger running circles in the hair over his ear. She said, "You know I care about you so much, right?"

"I care about you, too," he said. It was like she had more to say and he watched as her upper lip pulled in her lower and sucked on it. Then she smiled. She patted his cheek. "We should go back downstairs."

"Yeah, I guess we should."

It was over. It had been done. It was disappointingly quick, but it was done. And it had meaning, and it had power. He would show her later, sometime maybe in the afternoon he would get her in the mood, maybe even come up here and try again. But for sure he would be laying here with her tonight and despite what Kelsey Kay might say, they were going to make an awful lot of sex noises.

"Did you get your alcohol?" he asked her now, changing the subject and at the same time trying to hide the disdain in his voice.

She kind of rolled her eyes, ran her thumb on the edge of his jaw. "No, we didn't."

"All you girls put your heads together and you couldn't come up with something?"

"I'm going to ask KC when he gets here."

He held her hand and said, "Isn't that what I said?"

"We're just too far. None of our other friends are going to come up."

"Did you want to invite more people because your mom wasn't here?"

“Yeah, but everybody’s doing stuff already. It’s too late, and we’re too far north.”

Good. The best part about this weekend party had always been the exclusivity.

“Ask KC when he gets here, then.” Although he didn’t think that was a good idea. Taylor was smart, but there was no denying he could sometimes see wildness in her. And Shelby and Roxie were the same. Kelsey did drink, though not often. And while she might seem like the roughest amongst them, she also had a level head. Kelsey Kay he didn’t worry about.

Taylor’s eyes brightened, and she smiled again saying, “Oh hey, you want to see something?”

Whatever it was, it seemed exciting given the expression on her face that was excited yet somehow laced with a certain deviousness. It had him intrigued.

“What is it?” he asked her.

She said, “It’s something I have to show you.”

As she rose off the bed, standing again naked in that beam of light coming in off the lake and through her window, there was a sound of loud cheers and hurrah from the main floor below them and he figured someone else had arrived. There was the sound of bottles, a deep male voice booming and he figured it sounded like KC. *Great, now he was going to have to deal with Taylor’s continued quest for alcohol.* But she was moving now, like she didn’t even hear the new arrivals downstairs.

She was crouched at her suitcase, apparently no longer afraid to squat. His T-shirt was still bundled between her legs but she withdrew it now, one hand undoing the zipper on her suitcase, the other flipping over the T-shirt and wiping at herself again. She checked to see she was dry and opened the case.

He watched the muscles of her narrow back work, the flexing of her arms as she rummaged through her hastily packed bag. She gathered something up, something fabric in a bright turquoise color that she bundled now between her small breasts. She looked at him speculatively and he asked her, “What are you doing?”

She made a comical expression of deep thought and said, “I’m wondering if I should make you turn around first.”

“Turn around?—it looks to me like you’re putting something *on*, not taking it *off*. In case you didn’t realize, you’re completely naked already.”

He reached to the top of the bed, unfolded the top corner of her quilt, grabbed a pillow and pulled it down to him. He folded it in two and placed it under his head and up against the wall. As she still regarded him, he laced his fingers behind his head and watched her. Laying there happy as can be, strangely comfortably naked, just like her, though his body was nowhere near as exciting as hers. He was naked with his knees bent over the lip of the bed, and his erection still pointing straight up to his chin.

She said, "But it's a surprise."

"Want me to close my eyes?"

"Okay," she bubbled, laughing now. "Close your eyes and don't peek."

Through narrowed vision he watched her anyway, and even though she assumed he was closing his eyes (and it would *appear* that he did), she still turned her back to him. He watched the paler globes of her round perfect ass flex as she took two steps to the bed opposite theirs and plunked down one part of whatever her turquoise ensemble was. She said over her shoulder, "I hope you're not peeking. I brought something to wear to go swimming, and I was worried my mom would give me a hard time. Now my mom is on her way to Myrtle Beach ..."

There were heavy footsteps coming up the steps, male voices talking, but his focus was entirely on the naked young woman who was his, her specter a warbled vision through his squinted eyes. He assumed it was a bikini she'd brought, and he wondered what would be so special since she usually wore a two-piece when she was up at the lake. The color of it was definitely nice, a bright sparkling turquoise like how you would see pictures of the Caribbean shore. The item she tossed on the bed was the bra, he could see two separate triangular cups. They were small. Now she held what must be the stringy bottom and his heart raced at the thought that she might wear a thong in front of all their friends.

She said, "I went to the mall with Shelby, we went to that store, you know the one on the east end next to the Victoria's Secret?—we went there, and it might be a little expensive, but—"

The door to their bedroom burst open abruptly, and both of them jumped.

Standing in the gap was a young muscular man in a T-shirt with the arms cut off and displaying round, bulging shoulders; he was deeply tanned and had thick blonde hair in tangles behind his ears and below the brim of

his backward baseball cap; there was a gym bag at his waist, the black strap over his shoulder.

Harrison jumped and drew up his knees, hiding his nakedness. Taylor screeched and jumped, almost doing a dance, her knees coming up one after the other and jumping backward. She was naked, at least topless, her two hands thrusting between her legs and covering up her bare sex with her bundled bikini bottom.

The young guy at the door took it all in at once and he was overwhelmed with hilarity. His face broke wide with great humor, flashing a big white arrogant smile as his eyes sparkled. His vision went laser-focused on Taylor's bare chest. Without missing a beat, without hearing any of their protestations, the hand that held the doorknob lifted up, he snapped his fingers and pointed at Taylor, winking right at her and giving her a devilish smile, saying "What's up, titties?" He laughed then, scanned the room and saw Harrison but disregarded him.

In the moment before he closed the door and stepped back into the hall, Harrison saw the guy was chewing a wad of gum—and he recognized the face.

The door thunked closed, and he heard the voice he was sure was Colton Briggs's in the hall laughing with KC, saying, "I think that room is *taken*." And he heard KC's voice, saying, "Huh? Oh, yeah, that's my sister's room." Then there was more low masculine rumbling as the two of them continued on down the hall.

"What a fucking asshole," Taylor whined. When she turned around to face him he saw her cheeks had a rosy glow. Her mouth was open and breathless, and she continued: "What's so hard about knocking first?"

Harrison was on the bed with his knees drawn up, his two bare feet over the lip. He was stunned.

He said, "Was that Colt Briggs?"

"Yeah, I think so," Taylor said. She was stunned, too, standing there with her mouth open and her eyes bewildered. The bikini bottoms were still clutched between her legs but her breasts were bare and bunched between her two arms as if she presented them on purpose. *Is that what she had showed Colt as he walked into their private bedroom?*

Colt Briggs was three years older. When Harrison first went to high school Colt Briggs was a senior, and he was just about the biggest fucking asshole you could imagine. Loud, boisterous, and of course, a bully.

Harrison had spent most of his first year avoiding Colt and his friends. He was lucky he was good friends with Taylor, and Taylor's brother was KC. KC was also one of *those* guys, like Colt, but as long as Harrison was friends with Taylor he would be not so much protected but ignored. And ignored was good. Sure, *protected* might be better, but protected came with a price. When you were protected, they knew your name. At least when you were ignored you didn't owe them anything.

Harrison stood up now, naked and feeling vulnerable given the intrusion, and he covered his dick with an arm, hand cupping his balls. He went to Taylor, put his other arm around her saying, "Are you okay?"

"What? Yeah, I'm okay." Then she shook her head, took her bikini bottoms and snapped them out, stretching the waistband to put her legs through. She said, "It's no big deal."

"Should I *say* something?" he asked, knowing the answer would be no—God, *hoping* the answer would be no—but feeling like it was something he should offer.

"Say what? The guy just walked into a room he shouldn't have. It wasn't that bad."

"He saw you naked," he whined.

Taylor put one long leg through a panty leg-hole and Harrison could see now that it was for sure a thong-back bikini bottom. He felt at once excited, protective, and frightened. Now he was distracted, saying, "Is that a thong?"

She was putting the other leg through and she said, "Do you think my mom would've been mad?"

Holy smokes, *he* was mad—Trish would've been livid. He said, "Probably."

She said, "Aren't you supposed to be turned around?"

"Really?" he asked.

She turned her butt away from him so he wouldn't see the thong back and put her hands behind her like she was covering her cheeks even though he couldn't see them. Her breasts were bare. She said, "Really."

"Fine," he said, turned around and then felt uncomfortable again. She was looking at *his* bare butt, and he was looking at the door where that asshole had tumbled through without even knocking. So while he let her get her bra on, he went to the bed, sidestepping to keep his back to her, snatched up his shorts and underwear, and put them on. His T-shirt would have to go in the wash so he'd pull one from his knapsack in a moment.

“Okay,” she said behind him, ready for the revelation.

He turned around, saw her, thumped down, sitting heavily on the bed. The bikini she wore was scant. Two triangular cups that barely covered her breasts, just patches with strings. And her bottom was the same: just a small triangle that cupped her sex, showed off its shape, coming barely up her tummy before turning to a string that went around the back. He was afraid to imagine what it looked like from behind—he asked her, “What ... what does it look like from behind?” His voice was thin and frail and worried.

Even Taylor seemed nervous, and now she bit the corner of her lower lip with a canine, grouped her hands together below her waist, stayed where she stood and rotated until she faced away. Her whole bare ass was showing. Just a string across the back, a smaller triangle at the crest of her buttocks between the two divots on her lower back that became a string that disappeared between the round firm globes of her pert nineteen-year-old ass.

“Holy shit,” he mumbled helplessly, the words falling out of him unbidden. He wanted to be cool, say something confident and admiring, but the truth wanted to come out. This was *way* too much. “It’s ...” He couldn’t finish.

“Is it okay?” she asked, her head turning to show off her pretty profile as she asked him speculatively.

“It’s...”

“It’s what, Harrison?”

“I don’t know,” he sighed. And he *didn’t*. His eyes were glued to her bare ass and his hand came up and scratched his head absently. He didn’t know what to think. It was true, he wasn’t kidding. It was like his brain just stopped working. The only thing that came to him as the gears started turning again was all the guys that would be at the party would be *seeing* this. *What was she doing?* Did she *really* need a tan on her ass cheeks? Why did she have to show herself off like this to everyone?

And holy crap: *Colton Briggs*. He’d just seen her breasts, now he was going to see what her bare ass looked like?

He opened his hands, palms up over his thighs, still looking to speak but nothing came out except a low, froggy croak.

She turned to face him again, hiding away that bare bottom. She said, “Is that bad or good?”

“Both,” he said, finally regaining his ability to speak now that she’d hidden away that beautiful part of her. “Good as in I really like what I see, bad as in everybody else is going to see it.”

She sighed, seemed pleased with his answer.

She walked on her tippy-toes to the bed and threw herself down next to him. “Don’t be such a problem,” she whispered, kissed him on the cheek and hugged an arm around his neck. His hand stroked at her elbow.

He said, “We should go downstairs.” His voice was sterile and blank. “You should put on some shorts unless we’re, you know, down by the lake or something.”

She giggled, said, “Okay, I will ... *dad*.”

PART 2

HARRISON WANTED to hold her hand when they went downstairs to greet the new arrivals, but she got ahead of him on the stairs. At least she'd obliged him, putting her khaki shorts back on over top of the revealing thong bikini bottom. Still wore the tiny top that barely concealed her bouncy little breasts. She thumped down the steps ahead of him, hair tied back in a ponytail now, Wayfarers perched on her hairline.

Ten minutes ago he'd just shared the most intimate and significant moment they could ever have—one they would each refer to forever—but here they were, moving on and looking to party. Part of him was offended, like he would appreciate if she'd like to take a long moment for reflection the way he did right now. Then again, maybe he saw her point made earlier in the bedroom when he'd pleaded for sex: perhaps waiting till the day was done and their schedule was clear would have been a better time for them to perform that sacred ritual. It was kind of her to accommodate him knowing his male brain wouldn't survive till later. If only he could have lasted longer though...

Six people were gathered in the kitchen—three grown college guys he didn't know, plus Colt, Shelby Glass was there, and KC, too, who he hadn't seen in almost eight months. The three college guys, Colt, and KC each had a beer bottle in their hands, leaning their butts on counters or their elbows on the kitchen island. Shelby talked close with one of the nameless college guys that arrived with KC; her eyes were shiny, her cheeks flushed. Next week she would be a college girl, but he couldn't help thinking of her as a highschooler and it irked him to see one of his friends talking to much older boys.

Taylor trotted ahead of him, going in to greet her brother. KC smiled with great affection when he saw her and held his arms out. Taylor jumped into him and hugged him, playing it up, he thought, because he knew she wanted something from him.

“Oh Taylor, baby, look how grown-up you are.” He chuckled and groaned and held her. At times, when they were both young teens, their household relationship could be contentious. She’d once thrown a whole steaming cup of cocoa at him one winter and scalded his arm, but now they were both older, and KC was practically a grown man.

“I missed you,” Taylor said and squeezed his thick neck tightly.

KC was a big dude, and he played ball at State. From the looks of it, the guys he dragged up here for the weekend were ball players as well. Colt played football at Fraser High, and it figured he went away to school on scholarship. Similarly, the other three guys were beefy and well-built.

When their embrace parted, Colt was there, sliding himself along the counter to lean against it beside KC. He said to Taylor: “I didn’t catch your name,” his smile was pulled lopsided, and in the bright, sunny kitchen, light danced in his pale blue eyes.

“Taylor,” she said dryly, then to KC: “Tell your friend to knock on doors first before barging through them.”

Colt looked her up and down, working his mouth around, then said, “Tell your sister to put some clothes on when company’s here.”

“It’s my *bedroom*,” she said, on the verge of stomping her foot.

Colt said, “I think she was fucking her boyfriend in there. He was naked, too.” His eyes never left Taylor, reluctant to take her almost-bare chest in while her brother was present, but kind of doing it, anyway.

“Oh fuck, dude,” KC groaned and threw up a hand, turned to get away from the topic, coming toward Harrison. “I don’t want to hear anything about it,” he said, face scrunched like he’d smelled the worst fart imaginable.

Harrison greeted him with a hand held out, saying, “Dude, we’ve never even had sex *one* time, I don’t know what he’s talking about.”

“That’s what I want to hear, Harrison, *you* get it.” They shook hands and KC gripped his shoulder with a strong jock clasp. “Good to see you, bud.”

Now he still held Harrison’s hand in a shake and pointed to each newcomer around the kitchen, saying, “Hey, that’s Colt, you know him from Fraser, that’s Stevie, you know Shelby, hey Shelby ...”

Shelby waved at them playfully, acting dumb and saying, “Nice to meet you.”

KC continued, “... That’s Pontoon, and that’s Rick-Joe. Guy called Care Bear’s here, too. I think he’s out at the truck still.”

All the guys waved, said hey, and KC said, “This is my little sister, Taylor, and this is her boyfriend, Harrison.”

They all nodded, but their eyes mostly darted to the scantily clad Taylor, trying to get a look without her big brother catching them.

The side door of the kitchen that led out near the garages burst inward and a giant walked in carrying three cases of twenty-four beer at his waist, his chin resting on the top case. He was massive, with big hairy arms, and the densest, blackest beard Harrison had ever seen. He didn’t look like any college guy; he looked like a *man*. He strode through the kitchen while everyone watched him and when his eyes fell on Taylor, his face lit up, and in a deep, booming voice, he said, “Holy shit, fucking look at *you*.”

One of KC’s friends, maybe Rick-Joe, groaned, and the hairy guy kept walking, head on a swivel, eyes soaking up every bared inch of Taylor. She stayed still and let him, smiling, blushing.

Colt said to the passing big man’s back, “That’s KC’s sister.”

The guy kept walking, laughing now, realizing his fuck-up, heading down the hall toward the pantry where the Brooks’ kept a second fridge.

Colt shouted clarification down the hall: “His little *high school* sister.”

The guy roared with regret, “Ah-ho, ho boy, fu-uck me-ee.” Bottles clanked loudly as he set the cases down in the pantry.

KC rubbed the heel of his hand in his eye socket.

Taylor said to Colt, “I’m *not* in high school. I start college this week.”

Colt shrugged and jabbed a thumb down the hall, saying, “Anyway, that was Care Bear.”

SOMEHOW HE BECAME ENLISTED to aid in the unloading of the college guy's stuff. They'd come up in two vehicles, both of them pickup trucks. An older Raptor blocked the Soob from behind, and the other truck, beside the Soob, *dwarfing* it, was a lifted F-250 crew cab with huge tires and dual exhaust.

At least it was nice to be included in the *male* activities, and he took his turn as part of an assembly line, taking bags down from the beds of the trucks, handed to him by Colt who would stand up on the tailgate, then shuttling whatever was passed to Rick-Joe who stood at the door in the kitchen.

One time, Colt handed him down a styrofoam cooler and asked him, "Did you go to Fraser?"

He said, "Yeah. I was a freshman when you were a senior. What—you remember me?"

Colt said, "Huh—no, I don't remember you at all, bro," and got back to working gear out of the pickup's bed.

When they were near done and the progress slowed, he drifted away, walking around the house and down to the deck that looked over the lake. At the dock, he could see his friends, Shelby, Roxie, Kelsey Kay, Mikey, and Brady, too. They were just hanging out, clutched in small groups and talking, but he couldn't see Taylor down there. He took a few steps off the deck and down the stairs that led to the water, but looking back up at the house. Her bedroom window was open but he couldn't see her there—it would be a coincidence anyway for her to be looking down at the same time as he was looking up.

He walked counter-clockwise around the house now, coming up to the driveway on the far and opposite side of the house in time to see two more vehicles coming down the lane between the trees. Roxie's Santa Fe was in the lead and behind her there was a grey muscle car with tinted windows, maybe a Charger.

He doubled back now and headed down the hill toward the lake, coming down onto the deck that opened onto the bottom floor of the house. Hands cupped around his mouth he shouted down to the water, "Hey! Riley's here now ..."

Kelsey Kay waved back at him, and Roxie shouted *Okay*.

Between the barbecues, he opened the French double doors that led into the basement. It was quiet and cold on the lowest floor, and there was nobody down there. He made his way to the stairs and then up so that he came out at the kitchen. Pontoon was there with the one called Stevie and they both were drinking beers and talking. They stopped as he walked by and looked at him. He nodded his head and kept moving, and they resumed talking as he headed up the stairs to the second floor.

As he made it to the landing, the bedroom door at the very top opened and Care Bear came out, closing the door behind him. This guy, up close, had to be six-and-a-half feet tall. Harrison could feel the damp body heat coming off him, and they weren't even standing that close. He wore a Michigan State T-shirt in triple X and the sleeves had been torn off; he had shorts with pockets on the sides and wore flip-flops. When he turned, they were face-to-face now, and the guy regarded him blankly. Nothing else to say, and feeling uncomfortable, Harrison said, "Have you seen Taylor?"

He said, "Yeah, in there," as he jerked a thumb behind him to the door that he'd just closed.

That was a bedroom in there and it made Harrison's eyes flinch and blink rapidly, staring at the closed door. *This guy was in a bedroom with Taylor?*

"Maybe don't go in there," Care Bear said and began trotting down the steps, old wood creaking and groaning under his weight.

Funny cold dread whirled up inside him. His eyes continued to stare at the closed door.

That was a bedroom. Care Bear had just come from *in* there. *Taylor* was in there.

The possibilities worked through him, and it tightened and tugged at his core. Stomach muscles flinching, his eyes narrowed until his squinted vision warbled with wet. His heart pounded in his chest and he could feel his pulse in his neck. *What the fuck? How is this even possible?*

He lifted a hand and felt a breeze against his skin, the motion of the air tickling the sweat on his palms. He opened his hands and looked at both of them. Now he opened and closed them. How had his hands got so sweaty, so fast? God, his heart was still racing.

It would be so easy—just reach forward, turn the lever and find out what Taylor was doing in the bedroom. Instead, he stood there, his body racing with crazy emotion, adrenaline coursing through his system. It felt like he'd walked to the edge of the Grand Canyon and just decided to jump off. The electric excitement that worked through him was like what he imagined you would feel as you plummeted to your death. Intense thrill before certain death.

Now he stepped forward and rested his hand on the door's lever. It was cold and hard and brass. *Just fucking turn it.* Couldn't—it really felt like he would pass out.

His mind raced. What would he find when he opened this door?

He could picture it like it was real. Taylor lying in bed as he'd seen her do many times before. She was naked, and she was slick with sweat. He could see, as if watching through his own eyes, tumbling to the bed and falling on his knees before her, his vision filled with tears. As he looked close, he could see her body peppered with thick curling hairs stuck to her damp skin. All over her body, all over those perfect breasts and down those long legs.

With a sharp intake of breath, he snapped the lever down and shoved the door open ...

TAYLOR STOOD with KC while her brother looked like he was trying to unpack. She had her arms folded, still in her shorts, and she'd put on a loose white T-shirt. They both darted their faces toward him.

Pulse still whooshing in his ears, he said, "Riley's here." His voice sounded distant, frail and faraway.

KC said, "Okay," and Taylor turned back to face him, continuing her conversation.

She said, "Then let me just have some of yours."

KC seemed to consider it then said, "No."

"Why not?" she whined.

"Because you're my little sister."

"I'm not your *little* little sister."

"You're only nineteen, Taylor."

"So what?"

"So you're not of age."

"You were drinking when you were my age."

"I didn't ask my brother to get it for me."

"You don't have a brother."

"Exactly. I had to figure it out myself. Listen, I don't *want* you drinking. I don't want you drinking and I'm not going to be the one to get you the alcohol, for sure. Last thing I need is getting my final year scholarship revoked because I got my sister drunk and she got a spinal injury jumping off the swimming dock, or fell off the roof, or whatever. You know what Mom would say if you ended up in the hospital up here in the middle of nowhere and they had to pump your stomach? That's the last thing I need."

“I wouldn’t do that,” she scoffed.

He chuckled heartily, holding a bundle of folded T-shirts and looking at the ceiling, shaking his head. “Taylor, I’m looking out for you.”

“If you’re looking out for me, you would get the alcohol.”

“No, I’m looking out for you because I know what you’re like.”

“I’m a good girl—aren’t I a good girl, Harrison?” She darted a glance to him, brow lowered meanly.

He said, “She’s a good girl.”

KC said, “Riley was a good girl, then she went to college.” He put the shirts in a drawer and closed it, turned and rested a forearm on the top of the dresser. “You know she ended up in the hospital?”

“No,” Taylor said sulkily, but her mouth twitched.

“First year. Boom, right in the hospital from drinking too much. Poisoned herself. I knew Mom didn’t tell you but I thought Riley might’ve told you by now. Yeah, she went wild when she went to school. It would be nice if you *didn’t* do that.”

“What do you think I’m going to do with a couple beers?”

“You’re too young, Taylor.”

“I’m not a high school kid, for crying out loud, KC, I’m a college girl now. A woman. An adult. I go to California this week, you know.”

“Cool. You need a ride to the airport?”

Now she was sullen again, arms folded, looking at her toes and her pretty mouth turned in an upside down U. “No,” she said glumly.

“This is how it starts,” he laughed. “You should see all these good girls when they get to first year. You wouldn’t even recognize them, the shit they do. It’s shameful. Everyone complains about college boys. They ought to take a look at what’s happening with these girls out there.”

“Just forget it, anyway,” she mumbled and stormed past Harrison to get out of the room.

KC called after her as she went out in the hall, “And don’t ask any of my fucking friends, Taylor.”

TWELVE BURGERS SIZZLED on each of the grills, twenty-four total; twelve already served, twelve were ready to go in about seven more minutes, twelve were ready *almost* now, and Harrison was counting down to serve. Sure, Mom had made the patties, but he was pretty good on the grill so this was *his* show—his secret was a basting glaze he'd made with melted butter and brown sugar that he liberally brushed on while they cooked. He was at command central, in the middle between the two opposing stainless Weber gas grills. Steve Cisco was working as his *sous*, doing the dogs on a small charcoal-burning kettle grill behind him.

They had spectators. Taylor, of course, Roxie, too, and Pontoon, Care Bear, and Stevie were on deck for their burgers. The girls were talking with them.

Roxie stood looking up at Care Bear and said, "How tall are you?"

He shook his head like he was tired and this question had been asked of him *thousands* of times. "Six-six," he grumbled out of that thick black beard.

"Here, turn around," Roxie said, and she stepped behind him while Taylor watched and laughed. Roxie was tall, but back to back with Care Bear she looked tiny, not even as high as his shoulders.

"Hey, Chef, how's them burgers coming?" Stevie asked. He and Pontoon sat on a low ledge with their backs against the screen of the open window.

Roxie handed her phone to Taylor and asked her to take a picture. Taylor still wore her T-shirt and shorts, but Harrison knew she would be

down to that tiny bikini soon and the anticipation was tightening his stomach again.

Harrison said to Stevie, “Coming up in just one minute.”

Stevie gave him a hang-ten sign and went back to talking with Pontoon, both of them shirtless, wearing only swim shorts and flip-flops. Pontoon was a real big boy, probably as big as KC, but he was on the chunkier side. On his left shoulder he had a tattoo of a fierce looking viking. Stevie, though, was ripped. Lots of muscle, and well-defined, and he flexed a lot, making his muscles jump around even when he wasn’t really doing anything.

“Take our picture,” Roxie said to Taylor, “but crop his head out, you know, to make him look super-tall.” She took Care Bear’s huge, hairy forearms and guided them to cross over his chest like an intimidating bouncer. Then Roxie flipped around real fast and sassy, and made a pouting face, flashing imitation gang signs for the camera while Taylor giggled and took pictures.

Taylor said, “It doesn’t even look like you guys are the same species.”

Care Bear glanced over at his buddies and rolled his eyes around as if he were saying *Kids these days*. They laughed and swigged beer.

“Get a picture of this,” Care Bear said and his two giant hands gripped the narrow of Roxie’s waist. She screamed and laughed as he lifted her right off the ground and held her high, her long brown legs kicking, one of her slides spiraling off.

Pontoon called out, “You’re lucky it’s too far to the lake.”

Stevie laughed and added, “And lucky KC doesn’t have a pool.”

Taylor laughed and stumbled around taking pictures while Care Bear walked with Roxie held up in the air, her feet planted on his thighs, her two hands grabbing and holding his big wrists. Roxie had bundled her long hair on top of her head and it came loose now and completely covered her face as she laughed so hard she couldn’t breathe.

Care Bear lifted her even higher, peeking around her now but not spotting anywhere really fun to put her he headed to the patio set.

“Hey, whoa, hey,” Taylor called now, and she plopped Roxie’s phone down on one of the barbecue’s side tables, trotting to intervene. “It’s glass, it’s glass, don’t break it, my mom will shit.”

Care Bear disregarded her, setting Roxie’s bare feet down on the table—she’d lost her other slide—saying, “Relax, it’s acrylic, it’s fine.”

Roxie's laugh was now a high-pitched cackle that made Harrison wince as he flipped the patties one last time, saying, "Food's up, bring me your plates."

Without a word, working like a team, Care Bear turned his back to the table and Roxie hiked her long legs over his shoulders, climbing aboard to ride on top of them, one arm held up, hands clutching the overhang of the patio umbrella for minute adjustments in her balance.

As Stevie and Pontoon both came to get their burgers, Taylor tugged her top off and shook her hair out. The two guys stared at her almost bare back while they walked. She folded up her shirt loosely and left it on the table, no one sitting at it, everyone choosing to sit down by the lake to eat. She unzipped her shorts.

On top of Care Bear now, Roxie straightened her legs out and called out *Hey* to Taylor. When she looked up, Roxie wiggled all her toes and made an exaggerated sad face, pooching out her lower lip. Harrison watched, too, burger held out on a spatula. Taylor let her shorts drop around her ankles, standing now in front of everyone wearing only the tiniest bikini. Harrison's stomach tumbled, and he held his breath; the burger quivered on his extended spatula.

He'd already seen her in this—her private show up in the bedroom—but out in the bright, sunny daylight in front of everyone, especially lecherous college dudes, it was startling and outrageous. Taylor's body was flawless. Tall, thin, tanned, not even an ounce of fat, but swelling still with youthful pertness. She squatted down and retrieved the two slides that had fallen off Roxie's feet, and Harrison's eyebrows raised so high it felt like his scalp scrunched up. Taylor stood then, turned away from her audience and plopped the slides onto Roxie's held out feet. Pontoons, Stevie's, Harrison's, and even Cisco's eyes watched her bare ass, just a string woven between her narrow but round and bouncy ass cheeks.

"Holy fuck," he whispered, then swallowed dryly. His cock swelled up suddenly, still eager to solve previously unfinished business. His heart surged in his chest and he was at once insanely jealous and yet strangely proud. That was *his* girlfriend. That smoking piece of ass belonged to *him*. And there she was, slim and narrow threads away from being totally naked in front of strangers, showing off to everyone those things that were *his*.

Pontoon and Stevie definitely liked what they saw, both of them eyeing her up, eyebrows high with awe. They looked away, then looked back again

almost instantly, male eyes drawn to that perfection, as helpless to it as moths to a flame.

Pontoon had wandered close enough that Harrison was able to plop a hamburger patty on to his bun even though the guy's head was turned. Even though he felt a jealous spike, it was pride that washed upward through his legs and into his heart now, almost *liking* that these college dudes were gawking at something so fine that belonged to Harrison.

Stevie pulled his eyes away from that perfect and *almost* bare ass to see one patty on Pontoon's bun and brought up a peace sign, saying, "Two patties."

"For both of you?" Harrison asked. They both nodded now, and Harrison obliged, turning each of their burgers into double-burgers.

When he looked up, he saw Roxie using her hand to hold an imaginary glass and tip it up to her mouth repeatedly, her eyes locked with Taylor's. Some sort of secret and quiet communication. As Harrison lined up the next patties to be offered he watched Taylor. She caught this drink-miming that Roxie did, and gave her friend back a knowing nod.

From inside the house, coming out the lower level French doors right behind him were Riley, her best friend Cookie, and Cookie's boyfriend Jamie. With Pontoon and Stevie already served, and Taylor, Care Bear, and Roxie otherwise engaged, the three of them lined up to get their burgers. Harrison made small talk as he served them, but his eyes were glued to Taylor who now picked up her jumbo Solo cup and poured some of her drink into Roxie's. Harrison was sure the drink was spiked. One of KC's friends, or even Riley, had let Taylor get an alcoholic beverage. Or perhaps she'd even slipped into the kitchen when no one was looking and helped herself.

Care Bear was next in line now, but it was Roxie leaning forward, still up on his shoulders, holding out her plate with a prepared bun, saying, "Server, please, my burger, if you will."

Harrison plopped her patty down on her ketchup-soaked bun, his eyes regarding Care Bear's huge fingers pressing into her tanned thighs. To him, Roxie was the little kid who he'd known since Grade Five, and to see her with a much older guy, a *huge* older guy, made his stomach feel a little sick.

"Thank you, peon," she said in jest, and then it was Care Bear holding out an empty plate looking to get served.

In his deep baritone, he said, “Three patties, kid, no bun, no condiments. Get your buddy to throw some dogs on there, too.”

Harrison looked over his shoulder to see if Cisco heard that or not. He did, his face vacant but intimidated as he prepared some wieners to be thrown on the big guy’s plate.

“Hey,” Harrison called out to Taylor now as she got close and handed up an assuredly spiked beverage to Roxie. “You want in here? I’m running low ...”

Taylor smiled and said, “No, let the others go, I’m going to hang out up here, anyway.”

“Okay,” he said, but she wasn’t listening now, instead walking away with Care Bear and Roxie up on his shoulders, taking a swig from her cup.

He served Cookie and Jamie some burgers, then said to Cisco, “I better grab some more patties, you watch the grill for me.”

Cisco saluted with his tongs and Harrison squeezed past him to get to the French doors and into the house. Even though his mom’s hamburger patties were stored in an Igloo cooler, he’d put the cooler inside the house to keep the sun off it. Now he was in the cool finished basement, walking on the carpet in the quiet. The cooler was inside the door, just behind the window where Pontoon and Stevie sat, their backs pushing against the screen. It was noisier outside on the deck and they couldn’t hear him moving around behind them in the house. He popped the cooler open, pulled out a dozen raw burgers and put them on the platter.

Pontoon was trying to talk low to Stevie, but Harrison could hear him clearly. He said, “That Roxie looks like a good fuck, huh?”

It chilled Harrison’s belly to hear someone talk about his friend so base.

“You think the Bear’s gonna fuck her?” Stevie asked.

“Don’t know. He’d be crazy not to ...”

Stevie confessed: “Fucking KC’s *sister* is driving me *crazy*.”

Pontoon exhaled a loud exhalatory burst indicating he knew exactly what Stevie was talking about.

Stevie said, “You *see* that body? I mean, holy shit.”

Pontoon said, “KC would fucking *kill* you, bro.”

Stevie laughed, said, “What?”

“That’s his little sister.”

“So? He lets that skinny dweeb fuck her.”

Now his hands went cold, and he felt a tingling in his fingertips.

Pontoon said, “Yeah, but they’re the same age.” He took a bite of his burger, and then, with his mouth full of the food Harrison had prepared, he added: “And that kid doesn’t *fuck* her.”

They both enjoyed throaty and deep laughs, elbowing each other and getting off on how they didn’t think Harrison could please his girlfriend.

He hadn’t even eaten, hadn’t at all sampled his own wares—too busy trying to please others—but whatever he had in his stomach right now wanted out, and he right-faced as an unexpected esophageal tidal swell washed up a spicy mash of Dunkin’ cronuts. It lodged somewhere behind his breastbone. He went down on his knees and clenched himself tight, hugged his arms to his stomach and stared at the pink discs of his mother’s mashed cow flesh on a pure white platter right under his nose.

It took almost a full minute before the swell steadied itself and the gastric acid fell back to the protected surfaces of his stomach lining. He swallowed a lump of bile that had squeezed up and then gathered more patties onto the platter.

ON THE WAY back to the barbecue, holding the platter of uncooked patties with frail and shaking arms, the nameless dread that swirled through him came into focus.

It was fear.

Fear that his girlfriend would be away at school next week, thousands of miles distant, and she would be surrounded by guys exactly like Pontoon and Stevie. Hot guys, athletic guys, older guys; all of them looking to put their dicks in his unsuspecting girl. He dumped the platter down on the stand next to the grill with a porcelain clatter and rested his grip on the edge of the trim that surrounded the barbecue.

Across from him now he could see Care Bear gorging on meat, Roxie sitting next to him on a seat at the patio table. Taylor sat with her bare butt on a railway tie ledge a few feet away, her thumbs firing off text correspondence on her phone.

As he licked his lips and prepared himself to get back to his burger duty something attracted his attention. On the barbecue's side table, right next to his hand, Roxie's iPhone sat face up where Taylor had left it. The screen lit up with the life from an incoming text. He touched the corner of her grubby green case to straighten it so he could read. The message to Roxie was incoming from one Taylor Brooks, and the words typed out chilled him further, and his breath heaved out of him.

Taylor: Stevie's body is giving me palpitations! I think I'm in love!

She'd added shocked emojis, round yellow faces with big white eyes bugging out of their heads and a few rocket ships as well. His eyes roamed up from Roxie's phone to catch Taylor sitting now with her phone flat on one thigh, her hands curled over the black edge of the railway tie retaining wall, her eyes cast sideways to Harrison, watching the muscular Stevie talking with Pontoon. His girl was almost bare, her long tanned body striped with thin strings of turquoise fabric. And she was *posing*; wanting Stevie to look up and see her, see her bare body, see her staring at him ...

His own body dipped a little, a momentary haziness coming across his consciousness and his watery knees almost letting him drop to the deck.

Never in his life had he been more happy to see KC. Big brother showed up, coming down from the garage side of the house to join them—his presence would sort out his friends' lechery and maybe curtail some of Taylor's naughtiness. Still, Harrison's damp fingertips made streaks in the stainless barbecue lip as he clenched his hands, his stomach tightening further recalling his girlfriend's text. His eyes went down as KC came up with a plate, saw Roxie's phone had returned to blank, Taylor's words hidden from his eyes but not from his thoughts.

"Hey, look at the chef," KC said, "Command Central," his eyes moving around the grills. "You got it all under control."

"Do I?" he chuckled, feeling all his stitching coming loose.

"Sure looks like it, Harrison. Your mom make these burgers?"

"Yup," he said, struggling to make eye contact for fear of exposing his inner turmoil.

KC flashed up two fingers, indicating the number of burgers he wanted. "Your mom makes the best burgers."

Behind KC, Harrison could see Taylor sitting on the tie still, her posture more erect, her arms coming up, hands tangling her ponytail into a loose knot up top of her crown. Her pert little breasts were upright and flexing against the thin swimsuit material. The Wayfarers had come down and he couldn't see her eyes, but he wondered if she watched Stevie behind the dark of the lenses.

"Coming, uh, right up," he struggled to say around his too-thick tongue.

Riley had broke from her group of friends and saw Taylor sitting by herself and moved to sit with her.

After finding Taylor up in KC's room, he went downstairs with them and all three siblings had a touching reunion in the hallway. But all the

guests were caught in a confluence in the crowded front hall and they didn't spend much time together beyond hugging and cheek-kissing.

Riley had brought along Cisco and her friend April; Jamie and Cookie came together. It was Jamie driving the Charger, and Taylor told him that things between Jamie and Cookie were getting serious, like maybe Cookie might be the first among Riley's friends to get hitched. That was an intimidating thought. Such a big step, and to know someone close to your own age who was looking to leap that hurdle was a reminder that life just kept chugging along and you better keep your hands on the wheel. He'd grip his wheel tight because he knew for absolute certain Taylor would be the girl he would marry.

He inhaled deep and sharp, held it, smiled, flipped two cooked patties onto the buns on KC's plate and said, "Hey, look at this, all the Brooks' together, someone ought to take a picture."

KC turned to see behind him, his two sisters sitting together, Roxie with a plate of food on her lap. Taylor overheard, and she held her hands out to KC and made grabby fingers. Perhaps her chagrin over his alcohol-denial had been lessened—another sign she'd probably procured what she wanted in another way. Bygones were bygones when you got what you wanted through circumvention.

A photo op was his own method of circumvention—a reminder to Taylor of family and all the love and honor that came packaged with it. A reminder to be a good girl.

KC held his plate in one hand and his other searched his cargo shorts' pocket, pulling out his phone. He looked wistfully to Harrison (he could feel his plan working), said, "Would you take it, Harrison?"

"Man, I'd love to," he said with a curt nod that showed the oldest Brooks sibling he understood the duty and was honored.

He took KC's phone and nodded to Cisco, passing off grill duty for the moment. Riley and KC hid their plates behind them in the flower garden and KC sat down next to Riley and threw his arm over her shoulder, rested his hand on Taylor. They squeezed together and Riley darted KC a quick kiss on his cheek. Harrison was lucky to catch a picture in time, and they all laughed.

KC said, "We have time so Taylor can put a shirt on?"

Riley wagged a finger and said sternly: "Oh, don't you dare. You don't tell a girl what to wear."

KC dropped it, smiling still but definitely showing a burden in his features. He posed, looked up.

“Say cheese,” Harrison told them and they did, and he stuttered off a whole bunch of pictures of their three good-looking faces. Riley was so much like Taylor but she’d dyed her hair black since the last time he saw her, which was at the beginning of the summer. Harrison handed back the phone to KC and the two sisters told him to send them copies.

Riley looked to Taylor now and the sweet family moment seemed to get to her and she put her arms around Taylor and sobbed, “I can’t believe my little sister is going to college next week.”

Taylor patted her sister’s back and said, “We’re getting *so* old.”

“Stop it,” Riley said and laughed, clearing a tear from her eye.

“What’s with this?” Taylor asked, holding a lock of her sister’s hair on either side of her face, examining the color change.

“You like it?” Riley asked.

Taylor thought for a second, said, “Yeah. I do.”

Riley made a funny face, exhaled slowly from puffed-out cheeks, then said, “Are you ready for *this*?”

“What?” Taylor said, fearfully puzzled.

Riley looked over her shoulder to see KC had turned his back, and she stood up. She wore very short shorts, a baggy T-shirt with a wide neck that showed bikini straps, and flip flops on her feet. She doffed the T, and a girl undressing got the guys’ attention, all male eyes on her now. Harrison saw it first.

Riley turned and dipped a shoulder to show her sister the black tattoo of a scorpion that worked up her shoulder blade and over the top of her arm.

Taylor’s mouth dropped down as far as it would go and her eyes rolled wide with wonderment.

“What do you think?” Riley asked tentatively.

Taylor’s hand came up and her long fingers traced the drawing. She said, “It’s awesome.”

“You think so?”

“I really love it,” Taylor said breathlessly.

KC turned and saw it, slapped his hand over his face, but Harrison could see he still smiled. He made a paternal groaning sound.

Taylor continued to ogle it with green envy, asking now, “How much did it cost?”

“Like, seven-hundred.”

“No way, Taylor,” KC said, and she acted like she didn’t even hear him.

“Taylor, your burger’s up,” he called to her, back at his command post.

Taylor and Riley looked in each other’s eyes for a moment, then Taylor rose and walked across the patio to the barbecue. KC watched her bare body and his brow furrowed. Harrison didn’t check, he was too busy watching the way her tight tummy moved as she walked, but he was sure the other guys had their eyes glued, too.

She took a plate and plopped an egg-sized dollop of potato salad on it and presented it to him.

He said, “This one’s special for you.”

Her Wayfarers had slid down her nose enough he could see her eyes over top of them and she asked, “How’s it special?”

He made an incredulous face, like the answer was obvious, and said, “It’s made with a special ingredient.”

From the other side of the barbecue, he heard Stevie say, “Gross, dude,” and then Pontoon laughed around a mouthful of food.

“Is it love?” Taylor said, cocking out a hip playfully.

He winked and plopped her patty on the bun.

Riley *awwwed* from where she sat on the railway tie, then said, “I can’t stand to think of you guys apart.”

“Me neither,” Harrison said, feeling an honest sadness settle over him.

Taylor made a funny half-smile that tugged a deep pocket at the corner of her mouth.

Stevie asked, “Apart why?”

Riley said, “They’re going to separate schools.”

“Ohh shit, dude,” Stevie exclaimed, and while it sounded like a taunt, he was pretty sure it was the guy’s honest reaction to what was clearly an awful situation.

But Pontoon, when it was quiet, let out a loud sad trumpet sound: “Whomp, whomp.”

“Tell me about it,” Harrison said, still looking deep in Taylor’s eyes. “But you can’t get to me.”

Care Bear’s deep voice: “Oh, I’m sure you guys will stay together.” It was monotone and could go either way; sarcastic or supportive. No one laughed, and it was quiet for a wholly uncomfortable few heartbeats while he still looked in Taylor’s eyes.

Stevie gave a funny laugh, said, “Oh yeah, first year girls are always faithful to their boyfriends.”

Another uncomfortable giggle from somewhere.

But then Care Bear’s voice boomed again: “Hey, I’ve seen the girls at State. Who says homeboy won’t be drying his dick off on their dorm room curtains every night? First year’s a fuck-fest.”

It broke the disquiet but he could see that got to Taylor a little and her eyes gleamed wet and before she turned away, he could swear they were trembling.

WHEN THE BARBECUING WAS DONE, he served himself and Steve Cisco the final burgers and joined Taylor.

“Thanks for waiting,” he said, and she smiled.

Together they left the patio and walked down the wooden steps that cut a straight line down the grassy slope that led to the sand beach that ran a crescent around the Brooks’ lakeshore. Steve continued on to sit with Mikey and Jamie. Mostly everyone was already down there. Some had already finished eating and waded in the water. KC and Rick-Joe were heading into the boathouse, and Harrison imagined they were going to bring the boats and jet-skis out.

Five years ago wasn’t that distant, but it seemed like a different era. KC used the jet skis back then and some select older friends, but it was Mr. Brooks who drove the boat. None of the younger kids could ride the wave-runners, but Mr. Brooks would drive that boat almost all day long, towing kids on waterskis or inner tubes. He’d complain about the price of gas the whole time, and probably finish a six of High-Life, but he was a trooper. Kept the Brooks kids and all their friends entertained from lunch to sunset and let them make fun of his dopey fishing hat with its bright lures hooked through the khaki cotton.

“Why the long face, Harrison?” Taylor asked him as they settled, just the two of them on the grass above the beach just at the edge of shade. Taylor stretched her legs out so the sun fell on them and she kicked off her Birkenstocks.

“Thinking about your dad.”

“Don’t bum me out,” she groaned.

“Sorry. I just hate that things change.”

“Things are always changing.”

“Remember how he used to take everyone skiing all day?”

It was sometimes touchy bringing up her dad, but he watched her profile now and saw her smile. Sunlight reflected off the lake and while they were in the shade, her face practically shone.

“Yeah,” she sighed wistfully.

It was best to drop it while he was ahead so he said nothing further.

Taylor continued: “I miss those days.”

She wiggled her painted toes in the sun, her plate balanced high on her thighs. It had been a shock at first to see her so naked, but he’d grown accustomed now, and sitting here with her it looked like a regular bikini, and although the cups of her top were small, sitting down like this you couldn’t see the back of her panties were a thong. Her mouth pursed as she thought of something, and her expression clouded. She said, “It’s going to be so weird next week.”

He nodded, watching her still. He said, “I hate it.”

She said, “At least you’ll still be in Saginaw. I’m going to be so far away. By myself.”

“Are you scared?” he asked her.

“Not scared, no.”

“Excited?”

“I think so.”

“You stressed?”

“Definitely.”

“Maybe I can come visit,” he said.

She didn’t reply for a long time, her eyes cast out over the water. KC and some of his friends guffawed about something from inside the boathouse. She said, “I’ll be home for Thanksgiving.”

“Yeah,” he agreed. There wasn’t much hope of affording a flight out to California, anyway, not with all the other things that needed paid. Three months without her was going to be brutal. They’d talked a bit about the oncoming separation, but mostly it seemed like they both wanted to avoid the subject.

They ate for a while in silence, watching their friends hanging out and talking. Cookie and Jamie were in the water, not wearing swimwear yet, but walking into deeper water with their shorts legs tugged high. Brady Aaron

wasn't sitting with Kelsey Kay, she was with Shelby, the two of them sitting in the sand and talking close with their arms hugging their knees. KC and Rick-Joe came out of the boat house, Brady following them, fitting in well with the older jock types.

Taylor had finished her tiny potato salad, and had picked her way with small bites through the burger he'd cooked her, and he asked her if she wanted more potato salad.

"Okay," she said. "And can you take my cup," she passed her plate and her cooler cup, "in the kitchen fridge there's a pitcher of fruit punch. You know the gray pitcher, the one with the lid and it's got the rooster on the side?"

"Yeah."

"Refill it, please?"

"Okay. Is there booze in it?"

"Aren't you nosy," she said, and scrunched up one side of her face. When he didn't smile, she said, "Check it if you want, dad."

"Fine," he sighed. "Take my plate?"

She removed his plate from his lap, and he said, "Don't eat my burger. Take yours and put it on my plate."

She did, and he rose with her sitting there in her flossy bikini, looking hot as hell, holding his plate with both their burgers.

"I'll be right back."

He went up the steps and into the house, going through the basement doors and taking the stairs up to the kitchen. He found her pitcher in the fridge and while he wanted to check it, he didn't. Couldn't help taking a whiff while he refilled her cup. It just smelled like fruit punch. There was a chance he was blowing it out of proportion, and he didn't want to be a nag on their last weekend together before she went off to school in California.

Out the basement doors again, he stopped at the long table by the barbecues that held the prepared salads, condiments, buns, and things, topped up Taylor's plate with another small ball of potato salad, and headed down the steps to the lake.

Taylor didn't sit where he'd left her. She sat dozens of feet farther down on the sandy beach. From behind she looked naked; her back narrow and ridged with tanned muscle, her waist thin, her paler rump curving out, just a thin turquoise string up her butt and around her waist. Sitting next to her in what should be his spot, engaging her in what appeared to be humorous

conversation, was Colt Briggs. With his hat turned back and his golden curls spilling around his face, he said something that made her laugh even harder, and she covered her mouth with her hand and tossed her long shining hair over her shoulder. Harrison could see the bud of her nipple pressing out against the turquoise triangle of her skimpy bra.

WHEN HE PRESENTED Taylor's plate to her (wordlessly because he was mad), she thanked him.

Colt said, "Where's mine, dude?"

He said to Taylor, "You don't want to sit in the shade anymore?" He ignored Colt, knowing the guy'd already eaten.

"I came down into the sun," she said. Next to her was the plate with their two hamburgers. Sand had spilled over one low edge, the plate laying uneven on the beach.

Colt was sitting very close, his feet almost touching hers. He had his knees up and his muscular arms gathered around his legs, one veiny hand clutching the opposite wrist.

"You pass my burger?" Harrison said to Taylor as he set himself down in front of her, his back to the water, getting as close to her as Colt was.

"Yup," she said cheerily and twisted at the waist to retrieve the other plate. She tilted it, let the sand sift off.

The way she moved showed off her tight tummy, showed the muscle and ribs as they moved under her tight bronzed skin. She was so flat in her middle the wound string of her bikini bottom left a gap where it crossed the knob of her hipbone and a careful eye could get a peek down at her lady parts. Colt didn't miss it at all and Harrison darted his eyes to catch this college guy taking a peek inside the front of her bikini bottoms.

Taylor shifted, got onto her knees to present his plate to him, said, "Sorry, about the sand," and made a funny wriggly mouth at him. He told her it was fine, and they got the right burgers on the right plates, and she sat back on her heels, her feet folded under her mostly bare bottom.

Colt had already eaten, and he watched them a moment, said to Harrison: "Your mom make these hamburgers?"

"Yeah."

"Your mom makes great fucking hamburgers. Shitty you gotta leave home now, you're gonna hate dorm food, dude."

"I'm staying here. I mean back in town. Saginaw."

"You going to State?"

"Yeah."

"And you're staying in your mom's house?"

"My parents', yes."

"You're going to commute every day?"

"Four days a week."

Colt made a dubious expression, then shrugged it off.

Harrison added, "That's why I bought a car."

Colt took off the ball cap and set it next to him in the sand. With two hands he ran fingers through his thick, sun-bleached hair, his curls untangling as they combed through. He was square-jawed and deeply tanned and Harrison hated him. The guy said to Taylor now: "And you? California, huh? I guess you're not commuting. You're gonna commit to that college experience."

"I am," she said confidently but Harrison knew her a long time and saw her face contort nervously.

"What's Santa Cruz got that you wanted?"

She shrugged her shoulders and took a small bite of her hamburger. With the back of her hand over her mouth she answered him: "They accepted me."

"No, really," Colt laughed.

Harrison said, "Business Admin."

Colt's eyes narrowed, and he said, "I think someone wants to go surfing."

Colt had got it right it would seem because Taylor's pouting smile quirked to one side. "Maybe," she admitted. She'd talked to Harrison about it before, surmised that maybe she'd like to try out surfing while she was there.

"Yeah, I thought so," Colt laughed. "You should go to The Hook."

"You know Santa Cruz?" she said, looking at him now, running her hair behind an ear.

“I know *all* the Pleasure Points,” he said slyly.

“Ha, le ha,” she pronounced drolly, and squinted her eyes at him.

Harrison felt his back go up, could feel an anger that this guy would talk like that to his girlfriend. He said, “What’s that? Pleasure Points?”

Taylor took another bite of her hamburger and said, “Part of Santa Cruz.”

Colt said, “I went there once. I don’t know—year-and-a-half ago. Not just there, but all down the coast. I got some friends in the area.”

Taylor said, “I thought The Hook was dangerous for new people, like outsiders.”

He said, “Trust me, they’ll *love* you.” His eyes went over her again.

Taylor sang, “Shut up,” and she tossed her hair, and Harrison hated seeing her absolutely dig what Colt said.

“No, seriously,” he said, laughing it off, “give me a call when you’re there, I can hook you up with some dudes who’ll be good to you.”

Taylor considered it, then without replying she set her burger on her plate, the plate in the sand, and she turned away from them, stretching a crawl toward her bag which was thrown aside from where they were sitting. She gave him and Colt a direct view of her ass. It was round and taut, and the thong of the bikini back was completely wedged up her crack. It was like she was naked. From her purse she withdrew her phone. Harrison looked to Colt who burned holes in Taylor’s ass with his laser focus, a smirk tugging his lips to one side.

Harrison said, “So, hey, you graduated or what?”

Colt slightly turned his face toward him, but kept his eyes on target and said, “Not yet.”

“Then you’ll be out in the workforce?” he said, trying to lead this guy into acknowledging he was an adult. *But fuck, Taylor was an adult now, too, wasn’t she?* Neither of them were kids anymore even if they’d been kids recently.

Colt grunted an affirmation but disregarded him. Taylor had returned to sitting on her heels in front of them and now she passed her phone to Colt so he could give her his number. Colt took it, huddled up and tapped his number into her phone. Harrison watched Taylor. She was on her knees, smiling slightly, and he was sure she was getting off on having this older guy—a good-looking one—interacting with her.

An anger came up in him and it flooded acid up his esophagus. It was a borderless spate and he couldn't pinpoint what it was. He wasn't mad at *her*. Or was he? He *was* mad at Colt, sure, but it was broader than that. This feeling encompassed him, and he stared at the bright sparkling sand in wonder as it washed over him. Was it jealousy? Sure, that made sense, but it was far more powerful than just jealousy. It had begun to feel enormous. He said to her, "You really *that* into surfing?"

She didn't even look at him, her eyes instead watching Colt's large, manly hands work over her phone. "I don't know. I think so."

Colt handed the phone back and said, "Well, whatever you want to do, just give me a call. These guys are good guys."

Harrison said, "How old are they?" and couldn't suppress as much contempt as he wanted.

"Fuck, I don't know," Colt said without looking at him, eyes still on Taylor as she flicked through her phone to see the number he'd left there. "I don't go around asking people how old they are."

"Are they at UC?"

Colt didn't even respond, just laughed now and said something amusing that occurred to him: "Watch that Highway 17, when you go out there to the water. There's a ghost."

"Oh right, don't worry, I'll watch out for the ghost," she said sarcastically.

"No, for real," Colt said. "Me and my buddies saw him. He's an old native guy. We went through at midnight and we saw this old dude with, like, braids walking at the side of the road and for whatever reason all three of us thought it was super-creepy."

"You're not going to scare me," she said, taking another tiny bite of her hamburger.

"It's legit. Look it up. So we go to the motel and we said this to our waitress at the restaurant in the morning, and she's like, that's the old Indian ghost and how when you see him you'll never leave SC alive or something."

"You're here now," Harrison said. "Not much of a ghost story."

Taylor smiled at that but kept her eyes on Colt. She said, "He's just trying to freak me out."

Colt smiled back at her and said, "You going to California all by your lonesome?"

"I am," she said.

"What's-his-name here gonna be so far away and you have no friends going along to Cali?"

She shook her head no, still smiling.

Harrison reminded him, "Harrison," but figured he knew his name and was just being a dick.

"Your ghost is bullshit," she said, comically defiant.

Colt laughed loud and said, "Wanna bet?"

"Bet that you saw a ghost? How do we prove that?"

"That the ghost is real. That's the bet."

"Oh, please," she said skeptically.

Colt said, "Loser has to streak across the beach."

"In front of our friends? I don't think so."

"Nothing they haven't seen," he said with a smirk, eyeing her up and down again for the tenth fucking time.

"Gross. Not my friends. Well, maybe when I was, like, eight."

"Aw, somebody shy? You don't have much covered up, anyway, what's a little more?"

"Oh, *you're* not shy?" she said, raising up on her knees a little and taking a bite from the hamburger.

"Can't let fear stop you from doing things."

"Easy for you to say."

"Why's that?"

With her eyes turned down, looking at her hamburger again, she said, "Aren't you supposed to have, like, a really big penis?"

Harrison doubled over like he'd been punched and he inexplicably thrust his hands in the pockets of his shorts.

Colt threw his head back and laughed, his big muscular shoulders up around his ears.

She giggled, laughed, and when Harrison looked at her, she crinkled her nose. "What?" she asked petulantly.

Harrison said, "Why would you say that?" His voice was tight and constricted.

Colt mimicked him, his chin down on his chest again and looking at her through narrowed eyes. "Yeah, why would you say that?"

"I don't know. You probably like showing it off, so it's not really much of a wager, you know?"

Harrison said, “Jesus. Not *that*. Why would you even say *anything* about that?”

She shook her head, eyes looking up and to the right then at him again, as if she didn’t comprehend what the problem was.

Colt said, “He means how the hell would *you* know?”

“Oh,” she said with a sort of laugh, and rolled her eyes. She popped her butt back down to sit on her heels and took another small bite of the hamburger. She slumped to one side, drew her knees up and rested the hand that held a hamburger on her thigh. She said, “Girls talk.”

“I bet they do,” Colt said.

Harrison said, “I hope you *don’t*,” sounding too much like an adult right now. Like her dad. *And look where he ended up.*

“Oh please,” she said with another massive eye roll. “Like you guys don’t talk about stuff. Like what girls are *easy*.”

Colt laughed again, his head going back and the muscles of his shoulder flexing as he did. His big hands grabbed fistfuls of sand at his waist and let the fine grains sift between his tanned fingers. “How about you? You easy?”

Her features fell in horror, but she still held a smile. “How *dare* you. You know I’m not on that list.”

Now Colt smiled, and he agreed: “No, you’re not. Your brother says you’re a good girl. You’re *not* on that list.”

“Thank you,” she said, bringing the hamburger up to her mouth to take another bite.

“You want to be?”

It stopped her from taking the bite, and she laughed, covered her laughing mouth with her bent wrist, her pinky held up in the air. She laughed like she tried not to choke on what she had in her mouth.

“Easy, dude,” Harrison said to him.

“Relax, I’m joking,” Colt said without looking over, his eyes watching Taylor’s breasts jiggle in her bra top as she laughed now, snorting to breathe through her nose.

With regained composure, she sat upright again and flicked her hair away, and, eyes turned down almost as if she were afraid to meet Colt’s gaze, she looked at the hamburger and said, “You wish,” before she took another bite.

Colt surmised her, stifling a sort of smile as he watched her—watched her as she was *obviously* being flirtatious right in front of her boyfriend. He

gave no answer though it hung heavily in the air: *I do wish, Taylor.*

AFTER THEY FINISHED LUNCH—WHICH was done quietly and Harrison was sure Colt was getting off on the discomfort he provided—he bundled up the plates noisily and said he would return them. Taylor nodded, looking a little sullen because she knew she was in trouble.

Up the hill on the deck, he set down the collected plates, stacked them with some others and began to tidy, the whole while watching down the slope at what Taylor would do. Colt didn't leave, which figured, but worse, Taylor didn't shoo him off or pardon herself and come up to join her clearly bothered boyfriend. There were a lot of dishes to be taken care of, but she was crazy if she thought he would do it by himself while she talked to old-ass Colt with his big dick.

He'd heard that rumor, too, that Colt was big, somewhere along the way but didn't remember where. That was years ago. How would his girlfriend have heard that, and why the fuck would she bring it up? Was she thinking about that the whole time she was talking to the guy, doing her flirty things, tossing her hair, showing her half-naked body off and blabbering about surfing?

The whole thing swelled up that jealous rage again and he could feel his grip tightening on a stack of three plates—tight enough that had it been only one plate he would have snapped it in two. He set them down, rested his open palms on the long table with bowls of cold salads and hung his head; turned still to watch her.

Down there in the sun, on the beach with another boy, fuck, hold it, not a boy, a man—a *grown* man. His thighs tensed to steel and his fingers dragged the tablecloth surface as his hands turned to fists. Now his teeth

squeaked in his head as he gritted them. And, oh shit, here came that vision again, just like when he'd thought she'd been alone with Care Bear: the sight of her naked, in bed with Colt, the things he might do to her that neither Taylor nor her sweet, young boyfriend could ever dream of despite the amount of porn her sweet, young boyfriend might watch.

He bit his lower lip on the inside, doing it carefully though his mind raced savagely. It was a thought he hated but couldn't shake. What was worse?—the fact that Colt and his big dick might be able to do things to Taylor he could never do, or the fact that Taylor might be curious about it?

His hand gathered up the front of his shirt and he ran a clenched bunch of scratchy cotton over his chest in hard circles listening to the rasp against the meagre broadcast of soft chest hair he'd sprouted last summer.

Taylor laughed at something Colt said again, tossed her hair, too. Colt cocked his head at her and they watched each other a moment. Taylor put a hand out and planted it in the sand between them, leaning forward a little. Her hair slipped forward and now she turned her head, peeked past her locks, looked up the sloping distance between her and Harrison, expression despondent. Their eyes met, and she gave him a slight wave. He didn't give her one in return. When she turned her head to regard Colt again, her hair hid her face. She resumed talking with her new *friend*.

As Harrison began his tromping march back down the steps to the beach, Colt rose from where he sat and dusted off his shorts, sending off fine plumes of sand. Taylor and Colt said parting words and Colt began to head across the beach making his way toward the boathouse where KC and Rick-Joe were still talking.

As Harrison set foot on the beaten earth at the foot of the stairs, he could see Shelby and Roxie rushing to join Taylor, oblivious of his own approach. It was like they'd been watching from afar and wanted to know what exciting things had transpired between her and this handsome college guy. That dread returned, whirring cold and steely just below his heart. He watched his two friends come and fold themselves around his girlfriend, all long brown legs and arms in bikinis now, like hers but less revealing, getting close and conspiratorial, making their sounds of excited cooing, proving him right in his thoughts on their intention.

What he had to say couldn't wait, and he didn't care right now about being embarrassed so he continued on along the beaten path and onto the

hot sand. Shelby and Roxie stopped talking when they saw him coming, eyes turned up over the tops of their sunglasses to see what he wanted.

With a hand held out for Taylor, he asked her, "Would you come with me, please, for a minute?"

"Yeah," she said, looking up at him. She put her hand out, and he helped her to stand. She motioned for the other two to give her a minute and they nodded.

Her hand held in his, he led her across the soft sand of the beach and up onto the cedar deck that ran around the boathouse and became a dock that struck out maybe thirty feet into the lake.

The Brooks' boathouse was a dark green-painted double bay, sitting on the shoreline and extending out into the water. It had a half second floor, the front portion was a balcony with railings painted in white that looked out over the water below. There were two doors, and Harrison led Taylor into the rear most door, the one closest to the shore. It opened to an oblong room that was separate from the dim double bays. Through a window that separated the room from the bays they could see KC in there with Pontoon and they were standing inside the boat and talking. Stevie sat on a nearby jet ski and joined the conversation with his arms folded over the handlebars of the wave runner as it jostled on the undulating water inside the boathouse. Both bay doors were open and the guys' silhouettes were dark against the bright of the sky and the lake beyond. The front boathouse door opened, the one nearer the lake that opened into the bays, and a dark shape came into the boathouse to the regaling of Pontoon and Rick-Joe. Harrison recognized the muscular, backward-hat shape as Colt.

He reached over and tugged at the dusty curtain printed with arcing bass and fishing lures, covering up the view. Colt might get some satisfaction seeing Harrison giving his flirtatious girlfriend a talking to and he didn't want that.

Shelving units lined all the perimeters of the narrow room, stacked with boxes bulging with cottage-related equipment. It smelled strongly of gasoline and diesel, and the wooden floor was ringed with ancient stains. Taylor had put her back to the window, leaned the small of her back against the waist-high shelf. Her shoulders rested on her father's multi-tiered tackle box. She'd crossed her arms and stared at the stained floor with a sullen expression. He looked down, too, saw her pretty bare feet in her Birkenstocks, a bright sunlight flare on her toe ring.

She muttered, "Harrison, I *know* ..."

"That's good," he muttered, too, mimicking her volume and tone. After a long moment of silence, he said, "What was that, Taylor? Why would you say that?"

"I don't know," she said, still watching the floor. "I was trying to be funny."

"That wasn't funny."

She bounced her eyebrows a little and there was a defiance in it; she wanted to debate whether it was funny or not. She didn't say anything.

He was mad at her. He could feel it now. There was the poignant jealousy still, and an anger, and now he could sense the anger directed at her. Taylor was more than complicit in that escapade, she was provocative. It was *her* instigating Colt's interest, and it was *her* who wasn't dissuading it. She'd encouraged it and nourished it. Sure, he couldn't tell her what to wear, and sure, what a woman wore wasn't 'asking' for anything, but with a guy like Colt around (and, hell, all his football buddies, too) their reaction was to be expected. Even looking at her right now, her long, thin, and tanned body stretched out in the dim of this room reeking of nauseating gas his thoughts of her were sexual. The tone of her muscle, the sweep of her thighs, the flat of her stomach. She'd bared it all, and he was a victim to that presented sexuality; she provoked uncontrollable feelings emanating from the core of his masculinity, drawing up thoughts and impulses from the two powerful objects that hung under his wang. And now that thought prompted another unwanted notion: how big were Colt's balls and did Taylor ever wonder that as well? It made him wince, and he shifted uncomfortably. A swelling began down below and he couldn't parse it. But it seemed to send off his next line of query—he asked her: "Did your sister sleep with him or something?"

"Colt?—yeah," she said.

"And she told you he had a big one?"

She shook her head no.

"She didn't?"

"No. Another girl did."

"You guys really talk about that stuff?"

Now she looked to him and while he saw a softness in her eyes, her words came out and punched him in the mouth. "I can tell you, like, four guys at school who are supposed to have a big dick."

His jaw dropped, and that rage roared up in him and he pictured himself charging to her, looming and intimidating, taking things off the shelves and smashing them on the floor at her feet. His lips parted, and he struggled to speak. She'd bewildered him.

She said, "It's not a big deal, Harrison. I mean, I know it is, or might be, but it's not."

His gaze drifted over her pretty face as he struggled to comprehend her words, or her apparent carelessness with them. Revenge occurred to him and he considered telling her how he understood because, you know, he liked to jerk off to Roxie's much nicer tits. *Her tits are much better than yours, Taylor, practically perfect; bigger, fuller, I think all men would choose hers over your little pathetic nubbins. You bitch.*

Light streaming in from the open bays behind her and ambient light from the backside of the boathouse came in and painted white traces on the contours of her face and put daubs of shimmering light in the gray of her dazzling eyes. It made him powerless. He would never say a thing like that to her, it was just ego coming in and lashing out because it had been zapped. A ruler had told him he was fine, gaging against results on the internet, and that he fell almost directly on the line of what was most expected when a young woman like Taylor might look into a guy's underwear. That didn't chase away what he saw almost daily in porn, and he knew of at least one guy in his gym class (maybe one of the four his girlfriend knew about, too—wouldn't that be great?) who dangled something almost unreal. He wanted to ask her if size was the kind of thing she liked to think about but wasn't sure he was prepared for the answer so instead he pushed that query back down to the darkness from where it came.

Back on track, he said, "It was like you were flirting with him."

"I wasn't."

"I bet he thinks you were."

"But I wasn't."

"I think you were."

She rolled her eyes a little and tucked her chin to her chest, her sad mouth turning down in the corners.

In a quiet voice, she said, "I love you, you know."

He wished he didn't say it, but he did: "Are we over?"

Shock took her expression, and it lightened him instantly. She looked up at him and said, "What?—are you crazy? No. Harrison, do you want us to

be over?”

Now he had her and he felt his heart beating sweet life again.

“We’re going to different schools. We’re going to different schools and this is how you act on the last weekend we have together.”

“We said we would make it work.”

He was trying to lure her to him, wanted her to come and soothe him since she’d bruised him so badly but she stayed leaning on the shelf with her arms crossed. He said, “Can we?”

Her brow furrowed, and she said, “You’re breaking up with me?”

“No.”

“Then why are you talking like this?”

“I don’t even feel like we’re together today.”

It made her close her eyes and shake her head softly, disagreeing with him. When her eyes opened again, she said, “We are, Harrison, I swear. There’s so many people here, I have to be social. I saw you last night. We spent all night together. This morning you took my virginity all over again. I’ll see you tomorrow. All day. You’re acting like I’m ignoring you.”

“You are, kind of,” he said, enjoying seeing her on the defensive.

Now she got mad, getting off the shelf and facing him, her posture tilted toward him, and gesturing with angry stabs of her hands. “Jesus, Harrison. No, I’m not. For fuck’s sake, if I spend all my time with you then I’m rude to the guests, if I spend just a little time with the guests then we’re breaking up? Put some more pressure on me, *please*.”

“It’s not like that.”

“You can’t share me just a little bit?”

“I can share you.”

“You sure? You’re acting like a possessive asshole right now.”

“I’m sorry.”

It stung, and a tide of trouble began to rise up from his ankles as they stood there quietly and he watched her and she looked at the floor.

“It’s going to kill me when we go to separate schools,” he whispered.

Taylor hid her face in her hands. “Could I just please have a good time tonight without feeling like I’m letting you down? Is that okay with you?”

He stepped closer and rubbed his hand in a circle over her fine bronze shoulder. “Yes,” he told her.

FOR OVER AN HOUR, he left Taylor alone to be with her friends and he didn't bug her. A few times he checked on her to see what she and the others were up to. It was nothing. Hanging out and sitting in the sand with Kelsey Kay, Roxie, and Shelby. They went in the water and splashed around together. She went with her sister and Cookie to swim out to the floating dock and the three of them laid out there and sunned themselves. He played volleyball with Cisco, Mikey, and Jamie, too, which was a good way to kill an hour and still be nearby to watch Taylor and also for her to see him around. He made sure whenever she was nearby he was exuberant and vocal, and he would disregard her even though he knew he was being watched. *See, Taylor—I'm cool as a cucumber, you can't rattle me and I know my value.* Wasn't true on the inside, but if she ever got a good look on the inside, she would run screaming in the opposite direction.

After two in the afternoon and his football buddies were done fucking around, KC was looking to take anyone for a tow. Taylor had dragged out her waterski and the other girls brought out the guest sets and an inflatable inner tube that Cisco had helped them inflate with a battery-operated compressor.

The initial shock of seeing her in the thong wore away, and he got used to it. It seemed that the others did, too, but he'd occasionally catch one of KC's group checking out Roxie, Shelby, and Taylor. Kelsey Kay sometimes as well, but less so because her bikini wasn't as revealing and she had an obvious boyfriend that they liked and was hanging around with them. Kelsey Kay also put out a *Don't fucking look at me* vibe, and he wished Taylor could muster a little of that herself. Taylor seemed to be giving out

the opposite vibe. Stevie, Rick-Joe, Pontoon, and Colt picked it up and they could get flirty with her sometimes. He caught a few interactions where he found them all laughing together and Taylor tossing her hair around. Care Bear, at least, seemed to keep his distance, was sort of aloof with them except for Roxie who looked like she had a bit of a crush on the guy even though he was maybe three times her size, four years older, and had a beard as thick as an animal's pelt. Those overheard words would haunt him sometimes when he saw them together. "*Is the Bear going to fuck her?*" It was an almost sickening thought, but for some reason it kind of charged him up, too. Roxie was a long-leg stick like Taylor—what would she look like underneath that beast? And what did he have between his legs? A slender girl like Roxie couldn't handle that, could she? Of course she could, he figured, he'd seen it many times online, tiny girls taking very large men. The thought would sometimes pump him up and he'd have to tug at his shorts to straighten out his affairs—which was terrible because Roxie was his friend and he'd known her since they were nine.

Roxie, Kelsey Kay, Shelby, and Taylor went out first. KC drove the boat, Rick-Joe with a can of beer was in charge of the tow. He saw Shelby sneak a pull off his Rolling Rock and get caught but Rick-Joe didn't care. They went out for half an hour and Harrison bowed out of another volleyball game, preferring to sit in the sand on the outskirts of a loose group of Riley, Cookie, Jamie, April, and Cisco. Mostly he watched what happened out on the water as each of the girls took a turn on skis. It felt pretty safe because KC was out there with her and wouldn't want any of his college friends touching his little sister, and Colt was safely on shore. He watched with a nervous knot in his stomach, just the same.

WHEN IT WAS her turn because no one wanted to try waterskiing—not when they had a big old fun and bouncy inner tube instead—they all watched as she sat on the back of the boat and readied her ski. It was a slalom mono, a gift from her father after she won the Michigan State youth comp in 2013. A super-narrow Syndicate Pro, a sleek piece of aeronautical carbon-fiber that took her most of 2014 to figure out how to stay up on. It was sharp and fast and angled like a demon but it was so racy it was like she had to learn how to ski all over again. Dad kept her at it, and by August she was carving like a junior pro and she won the age-group again that summer. But the next year she didn't even ski at all and she was just a bitch to her dad *all* the time. Then high school started and the next thing you know Dad was moving out. Fucking Harrison bringing it up down on the beach—it was hard enough coming here in the first place, she didn't need pointed reminders, thank you, buddy.

Behind her, KC said, “Look out everybody, it's the hotshot. She's getting her custom ski on.”

They were mid-lake, and the pressure was on, all eyes on her. The water was pretty chopped but she could handle it, she hoped. Nobody on this boat but her could do a deep water start anyway, so they were easy to impress, but still she felt the tension begin to twist and she wanted to lash out and make them all look away. She bit her tongue.

She said, “Aw, come on, KC, I hardly go out ever, anymore.”

“Hardly?”

“Geez, like not at all. I probably can't even ski anymore.”

“The talk of the forever-sandbagger,” KC said toward the sky. He held a coolie cup with the neck of a High-Life poked up out of it. His butt leaned on the boat’s steering wheel and he couldn’t help looking like an overly muscular version of their dad.

“Fuck off,” she muttered and as she turned back her left foot grazed the saddle of her waterski. *Ah, fuck.* That was as bad as putting your left foot in first and even Pythagoras knew that was bad luck.

KC taunted her: “You want the thirty-five rope, hotshot?”

“No, KC. Don’t. Just leave me alone.”

She rubbed the back of her wrist against her forehead and hoped they weren’t looking at her. You couldn’t just put your right foot in now like the left foot never touched it. She hunched forward and hid her face while she spat in the saddle. That removed the curse, as legend told, and now she put her right foot into the binding with her left held far away and safe.

The anger was back, and she said over her shoulder, “Give me the thirty-five rope, asshole.”

“Uh-oh,” KC sang, “Tay-tay’s mad.”

She hissed, “I need the boat at thirty-six—you think you’re man enough to get it up to thirty-six?”

KC said, “I’ve never had problems getting it up, Tay.”

Roxie interjected: “Not what I heard.”

The girls and even Pontoon admired the zinger with a lowing sound and watched to see how KC would react.

KC said, “Your mom did everything she could, Rox, but the way your dad was watching me and stroking himself just freaked me the fuck out.”

Roxie laughed but her face went wide with horror and disbelief that he would say something like that. “Are you kidding me? That’s *so* mean ... I can’t believe you said that ...”

“Hey, don’t make fun of a guy not getting it up. You punch low, I punch low.”

“Yeah, but a joke about my mom ...?”

KC smiled at her as she folded her arms protectively like she’d been physically injured by his joke. He said, “It’s kind of more of a joke about your *dad*, really—your mom is hot, I’d totally get it up for your mom ...”

“You’re *eee-vil*,” Roxie said, wounded, but KC had got her laughing again and now he took her in a hug and whispered in her ear. Roxie tugged herself away and acted like she was still mad but she wasn’t.

Rituals complete, Taylor looked at her happy friends and forced a smile. “I’m ready,” she said, and hoped to God she was.

THE GIRLS CAME BACK to the dock with boisterous laughter and yelling that he heard before they even got to shore. Climbing out of the boat's cabin, taking turns, Taylor turned and shoved Shelby off the back of the boat when it was her turn to step off. Shelby tried to save herself but eventually toppled, going with it and kicking her legs high so she ended up doing a dive. KC yelled at Taylor for being an idiot because the motor was still running. She told him to relax, and he bear-hugged her like he would throw her off as well. Taylor's scream was high-pitched and sharp and KC laughed and let her go, kicked her almost-bare ass as she climbed out, making her giggle and run away. He scolded her and told her to put on some pants; joking, but kind of serious, too. Then he lamented that hugging her had got his T-shirt wet.

Harrison met Kelsey Kay at the entrance of the dock and she was wringing her silver hair out. When he approached she swung her wet, tangled mane at him, trying to get him wet but he deflected it with his hands, saying, "How was it out there?"

"Fun," she said. "Your girlfriend is *so* unbelievably good."

"I know," he said. "You ski?"

"No, we went on the tube. We watched Taylor rip it up for a bit and KC tried to shake her off but he couldn't."

Over Kelsey Kay's shoulder he watched as Roxie and Taylor helped Shelby out of the water and up onto the deck, each hoisting her by holding one of her hands. Once safely on the deck, Shelby made like she would throw Taylor into the lake now, but Taylor turned her back to her and hunched her shoulders, yelling, "Don't, don't, I'm sorry, I'm sorry." Shelby

hooked a long forearm around Taylor's neck like she would choke her but didn't. Instead, she let go, let Taylor get one full stride ahead of her, arm winding way, way back. Then she hauled off with an open palm slap across Taylor's ass cheek, the sound so loud and so wet it echoed under the low canopy of the shoreline maples quadruple-fold. It made Taylor's flesh shake, and she yelped. Her mouth pulled back to a ring, lips peeled in an O over her white teeth. Stevie had come out of the frontward boathouse door at the exact moment and he laughed and pointed. As a coup de grâce, Shelby tugged the string of Taylor's bikini top with the flare of a magician.

The turquoise triangles of Taylor's bikini top slumped and clung loosely to her bosom. Taylor jumped realizing what her friend had done, and both her brown nipples showed for an instant. Now Stevie had seen her bare breasts as well. She screamed, laughing at the same time, clutched the material over her breasts, and trotted out of Shelby's reach. Kelsey Kay laughed as well and closed the distance between them. Taylor turned her back seeing her coming and hunched forward. Kelsey Kay retied the knot for her. Shelby was keeping her distance, giving Taylor a threatening fist and a mean smile. Taylor shouted at her, "You bitch." Taylor's pale ass cheek showed a red hand print.

Stevie clapped his hands like he was applauding. Then behind Stevie, idling a jet ski out was Colt. He had his sunglasses on and his baseball hat backwards. His tanned face was turned up to see what was happening on the dock. He saw the girls gathered, and he gave a startlingly loud wolf whistle at them. They giggled, and Roxie wagged her bottom at him. He gave her an OK sign. Stevie then joined the four girls and said, "Who wants to go for a jet ski ride?" Shelby threw up her hand like it was a classroom and she had an answer to the question. But she didn't wait to be picked, instead sitting down at the edge of the dock and waving Colt to come over and get her. Stevie said to Taylor, "How about you?"

Kelsey Kay had waved them off and was returning to the front of the dock. Beyond Kelsey's shoulder, Harrison could see Taylor turning and giving him a sheepish look. He just watched her.

Kelsey joined him, standing next to him and watching down the dock. She said to Taylor, "You going?"

Taylor kind of shrugged, and said, "I don't know." She made eye contact with Harrison and he hated that she was confronting him like this. She had to know what he thought given the conversation in the boathouse.

He was reluctant to tell her no, just staring at her in disbelief that she would challenge him so soon after they had a good talk. Stevie stood waiting, that body bared and rippling.

Kelsey Kay said to him quietly, “Are you kidding me? Harrison, let her go.” It was direct and straightforward—and she was right, what kind of guy would stop someone from doing something? That would be a guy who had no pull. No strength in his relationship. And he didn’t want to be like that.

“Yeah, go,” he said not quite convincingly, but he waved at her shooping her away. It made her beam, and she flashed a smile at him. He couldn’t help it—he smiled back.

Now he stood with Kelsey and watched as Taylor went side-by-side with Stevie down the five steps to get to the water’s edge. There was a jet ski tied there, and he got on first, waiting for her to join him. It was crazy, watching her go. Watching her go off with another guy and barely wearing anything. From the back it was like she only wore strings. And here she was, long legs extending to get herself onto the jet ski and she clutched against another guy. Pressed her bare and naked body to Stevie’s bare and naked back. She kept her hands on her spread knees. Stevie was a muscular guy, and Taylor was aware—she’d let Rox know exactly what his body was doing to her heart. He didn’t want to let her go off with him, but couldn’t be the kind of guy to stop her. It was harmless, wasn’t it?

With the jet ski in a low idle, Colt led the way from shore, Shelby clung to his back with her arms hooked around to hold his chest, and then once they were about forty feet from the dock, they opened them up, sending sparkling white rooster tails into the blue sky and darting toward the horizon at full speed. Taylor had put her arms around Stevie as they accelerated and held him like Shelby had held Colt.

Kelsey nudged him now, and said, “Come on and join me, come and sit with me.” She waved a plastic puck of Skoal at him. Sometimes she liked to chew, especially in the summer, and he would occasionally join her. It was a perfect reason to go and sit at the end of the dock and keep an eye on his girlfriend while she was out with those two good-looking college guys.

HE LET Kelsey Kay get ahead of him on the dock and watched her walk. She was shorter than the other girls and had a fuller figure, but she brimmed with confidence. She was curvy and shapely; her bathing suit was nowhere near as revealing as Taylor's, but she still attracted attention. Her long silvery hair had gone a flat gray color with the wet, and the pink tips had turned a deep rose. She walked along, tossing the puck of chewing tobacco up and down and catching it, sometimes drumming a little beat on its top with the fingers of her other hand. Beside them, KC was in the boat waiting on the next batch of fun-seekers and the deck shuddered under his feet as Riley, Jamie, Cookie, and probably Cisco, maybe even Mikey, trotted up from the beach and onto the decking.

At the end of the dock, Kelsey Kay sat herself down with her legs hanging over the edge. He joined her, sitting down right next to her so their shoulders touched. The boat began revving as he started to say something and he held the words back, the two of them looking at each other and smiling as twin Volvo motors roared behind them. The boat went in gear, still revving loudly but traveling at slow speed. As it came along next to them they turned to look and saw everyone giving them solemn and blank faces, Cisco in the back hugging the huge inner tube. Before he caught on, he shrugged to them and said, "What?"

In unison, five people flicked bottle caps at them and he protected Kelsey Kay and put up a hand to cover his eyes. They all laughed and none of the caps hit them. The boat went into action, roaring loudly, hunkering down and shooting off into the depths of the lake with a wet, guttural drone.

"Assholes," he said to Kelsey.

“Tell me about it.”

She pried open the lid of the puck and Harrison saw that they were prepackaged Bandits because Kelsey Kay was a lady. She plucked one of the pouches, passed it to him and he popped it in his cheek. She did the same.

It was lively out on the Wolf today. Not just the Brooks’ jet skis and the Brooks’ boats, but many others out there as well. Jet skis zipping along silently on the far shore and big boats out in the middle of the lake. Off to the right-hand side there was some sort of conclave of boats all gathered around in what looked like a ring, some sort of party happening out there. On the left-hand side of their view was a small island maybe almost five-hundred yards away. The house that had been on it burned down maybe ten years ago or so, just before the first year he’d come up here. During a winter, it had burned down when the owner came up with his hunting buddies and somebody fell asleep with a cigarette. Burned the whole thing down to sticks. Nothing had been built in its place yet. The island had a boathouse as well, a big single-bay that looked in need of some serious care. It was left untouched by the fire, and Taylor’s dad told him the owners of the island would never tear it down despite how crooked it might get. You couldn’t build a new boathouse these days what with the updated environmental laws, but *old* boat houses were grandfathered in. The guy was trying to sell the property and the boathouse would be a great feature.

Kelsey Kay shielded her eyes from the sun with a saluting hand and squinted at the horizon. He did as well, looking out to see where Taylor was. The jet skis were far and he couldn’t tell which one was which. As long as they were moving he felt pretty good about it. He didn’t like thinking of Taylor’s arms around Stevie. Especially given what she’d written in her text to Roxie. In fact, he would have liked to prevent her from going, and would have if Kelsey Kay hadn’t intervened. Now he was regretting it. He worked his fingertips over his palms, his hands in curled, tense cups.

Kelsey Kay leaned forward and let out a stream of spit. He followed suit, aiming to project his further.

He said to her, “Where’s Brady?”

“I don’t know.”

Harrison turned and looked back at the beach. Waist-deep in the water, Care Bear and Brady tossed a football back and forth.

He returned to face the horizon and said, "He's playing football with that big guy."

"That's good."

"You guys okay?"

"Yeah, we're fine. I'm done with him."

It made him laugh, and he had to push his tongue up so he wouldn't swallow the pouch of chewing tobacco. He said, "You're done with him?"

"Yeah, he was fun."

"But his time's up?"

"He gets on my nerves a little."

"Everybody gets on your nerves a little. I get on your nerves a little." He spat out into the water.

"That's true, but I don't fuck you."

"Your loss."

She laughed, then said, "That's not what I heard."

He knew she was joking, she did it to him all the time, but somehow after all the shit today his defenses were weak and watery and that jab got him right in the bread basket. "What did you hear?" he asked, playing along a little, but curious to see what his question might provoke from her. Curious and worried.

"Huh?" she turned and looked at him sideways, her brow lowered with meanness.

"What did she tell you?"

"Taylor? About you? Nothing. Gross. She started to tell me, I'd stop her."

The tension relaxed, and he joked, "Afraid you'd get jealous at what you're missing?"

"Sure," she said, and instead of being mean now, she leaned forward and pulled her hair back so she could spit, then with her forearms on her thighs, she regarded him, squinting but smiling. She said, "How are you guys doing?"

"Me and Taylor? We're good." With that said, he peered off to the horizon, his hand shielding the sun.

"You don't like seeing her out with those guys ..."

"You were the one said I should let her go."

"You should."

"I did."

“There’s going to be a *lot* of guys out in California.”

He said, “What does that mean?” Now he regarded her and that sick twist had returned below his stomach.

“You’re going to have to be a cool cucumber, Harrison. You might as well get used to it.”

“Did she tell you anything?”

“About what?”

“I don’t know. About going out there without me. About our relationship.”

“She said you were going to try to make it work.”

“Try?”

Still with that smile, she studied his face for a long time and they said nothing. She blinked and watched him, that smile never faltering. The waves washed to shore and lapped at the supports of the dock below their feet. At last she said, “I did you a favor. Let Taylor go and do what she wants to do. You try to stop Taylor, control Taylor, she’ll run you over. You’re too good to get run over.”

“She won’t run me over.”

“She won’t if you’re not standing in her way.”

“Do you think I’m standing in her way?”

“No, but it’s like you’re wandering around on the road with your earbuds in and your head down. Look up, look around.”

“I’m not stupid,” he said.

Far out on the lake, the jet skis zipped back and forth. On one of those machines his girlfriend sat with her arms around a jacked-up good-looking college guy who she’d texted to Roxie the squeal that she was ‘falling in love’ with his body. It was a joke, but it hurt him. He’d let that wash off his back though, didn’t even mention it to her. His head was up.

He said, “We’re not using condoms anymore.”

Kelsey Kay nodded, watching the horizon. “She told me.”

With the words out in the open and Kelsey Kay’s sedate response the truth of it came to him. It had been there the whole time, bubbling at the bottom of his pot, but now reality was beginning to rustle the surface. *His girlfriend was going on the pill as she headed off to college.*

A sickness worked through him and he hunched over. Disguising his sudden emotional response, he sent out a good long squittering blast of tobacco-spit that arced into the water like a leaping salmon.

Kelsey Kay chuckled and whispered, "Good one."

He nodded and sat upright despite the cramping in his stomach.

The sound of the jet skis' drone came and went with the wind. One time they got closer to shore and they could both hear Taylor whooping, and Shelby yelling something excitedly.

Kelsey Kay said, "You guys have been together a long time."

"Yeah, we have."

"How long have you been dating?"

"It's, like, two-and-a-half years now."

"And you've known each other how long?"

"Forever. Since, what?—Grade 5? Nine years, ten years. She's my best friend."

"That's a long time for you guys to be together."

"Is that a bad thing? What has she said to you?"

"She hasn't said anything."

"Are you sure? Because it's like you're trying to break something to me."

"You're my friend. But you gotta see."

"See what?"

"You guys have been together a long time, and now you're going to be apart ..."

"So?"

They watched each other's faces for a few heartbeats then she changed the subject. "We going to hang out at Michigan State?"

"Sure. But seriously, what are you getting at? Are you trying to tell me that Taylor's going to cheat on me? Has she said that to you?"

"I told you she didn't tell me anything. But..." She let it hang. And now she couldn't look him in the eyes, her shoulders lightly shrugging and her eyes rolling around looking up at the clouds.

"But what?"

"She could've gone to Michigan state."

"She didn't get in."

Kelsey Kay gave him her best *seriously?* face, pursing her lips in a wriggling line and tenting her eyebrows while her head was cocked. "Bull shit," she said.

"You're telling me she got in?"

“She gets into Santa Cruz but she doesn’t get into Michigan State? Her SATs were fine.”

His insides had constrained to hard jagged shapes that pressed against his skin. He said, “Well, then she lied to me.”

Kelsey Kay leaned over her knees and spit a long brown stream into the lake. “She loves you.”

“Loves me enough to lie to me?”

“Maybe. She doesn’t want to hurt your feelings.”

“She doesn’t want to break up with me.”

“Harrison. Maybe I’m really fucking wrong. But I don’t think I am.”

“So she’s your friend and you’re gonna throw her under the bus like this? Say shitty things about her to her boyfriend, tell her boyfriend she’s purposely going to a different school, so, like, she can get away from him. Fuck you, Kay. Seriously, fuck you. You’re just causing shit. You always do that, always *needling* people.” His pinched fingers wriggled around inside his cheek, yanked out the sopping wet Bandit. He flicked it into the lake, shook his head. Now he just got up, drew his heels underneath him and stood.

Kelsey Kay didn’t care. She stayed looking out over the water, always too superior to fight. *Fuck her.*

He left her there at the end of the dock, turning his back on his girlfriend as well (who he apparently should be keeping an eye on), and stomped back along the deck, past Brady and *The Bear* (who might fuck his friend Roxie tonight), hated his own thoughts right now, and he ran up the stairs to the house and up to the kitchen.

WHILE PUTTERING around the kitchen it began to grate on him how he'd been a dick to Kelsey Kay. Those dumb, defensive words kept playing back in his ears and it made him feel foolish. The things she said sure pricked at him, but she wasn't provoking him. The understanding she had of the situation between him and Taylor wasn't as broad as his (she said Taylor had told her nothing), but admittedly, he wished his understanding of the situation could be a little better, too. He was positive that Taylor didn't have all the answers either. This was the greatest challenge their relationship had ever faced and instead of confronting it, they'd let it turn gray and milky, despite neither of them trying to stir it too much.

The second cooler he and Taylor brought was filled with chicken breasts and pork, and store-bought hamburger patties. The contents had been transferred to the pantry fridge, and he brought them out to the kitchen and began to season them; just doing it to keep his hands busy. They were defrosted already now from the ride in the cooler and sitting in the fridge. Once that was done, he sealed them back up in their containers and put them all back in the pantry fridge.

Back at the sink and washing poultry off his hands, he watched out the window that looked down the slope and the beach; a big sunny view of the lake. The jet skis were zipping along nearer to shore now and strafing the floating dock where Care Bear stood, Brady floating in the water next to it on the shore-side. The swimming dock was about eight-by-eight, and Care Bear made it look tiny. He had his shirt off now, just wearing swim shorts. He was furred all over and bulged with muscle. His stomach was a little round looking but somehow not flabby. He had his arm cocked with the

football in it and now he looked to peg one of the jet skis. Colt and Stevie both raced nearby taunting him because he only had one chance.

Also coming back to shore was KC and the motor boat. The inner tube bounced and jounced behind him and there was a tangle of arms and legs on it holding on for dear life. Three people on it, maybe four, but it was too distant to tell who was who, but the laughter and yelling that he could hear even through the glass was a mix of boys and girls.

One thing that struck him now, and it got his stomach flinching: he saw Stevie laughing and taunting Care Bear, pointing a finger and daring him to throw; his wet brown hair swept back from his face, Taylor clinging to his bare body. Only it *wasn't* Taylor who rode with him. That was Shelby's long brown arms hooped around his mid-section. Now his eyes darted to the other jet ski to see that Taylor rode with Colt. Colt had his shirt off, too, and Taylor laughed and taunted Care Bear along with him, and her bare hands were spread wide on Colt's hard, flat stomach. They were low enough to touch the waist of his shorts.

"Aw, Taylor," he sighed to the empty kitchen, and winced. His heart had been in a real workout today and somehow after the initial jump at the sight of her with her hands on Colt, he didn't feel lightheaded and its beat didn't get thready, instead he saw it as part of a bigger picture. One Kelsey Kay had prepared him for. *Get used to it, Harrison*. Taylor would have friends soon he didn't know, she would meet all sorts of girls and guys and forge friendships that would probably last a lifetime. *Without him*. He wouldn't be the one to prevent that. An asshole would do that, and he wasn't an asshole.

Seeing her happy and laughing, engaged in horseplay with boys he didn't really know twisted at him, but what was worse was that he could believe that she chose not to go to State. But why? And why not just tell him she wanted to go to California? Was it because he hadn't applied there?—and if she knew all along she wanted to go away without him, did she know back when they were applying? She could just *tell* him what she wanted. He would listen. Did she think he wouldn't?

All the things they discussed about being away and apart (and it wasn't very much) had been how they would make it work. Why would she do that if she didn't intend it to be true? He didn't think Taylor could lie to his face. Not without him knowing.

Now he could see Kelsey Kay walking along the beach with her arms folded over her chest and he felt bad that he had said such mean things to

her. She was his friend, and he lashed out when she was just trying to have a conversation. She stopped and watched everyone coming back in, her feet planted in the hot sand. He wound the window open with its lever and the pane stretched out. A breeze passed his face, and he could hear their voices more clearly.

As Colt and Taylor swooped by the swimming dock again, Care Bear finally rifled the ball and it went like a shot but had a bit of a wobble. Colt and Taylor whisked their heads away and Taylor hugged herself to him tightly, pressing her almost bare body tightly to his naked back.

The throw was off, but not by much, and as Colt looped the jet ski around he pointed at Care Bear and laughed. His yelling voice traveled up through the open window, telling Care Bear he was a fatso with a shit arm. Colt slowed the jet ski near the bobbing football and Taylor bent to retrieve it.

They came in slowly to the dock and Care Bear held out a hand to help Taylor off. She was hoisted up easily and Harrison jolted as her tiny bra shifted sideways and both her nipples were bared. She laughed and jumped up, bouncing on her toes. The football was passed to Care Bear, and she adjusted her top. Care Bear and Colt exchanged a brief smiling look.

He dried his hands with a tea towel and continued to watch. Stevie and Shelby drew near on their wave runner but not close enough to have the ball thrown. Taylor encouraged Colt to throw, wanting to see if he could hit them, even clutching his shoulder once, her thin hands curving over his muscle. Care Bear turned and while he was standing next to Taylor, he shoved his shorts right down to his knees and bared his moon to Stevie and Shelby. Taylor looked down, his bare ass a half foot away, and she laughed and covered her eyes. It wasn't impossible that she'd seen the guys hanging ball sack and now his stomach tightened again. He adjusted his shorts, feeling an awkward surge in his cock that made no sense.

Stevie bailed eventually, probably knowing Colt had a much better arm than Care Bear, and he tied his jet ski to the dock and helped Shelby up, his hands on her ass and thighs and Shelby didn't seem to mind at all. No pseudo-karate on handsome Stevie with the swoon-inducing body.

KC brought the boat into the dock and Stevie helped tie it off to a cleat as the gang disembarked raucously and trotted along the dock and onto the beach. Colt tossed the football and Pontoon ran on the shore to catch it, jumping into the water with it clutched to his chest. Colt and Care Bear

began enjoining the others for a game of football in the waist-high water and Taylor swum to shore. Kelsey Kay stood waiting for her on the beach.

They had his attention now, and he watched as Taylor came up out of the lake, water streaming down her gleaming body, pulling her wet hair back from her face. Her eyes were on Kelsey Kay and she was listening to something she was saying. Her expression showed concern. The two of them got close together and talked. Cisco and Mikey passed them, moving along into the shade and up the beaten path to climb the stairs back up to the house. Taylor squeezed her hair out and the concern on her face became a sort of sadness. She shrugged a lot and shook her head. He wondered if they talked about what had happened between him and Kelsey Kay on the dock. It was most likely, but he wondered what it meant. Had the two girls talked before about this? Was it possible that Kelsey Kay had been ordered by Taylor to do the breaking up for her but flubbed it?

A sickness worked into him again and his shoulders felt suddenly heavy. The basement door thumped closed under his feet and he heard Mikey and Cisco laughing about something.

When they came up the stairs, he'd forced his face into a false expression of good humor.

"There he is," Cisco said as they came into the kitchen.

Mikey said, "Hey, you need some help?"

He nodded and smiled but couldn't speak for fear of the intense hurt showing up in his voice.

MIKEY AND CISCO spent half an hour with him prepping food for dinner and making s'mores that they could cook on the fire. The work and the camaraderie helped take his mind off Taylor. Soon the uneasiness in him settled, and he was back to thinking this was an overreaction on his part. If Taylor wanted to break up, she would tell him. Sure, it might throw doubt to think things like she just wanted this last weekend to go smooth and then she would break up with him on Sunday, but he'd given her the opportunity to break up when they were in the boathouse and she didn't take it. In fact, she was adamant that they had said they would make it work. Thinking that Kelsey Kay was supposed to be the breakup agent was just his mind playing games since all the jealous provocations he'd encountered seeing Taylor with the college guys. They would figure it out somehow, and he would take Kelsey Kay's *good* advice: *You're going to have to be a cool cucumber, Harrison.*

Once the food was prepped, he left Cisco and Mikey in the kitchen, went out the side door and grabbed an armful of kindling. It was late afternoon, and though it would be four or five hours before it was dark it might be nice to have the fire going. He dumped the kindling by the fire pit which was halfway down the slope between the patio and the beach and tucked away to the side. It was a flat area with rough flagstones that were mostly hidden under a bed of soft pine needles. A dozen Adirondack chairs circled a deep pit lined with jagged suitcase-sized granite boulders.

Down the slope twenty yards or so, Kelsey Kay sat in the sand with Taylor in her tiny bikini. She had her Solo cup again, and he wondered if

she had it spiked. It was best to push that thought away. Cool cucumbers didn't nag their girls, they let them have fun.

Most importantly, whatever tense conversation had transpired between Kay and Taylor when she arrived off the jet ski was over with, and both of them now were in obvious good moods. They watched the college guys play football. Brady had joined in, and it reminded him how Kelsey Kay had said she was done with him. There was something satisfying in that, and he wasn't sure what it was. Like, maybe it confirmed to him Brady was an empty kind of guy and Kelsey Kay had been with him just for his body. Girls could use guys for sex, too, it wasn't just boys who did that. That should be frightening but it was somehow comforting. Harrison was 'keeper' material, of that he was sure. No one would use him for his body. A girl who loved him did so because of the whole experience. As Taylor had said in the boathouse: *No one could love me like you do.*

The football game continued near the shore, all the guys having fun and running as best they could through almost waist-high water. Shirts were off and muscles gleamed and the girls watched. Including Taylor.

There were two teams; KC, Stevie, and Pontoon on one side, Colt, Rick-Joe, and Kelsey Kay's Brady on the other. Care Bear sat on the floating dock with a six-pack and reffed, or something, hurling insults against both teams. Taylor leaned close to Kelsey Kay, and they both laughed about something then applauded a good tackle. He was pretty sure it was Stevie they watched and whispered about. His shorts rode a little low, and he had great abs and those deep lines that led down toward his cock from his hip bones that girls always seemed to go extra kooky for.

Whatever. *Cool cucumber, Harrison, remember.* If he was down on the beach with his friends and it was girls' volleyball happening, he'd be a little pie-eyed, too, and elbowing his buddies. Taylor didn't know he was close behind her, just let her have fun.

There was some good dry cedar that was cut and split and stacked up at the stone wall of the house, underneath the kitchen windows. Trish had some guy from the Wolf Lake area who got it ready for the summer season for them.

He went up there and gathered a couple arm loads, bringing them down and plopping them around the fire pit. There was more uproarious laughter from the beach, and he could see now the ball had landed up in the sand. It was Riley who had everybody laughing. She had the ball cocked back and

looked to throw it at someone. The girls laughed, but the guys playing football were bold and taunting, looking like even if she could manage to hit one of them it wouldn't even hurt, anyway. Some of them saying Come on, go ahead, some of them warning her that she didn't want to do that. Care Bear jumped to his feet on the swimming dock, his beer almost toppling over as it bounced on the waves with his weight. He hoisted his pants down again, no balls seen, bared his ass at Riley for a target. He slapped his own cheeks and challenged her.

Riley laughed, took aim, trotted three girlish steps and winged the ball as hard as she could. It was nowhere near Care Bear. It shot up almost straight in the air and to the right, going and over and, and the guys laughed at her. She told them to Fuck off and tumbled back to her beach blanket where she'd been sitting with Cookie and April. Taylor was clapping for her sister, saying, "Next time, Riley."

Harrison got back to work and set up a nice teepee in the center of old ashes that had been left in a tufted mound in the center of the fire pit. He brought down a rolled up newspaper to tear strips off it and thatch a nest underneath his teepee. There was more yelling down at the beach, and he looked. There was taunting going on, some finger-pointing and some challenge made—though he didn't follow what had happened.

Some wager had been issued between the two teams. Stevie yelled out, You're on, and gave them a deadeye. Pontoon had been drinking as well, and Harrison watched as he walked backward with his team yanking down the front of his trunks, reaching in and pulling out his dick. He wagged it at Stevie threateningly. Stevie covered his face as if he'd been splashed with acid. The girls laughed uproariously.

That sick flinch fluttered through Harrison's stomach again. Taylor had *seen* that. Taylor had watched another guy take his penis out and wave it around. Pontoon wasn't super huge or anything, but he definitely had nothing to worry about. The image burned like a phosphorescent print even when he closed his eyes. Now a chant began.

Ste-vie, Ste-vie, Ste-vie, Ste-vie ...

Harrison looked up to see the girls wanting Stevie to take his pants down to show them what he had. Taylor chanted and clapped her hands with the rest of the gaggle. Stevie waved them off, and he was laughing. Colt laughed, too, punching Stevie in the shoulder.

Harrison had to get down on both knees and take a deep breath. He was split with rage and jealousy. But he couldn't deny there was something in it that was exciting. Something about seeing his girlfriend being so bad put a thrill inside him that he hated. But at least it was like a relief valve. Maybe that's all it was. He just witnessed something so terrible that if this were caveman days, he would grab her by the hair and drag her away from there. Probably given her a good clubbing or something, whatever it was the Neanderthals did. But his modern and civilized mind found an escape route. Found appreciation for her femaleness, respected her desire for naughty fun—it was pretty much just like that when he was with the guys. There was even something strangely *arousing* about it. He pushed it all away, gritted his teeth and struck matches until he got the fire lit.

WITH THE FIRE lit and burning stably, Harrison stacked some of the harder wood around the flaming cedar. They popped and snapped, and he was pretty sure this was going to be a good fire tonight. He did this amidst cheering from down at the beach. The game seemed to be drawing near a final score because each play brought louder roars and groans from the players, and taunts and clapping from the beach.

He stood with his hands on his hips for a moment and watched down at the water. Three guys lining up against three guys, everyone watching and laughing. The play burst out, Stevie falling back with the football cocked. Taylor was down there, sipping a drink then setting it down and raising a fist to cheer. It made him smile. She was having fun. She was having fun and her good boyfriend was letting her. Wasn't being a nag and wasn't acting bothered. Cool cucumber, indeed. Fuck you, Kelsey Kay.

He walked back to the barbecue station, scrubbed the wire brush on the grates to clean them, getting them ready for dinner time. He grabbed a couple of ice cold Rock n' Ryes out of the cooler, three cans, bringing one even for Kelsey Kay. He probably should apologize.

Before heading down to the beach, he returned to check his fire—frankly, to admire his handiwork—then shuffled down the grassy, pine needle strewn slope to join Taylor and Kelsey Kay.

Out in the water, two sets of three players lined themselves up again head-to-head. Pontoon hiked the ball back to Colt, and he jumped and splashed through the thigh-high water while KC ran block for him. Brady Aaron tried to sweep around and Kelsey Kay yelled out a weak *Yay, Brady*, and it made him laugh. This was Brady's last day with the group.

Stevie drew back farther, KC now shoving Brady headfirst, and he disappeared under a wave. Stevie threw the ball like a lightning bolt. Pontoon was there, working his way past Colt and jumping high, the ball tipping off his fingertips and shooting straight up in a somersault. The crowd gasped and laughed, and KC shoved Colt away as Pontoon jumped one more time and caught his own fumble.

Everyone went out of their minds.

Stevie roared and shot both his fists straight up in the air. All the girls on the beach were shouting and cheering. Pontoon was *gone*, high-stepping it with his knees shooting up to his chest as he broke free from the crowd of players and ran along the shore. He was laughing and when he was distant and his touchdown assured, he cradled the ball at his side and taunted with a pointing finger.

An *Oooohhh* sound wormed through the crowd, Harrison figuring this was the end of the game and the wager was determined. Stevie was clapping and laughing, KC as well. Pontoon threw the ball back and Stevie caught it.

KC said, "Come on, guys ..."

Colt and Rick-Joe weren't happy about it. They had half-smiles and ambled around in hesitant circles with their heads down. Brady came up out of the water and brushed his hair back, waded over to join them. Rick-Joe gave him a gesturing hand, letting him know that they lost since Brady might have missed that because he was underwater. Brady groaned and threw his head back, dropped down and disappeared under another wave.

Kelsey Kay laughed now, clapping her hands and saying, "Let's go, Brady, let's see it ..."

Colt shouted, *Fuck this*, not aggressively but resignedly. His hands disappeared underneath the water then yanked downward on the legs of his shorts.

Harrison froze where he stood, just a dozen feet behind Taylor and Kelsey Kay. His feet burned in the hot sand. Kelsey Kay and Taylor cheered. Colt's bare ass was revealed to them. All the muscles in the guy's back rippled, his paler ass was pert and round and perfect. Even Harrison could see that. He hunched over painfully, but his eyes were glued.

Rick-Joe threw up his hands as well, but he didn't have the dramatic flair Colt did. Back turned to the crowd, he shoved his thumbs in his waistband and pushed his shorts right down to his knees. He slapped his

own ass, and it drew cheers from everyone. Even Cookie was getting into it, laughing and kicking her feet. Jamie good-naturedly covered her eyes up with an extended hand. She laughed and held it over her face. Brady joined in as well, hanging his head, while he stood up from the water before pulling his shorts down.

Taylor shouted, "Let's see them, guys!" and Harrison almost fell over.

KC pointed at her and said, "Shut up, Taylor. Turn around ..."

Taylor leaned close to Kelsey Kay and Harrison heard her say, "It's your stupid wager, KC." They both laughed and applauded.

Now the guys began to stride through the deep water, Brady covering up his genitals with his shorts, Rick-Joe doing the same, holding with one hand his wadded up shorts between his legs.

Colt did not. Taylor had postulated he wouldn't care because he had a big dick and she was right.

He strode to the shore with his testicles snug up high from the cold, tucked underneath a huge flaccid penis. It was long and thick and circumcised, and as his feet found the shallower water, he began to jog. It bounced and slapped between his legs. Harrison wanted to scream watching his girlfriend look at this. The guy's big dick flung around between his legs as the jog became a run in the shallower water, even nodding up and down, getting longer and shorter like a slinky.

Harrison formed a fist and dug it into his hipbone. He was filled with rage and jealousy ... and *lust*. And covetousness. He couldn't deny it. Watching his girlfriend ogle this male specimen made him want to *be* Colt.

Colt ran up onto the sand, impressive penis flopping around and everyone cheered. Riley's circle of friends all watched and howled. Brady came up now, too, falling behind Rick-Joe. All three of the naked football players tossed their sopping wet shorts into the sand as they ran up the beach. Colt was confident, pointing at all the girls as he ran past with an arrogant smile. Brady didn't seem to care either. And though Harrison witnessed Kelsey Kay buy her boyfriend regular-size condoms, the thing Brady had between his legs looked pretty big. Enough that it bounced and slapped as he ran. Rick-Joe had nothing to be shy about either. His testicles were *gone*, but while his dick was shrunken from the cold, it was twice what Harrison had. It didn't go left and right, just bounced up and down like it was very emphatically positive about something.

Now Colt passed close by Taylor and gave her a special pointing finger and Taylor did a little dance for him, putting her hands up over her head and swaying her hips even though she was sitting on her feet. She hooted louder than anyone.

Rick-Joe and Brady passed close, heading up the steps at a jog, shedding water while their genitals bounced around. KC hauled back and threw the football. Everyone let out a long *Ooohhh* again as they watched it spiral high through the air. It smacked wetly dead center in Rick-Joe's back and Brady caught it as it bounced off his shaking flesh. Rick-Joe hollered then laughed, and he gave everyone the finger over his shoulder as he continued running up the stairs with his muscles jumping. Taylor turned right around—didn't see Harrison—craning her neck to watch the naked men run up the steps. Kelsey Kay turned around, too, but she rotated toward Taylor throwing her chin over her shoulder to watch the boys. She saw Harrison.

Taylor moaned loudly, and bumped into Kelsey with her shoulder, saying, "Oh myyy God. I can't *wait* to go to college." Kelsey smiled thinly, her eyes locked on Harrison's.

He stood there with three freezing ice cold Faygos pressed to his stomach. Water dripped and ran off them through his fingers and stained the front of his shorts. He was bewildered. Lost. He couldn't believe what he'd seen. It was terrible, but wasn't it fucking obvious? She was a red-blooded young American girl, and those were three good-looking naked guys. What did he expect? He wanted to throw a can at her, hear the sound of it whacking her right between her shoulder blades—a dull thump that would wake her up with its icy cold punch. He'd love her to turn around and he would hate-fuck her with his vision. Blast all the hurt in his heart right now through his eyes and into hers. Something like right out of those comic books eleven-year-old Harrison used to pick up at the WC and read when he came up to this dumb fucking cottage. He felt sick, lunchtime burger taking a few turnovers in his stomach.

Kelsey Kay still held his gaze. Her face was solemn. Understanding. He hated her face right now.

Riley jumped up, spilling her drink, and stumbled across the sand in a big hurry. Taylor seemed to know exactly what her sister was up to, and she jumped up to join her. Harrison watched Taylor running in her flossy

nothing, showing off her beautiful tan body to anyone who wanted to look at it.

From the water, KC shouted, “Oh no you don’t!”

Riley shouted, “Shut up, KC!”

KC threw up his hands in surrender and smirked. The two sisters ran and scooped up the boys’ shorts. For a moment they didn’t know what to do with them and then it was Taylor making the decision: she shouted, “The boathouse! Quick!”

Riley thought that was spectacular.

The two of them ran, pumping their thin legs through the sand and kicking up dust to great applause from everyone else gathered on the beach. Kelsey Kay had turned back now to see what was happening, and she gave her own applause.

Even from this distance the two sisters’ cackling was brash and arrogant, both of them sprinting up the dock’s steps, running into the boathouse and closing the door behind them.

Harrison looked behind him, saw the oblivious guys running past the barbecues, going to the right and heading up the slope to the front of the house. He figured the wager was running naked one time around the house.

Kelsey Kay was watching him again.

He felt funny. Hurt. But something more. It had been *arousing*. The whole while his brain was shouting *No! No! No!* at what he was witnessing, between his legs his penis was kind of interested. It picked up, and he could feel it bulging against fabric. He could feel the wet from the dripping Faygo cans soaking into his plumped out underwear.

He’d like to turn around and go back up to the kitchen, hide away from all this nonsense and be alone with his thoughts. Instead, he held Kelsey Kay’s gaze for another moment and then he walked the remaining steps and plopped himself down next to her, sitting in Taylor’s spot. He set the cans down then offered her one. “R n’ R?”

Still holding his gaze, she took the can and thanked him. She popped the top and winced at the burst of carbon dioxide. It was like she wanted to say something but saw that her friend was struggling with their earlier conversation and she waited to see what he would say first. He said nothing. Watched KC and Stevie and Pontoon lingering out in the water. They had no football now, and they waded and talked to each other, their unfortunate opposing players already forgotten.

Riley and Taylor came out of the boat house laughing, elbowing each other and stumbling around.

To Kay, he said, "Hey."

Kelsey Kay said, "What?"

"Sorry. For before."

"It's okay. I ought to keep my mouth shut."

"You don't have to. But ..." He let it hang. *It might be better if she did.*

TAYLOR SPOTTED him sitting with Kelsey Kay. She smiled but didn't wave. Riley was still clinging to her, and they got close together again and Taylor whispered something into her sister's ear behind the cup of her hand. They both laughed so hard they doubled over. The two of them stayed on the beach standing where the shorts should be. It bothered Harrison. It was like they were standing there waiting to see those dongs come bouncing back.

But then the girls realized they didn't want to get caught, and pushed each other away and each ran back to their respective beach towels, Riley running and stumbling clumsily onto hers. Harrison wondered about what KC had said earlier about her drinking. Taylor was the same, long legs moving clumsily in the sand before she toppled onto the towel between him and Kelsey Kay. She was laughing and her cheeks were flushed. She smiled, fumbled around and grabbed her sunglasses and slipped them on her face like a disguise as she lay on her back between them. Harrison looked down at her big smile and her white teeth and glossy lips and for the first time in the last two years felt *distant* from her. She said, "Hey. Where have *you* been?"

He said, "Cleaning up. Cooking. I got the fire going."

The smile faded a bit as she recognized all the things he did.

She said, "You're so awesome."

He said, "We're almost ready for dinner up there. And the fire's going pretty good."

"Aww, Harrison," she said, and she sat upright now, adjusting her sunglasses and shaking the sand out of her hair. He caressed her back, and

she leaned herself against him. He brought his hands together around her middle and rested them in her lap. She leaned against him and he felt good again.

Kelsey Kay watched both of them, and she said to Taylor, “He’s a good guy.”

There was a hesitation, but then Taylor said, “He is. He’s the best guy in the world.” Now her hand came up and stroked his cheek while she nuzzled the crown of her head against his neck.

Behind them, came the huffs and puffs of the guys making their way around from the other side of the house, coming along the stone wall where the firewood was stacked. Harrison looked over his shoulder, but kept Taylor braced against him so she couldn’t see. Sure enough, of course, they were still naked. Jogging along, wangs bouncing and slapping between their legs. He could hear the wet tap-tapping even down on the beach.

The guys came across the barbecues and began trotting down the steps and Kelsey Kay watched with a smirk. He didn’t know how to feel about it. All these guys with their dicks and balls flopping around and here was this girl that he thought of as his young friend—yet here she was watching. He already knew, but it suddenly came over him again: *they were adults now*. This was the place where he’d been a kid but they weren’t kids anymore. He could feel Taylor tensing, and he whispered near her ear, “Did you hide their shorts?”

She giggled and put her hand over her mouth and he squeezed her tight. The three guys came down now, running across the sand to where they’d left their shorts. They’d been bold when they started, but Rick-Joe and Brady cupped both hands between their legs to cover themselves. Colt didn’t.

It was Brady and Rick-Joe who realized first their shorts weren’t where they should be. They turned around in circles, and started looking at all the faces, waiting to see which person would laugh first. Colt was turning, too, and Harrison playfully slid his hand in front of Taylor’s vision. She laughed, and it made him feel good. He covered her eyes. She put her hands over top of his just like Cookie had done with Jamie. The good girlfriend letting her boyfriend prevent her from seeing something that maybe she shouldn’t.

Colt turned left and right, and Harrison watched all the muscles in his body move. He had long straps in his legs, a tight round behind. Abs, of

course, but big muscular chest and shoulders. And that penis?—it swung around and even he couldn't stop looking. He would hate it if Taylor could see this.

Brady said, "Come on, guys." He looked toward where they were sitting and saw Kelsey Kay. "Hey, come on, where are my shorts?"

Kelsey Kay didn't even laugh. She just looked at him like it was his fault. She shrugged and frowned at him. He knew not to ask her again and now he went to Riley's towel with Rick-Joe coming along. Colt went there as well, seeing Riley unable to stop herself from laughing the closer they got.

"What's happening?" Taylor asked, and she moved her hands to pry a gap between Harrison's middle and ring finger, forming a V that she could peep through. What she would see now was Colt standing over her sister who sat cackling, curled up on her beach towel. Her friends had scampered a few feet back and Colt was threatening her with handfuls of sand that he was going to put in the backside of her bikini.

"Don't, don't, don't!" Riley kicked and laughed.

Rick-Joe was yelling "Where are my shorts?"

His buddies, KC, Pontoon, and Stevie were howling, wading around the swimming dock where Care Bear sat with his feet dangling in the water still. From this angle, with Colt's back mostly facing them, his cold-shrunk sack bounced around. Taylor would be seeing this and he knew that she would be looking right there, too, catching the occasional glimpse of that big wet penis as it dangled between his legs while he horsed around with her sister. He hated it so much he wanted to clamp his hand completely over her face, but he didn't want to be a jerk. He didn't want her to think he was jealous. He didn't want to think it bothered him. It did, but he couldn't deny it—for some crazy reason he was aroused from this. His heart was seized up like this was the worst thing that could happen yet between his legs there was a disagreement with that. He didn't want to be hard, but he was.

Riley cackled, "Taylor did it, Taylor did it."

Colt looked over at the three of them sitting on their beach towels and frowned. Harrison panicked in preparation for what he would do if this guy came over and started wrestling with his girlfriend with his dick out.

Colt didn't believe it. He was back at Riley, grabbing fresh fistfuls of sand and thrusting them into the backside of her pulled out bikini bottoms. But now Riley was getting mad. She was kicking at him hard, and she

wasn't laughing anymore. She whacked him in the leg with her heel, her face pinched mean, and she shouted, "You asshole! Your shorts are in the fucking boathouse!"

Colt shouted back at her, "That's all I wanted to know!" like he wasn't having fun anymore, either.

Another *Oooohhhh* went through the crowd as they felt the tension. Riley was furious and upset, standing up and now shaking out her bikini bottom. Sand filtered in a cloud down one of her legs, blowing away in the breeze. Harrison could see that her face was red and her eyes were wet. She left the beach, stomping up the steps to go back in the house.

Kelsey Kay said, "It's all fun and games until somebody gets sand up her asshole."

PART 3

BEFORE DINNER, gathered in the kitchen with his buddies—Mikey and Cisco helping him bring down the raw meat and the vegetables and the potatoes to the back patio grills—he was quite proud of his decision to be the ‘big guy’ here. Inside of course he wanted to go after her and tear her down for doing something that just was honestly biologically natural.

Colt was a fine physical specimen and his girlfriend appreciated it. He wasn’t stupid. Once again, if there were a bunch of Victoria’s Secret models cavorting on the beach, he would be sure to be down there with his beach blanket pretending he wasn’t watching but oh he would definitely be watching. He could be trusted. Of course, none of those Victoria’s Secret models would actually sleep with him. It was 100% certain if Taylor curled her finger at Colt to come and join her somewhere, he’d have her bent over and ramming her from behind. Shit, just thinking that formed a cold knot in his stomach. And it pushed out his cock. Why was that so fucking arousing? It made him mad. Did anger get him aroused?

He pushed it away. This was all about being the cool, *mature* guy that Taylor was dating. Not the high school kid. The guy that started Michigan State this week. Sure, that guy was also staying at home and driving back and forth from school, but, he’d earned enough money to buy himself a car to do that. That counted for something. He was responsible, and he was a good guy. They both said it, Kay and Taylor.

He’s a good guy.

There had to be good guys and there had to be muscular guys with big dicks. He wasn’t going to be the latter but he would knock the former out of the park. He would be the rock. The one Taylor would always count on. So

yeah, sure, it occurred to him that he would prompt her and poke her about what they witnessed on the beach. He could picture himself saying to her, “Wow, looks like you were right. You see the dick on that guy?” Just to feel her out. See what she’d say, how she’d respond. Nothing ever came out right—he would say something like that and she would look at him funny. And he would feel stupid. It *was* stupid. Boyfriends didn’t talk to their girlfriends about hot guys, even when they were fishing. So as much as he’d like to get her opinion on what she saw, he would let that one stay quiet in her head. She could talk to her friends about it. You couldn’t stop that. You could hate it, but you couldn’t stop it.

He laid out all the raw meat on wax paper around the grills, got his crew together and he whipped up a really amazing dinner. He used to help Trish and some of the chaperones around the kitchen, but look at him now: he was large and in charge and he was keeping the Brooks’ guests well-fed and happy.

Some of the people gathered around while he was preparing and he was the acting host. Politely serving food, being a gentleman, and Taylor hung around. She didn’t go cavorting with her friends and she didn’t go cavorting secretly to talk to Colt. That would’ve killed him. But you know what, when you were the good guy, girls didn’t do that to you. What Taylor was witnessing right now was the man she would hopefully marry. At least he hoped that would be the case. The guy who looked at home out back of a nice, expensive lake place, grilling up food for everybody; the good host, the good guy. *The guy who was awarded her virginity.*

He put on a show, Mr. Gracious, and it went over well. He felt good. Steaks and chicken and burgers were served with great aplomb, and everyone went to their spaces to enjoy his food. Compliments of course to Cisco, his sous. He cuddled up with Taylor to eat, and they laughed and everything was cool. They enjoyed their time together. They had at least ten minutes alone before they were joined by Kelsey Kay and Brady, and that was okay, too, even though Brady was shirtless. Taylor gave him a couple of side glances. A few times he caught her craning her neck around and watching where everybody was, and secretly, he held the notion that she was trying to pinpoint where her boy-toy was. Her stud.

Colt was off with his friends. Off with KC and the football crew, eating down on the beach and then wading out in the water and hanging out around the swimming dock. Riley was out there, too, sitting on the beach

with her friends Cookie and Jamie, and April. There was a patch-up with Colt. Riley reluctantly accepted Colt's good humor again—he didn't even apologize, but he taunted her in a good-natured way. She rejected him, but he persisted, and soon he had his hands on her and she was laughing. He hugged her, and she hugged him back. That's how easy it was to resolve conflict when you looked like Colt.

It made him wonder what sex was like between Riley and Colt. Back when she was in high school, Riley had been a slightly hotter and more popular version of Taylor. Taylor never was the wild girl her sister was and while she was top five if you asked the guys of Fraser High to rank the hottest girls, she was sometimes too quiet and introverted. Riley lived out her admirer's expectations.

He wondered where Riley and Colt *did* it? He didn't think they dated. Didn't remember that. He didn't like that guy back then and it would've stuck out in his mind. He didn't like him now, either, but whatever. Maybe it was a high school dance, maybe the prom. He didn't think Riley went to the prom with him though. Shit, maybe a booty call. *Why was that such a hot thought?* Just like Taylor, Riley had heard of what swung between stud Colt's legs. Wanted to experience something a little larger. Shoot, here came those thoughts again. He had to push them away.

Dinner was done, and people were kind enough to mostly congregate their dirty plates in one place. Some of them stacking them on the salad tables, around the barbecue, some extra-eager people even managing to locate them up in the kitchen.

Once dinner was done and before he began cleaning, he stood out on the back deck by himself. Taylor was off in her clutch with Shelby and Roxie. Kelsey Kay was off with Brady, the two of them down at the water. The sun was going down, and the lake was beautiful this time of night. The water was much more still now, and the sky glowed orange. That ambience was reflected in the gently undulating surface of Wolf Lake. Dark figures bobbed in the water. Groups of his friends in little bundles, laughing and joking, taking sips off drinks. The stereo was playing low, and he could hear the flicker of his fire as well. Mikey was there, right now, sitting by himself and going through his phone.

This had been the great bash of the summer all through his childhood. But here they were, what, roughly eighteen young people who had the same

experiences he did here. None of them today were kids anymore. It was official. They were all adults.

He shook his head, took a deep breath, went through the basement doors and up to the kitchen to get started on tidying.

HIM AND MIKEY AND CISCO, Cookie and Jamie all managed to get the kitchen back in order in under forty-five minutes. They worked as a team, rinsing dishes and getting them into the dishwasher, scrubbing bowls and pans; Cisco went down and did the grills and tidied up the salad table. When it was done, the cleanup crew gathered in the kitchen and shared a drink. Cookie drank wine, the guys drank beer, and he had a Coke. They laughed and complimented each other and from outside they could hear the sounds of people laughing and yelling, running on the beach and splashing water. It was much darker now; the orange gone in the sky, fading to denim. The black spires of the tall trees on the opposite side of the lake poked up into that frayed color. Campfires dotted the opposite shore and smoke was in the air. There were other parties in the vicinity, other distant music playing.

Cisco said, "I think it's time to sit by the fire."

Cookie said, "It's almost time to go skinny dipping." Jamie hugged her, and she laughed.

Mikey nudged his elbow, said, "You help me bring down my stuff?"

"What stuff?"

"My guitar and stuff."

They went upstairs together, to the room where Harrison would usually stay, and Mikey sat on his bed. He had an old steel body Gretsch acoustic that he loved. He'd played it for as long as Harrison remembered him.

Mikey didn't need help moving any gear—he pulled out a baggie of weed. He rolled himself a joint, and they shot the shit, Mikey telling him all

about his first year at college. It went okay, but it didn't come without hardship. Mikey told him he was on academic suspension.

"That sucks."

"I gotta smarten up," he said.

The joint was a polished looking roll but Harrison didn't smoke, so when Mikey offered it to him he begged off.

The room he usually stayed in was much like Taylor's except for the slanted dormer roof, and it was the one that Harrison was used to. He'd been *upgraded*, as they say, staying now in the *honeymoon* suite.

Mikey scooted himself farther up the bed and sat by the open window. There was yelling outside and some laughter. He opened the screen and set down an empty tuna can that he could ash into. While he smoked the joint, Mikey asked him, "How's it going to work with you two next year?"

"Me and Taylor? We're good. I'm going to miss her, and it's fucking crazy that I won't see her every day, but we're going to work it out."

"That's cool," he said exhaling out the window. The room became filled with the pungent odor of weed despite the open window.

Harrison continued, "I don't know how I'm going to take it. Her so far away." Now he was almost talking to himself. He turned around and sat himself down at the foot of the bed. He stared at the floor. "I'm going to think about her every day. Going to think about what she's doing. I hope I don't get put on academic suspension."

Mikey exhaled laughter in a tumbling balloon of smoke. "You gotta keep your head in the game."

Just like Kelsey had told him.

"Cool cucumber," he said.

"Cool cucumber," Mikey drawled. He ashed into the tuna can.

Harrison said, "I am. I'll do whatever it takes. I want her happy."

"You gotta be happy, too, hombre."

"I'm happy if she's happy."

"Don't think that's how it works."

"That's how it works for me."

Mikey made a funny little eye roll but didn't pursue it. He dabbed the remaining half joint, putting it out. He closed it inside the tuna can and put it up on the dresser. He flicked his lighter a couple times, watching Harrison, then smiled.

He said, "Okay, I'm ready."

It was time for the sing-alongs.

MIKEY TUNED his guitar sitting by the fire, lit up in flickering orange with his eyes turned down so he could hear each note and adjust it with the pegs. People began to gather. Harrison brought down the s'mores and left them at the salad table by the barbecues for whoever wanted to roast one. He'd arranged sticks for everyone's selection and a few metal tongs for the bourgeois.

Mikey began to play. Warming up with an ironically folksy and acoustic Justin Bieber song. Harrison watched people coming, taking their spots in Adirondack chairs or sitting on rocks. He looked for Taylor.

Cookie joined them, sitting and holding Jamie's hands. This might be the last summer all of them were together around this fire and he got a heavy heart again. Roxie showed up, coming from somewhere around the boathouse, wearing a bikini still, but with a flannel shirt draped over her shoulders. She looked exhausted. Kelsey Kay was there now, too, coming up with Brady from the beach. Pontoon, Rick-Joe. No sign of KC, but Harrison remembered the last time he saw him was in the house. He wondered if Taylor was in there, too, wanting a drink to sit with by the fire. Taylor probably trying to sway her brother who'd been having a good day today. *Please, KC, I'll be good, just one bottle of vodka, pretty please ...*

Then when Mikey figured they'd all gathered, the crowd favorite began in gentle strums underneath his long fingers. The sing-along song they'd done probably nine years now. The opening melody of American Pie by Don McLean. A song about three times older than anybody here. Who'd begun it? He was pretty sure it was Mr. Brooks. Taylor's dad had been the

one who championed this wonderful song that made no sense to anyone there yet somehow resonated with them.

Most began to sing along, and Harrison sat down with his back to the lake so he could face the house and look in the windows. He watched for movements in the bedrooms, looking for signs of Taylor or KC. They sang the first chorus, all of them doing it together, some of them getting the words wrong and laughing and elbowing each other. During the second verse, he saw KC in the kitchen. There was no Taylor.

Roxie took his left hand, and he watched now as everyone tried to make this dumb moment even dumber, but sweeter, by holding hands and swaying. Next to him was Brady, and they looked at each other uncomfortably but then gripped hands.

A panic wormed through him as he sang along and tried to keep a pleasant expression.

Where was Taylor? Where was Colt?

Now he sang idly, mouthing words but not issuing any sound at all. He tried not to frown and show a look of concern on his face but he was scanning the crowd. No Colt at the fire. No Taylor at the fire. His heart began to pound.

Mikey switched it up and threw them all for a loop and making them laugh—still to the tune of American Pie, plucking away at his old metal Gretsch that had been his father's, Harrison recognized the first verse of Ice Cube's Growin' Up. It was well done, Mikey had the knack, and the crowd laughed along at the out-of-place yet paradoxically congruent lyrics.

Harrison let their hands go, his heart fluttering in his chest. He stepped back from the ring of people and hands closed up without him, Brady taking Roxie's. American Pie emerged again from the melody, slipping now into the third verse and everyone singing together.

He watched them all; happy faces oblivious to the wild maelstrom whipping through him right now. He looked up at the house, looked at the windows. Was she up there? Was she in the bedroom right now with that big dick stud she'd been flirting with? Was she on her back? Was he between her legs? Was she crying out at how large he was when he entered her? ...

He practically hunched over with pain and surprising lust. He turned around, afraid to face the house. Afraid to look and see two figures moving up in Taylor's bedroom.

The fading sky still glowed weakly on the surface of the lake. The calmness had subsided and there was a gentle chop now. Out beyond the floating dock, there were two shapes. Two black heads bobbing in the water. Two people close together.

No Colt here. No Taylor. *It was them.*

He didn't even look back, began stumbling stiffly down the hill like the Frankenstein monster, lurching from side to side as his heart pounded. He skated on pine needles, fell onto one ass cheek. When he got up he couldn't see them anymore.

He continued down the slope in a crouch, making it to the beach and stumbling onto his hands and knees. He crawled along the beach for a dozen feet, his eyes scanning the horizon. When he stood, he saw them again.

Farther out now, two people *way* too close together. There weren't any couples here that weren't around the fire. *Were they kissing?*

He wanted to call out. He wanted to yell *Taylor!* and if it was her and she called back *What?* he would scream at the top of the lungs *Get fucking back here!*

He had no voice. Nothing uttered from him when he opened his mouth. He wanted to collapse again. It would feel good to fall to his knees right now.

Instead, he tossed away his shirt and kicked off his shoes. He wore swimming trunks but hadn't been in the water yet today. Too busy. Too busy being the good guy. The good guy whose girlfriend fucked the bad guy with his muscular body and his big dick behind the good guy's back while he held hands around the fire and sang songs like a dumbass.

Now he was mad—mad and turned on—and he was trotting into the water, trying to move quickly but not kick up splash that would get their attention.

He would catch them in the act.

He would catch her and embarrass her. Embarrass her in front of all her friends.

How could you? How could you, Taylor?

The water was icy cold, and it pushed the breath out of him. But he dove and kicked his feet, gaining twenty feet underwater before he came to the surface again, whipping around and trying not to gasp for breath and give himself away.

WHEN HE BROKE THE SURFACE, he took a shaky, stuttering breath as quietly as he could. He bounced on the waves, a steady chop on the surface now. He rode the swell, gently kicking his legs and moving around in circles, swishing his hands under the water like a belly dancer. Around and around, three-hundred-and-sixty degrees, seeing *nothing*. He'd lost them.

He blinked, rubbed water out of his eyes, flexed his ears and wiggled his jaw trying to hear better. The distant shoreline strum of Mikey on his guitar came from behind him. He paddled around and faced the Brooks' beach. He was about fifty feet out from the floating dock and he could see halfway up the hill to the house and on the left-hand side the glow of the fire he made. There were lit faces sitting and listening as Mikey played his guitar. There were other sounds, music from distant cottages. Sounds of laughter. A motorboat, very far away, behind him now on the other shore of the lake. He paddled around facing outward again.

On the right: faint bobbing lights—the ring of boats he'd seen out there all day, having their own long-lasting party. He could pinpoint music playing from one of them. Recognized Pearl Jam, pegging the party as a bunch of old people.

On the left: the black shape of the island, and on its further most left-hand-side half of the rigid right-angle shape of its creaky old boathouse.

It was a place where they'd gone before. He could remember one year him and Taylor, Cisco was there, too, and a guy by the name of Jaxon who'd only attended one year (was that guy Riley's boyfriend back then?—he thought so), all swam out at nighttime to check the place out but they didn't bring any lights so they bailed because Jaxon was a little freaked out

by the dark. Harrison had been there once during the day as well, going out one time with Mikey in a kayak and poking around. It had been empty, not much to see. All the debris from the burned down house was carried away a long time ago and there was nothing in the boathouse. It had been a boring island with an empty boathouse.

But now between the boathouse and Harrison—his eyes adjusting to the early evening dim—he spotted the two bobbing shapes again. Two round humps like balls, low in the water. Staring at them now, he could pinpoint the sounds of splashing. They were low in the water because they were swimming. *They were going to the boathouse.*

He began to kick his feet and breaststroke, keeping his eyes on them. It *couldn't* be Taylor and Colt. There was no way. He was mistaken. It could be two people from another cottage. Shelby wasn't at the fire, was she?

There was no way to dissuade it. It *could* be them.

He hadn't seen Taylor, and he hadn't seen Colt. Maybe this was some weird jealous thing working up through him, but he *had* to know.

His breaststroke became a side stroke, and he tucked his chin down and tried to keep pace with them. They were moving quickly. Shit, and Taylor was an awesome swimmer. This wasn't helping him think he was wrong.

One moment, he was sure he heard a girl laughing. She sounded young, the voice bright and cheerful. It could be Taylor's voice. He could be right about this. Or it could be *any* teenage girl. It slowed his stroke, and he waited for a few moments as the swimmers he chased got further ahead.

A strange sort of glow began between their two bodies. He resumed his breaststroke, eyes lowered, teeth chattering as he tried to comprehend what he was seeing. Between the two black shapes was a ghostly green phosphorescence under the water.

The heads neared the shore, and he lost the distinction of their silhouette, the black shapes swallowed up by the black shore—but there was still that glowing green.

“What the f-fuh-fuck?” he chattered.

Now that glow worked its way to the left, heading to that hulking square-edged shadow of the decrepit old boathouse. The glow worked closer and closer, and he could see it begin to light up a gentle dim shine on the boathouse's boards. He knew what it was. A phosphorescent glow stick. Someone brought a glow stick to see their way out to the boathouse. Why would they do that? Who would come prepared? It couldn't be Taylor. It

had to be somebody from the next-door cottage. Some neighbor coming out to take a look at this place for the first time. Or two people going there to make out. That was the kind of thing that would happen. It didn't have to be Taylor and Colt. Taylor was back at the cottage, he was sure of it.

Not a hundred percent sure so he continued his sidestroke again, eyes watching now as the glow worked underneath the closed garage bay door of the boathouse. He could see faint light in the gaps of the crooked boards of the old structure. Shit, he'd let them get too far ahead. Now he was less concerned with making noise so he busted out a solid Level XII Aquatic Academy sidestroke, heaving breath without fear of being heard.

His body had grown accustomed to the chill of the water but he still felt cold at his core. Part of that he was sure was fear. Fear of the unknown. Fear of discovering the *truth* of the unknown. Fear that he would pop up inside the boathouse to find Taylor naked with Colt behind her, gripping her skinny waist and pounding the shit out of her with that huge dick.

"Fuck," he grunted and squinted his eyes through a faster stroke. As he got close, he slowed and fell back to his breaststroke again for the sake of quiet. He moved as quickly as he could but trying to catch his breath. He couldn't swim in there huffing and puffing. If it was the next-door neighbor and his girlfriend or his wife (*it could be middle-age people, you know, Harrison, they liked to have sex, too*) the guy might just punch the shit out of him for being a peeper. So he doggy-paddled until he was close then waited until his breathing slowed.

The glow stick was moving around in the boathouse and he heard that girlish laugh again. *It was fucking Taylor*. He was sure of it. Again, not a hundred percent sure. It *was* teenagers. Not middle-age people. But still, if it wasn't Taylor, and it was some other girl, the guy would definitely want to punch the fuck out of him for spying.

Still paddling, he worked on building up the nerve. *He had to go in*. There was no way around it. He swam all this way just to know. You couldn't turn back when you'd done that. He would just slip in, take a peep and get out. Unless it was Taylor. Then he was sure he would have a meltdown.

The thought of it being Taylor had him trembling. He could feel his eyes swelling with a sadness. He even sniffed wetly, and it gave him the nerve. He kicked his heels up and dove deep, swimming under the water and kicking his legs in a big bowing crescent, breaking the water surface again,

coming right up at the jagged maw of the old boathouse. In the daytime it was a faded denim color with white painted trim that had chipped and peeled. Right now, it was just all charcoal gray and black. He could see the boathouse's open mouth, just a grim humorless black line a foot above the waves; could see the jagged rents in the battered old boathouse door.

Inside the glow was static. Stationary. Like the stick had been set down on the ground. He bit his lip, knowing there was no turning back. Another few breaths preparation then he slipped straight down under the water feet first and paddled himself forward.

SLOWLY AND SILENTLY, he emerged in the center of the boathouse's bay, the ceiling and rafters above him tall and high and cavernous like a cathedral. Its old wooden structure shone in the ghoulish green of the glow stick, slashed with crosses of black shadows.

Only his eyes had broken the surface. But as his ears came up, he listened. There was a moaning sound. A girl moaning. Wet sounds. Kissing. He was right, teenagers coming out to fool around. Or, possibly, a teenager and a *man*. A twenty-three-year-old *man*. It sickened him. It sickened him that Taylor would fall for that. But why? Couldn't *you* see it, Harrison? Can't you see with your eyes? The guy was hot. Just think—when Taylor had spoken to him on the beach, getting flirty with the guy, and you left, when you returned, Taylor's friends had come skittering over to find out the goods. *What did he say, Taylor? Oh my God, he's sooo hot ... You know, I hear he's got a big dick ... Me, too, me, too!*

He clenched his hands under the water and kicked forward.

Now he could see the source of the light was blocked by two figures. The glow stick had been dropped on the decking at the back of the boathouse. There was a table and shelves that ran along the whole back wall, all of it empty. But there, sitting on the edge the boathouse deck were two people side-by-side. Their feet must've been hanging over the edge, but he could see that their hips touched and their torsos were turned toward each other. Their two faces were pressed together. They were kissing.

His stomach tightened again at the thought that it could be her. Would she really do this? Would she really take another guy out to this boathouse while her boyfriend was here on the last weekend they would spend

together? Take him out so she could make out with the guy? How could she be like that?

He wished he could say it was impossible. There was an inkling in him. A little goblin of doubt dancing around, teasing him, jumping up with a flute at its mouth, popping poisonous darts at him. Jabbing little thoughts.

I'm on the pill now because I'm going to college. I want you to be the one to officially take my virginity.

Why? Because others would now be getting in line?

Mr. Brooks. Poor Mr. Brooks.

Trish and her hungry eyes. Trish dancing around from man to man after the divorce.

Bad Riley. Bad Riley and all the boys she slept with. Bad Riley and her bad reputation.

It was in the blood. It was in Taylor's blood and she'd already shown him the signs. This was their last weekend together. She meant that literally.

Tears came now, and he squinted his eyes to squeeze them away and still see the two people on the deck. He shook it off, pinched at his nose so he wouldn't sniffle. His heart absolutely thundered in his chest. He kicked his legs, got himself a little closer. The bodies were too cast in shadow to see their details, but he could tell a few things. The boy was on the left. Man, probably. He was muscular. Jacked. The stick glowed behind them and showed off the big round globes of the guy's shoulder muscles. He had curly hair. It was wet and slicked back, but at the nape of his neck there were the distinct crescents of curls. Golden curls, probably—but everything was green and black in here. The girl was thin. Thin and leggy ...

It was Taylor and Colt.

Or was it Shelby and Colt?

Or was it some muscular guy and some girl hot girl from next door, Harrison? Don't make a fool of yourself here.

He took his two fists and pressed them on either side of his ribs, slipped them down and pushed hard on his stomach trying to crush the pain and nausea that swirled underneath. *It couldn't be.* It couldn't be, but dammit, it really *looked* like it. It really did look like Taylor and Colt.

They kept kissing, heads slowly rocking together, their wet mouths making sucking noises. *Was it Taylor?* Was Colt slipping his tongue into her mouth? Was she taking his tongue? Was she *giving* him *her* tongue?

Now his fists beat lower, began to rap against his hipbones. This was all *too* much. His heart rate was through the roof. His brain was screaming inside his skull.

Their hands were exploring each other's bodies. She was touching his neck. He was touching *her* neck.

Colt was touching Taylor's neck!

It occurred to him he could just shout out now. Shout out *Stop!* When the two people jumped up, and he saw it wasn't Colt and Taylor he could duck under the water and swim out of here. But it also occurred to him in his haste he could whack his head right against the support structure of the boathouse door. Bang his head and break his neck. Or he could make it out, break the surface, then some jacked-up football player he didn't even know would grab his ankles and pull him back under the water, put him in a headlock and punch his face while he breathed in gallons of lake water.

Or he could get away. *But he also couldn't ...*

So he had to watch. He had to paddle here and watch what could possibly be his girlfriend make out with another guy. He was baring his teeth, snarling at her silently. Gritting teeth together with hate. Hating Colt. Hating Taylor. But not sure he should.

The figures upped the ante on him.

The girl's hand caressed the boy's—correction, *man's*—chest. She stroked lower and began to touch at the muscles of his stomach. Yes, Colt had a great body. *Put your hands all over him, you whore.*

The guy mimicked her. No details could be seen, but he could tell the guy's forearm dipped lower, his hand probably gripping her left breast right now. Squeezing Taylor's pert little B. Her nipple probably pressed out the fabric, he would feel it hard against his palm and he would love it. The girl made a panting gasp. It sounded like Taylor. *But fuck, it probably sounded like every teenage girl.*

Now he could hear a hand on quick-dry board-shorts fabric. His heart stuttered and skipped a beat. The girl was touching the guy's shorts. Her hand was between his legs. Holy fuck. He opened his mouth and panted silently as he watched, and the water splashed at his face as he bobbed up and down. Outside a motorboat droned, coming close.

Now the guy's figure moved—his right arm drawing up, the elbow pointing out. His hand grabbed at the waistband of his shorts, and his body shifted as he began to tug them down his thighs. He heard the girl make a

gasp. She touched his cock. He was sure. That gasp was from the feel of the boy's large size in her practically virgin hand.

No, Taylor *wasn't* a virgin, at least with her hand. He'd assumed she'd messed around with boys before him. She'd never had sex before him but that didn't mean she hadn't done *other* things. Still, she would gasp because Colt had to be the largest. Or maybe she was just turned on. Shit, the way his brain was flip-flopping, it might've been his own gasp, and he didn't realize it.

Now he exhaled long and slow. His open hands slipped down his own stomach, caressing his hipbones. His cock had grown fully hard and poked out the front of his swimsuit under the water. *Why the fuck would that happen?* He gripped it through the material.

He could see the girl's arm moving. They were making out, and she was giving this guy a hand job. Holy fucking cow. He couldn't believe it. His own cock throbbed between his legs. It was astounding. He was inundated with jealousy and hate and rage. He wanted to *punish* her (if it *was* her!), but his body was going wild and his mind was doing crazy cartwheels. He held his breath and watched.

Now the guy had his hand on her tummy, and he could see his shoulder roll forward, the guy's hand slipping into the girl's bikini bottoms. *The bikini bottoms that were hardly even there.* Slipping in and touching Taylor between her legs. Another guy maybe even putting his fingers *inside* her.

Harrison had seen Colt's muscular hands on the beach. The guy had nice hands. Masculine, well-formed with big knuckles. Thick skin and thick veins, tanned, manicured, clean fingernails. Would he put one finger inside her, or two?

He squeezed his cock harder. Then the decision came to him.

Aroused or not, he couldn't stay here. He couldn't watch this. It had to be stopped.

He waded closer, got right underneath them. He put his hand out close enough that he could grab at their feet. He looked up between their knees. No light touched their faces. He *couldn't* be sure. It sure did look like them though. It really did.

He squinted and studied. The girl slowly jerked the guy off and her hips wriggled as he was sure the guy was slipping his finger in and out of her.

Fuck, Taylor, how could you?

He looked at the feet. It was dark, but he could tell where they were. He put his hand out very near to touching them. Something occurred to him.

Now he bobbed even closer, getting below them. He couldn't see their heads or faces or bodies at all, but against the ghostly luminance on the rafters above, looking almost straight up, he could clearly see the shapes of their feet just above his face. Their feet dangled over the edge and they were outlined against the green glowing roof.

The girl had small, narrow feet. And one thing was for sure, on the second little piggy on Taylor's right foot would be a gold toe ring. A three-year-old bit of jewelry studded with a pale blue gemstone held in a thin-arm golden clutch.

Slowly, he extended his hand. He could see it shaking and trembling against the green glow. He steadied himself, held his breath. Above him they kissed. Sloppy sucking sounds. Moaning in their throats, snorting breath through their noses. Slick hand on cock sound. A wet finger in pussy sound.

With sudden anger he lashed his hand out pinched at that toe.

The girl screamed and shrieked and the two figures jumped up and away.

He was gone. Slipping below the surface, doing a steady underwater breaststroke headed for the lake.

Nice and easy, Harrison. Don't whack your head. Don't end up in a wheelchair. Be cool, be calm. Swim like a cucumber.

He stroked and stroked, legs kicking, arms paddling, his heart *pounding*, but his breath good and steady. When he came up it was nighttime air all around him. Sounds of parties and distant music and a drone of a motorboat.

There was no toe ring. It wasn't Taylor. Hallelujah, it wasn't fucking Taylor.

WHOEVER THAT GUY WAS, he was muscular, and if he figured out someone had grabbed his girl's foot—not some curious pike or something—he'd be mad and looking to show off for the girl, strangle the little creep that did it. So as much as he wanted to bellow frigid air out of his lungs and shout in triumph up to the burgeoning stars above, he kept his mouth shut.

Mostly he swam underwater. He didn't head back to the lake house. Not directly. He made his way clockwise around the island so if anybody was following they wouldn't think to do something so strange. He swam around the island, going deep underwater for long jags, breaking the surface quietly and listening, going around in circles and watching to see if someone would follow.

Once around the island he felt a little better, pinpointed where the house was; could see the lights in the kitchen and some of the bedrooms, could see the shimmering fire halfway down the hill to the lake. It made him feel warm despite the cold. He even pumped his fist a few times under the water.

What was wrong with him? How could he think Taylor would do that? He didn't even want to circle around the arousal watching that scene had provoked. It overwhelmed him with jealousy yet while he watched he'd sprouted a *really* solid erection. *Don't think about that, dude, just get back to shore. Don't get hit by a boat.*

Now that he felt safe from pursuit, he made a straight line along the surface, alternating breathing on his sidestroke. Soon he saw the bobbing, rigid shape of the swimming dock. There were people in the water near shore, two heads and shoulders wading just off the beach.

He swam around the swimming dock and made his way to shore, watching the two heads. Despite his recent victory, his heart started to pound and his brow lowered again. If this was Colt and Taylor wading near shore what would he think? Could it have been them in the boathouse?

All the happiness began to chill from him. But as his feet touched the sandy shore, and he stood, waist deep in the water, he saw it wasn't Colt and Taylor. He sighed, and it made the girl flinch and gasp.

She hissed, "Who's that?"

"It's me, Cookie," he said, recognizing her voice.

Jamie's voice: "Were you swimming?"

"Yeah, I was."

"You scared the shit out of me," Cookie said.

"Sorry," he laughed now. "Your fault for creeping around the shore like that, trying to spy on me while I'm swimming."

They ignored him now, came together and embraced. He let them be, came up onto the sand and let the water run off him. He didn't have a towel, his was back up at the house, folded neatly near the barbecues. Squeezing the wet out of his shorts as he went, he trotted the steps up to the back of the house.

He had to find Taylor.

As he came level with the fire he examined the faces of the people gathered there. He didn't see any of the football guys. Saw Roxie, Mikey, Cisco, April was there, too. Care Bear stood nearby, talking to Pontoon. Someone else was wandering just out of the fire's light, but by the muscular legs he thought it must be KC. No Taylor.

He grabbed up his towel, snapped it out and put it around his shoulders. Where the hell did Taylor get to?

He looked up at the house, up at the windows on the second floor, but he was too close to see in them. He dried off his legs and feet, went in through the basement doors, and up the stairs to the main floor.

Shelby was in the kitchen, flittering around in her bikini and flannel shirt. It wasn't Shelby in the boathouse. The weight of concern came back to him.

Could he be wrong?—had he picked the right toe? Now he tried to consider his view from underneath the feet again. In his mind's eye, he pictured them above his head, the ghostly green making them black shapes. Of course he got the right foot. He was facing the same direction as them.

But she had one foot crossed over the other, right? No, he could *see* the feet. He picked the right foot, he picked the right toe. There was no toe ring. End of story. *It wasn't Taylor, okay?*

“What the heck are you doing?”

Shelby addressing him now, coolie cup in her hand with a beer bottle plugged in it. He said, “What do you mean?”

“Standing there staring at me like a dummy. You hit your head or something?”

“No, sorry, I was just thinking.”

“Yeah, Taylor says you do that, like, once a year or so.” She nudged him with her elbow and smiled amiably as she passed by.

He turned and watched her as she trotted down the steps to the basement, listened as the French doors opened and closed. It wasn't Shelby. She was dry. So who was it? Some guy from another house? Some girl from another house? It was just weird coincidence that they both looked like Colt and Taylor. Get over it. She wouldn't do that to you.

He shrugged it off, but it wouldn't leave him completely.

He made his way to the stairway to the second floor, a growing look of concern on his face. Male voices upstairs had him looking up now. Coming down the staircase were Rick-Joe and Colt. Colt had no shirt on, just his shorts. His muscles bounced and jumped as he came down the steps.

Harrison was sullen, and he gave them wide berth. The staircase had lots of room but he pushed himself to the far right wall so they could come down on the left. As they trotted past Colt suddenly burst out in explosive barking right in his face and shook his head like a pit bull. It was brief, but loud and tense. It had him jumping right back, and he banged his shoulder on the wall almost knocking down a hanging picture frame.

His left hand jolted up to brace it as it swung pendulously. A collage of the Taylor girls at the lake house when they were kids, back when Mr. Brooks was around—the prime photo was skinny teen Taylor on waterskis, ripping through a slalom almost sideways to the water.

Colt laughed, Rick-Joe, too. No words were exchanged, just a good-natured little humiliation between muscular guys and skinny guys. He was used to it.

He leaned on the wall with his heart pounding, watching Rick-Joe and Colt resume their conversation like nothing happened, Colt's round shoulder muscles (much like the ones silhouetted in the boathouse) flexing.

Hey—then it wasn't Colt in the boathouse, dummy.

That was right. It *wasn't* Colt in the boathouse. It wasn't Shelby. It was some people he didn't even know.

He slumped against the wall under Taylor's photo, put his hand over his heart, his fingertips caressing just above his sternum. It was racing, and he was sure that he was in some sort of coronary trouble right now. But it was good news—it was pounding with relief.

He thought about it more. It wasn't Shelby or Colt—but where *was* Taylor?

Now his chin lifted, and he looked up the remaining few steps to the second floor. Well, she had to be upstairs. But then what was Colt doing up here? And Rick-Joe? Had he been out watching two people he didn't even know making out in the boathouse meanwhile his sweaty girlfriend was getting double teamed in her bedroom?

His grimace returned again, this was an up and down fucking roller coaster. He set his mouth firmly and trudged up the remaining steps, turned left and paused at the door to Taylor's room. Would he find her in here? Would he open the door and see her squeezing her tummy and making all the semen flow out of her slit like he'd seen her do this morning when it was just him and her and the moment had seemed so tender? That thought almost buckled him. His knees went to gravy, and he rested his palms on the door and slowly his forehead came to touch.

The door's lever was cold and hard against his soft grip and he gave a silent prayer. *Please don't be in here. Please don't let any of this be true. I'd do anything for this night to end.*

He turned the lever and pushed the door. The room was dark. His hand moved slowly along the wall looking for the switch, his eyes set at the right angle to see the bed, waiting for the lights to switch on and see her spreadeagled, pussy gored open after two guys fucked her *real* good.

That skinny dweeb doesn't 'fuck' her.

Click, the lights come on. Bed empty, room empty. She wasn't here.

No, of course not, she's not stupid, Harrison, she fucked those two guys in their room.

"Jesus Christ," he sighed and thumped the sides of his head with his fists, trying to pummel those thoughts out of his system. She wouldn't *do* that.

Now he was moving swiftly, legs dancing over discarded clothes left strewn across the floor by Kelsey Kay, Taylor, and Brady. Found his neatly packed bag, opened it, tugged out dry shorts. He stripped naked, whisked a towel over himself, pulled the dry shorts on and a new T-shirt. *Shoot, he left his other T-shirt on the beach. He'd have to remember to pick that up.*

Everybody was at the fire, Colt and Rick-Joe just went downstairs—these bedrooms should all be empty.

He went down the hall, lightly rapping on each door and pushing it open. Empty. Empty. Empty. Empty. When he was done, he leaned his back against the hall wall, let his head come back to touch. He had to stop this. His hand wandered down between his legs and found himself still aroused. Not rock hard like when he'd watched that girl make out with that guy in the boathouse thinking it was his girlfriend. But even thundering through these halls like a madman (yet still politely knocking and gently opening doors), the whole fear that enveloped him produced the strangest arousal.

Okay. New mission. Just find her. She didn't do anything. Find her and stay with her now.

He readied himself with a deep inhale, bounced off the wall and trotted down the steps. Then he was through the basement, coming out the French doors. He walked toward the fire but saw that she wasn't there. He looked down the slope and could see more people standing down at the beach, some wading in the water. He used the stairs to get to the beach, walking now, cool and casual, hands in his pockets. Roxie was one of the dark figures, and she said, "Hey, there he is."

"Hey," he said. "Anybody see Taylor?"

Her voice: "I'm here."

He squinted and watched the bodies in the water. It was Roxie and April on shore, Cookie and Jamie in the water still. Shelby was standing in the lake, the water up to the hem of her flannel, beer in hand.

"Where were you?" he said. "I've been looking everywhere for you."

"I was here the whole time."

"No, you weren't. I just came through here. I was out swimming."

Roxie said, "We were swimming, too. We must've missed you."

There it was again. A strong grip getting a hold of his heart, pinching it with thumb and forefinger—and not just pinching, twisting, too. Squeezing and turning. That sounded like bullshit. Roxie had been by the fire earlier.

Taylor said, "Come in. Come in with me, Harrison."

Lamenting that he changed to dry shorts now, he moved to take off his T-shirt and walked along the beach a little, seeing the dark shape of his other shirt in the sand and then picking it up. He put his two shirts together on the grassy edge where the beach met the slope. Then he came to the water and walked in.

"I'm over here," she said, then waded toward him. He took her in his arms and held her and she hugged him back. He kissed her neck, his nose working overtime trying to detect the smell of another guy. He had to stop this. *It wasn't her. She didn't have a toe ring. Colt was in the house. Get over it.*

"Okay," he said now, and he bear-hugged her hard, feeling her thin body in his clutch. He hoisted her off her feet.

She mumbled in his ear, breath squirting between her teeth because he squeezed her too hard. When he set her down, her hand went down his body and gripped his dick right through his shorts. She said "You only think of one thing?"

He'd forgotten he was hard. Not fully, but enough she noticed it pressing into her. He said, "I missed you."

She laughed, circling her arms around his neck. She said, "I missed you, too. Where were you?"

"I was looking for you."

"I was looking for you, too."

"You want to hang out for a bit?"

"I'd love to," she said, "You want to come up and sit by the fire?"

"Swim with me for a bit then we'll go up. Mikey's putting on a real show tonight."

"We could hear him down here."

"Did you miss American Pie?"

"I heard it."

And even though he knew to let it drop, a little goblin jumped up and shot a dart into his brain. *Ask her if she heard the interlude. Ask her if she heard Ice Cube. If she doesn't know what you're talking about, she's lyyyyiiing ...*

He shook it off and ran his hands up and down her waist. They circled around now and grabbed her butt cheeks. Maybe he did like this stringy little thing she wore. He got some benefit, too. Sure there were a lot of Top Dogs around here looking at her goods, but those were Harrison's goods.

Maybe they thought more of him since he could bag such a smoke-show, as they might call her. Of course, then would they bark in his face when he was walking up the stairs obviously looking a little sad?

He put his mouth on hers and they kissed. Cookie and Jamie did as well, and Roxie made a cooing sound. Mikey played his guitar by the fire and it was wonderful accompaniment.

AFTER THEY MADE out for a while, they decided to go back up to the fire to get warm. Roxie and Shelby had departed, getting bored standing with two couples making out, and Cookie and Jamie stayed in the water and kissed but left eventually, too.

He'd humped his erection into her stomach while they kissed and she played with it overtop of his shorts, but she never made the move to go any further. He took her by the hand and they made their way to the beach. They lingered there for a little bit, not really saying much, both of them knowing they waited for his erection to go down enough they could rejoin their friends by the fire. He shifted from foot to foot and she hugged her arms like she was cold. She said, "Hurry up."

"It'll go down. Give me a minute."

"I'm freezing," she whispered.

"We could take care of this," he said and gestured to the tent in his pants.

"Not here," she said, "everyone's like right there. Someone could come down ..."

Making the request of her made him feel selfish now. *His* erection needed tending to, and *he* wanted her to use her mouth or her hand or something, maybe duck into the bushes and have sex real quick. *His* needs. His needs again, and just this morning she relied on him to take her virginity and he couldn't last more than ten strokes before he was gushing inside her.

That kid doesn't 'fuck' her.

“Nah, let’s save it for later,” he said. “I’m going to make it up to you, okay ...”

“Wh-what?”

“For earlier ...”

“O-oh ...”

“I’m going to take care of you, Taylor.”

A flash of white as she smiled for him. “I’m g-going to ho-hold you to that, buddy.”

“You’ll see,” he said and held her, hips shot back so his erection wouldn’t touch her and prolong the wait. She shook in his arms.

“God, I think I was warmer in the w-water,” she said and her knees were literally knocking.

“How long were you out there?”

“I d-don’t know ...”

“You went swimming by yourself?”

He could see the whites of her eyes in the dim as she studied his face. Her jaw trembled and her breath came shaky. “Y-yeah,” she said.

“Didn’t Roxie go with you?”

“N-no,” she stammered. Her knees dipped, and she stepped out of his hug and looked between his legs. “Can w-we just go up to the f-fire, puh-please?”

“Okay, okay, let’s go,” he said and gave his package a feel. He was good. It wasn’t pointing up right now. Just downward. But it was plump. Boy, was it plump. They would go sit by the fire, get warm and dry. Maybe Taylor could have another little drinkie-poo or whatever it was she was up to. Then in a while they would slip away from the party, head up to the bedroom and have more bare penis in bare vagina sex again, and he would fulfill his promise to her.

Mikey still strummed as they joined the circle around the fire. Riley was there, and she looked around her, snatched up a towel and tossed it to him so he could warm Taylor who was the most naked person here. She put it around her shoulders and picked a rock to sit close to the flickering flames. Harrison found a towel as well, taking one from Roxie, and it smelled like Roxie’s perfume. He cowed it around his shoulders as Mikey picked at the fret board without singing. Shelby passed Taylor a Solo cup, and she held it in her lap under the protection of her towel.

They sat together by the fire, sitting sideways and facing the flames. He watched his friend's faces, listened to Mikey's fingers zip and stroke the strings, and gradually began to feel a little sleepy.

Swimming out to that island was no joke when your heart was racing like his was. Then all he'd witnessed provoked an acme of adrenaline through his system. Then he swam the whole way around the island, out in the deeper water. Then his CNS got *another* workout as he darted around the house on the verge of tears looking for his girlfriend. Now it was all over, and his eyelids felt heavy. He'd never liked the sound of Mikey's guitar more than right now. They were all together. Good friends. Best friends, some of them. Brothers and sisters and a whole host of childhood memories.

He leaned forward against Taylor and she met him, letting her wet head rest on his shoulder. He opened the shroud of his towel like a vampire's cape, hooked his arm around her front so they could cuddle together under one towel. His other hand rested on her thin knee. Down her legs he saw her bare feet pressed together.

He started. "Where's your toe ring?"

"What?" she said.

Like barbarian fists beating at the gate, his heart railed against his ribs; his eyes lost focus, his vision went cloudy. He said, "Where's your toe ring? Your toe ring, Taylor ...?"

She extended her legs out now and flexed her feet. "Oh no. Oh no, my toe ring ... I lost my toe ring ..."

He'd spent a week with her in Martha's Vineyard during August of 2015. It had been family vacation time, but rapidly maturing Riley and KC had *way* more important things to do, but Taylor couldn't get out of it. She wanted Harrison to come along and her parents agreed. Taylor had been a surly brat with her parents during that trip, sometimes embarrassingly petulant and disagreeable. The relationship was strained between Trish and Mr. Brooks, even Harrison could see it—some of the meals were virtually silent. Retrospectively, he wondered if the trip had been an attempt to save their attenuating marriage, and then felt guilty that he and especially Taylor hadn't been more congenial. On a grim, sunless day, browsing shops on the beachfront, Mr. Brooks bought her a ring she swooned over. Harrison wanted to be the one who bought the toe ring for his friend once she ogled it, but it was ninety bucks and he just didn't have it—and they weren't even

dating then, though he ached for her secretly. Mr. Brooks overheard her desire for the pretty piece of gold, swooped in and bought it for her eagerly and was the lucky guy that day who got to put a smile on pretty Taylor's face. She *Thank you, Daddy'd* him all afternoon. The price was well worth it for Mr. Brooks, and it afforded him a cheerier day, at least for a few hours.

Harrison let her out of his towel now and scooted back so he could look at her. She was upset that she'd lost her toe ring. Poor girl. She had no idea what this meant to *him*. She was *killing* him without that toe ring. Panic rising in his voice, he said, "Taylor, where's your toe ring?"

She looked at him and her eyes were wet. She said, "I lost it. I lost my toe ring ..." her voice was high and tense. She *loved* her toe ring.

"Where is it?" he said, meanwhile in his head he *knew* where it was. Kicked off her foot while she swam with Colt to the boathouse. Her gold toe ring was sitting at the bottom of Wolf Lake somewhere between here and the island.

He stood up, face bewildered.

She got up, too, said, "Where did it go?"

Mikey slowed his strumming. Riley said, "What's wrong?"

Taylor, on the verge of tears, said, "I lost my toe ring ..."

Riley said, "Aww, we'll find it."

"How? I probably lost it in the water," she said and looked up at the sky like she was ten-years-old again and was going to cry.

Now his heart did go out to her.

It wasn't her and Colt, you asshole. There's something in it that makes you want to believe it is. It's your dick. You like the idea ...

"No, I don't," he said aloud. Nobody heard him.

Was it selfish? She lost her toe ring and all he could think was how that meant she was in the boathouse giving Colt a hand job.

He said, "We'll find it, Taylor. We'll find it in the morning ..."

She cried, "No, we won't. It came off in the water. I just *know* it ..."

She looked so sad he took her in his arms again and she slumped against him. He *squeezed* her.

Mikey strummed the opening chords of 'Shake It Off.'

THEY SAT CLOSE TOGETHER with their bodies touching, her cuddled in her own towel, him with his towel around her. Mikey played the Taylor Swift sing-along Roxie loved even though it was an unfamiliar acoustic version. Harrison got closer to Taylor's ear and whispered, "I'll get you a new one."

She nodded and leaned against him harder. She was shivering.

"You still cold?"

She nodded.

Figures moved into the warm light, standing amongst them. Colt had joined them with a beer in his hand, also wearing a flannel shirt now, too. Rick-Joe was with him and they came and stood behind Brady. For a few minutes they listened to Mikey play and obviously didn't like his song selections, rolling their eyes at each other.

Colt swigged his beer and looked around, eyeing the people who were sitting around the fire. He shuffled counterclockwise and stopped when he came near Taylor and him. Harrison peeped around her shoulder to see what got his attention. Taylor was sad and sullen, her eyes watery, and her beautiful hair hung lank and damp down the sides of her face. Her teeth were chattering.

Colt moved around Brady to stand next to Harrison. He said to Taylor, "Are you okay?"

She looked up at him with her lips parted. "Yeah," she said.

"You sure?"

She said, "I lost my favorite toe ring."

Colt gave a little laugh, like he thought it was something more serious. He said, "Maybe we can find it."

"It's dark," she said.

"Yeah, when it's light I bet you I can find it." He watched over the fire again and took another sip of beer.

Harrison looked up at him. His head was level with the guy's waist, and he craned his neck to look up. The baseball hat was on forward now. His long, blonde hair curled around his ears and neck. His hand was stuck in his pocket, but Harrison could see in the gap of the unbuttoned sleeve cuff the leather bracelets around his wrist. *Why could he find Taylor's toe ring?*

Because he knew where it was.

Harrison said, "You know where it is?"

Colt looked down and shot him a look of disdain. He said, "I bet I can find it."

Harrison said, "I bet you know where it is."

Colt frowned for a moment, watching him, then said, "What, like you think I fucking stole it or something?"

Harrison responded with equal venom. "No, I think you know where it is. You think it's in the boathouse."

"Why the fuck would I think that?"

"Because you took her there."

"Took her to the boathouse?" He tipped his chin down toward the beach, frowning at him with an angry brow.

"Yeah, you two fucking snuck off together."

The guitar jangled off key and stopped. People were watching. Colt grinned with humor. He showed his hands, an okay sign circled around the neck of his beer bottle, said "Oh, all right, whatever, dude. We snuck off, and I swiped your girlfriend's toe ring, you fucking nerd." There were uncomfortable sounds from around the fire. Harrison shook his head. He should've let it go.

He looked at Taylor and she stared at him wide-eyed. She looked like she'd seen a ghost. When their eyes met, she looked away and stared at the fire, eyes still wide in shock.

Why the fuck did he even say that? Why would he say it, and why would he say it in front of everyone?

Colt snapped his fingers and looked up, instantly recalling something and smiling. He pointed at Taylor and said, "The foot job."

Taylor frowned and darted her head back. “What?”

“When you gave me the foot job. It’s probably in my underwear.” With the punch-line, he grinned wide then swigged his beer.

Rick-Joe leaned forward so he could see Harrison’s face around Colt and asked him earnestly, “Did you want to take a look in there?”

They were being assholes, and he’d walked right into it. He should have kept his mouth shut. He knew better. There was chuckling around the fire, and he wished he could laugh it off with everyone but his heart was way too heavy so instead he just scowled.

Across the fire, standing with a beer in his hand, KC also scowled, watching Colt. That made him feel better. Sure, Harrison was the one who got bullied, that’s the way he was used to—but he was *right*. And Colt shouldn’t say things like that about Taylor.

Taylor stared vacantly into the fire. Her cheeks were blazing red right now and her eyes had gone wet, twinkling with the threat of tears in the light of the fire. She sensed him looking at her and she pursed her lips then bit down on them.

The drink she held was set on the ground in front of her between her feet and she stood, gathered her towel around herself and left the light of the fire.

He wanted to follow after her, wanted to comfort her after he’d embarrassed her but everyone was watching and he didn’t want them to see him grovel. He looked back to the fire and waited for everyone’s attention to turn to something else before he followed.

It was Colt who pursued her.

Turning suddenly and saying, “Hey, wait up,” Colt disappeared behind Harrison, following Taylor. When he was out of the light of the fire, Harrison heard Colt telling her, “I was just fucking around, sorry, you know ... That was rude, I’m sorry ...”

Now he’d really fucked up. Face turned to the fire, staring at the dancing flames he could see all the faces still turned to him in his unfocused periphery, watching him make yet another stupid mistake. They could all see she was going to dump him. They could all see she was going to fuck Colt, or already had. They all looked at the chump sitting on the rock realizing he was way out of his league with Taylor and didn’t deserve her in the first place. He sighed, darted a glance up to the stars in the sky, avoiding everyone’s gaze.

Taylor and Colt were gone, leaving the warm circle of family and friends and going off together into the dark nighttime blue. He could hear the sound of their feet on the grass and dirt getting distant, Colt's voice low and soothing.

Mikey took up where he left off, strumming again, starting all over from the beginning in G, the opening of 'Shake It Off.'

ONCE THE MUSIC HAD RESUMED, and the faces turned away to watch Mikey play, he stayed a while longer. Inside he was buzzing with electricity but his body was enervated somehow, leaden. He made it through one full song then stood. No one looked, but he knew they saw. He gathered Roxie's towel around himself and left them.

It was cold beyond the fire. He headed to the house, the same direction that Taylor and Colt had gone.

Into the basement through the French doors, he wound his way up to the main floor and found the kitchen empty. He looked out the lakeside window and saw everyone gathered around the fire. There were three figures down by the lake—he could see their black shapes against the pale of the sand. All guys, no slim Taylor.

The moon was out now and it flickered on the surface of Wolf Lake. He stood with his hands curled over the edge of the sink watching everyone down there having a nice time. He ruined it. Acted like a total kid. The total opposite of a cool cucumber, he was a hot and sour fucking pickle. Way to go. You had one simple thing to do: just be cool. You can't even do it for one full evening? He'd made a fool of himself and he'd embarrassed his girlfriend. And she *wasn't* with Colt. He already knew that. Why did these thoughts torture him like this?

"Fuck," he softly said, and made a fist, tapped it on the curved neck of the faucet.

Then the thoughts came back.

They probably went *upstairs*.

Would they use Colt's room or her own room? Would she have the audacity to fuck Colt on the same bed where she'd let her boyfriend have her real virginity this morning?

With grim resolve, he headed up the stairs, watching the hallway at the top as he went, looking for signs of them up here.

For the second time tonight, he softly rapped on each of the doors and opened them to peek inside. They weren't up here at all. *Didn't mean they weren't fucking though now, did it, Harrison?* Probably had her in the back seat of his pickup truck. That thought made him groan, and he grimaced and hunched over.

In Taylor's room, he opened his knapsack and pulled out *another* set of dry clothes, glad that he'd over-packed. A new T-shirt, a light sweatshirt, and dry shorts, were slipped on.

He went down the hall to the room where KC and Colt and the other guys stayed. It was the bigger room over the garage and looked out on the driveway. In the spot where he'd caught Taylor and KC talking about Riley's alcohol problem this morning, he pushed back the curtain with his hand.

The lights were on so he mostly saw the reflection of his own face, but he closed the curtain around the back of his head and looked down to the driveway. The front lights of the house were on and he could see the cars parked out there; could see his Soob, Shelby's Mustang with the top still down, could see the two big pickup trucks, Riley's Santa Fe, and Jamie's Charger.

Two people sat in the bed of the jacked up pickup parked behind the Soob. The tailgate had been flipped down, and they sat with their knees bent and their feet hanging off. It was Taylor and Colt. He had to touch his hips as a jealous hurt whipped through him. She wore Colt's flannel shirt. He was shirtless. They sat close together, their thighs practically touching, faces turned toward each other while they talked. What would she have to talk about with *that* guy?

He stayed still and continued to spy on her. His erection grew harder, and he gripped it over top of his pants.

Taylor still looked sad. Her body posture was heavy and slumped forward. She was so small and thin and she was drowning in Colt's big plaid shirt. She'd rolled the sleeves up to just above her wrists. She was wiping at her face while she talked. Was she crying? Probably telling this

guy about how she had to get rid of her high school boyfriend this weekend. Probably telling him how she had to go to Santa Cruz to get away from him because she couldn't stand to be at Michigan State if he was there, too. Breathing down her neck. Total hot sour fucking pickle this guy.

And Colt was supportive, nodding—he couldn't really see his face but could understand from the guy's profile that he was giving her that serious look. That *I'm listening* look.

He watched a little while longer as the two of them talked, he watched until the mood between them lifted. Colt got her laughing even. Her shoulders shook and light glinted off her teeth as she laughed. She wiped at her face. *Handsome Colt chasing her tears away.*

Colt put his hand up to her face, rubbed her cheek with a knuckle to dry away one she had missed. They held their gaze for too long a moment.

"No, no," he sighed, squeezing his erection and pushing it upright. He pulled his shirt down so it wouldn't show, let the curtain return to hang open and left the room. He trotted down the steps and into the front hall. Out the front door, he headed onto the porch and turned to the driveway.

There was a moment of hesitation. He winced in preparation. Would he find them kissing? It had looked like they were going to. When he stepped around the corner and onto the driveway would he see the two of them fully making out? ...

WHEN HE HAD THE NERVE, he turned, found them still talking; they weren't kissing.

Cool cucumber. Cool cucumber. He put his hands in his pockets, refrained from whistling but brought out that whistling kind of attitude. *Hey guys, sorry I messed up back there. It's been a long day.* Then the bad thoughts: It's been a long day because I've been doing dishes, cleaning and cooking while you two were making eyes at each other and flirting, talking about his big dick and swimming out to the boathouse so you can touch it and jerk it, *you fucking traitorous*—nope ...

Strolling past the Subaru, he checked his reflection as it wavered in the long side panels of the cargo area. He came alongside the big jacked-up pickup truck. They heard him coming—he wasn't out to startle anybody—and Taylor darted a look over Colt's shoulder and saw him. She showed no expression before turning away again and hanging her head.

Now he came around the tailgate, and Colt watched him, too. He took a swig of his beer. Taylor had a bottle as well, but he saw it only briefly before she hid it behind her.

"Hey," he said.

"Hey," she said softly but wouldn't look at him.

He said, "Sorry about back there." Might as well get this over with. It was Colt he should probably apologize to as well, but he spoke only to Taylor.

Taylor nodded.

He said to her, "You okay?"

"I'm fine."

Her eyes were puffy. She'd been crying.

"Yeah, seriously," he said now, scratching the back of his neck, "I was out of line back there."

"It's okay," she said.

Colt smiled, took another swig of his beer. When he set it down, he said, "We were going to take a swim out to the boathouse. You want to keep an eye on our stuff?"

Taylor shook her head and looked a little sick. Harrison frowned.

Down by the fire, Colt had acted like Harrison meant the Brooks' boathouse when he made his accusation. Colt had pointed with his chin down toward the beach but his eyes had been on the green-painted Brooks' boathouse. But he'd just said now: *Take a swim*. You would only swim to the abandoned boathouse. Was it a ruse earlier? Was it that initial reaction to throw Taylor's crafty boyfriend off the scent?

I so don't know what you're talking about that I don't even know what boathouse you mean, dude.

Colt really *does* know. Taylor swam out with him to the boathouse. He didn't know how they got back as quick as him but it wasn't impossible. Once he'd pinched her toe would she stay and make out? Wouldn't Taylor have been so freaked, she wanted to get back home? First thing back, Colt ran up to his bedroom to change into dry clothes, and Taylor paddled around far from the boy she had been cheating with ...

His face went drawn and thin again. He said, "You *did* go out there. You two went out there."

"Some apology," Colt said.

Taylor looked away.

He was sure of it now. So sure of it. He said, "Yeah, I *knew* it. You two went out there and made out."

"You and I made out?" Colt laughed and looked to Taylor. "Were we necking?" He nudged Taylor with an elbow and she *actually* smiled a little.

It made him livid. "I saw you two."

Now she looked up at him and her mouth fell open. She said, "No, you didn't."

"I did, too. I swam out right behind you. You think I'm stupid?"

"I don't think you're stupid."

"You did. You know exactly what I'm talking about, Taylor."

She looked to Colt who seemed to be enjoying this. Her lips trembled. Colt said now to Harrison: "You saw us kissing in the boathouse?"

"Yeah," he said, nodding once and holding Colt's gaze.

"You sure?"

He said, "I saw it."

"Are you really sure?" Colt asked.

He said, "Yeah," firmly, feeling blood begin to pump through him.

"Really?" Colt said and raised his eyebrows. He set down his beer bottle on the left-hand side, turned his face to Taylor but said to Harrison, "Did it look like this?" Now he moved his mouth towards Taylor's. She didn't move away, her eyes lowered to watch his lips. Her eyes flitted, tugging to look at Harrison but then closing. She kissed him. She *really* kissed him. Colt and Taylor pressed their lips together and kissed dryly. It wasn't intimate, it wasn't loving. They were trying to make fun of him.

Colt laughed, and Taylor did, too, seeing that Colt was only joking. She wiped at her lips with the back of her hand.

"So?" Colt asked him. "You sure it was me? It looked like that?"

He just stared. Didn't know what to say. He was so filled with rage, so filled with jealousy, but he felt like he could do nothing. Taylor just sat there, meekly smiling trying to make things better by being cute.

Colt said, "Dude, I didn't go to the boathouse. Your fucking girlfriend didn't either. Why don't you leave her alone?"

"She's *my* girlfriend, why don't you stay out of it?"

"Because you're being a dick to her. Leave her alone. Why don't you give her, like an hour, and you go fucking cool off."

"I don't need to cool off. I need to talk to my girlfriend. Why don't you fucking get out of here, asshole?" Soon as he said it the confrontational tone pinged in his head as going *too* far. He couldn't back it up. There was nothing stopping Colt from jumping down off the tailgate, giving him a good one-two, and he would be lights out. He might *never* wake up, falling backwards and cracking the back of his head on the driveway. Oh, he might come-to for an hour or three in the hospital, enough to squeeze his mom's hand, but then it would be Goodbye Harrison forever. He put up his hands before Colt did anything about it. He said, "She went to the boathouse, okay?"

"Stop it, Harrison," Taylor pleaded.

“Look at your face,” he said. “You look *so* guilty. I saw you out there, jacking him off and making out with him.”

Colt laughed and thumped his knee. “I got a hand job, *too*?” He whooped with excitement and pumped his fist. “I’m on fire tonight,” he said as a comical aside. That got Taylor laughing a little. “Hey,” he said now, getting serious again. He rested his hands on his knees and leaned forward to make sure that Harrison was looking at him.

“What?”

“You saw that hand job?”

“Yeah.”

“You saw your girlfriend giving me a hand job, and you did what? Nothing? You watched?”

His mouth moved around, but he said nothing. A draggy croak emanated from his throat.

Colt said, “You’re not too sure, are you? You didn’t see shit.”

Harrison still said nothing.

Pulling back now, Colt turned to face Taylor again. He took her wrist, parted his legs, and laid her long, thin hand over the bulge between his legs. He kissed her dryly again. The two of them making fun of him, giving dry kisses. But she *really* had her hand on his bulge. She didn’t move it away. He could see her grip curl against the cotton lump of his large genitals and give it a squeeze. She ran her thumb over its shape. They broke their silent kiss and her hand finally lifted away.

“Are you fucking kidding me?” he said.

She smirked a little, then that same hand that had just gripped another man’s manhood swiped at her lips. She said, “Harrison, come on ...”

He whispered grimly, “I saw you in the boathouse.”

“Don’t ...”

“Yeah, you can’t keep your hands off him. What is *wrong* with you?”

“What is wrong with *you*? I wasn’t in the boathouse with Colt so leave me alone.”

“This is fucking great. Why don’t you just fuck him, then?”

Colt laughed. “You hear that?”

To Harrison, Taylor whispered, “Stop being such a problem.”

“Are you kidding me? You’re kissing him and giving him a hand job and I’m a problem? That’s where your mind goes?—to me? I’m not a problem, you’re a slut.”

“Oh no, dude,” Colt hissed, knowing that was bad.

Taylor uttered a souging sound of hurt, a horrible moan that slid out on an exhale of air forced out from her wounded heart. She whispered, “I’m just kidding around. I don’t want to hurt *anybody* ... I can’t *even* ...”

Harrison blurted, “I’m sorry ...”

Taylor avoided all of them, tucked her head down and hid her face in her hair as she slipped forward and slid off the back of the tailgate to set her feet down on the gravel of the driveway. Colt put his hand out supportively but didn’t touch her. When Harrison made a move to put his hand on her she darted out of his grasp and then she kept moving. He watched as she folded her arms around herself and trotted away, heading not to the lake or into the house but disappearing off the side of the driveway and stumbling into the dense copse of black woods.

“Taylor,” he called after her weakly but knew it couldn’t be enough to get her to return.

Her footsteps cracked through the woods in the blackness.

Colt said, “Way to go, Romeo.”

“I really fucked up,” he whispered to himself and put his hands in his pockets, still watching the black trees and listening for her.

Colt said, “That wasn’t me and her in the boathouse, dude. You’re being a real asshole, for sure. But I *am* going to fuck her tonight.” He swigged his beer.

“What?”

Colt clarified: “I’m going to fuck your girlfriend tonight.”

“No, you’re not.”

“Watch me, bro.”

Colt stared directly at him now with no humor, only malice. A menacing look he remembered from when he was in Grade Nine. He was hunched up, leaning toward him, staring down from the tailgate, big traps and shoulders, muscles flexing in his jaw, a high overhead light from the room above the garages tracing the gold in his curls. This look used to signify that he was on the verge of getting pounded if he didn’t watch himself. But Colt clearly said it would be Taylor getting pounded tonight. Taylor would have to be willing, and a chill worked through him realizing Taylor *was* willing. He huffed through his nose, held Colt’s gaze and said the obligatory, “Whatever,” before turning and heading into the dark patch of woods

between the Brooks' house and the neighbor's. It was where Taylor had gone, and he had to find her, had to set things right.

FROM THE BLACK THICKET, Harrison could see into the windows of the neighboring cottage. Making his way through the woods with his hands out in front of him, touching tree trunks and stepping carefully over crackling deadfall, he could see middle-aged couples with glasses of wine moving around in amber light, warm silent, square windows set in a nighttime blue summertime home much like Taylor's big place. Crickets whirled in his ears, but the sound of Mikey's guitar was faint in the air.

"Taylor? ..."

He'd been calling her name softly, and she hadn't been answering. He didn't expect her to. He'd just called the human being he loved a *slut*. All on supposition. Even if what he supposed *were* fact, she didn't deserve such harshness from him. He couldn't believe the word came out of his mouth, but seeing her with Colt slipped a red gauze of rage over his vision.

"Taylor? ..."

It was *Colt's* fault he called her a slut. The blame was his own for saying it, he accepted that, but he wasn't mad at Taylor—he was mad at Colt. And he lashed out at Taylor because he was too afraid to lash out at Colt. What would Taylor ever do in retribution to her Harrison? She'd been nothing but his eternal best friend. Colt on the other hand would definitely have hopped off the tailgate and humiliated him in front of his girlfriend, punched him out or whatever meanness he felt like conjuring. So what does jerk Harrison do? Lashes out at the person he cares about. *Because he was a coward.*

"Taylor? ..."

In the deep black of the woods now he could see a ghostly set of thin legs and above it the threaded white lines in Colt's plaid shirt.

“Taylor,” he said quietly and with care. He could tell she had her back to him and her arms were still folded. Her head was tipped forward, hair hanging down lankly, and as he got closer, she looked like a little girl in a horror movie, one that would wait till he was about to put his hand on her shoulder then would whip around and lunge to bite his face with paranormal speed. And were they not fighting right now, Taylor would probably *do* that, too. Hunch forward, play mute, lure him close so she could jump around and scare him. One time—only one time!—she’d done something similar to him and provoked a brief but girlish shriek from him, and now she universally proclaimed to their friends that he screamed like a girl. It was *one* time. She’d got him good. But it was *one* time.

Just a few feet away from her now, he said, “Taylor, I’m so sorry. I really am.”

His eyes focused on the paler shape of her and grew adjusted enough to make out that she was nodding her head. His heart opened in his chest like a blooming flower. He said, “Baby, I really am. I can’t tell you how sorry I am I said that.”

“I’m sorry, too,” she whispered.

Now he was standing right behind her with his arms at his sides and afraid to touch her. He asked her: “Can I hold you?”

She nodded again. He put his arms around her and held her. Her hands came up and stroked at his forearm and his thumb. He said, “I didn’t mean it. I’m mad at Colt. I *really* hate that guy. He makes me so ... *mad*. I don’t know why I lashed out at you ...”

She didn’t answer and he could feel her shaking.

“Are you crying?”

“No,” she said unconvincingly.

“I’m so sorry,” he said and held her a little tighter.

“I’m sorry, too, Harrison. I don’t know why I did that.”

The boathouse? “Did what?”

“On the tailgate. With Colt. I’m so sorry.”

“You kissed him,” he said.

“Not really.”

“You had your hand on his crotch.”

“He did that.”

“You did it, too, Taylor.”

“It was just ...” She trailed off and sighed heavily.

“What—a joke, Taylor? Teasing me?”

“Yeah, I guess,” she whispered weakly.

“You’re not teasing me,” he said, seeing it so obvious now. “You just wanted to touch him. You wanted to kiss him and you wanted to put your hand on him.”

The right thing for her to do would’ve been to protest. The best thing for their relationship would be for her to be further infuriated with him, stomp her foot, rip from his grasp, and flee deeper into the woods and make him chase her. But she said nothing, and it stabbed him in the heart.

The silence told him everything, but he hated not hearing her voice. If she was silent, they were disconnected. He said, “I’m right.”

The silhouette of her cocked its head to the side, and he could imagine her rolling her eyes up in the dark. The hands she’d rested on his arm pried his clutch away and she stepped from him, hand pressed to her forehead now, running it up to her hairline. She shook her hair out and sighed.

He said, “Just tell me.”

“Maybe,” she said, her voice quiet, almost hidden beneath the sound of the night bugs.

This was where *he* should’ve stormed off deeper into the woods. She just told him she was interested in another guy. It was *over* between them. But he just stood there and listened to both of them breathe.

Now it was his turn to speak quietly. “You want to fuck him?”

No answer, she just held her arms around herself, head turned away. Her body shifted uncomfortably, and he heard her ankle make a small click.

“Was it you and Colt? Did I see you making out with him in the boathouse?”

“Would you be mad?”

“Yes.”

“No, it wasn’t.”

“That’s not an answer. You can’t frame your answer like a lie and expect it to go away.”

“Whatever,” she sighed and he could see her shoulders slump.

“Whatever ...? Oh my God. Do you even care about me? Care about our relationship? This is such fucking bullshit.” Both his palms came up, and he exhaled with exasperation, but it was lost on her because she still looked away—his best friend couldn’t even look at him right now.

He said, “I don’t even *know* you,” and those upright palms closed to fists—he hiked to the left and marched through the woods, aiming for the fire pit. Over top of his own feet cracking branches he heard the quick but soft patter of her feet through brush coming from behind. Before he could even turn, Taylor had flung herself on his back and wrapped her arms around him.

“Don’t, please don’t,” she panted in his ear.

“Get off me, Taylor,” he said, but held her arms.

“Don’t go, Harrison, don’t—of course I care about our relationship.”

“No, you don’t, you fucking made out with that guy behind my back. Probably fucking jerked him off down there, too.”

“I didn’t, Harrison, I swear I didn’t ...”

“But you kissed him?”

“Unh-unh,” she whispered in his ear, and he felt her head vigorously shaking no.

“What the fuck, Taylor? Was that you and Colt or not?”

“It wasn’t, Harrison. I swear it wasn’t,” she said. “But ...”

“That wasn’t you down there?”

“No.”

He said, “Why didn’t you say that?”

“I don’t know,” she said, then made a muffled sound of pain. “Because ...”

“Because ...? What the fuck is going on here? What are you not telling me?”

“I just want you to be okay, baby,” she whispered before reaching to stroke his cheek. He stopped her, putting his hand on her wrist and trying to look in her eyes. She avoided him, cast her gaze downward.

Wrist let go, he stepped back. Taylor folded her arms around herself, body slumped as though she was hurting, looking away and crying; Taylor’s perennial posture when she wished to be held but didn’t want to ask. He turned and fled.

IT WAS obvious she was going to break up with him; he was the only one who hadn't seen it coming. Kelsey Kay had pretty much told him exactly that sitting down on the dock today and he told Kay to fuck off. Taylor was going to a different school on purpose. Wanted to be away from him. Her school selection was eight months ago. She knew she was going to dump him that long ago. Just stringing him along. Letting his heart get more and more entwined with hers. But hers was cold. A lying heart. Tangling over his like vines with thorns. Going on the pill before she goes to college. Offering him her real virginity. Why?—because she was about to have sex with other guys and she *knew* it. This, their final weekend of the summer, was their final weekend *together*.

As he emerged from the sliver of woods, stomping across the hard pack and then into the Brooks' grass, the tears came. It wasn't just the betrayal, not just the realization of all the things she said coming together in a straight line and showing him the path where it had been and where it was—it was the bright, beautiful flowers scattered around that path growing hazy in the fog of where they'd *been*. Dots and flashes of happy memories. Not even them as a couple—they'd been best friends before they first kissed. Best friends who spent every day together. Amusement parks, school, summer vacations, haunted houses, late night movies, long talks till dawn on their phones, heart-to-hearts ... He was losing his *best friend*, too.

Through warbled, teary vision, he found the steps, saw the ring of fiery friend's faces and heard Mikey's guitar. He hiked right and stomped up the stairs and in between the barbecues, pounding through the basement doors and then up the steps. He went directly to Taylor's room, still crying and

sniffing, choking back real sobs he would save for the ride home. He gathered up his few things, his phone on the dresser, grabbed up his knapsack and stuffed errant items into it. He threw it over his shoulder, cleared his eyes with the back of his hand, and went down the steps.

At the front door, following the same path where fifteen minutes before he'd expected to find them kissing, he didn't even care if Colt was still there sitting on his tailgate. He made a growling noise, used anger to push away the tears. He wiped at his eyes again, stomped around the corner and headed to the Soob. Colt wasn't there. Not sitting on the tailgate of his truck at least.

But the Soob was boxed in. He wasn't going anywhere.

The disappointment tugged at the anger and allowed the tears to come back. He blinked them away, slumped and leaned against the side door of the Soob. He got the fob out of his pocket and unlocked it. With the back door open he shoved his bag in ahead of him, climbed in on his hands and knees and closed the door behind him. Knapsack as a pillow, he curled up on the back bench seat. Pale light flooded the windows of his car from the Brooks' outdoor lanterns. He stared around at the empty cabin, not knowing what he would do.

Why didn't she just break up with him? Why didn't she just tell him it was over? Why did she have to be like this? Drag them all the way out and do it in front of their friends ... They all saw it coming. Mikey with his suspicious questions up in the bedroom, Kelsey Kay trying to be Taylor's proxy, leak a little warning to her friend, trying to reduce the sting. He clenched his hands and punched his thighs. *She was such a bitch.*

Only she wasn't. He loved her *so* much. They were best friends. She didn't tell him it was over. She said it wasn't her in the boathouse. And he didn't know if it was. He'd convinced himself it was, but that didn't make it so. He embarrassed himself. Embarrassed her. Chased after her when she wanted to be alone and confronted her. She *still* didn't break up with him.

Eyes opened again, he blinked, turning on his side and looked out the front window of the Soob at the painted Brooks' garage door lit up by the porch lights. Was there a chance? Or was she just the biggest chicken he'd ever met? If there was a chance, was it worth it? The answer to that was a definitive yes. He loved her desperately and deeply. He would do *anything* for her. She was his best friend and the most beautiful girl he'd ever seen.

Yes, yes, yes a thousand times over. But what if she *was* just a chicken? Was he making it harder for her?

He exhaled all the badness, tried to settle. His head and heart pounded in unison. A steady thrumming beat overtop the quiet strains of Mikey's guitar from around behind the house. Occasionally there was a bright bit of laughter from his friends outside. In time, despite the sadness and the hurt, he drifted to sleep.

The car door clunking open woke him with a jolt. He jumped, raised his knees up, preparing to kick with his heels to defend himself. It was Colt and his buddies come to take him, drag him out of his car and beat him up. Wasn't the first time he'd been underneath three or four dudes kicking and punching.

But it wasn't. It was Taylor. She had pleading eyes, climbing in the Soob's cabin now with her feet still on the driveway. She said, "What are you doing?"

"I'm fucking sleeping," he said, still mad even though his heart was telling him to do anything she wanted if it would keep them together.

"Were you trying to leave?"

"These guys fucking blocked me in," he said, using that anger trick to keep the sobbing cries out of his voice. The truth in the statement was evident: he was too chicken to go and ask them to move their truck even as mad as he was. Instead he would take it out on her.

She said, "Don't you dare. Don't you dare," and took both his ankles in her hands and squeezed him. "Don't you leave. I'll kill you."

The warmth of her touch soothed him instantly. He took a deep breath to demonstrate to her the inner turmoil she'd caused. A dramatic pause where he would now apologize, she would as well, and they would set themselves right again. But interjected into his dramatic caesura were the sound of two voices behind Taylor. Colt and Rick-Joe. They were coming along the driveway, just beyond Taylor and the open door of the Soob.

She turned her head and said to them, "He's in his car. I found him," and images of everyone wondering *Oh no, where did Harrison go? ... Maybe he went to hang himself in the woods* came floating to him.

He said, "I'm fine. I just want to sleep. I just want this night to be over."

"No, don't say that. Come out. Come sit by the fire."

He struggled to comprehend. Didn't she see what was happening here? He said, "Are you breaking up with me?"

“Harrison,” she whispered, climbed in a little deeper, leaning over his legs now to grab at his arm. She took his wrist, and pulled him, trying to make him sit upright. She said, “Come down and sit by the fire. Don’t try to leave. I’m serious.”

He was pulled to sit upright reluctantly. Now he was up, he could see Rick-Joe and Colt passing by, talking about something and laughing, ignoring what was happening in the Subaru with sexy Taylor and her stupid high school boyfriend. They went to the pickup truck, opened the front door and leaned in to retrieve something. He said, “Just leave me alone, okay, please?”

“Don’t be like this, Harrison,” she said. “Please, don’t. Just come down and sit by the fire. I *need* you.”

“What’s happening with us?” he said, not looking at her, watching Colt and Rick Joe using the driver-side door mirror.

She said, “Nothing. Nothing’s happening. Okay? ... Just come down.”

He wanted to grab her, pull her in with him, close the doors and cuddle up with her. Spoon her, put his arms around her, and they would fall asleep together like they’d done so many times before laying on the Brooks’ couch watching horror movies.

There was no time for words. There was no time for anything, the pickup’s door slammed behind them, and soon the sound of the football players feet shuffling up next to the Subaru.

Colt said, “Come on,” to Taylor.

Taylor pushed herself away from Harrison, using her hands to squeeze his body as she did, then stood next to his car. Now he couldn’t see her face, and she rested an elbow on the roof. She said, “I’m coming. Hold on.”

She bent down again with her hands on her knees and her head dipped low enough to make eye contact with him and said, “Come to the fire, Harrison. Don’t be like this.”

Then she was gone. Standing up, walking away. He turned in his seat and inched himself to the door she left open, put his feet out, and watched her walk away, Rick-Joe on her left, Colt on her right. She still wore Colt’s flannel shirt, her skinny bare legs strutting underneath. She laughed and talked while they walked, hands on her hips but with her elbows pointed almost behind her. It thrust her breasts out. They would be looking at them.

Darkness swallowed them as they dipped down the slope heading to the fire pit.

Well what do you want to do Harrison? What do you want to do? You can't leave. You're blocked in. You can ask Colt to move his car (and Riley would have to as well). You can go and talk to them, tell them how you have to leave, and embarrass the fuck out of yourself. And then have to wait and listen as Colt told you he couldn't find his keys or something, playing out your torture with cruel glee.

You could go and sit by the fire.

She wasn't saying you were done. If it wasn't over, it *wasn't* over. She didn't want you to sit in the back of the Soob. She wanted you by the fire ...

"Fuck," he said. He didn't want to go sit by the fire. He wanted to go home.

Out of the Soob, bag slung over his shoulder, he followed where she'd gone, walking down the slope toward the back of the house. He cut across by the barbecues and came to the top of the steps. He was going to set his bag down and rejoin his friends but he saw them all around the fire—Taylor sat on Colt's knee.

Bundled up in his flannel shirt, she gathered it around her thin body and clutched it between her breasts as though she were still cold. Colt's hand lay on her back, his other hand on her knee.

He didn't even see any other faces, he just saw that.

He took a step down, hesitated, took another. Taylor's eyes came up and met his and she smiled. It was too much. He turned around and stomped his way back into the house.

Fucking bitch. What was she doing to him?

He hammered up the steps and threw his knapsack down the hall where it bounced once, hit the hallway table and skidded to touch the front door. "Fuck!" he shouted. He was trapped here, and it was the last place on earth he wanted to be right now.

"Hey."

A soft, soothing and gentle voice next to him.

Taylor stood at the top of the basement steps, one thin leg lifted, her foot on the bare hardwood floor. Colt's shirt was open and he could see her tight tummy and the strings of her tiny bikini. Her wet hair had dried but was tied up in a wispy bun on top of her head. She wore no makeup, but she'd never been more beautiful than right now. Her eyes flitted from his to see where his bag was thrown. She'd witnessed that tantrum.

She said, "Come up to my bedroom."

THE FIRST THING she did when they were alone together in her bedroom was step with her feet in between his and wrap her arms around him. She hugged him tenderly, rested her chin on his collar. Over his back, her hands began to work, squeezing his shoulders and his neck. She said, "I love you so much, Harrison."

It was one of those sentences where a '*but*' was expected. This was it. He said, "Just do what you need to do."

Hands still working on him, she said, "What does that mean?"

"Say what you have to say."

"I love you," she whispered into his chest.

He waited a few heartbeats before his hands went to her, moving up underneath Colt's flannel shirt and finding her bare chilled skin. Her stomach fluttered at his touch. She said, "Your hands are *so* warm."

The tension he felt was now being squeezed out of him, a certain excitement coming on in its stead. He said, "What's happening tonight? Just tell me."

"I don't know," she said, and that stabbed him.

"What do you mean you don't know?"

"I don't know what's happening."

"Look at me," he said. Hands taking her by the shoulders, he put some space between them and looked in her gray eyes. She was on the verge of tears as well, biting at the inside of her cheek and watching him. His hand moved to cup the side of her neck, thumb stroking on the fine angle of her delicate jaw.

She said, "I really don't know what's happening."

“We’re not good, are we?”

“I hope we are,” she said, in a sanguine tone. In her eyes he saw some light.

“You *hope* we’re okay?”

“I do.”

He said, “It’s you. Your decision. You’re the one that has *all* the power.”

She tilted her head to rest against his hand, pinching it against her collar.

She said, “That’s not true.”

He laughed without humor. “You know it’s totally true.”

Her hand came to cover his, the two of them holding her neck now. She said, “We’re going to be so far away.”

“Can I trust you?”

She closed her eyes.

He waited and still she didn’t answer. *It was a really simple question, Taylor.*

He asked again, “Can I trust you?” His voice was firmer.

She said, “Harrison, you’re the best guy in my whole life. My best friend.”

Here was that but coming.

Neck sweeping from his grasp, she moved away, turning her back to him. Arms crossed around herself like she was cold, she walked toward her bed with her head down.

He said, “That sounded like a but was coming.” *Might as well get right to it.*

She turned around to sit on the bed. She said, “I mean it. There’s nobody in my whole life I can rely on more than you.”

“Okay,” he said, and took a few steps toward the bed, stood near the foot. She looked up at him, patted the spot next to her. It felt like a trap.

He went anyway, took a few more steps and sat down next to her, turned his face to hers. “I love you so, so much,” she said.

He said, “Did you get into Michigan?”

She shook her head no. He said, “Did you *apply* to Michigan?”

She shook her head no again.

An odd, embarrassing sound hissed from him, and his hand leapt to his stomach and covered it. Thumb pressing into his diaphragm, he dug at what felt like a lead ball that had just popped up like a big balloon inside him.

Kelsey Kay was right. *He knew she was right all along and didn't want to admit it.* "You didn't?"

She still shook her head no.

He said, "You told me you did."

She said, "I want to go to California."

"I could've gone, too," he said. Those words out in the open air sounded so lame, so weak. *She didn't want you there, Harrison.*

Taylor stared at the floor, her head continuing to oscillate side-to-side, still saying no.

"Why are you doing this to me?" His voice had thinned to a whine.

That woke her up, and she shook her head before looking at him directly. She said, "The last thing I want to do is hurt you," as she reached to cup his face.

"But you are. Everything you're doing."

"Harrison, I don't know what to tell you. I don't want to hurt you."

"That's why you're going to break up with me?"

"I don't want to break up with you."

"You don't?"

Now her eyes welled up, and she squinted. A tear squeezed from her eye and fell down her cheek, splashed onto Colt's flannel shirt. A dark stain spread in the colors of his plaid. She said, "I have to."

"What do you mean you have to?" he said, darting his head back so she couldn't touch him.

Her hand still hovered between them and he reached out and held her wrist tightly. More tears came from her, and she said, "I don't want to hurt you."

"Then don't break up with me."

"I have to," she cried, crawled forward and fell against him. He put his arms around her and held her. This was crazy. *What was she saying?*

He sat with her for a while, and she cried against his collar and he rubbed her back. Soon he eased her to sit upright again. He said, "Don't break up with me. You don't have to. Not if you don't want to."

She turned her face away, her pretty features pinched and curved with intense sadness. Her face shone red, marks of tears lined her neck and cheeks. She very softly said something he couldn't hear. One word stuck out, and he feared the meaning. He said, "What did you say?"

She sniffled, whispered, "I'm not going to be faithful."

It was like his bomb bay doors opened and all his guts fell out somewhere over Berlin. Suddenly empty, his head lifted off his body, his airy mind floating somewhere near the ceiling and looking down on all this hurt. He said, "You can't be faithful?"

She shook her head no. "I know I'm not going to be."

He shook her shoulders to make her open her eyes. She turned her face away farther, and he grabbed handfuls of Colt's shirt to make her sit upright and face him. He said, "What are you saying? You're not going to be faithful?"

She said, "I don't want to break up with you. I love you. But when I go to college, I'm going to ..." She couldn't finish.

"Going to what? Sleep with other guys?"

She nodded her head yes and her face twisted up again. She sobbed and leaned forward looking for another hug. Typical Taylor. Always getting what she wanted. He was hurting, and she was the one who needed to be hugged. Hypocritical Taylor, completely unaware of all the hurt she caused.

He pushed her back, and she startled. Now she cried harder. "That's why you're going on the pill?" *Stupid question.*

She didn't answer, hid her face from him and tucked her hands between her knees. She said, "I'm sorry."

"I can be faithful to you. The easiest thing in the world for me to do. You went away to a different school to get away from me?"

She shook her head no again. "I just want to go surfing," she sobbed.

"Bullshit," he said. "How can you do this? How can you be like this?"

She said, "I love you, Harrison. I love you with all my heart."

He stared at her sweet face. She wasn't kidding. She wasn't doing it for attention and she wasn't doing it to encourage him to soothe her when she was hurting. He could see she meant it. "If you love me so much, how can you sleep with other guys?"

"Harrison, you're my only boyfriend ever. Real boyfriend. I've only ever been with you."

"Is that true?"

She was offended. She said, "I've only ever had sex with you."

"I've only ever had sex with you, too," he said, liking the feel in this moment.

She said, "Nobody will ever be better to me than you. I know it. I really, *really* know it." She closed a fist and pressed it between her breasts. She

said, "I can't ..."

"Can't what?"

"Can't marry the only guy I've ever been with. I can't marry my high school boyfriend ..."

He put his hands up, unsure of how to respond. He said, "Who said anything about—"

She said, "I don't mean *that*. I just mean, I can't be with you only ever."

"You just *have* to sleep with other guys?"

She said, "I don't have to, I'm just *going* to," slightly irritated.

"You want to," he said coldly, like it was shameful.

"I want to," she agreed plainly.

A roaring swell of hurt came up from his knees, washing through his insides, weakness swirling up his back and making him slump forward. *Taylor desired other men.*

"You can't even wait to get to California, you want to have sex with Colt tonight, don't you?"

"I don't know."

"You don't know? You might?"

She shrugged.

"We're done then? This is it? This is how you want to end our friendship? How you want to end *us*? We've been together so long, Taylor ... Colt is really worth it?"

"I don't want to end us, Harrison ..."

He scoffed, incredulity sparking through him, static shock at how selfish she was. "Typical privileged rich little white girl," he spat. "Your wants are so simple. You just want fucking *everything*. You're such *bullshit*."

She sighed heavily, a sob really, and continued to stare at the floor. A tremble took hold of her lips and her eyebrows tented.

He said, "You're *everything* to me. I wake up I think about you, I go to sleep I'm thinking about you. I do everything for you and this is what I get? ..."

"I don't ask you to ..."

"That's what you do when you're in love, Taylor."

"I do love you," she cried, "I do, Harrison, I do, I think about you all the time ..."

She broke into full sobs now and he couldn't hold his back anymore.

"Then why are you killing me? This is killing me, Taylor ..."

"I don't want to hurt you, I told you," she cried. "Can't we just take a break? ..."

"A break? Are you kidding?"

"No-ho," she sobbed.

"What—you want to fuck every guy at UC then come home and you'll sit at my family's Thanksgiving table?"

She stared at him, eyes trembling, tears streaming, huffing shaky breaths. She'd pursed her lips tight, but it didn't stop them quivering.

"I'm not going to say it, Taylor. I'm not going to do it for you. I'm done making your life easy for you. Grow up. If you want to break up with me say it to my face. Tell me we're through. *You* push away the best thing you'll ever have. *You* do it. Push away your best friend. A *break*? ... You want us to go on a *break*? You're a coward. That's what a coward says."

"I'm not a coward."

He didn't answer, just shook his head at her. Tears returned, and he had to blink them away.

She said, "I don't want to lose you. I don't want to break up with you. Can't you hear me, Harrison? I love you."

"Tell me what you want then. Really want. Be honest with me for one fucking time this weekend."

Before slimming to a line, her lips trembled. She said, "That wasn't me in the boathouse with Colt."

He sighed heavily, looked away and shook his head. "I know. I believe you."

She sighed, too. Once, deep, the brief, hoarse sound of a sob laced inside it. Now her face turned up and her gray eyes were wet, the whites gone pink. Tears rimmed her eyes anew and one rolled down and she swiped it away with a quick, childlike movement.

"What?"

She said, "That wasn't me with Colt."

"I know, Taylor."

"It was me with Stevie," she blurted, the other boy's name practically unintelligible because now she burst out crying. She fell against him and her arms hooped his shoulders, clutching tightly; her light body clung to him with surprising weight. She sobbed and wailed into his chest and he held her, eyes staring wildly across the dim bedroom.

He was right. Of course he was fucking right. He knew it. *Knew it was her.* Stevie, damn it, it was Stevie.

“You did that with Stevie?” he whispered.

“I know,” she cried, acknowledging how bad they both knew it was.

“You kissed him. You ... You had his penis in your hand. Did you jerk him off?”

“No.”

“I *saw* you ...”

“I didn’t finish it ...”

“His finger ... did he finger you?”

She didn’t answer, clutched him tighter, thin forearms like hard sticks pressing into his neck and hurting him. She was wracked with tremors now.

“Did he finger you, Taylor?”

She nodded her head, pointy chin digging into him. He reeled. She’d gone out there to jerk Stevie off, to fool around, who knows what else. Would they have fucked? *Stevie put his fingers inside her.* He wanted to cry, he wanted to throw her down on her bedroom floor, he wanted to *fuck* her. His cock had grown hard despite his jealous pain.

“How could you *do* this?”

“I don’t know,” she cried in soft chugs.

“You took him out there?”

“No,” she whispered. “We just went out swimming.”

“He wanted to go to the boathouse?”

“Yes.”

“Did *you* bring the glow stick?”

She made a whimpering sound—his mention of the glow stick confirming to her that he indeed swam out to the boathouse and watched. Her head shook from side to side, and he caressed her back. “He did.”

“I saw you with him, Taylor. You were ... *eager* ...”

“I *know* ...”

“You admit it?”

“I’m not sorry—”

He scoffed, hurt, pushed her face back to watch her eyes.

She said, “I mean I’m *sorry*, sorry for you, but I’m not sorry ...”

“*You’re not sorry?*”

“I am, I am. I’m sorry, Harrison. I’m such a bitch, such a bad girlfriend. I’m *sorry* I hurt you.”

“But you’re not sorry you did it? You’re sorry I found out?”

“I wanted to do it.”

“Wanted to make out with him?”

She nodded, her eyes averted.

“Wanted to jerk him off?”

She nodded again.

“*Are you serious?*”

“Not exactly that. But who knows? ...”

“More?”

She nodded again, looked in his eyes now.

“Fuck, Taylor. Fuck. What is *wrong* with you? How can you even say this?”

“I don’t want to hurt you,” she said in a kindly sing-song, thick with sadness.

“Don’t want to—? ... Taylor, you’re breaking my heart,” he said pleadingly, clutching his chest to show her. His eyebrows tented and he couldn’t help his own tears now. “Why? What did I do? What did I ever do to you?”

“Don’t leave me, Harrison. Be my friend ...”

“Your friend? After all we’ve been through, you do this to me, and you want me to still *like* you?”

“You won’t like me?” Her voice was thin but shrill.

“Taylor ...”

In rushed desperation, she said, “If we met for the first time when we were out of college, would you fall in love with me?”

“Of course ...

“But I would have a past ...”

He laughed a sound showing off his irritation.

“What ...?” She looked at him pleadingly.

“You want to go on a break to fuck your way through college and have me waiting at the end for you?”

“You can ... you can ...”

“What? Sleep with other girls?”

She nodded.

“That’s breaking up with me,” he said.

“Not to me it’s not.”

He stared into her eyes, feeling the anger subsiding, seeing less and less the slut-vixen he'd painted her as in his own mind over the last hour, and returning to him was his best friend, his buddy. His girlfriend. Her eyes were honest. Her words were pain, but she was no coward. She wanted to go on a break.

"I don't want to sleep with anyone else, Taylor."

Her head rolled slightly, knowing that was the right thing to say to someone you loved, and she had just professed endlessly how much she loved him.

"I'm awful," she whispered, more tears coming.

"You can sleep with other guys and still love me?" he said mockingly.

Her mouth worked around and she inched closer to him until their bodies pressed. She cupped his cheek and looked in his eyes. "I know I couldn't ever stop loving you, no matter what."

The tenderness of her touch and the kindness in her words warred with her enormity. She was at once the greatest human gift his life had been ever presented, a beautiful being he couldn't bear to be without, one whom he thought of endlessly even before they professed their romantic love for one another—and yet what she'd done this weekend was depraved and hurtful. She thought she could get away with it but she got caught.

"You've never cheated on me before?"

"Did I cheat?" she said bewilderingly, more to herself than to him.

"Yeah. You did."

"I did," she whispered. "Harrison, on my life, I've never done something like this before, not even close."

They sat together, looking at each other's collars and breathed.

After a long while, he said, "You can do what you want."

"Don't hate me."

"I won't hate you, Taylor," he said as his hands let her go and he stood at the side of the bed with his back to her.

She asked him: "Well, what are we doing?"

"I don't know, Taylor." He stooped and retrieved his knapsack.

"Where are you going? Please, baby, don't leave ..."

"I'm not leaving, but I'm not staying in *here*."

"Harrison ..."

"I'll be in with Mikey and Cisco."

"Don't leave, Harrison. Promise me."

Paused at her bedroom door, he said, "Fuck whoever you want, Taylor. Fuck Colt, fuck Stevie. Have a great time."

"Harrison ... don't say that ... Are you ... are going to hate me?"

"I don't know yet. Do it and find out."

"Harrison, please don't leave my room. I *want* you in my room." She stared at him solemnly and he glared back at her. She wiped at her cheek as he stepped out into the hall and closed the door behind him.

PART 4

WITH HIS BAG slung over his shoulder he walked heavily down the hall. The corridor was dim, the only light coming from the kitchen below.

He felt aimless, knowing where he was headed yet listing from side-to-side, one hand touching the left wall then the right hand touching the right. His eyes were wide open, but he wasn't seeing. Then he was at the door to the room where he used to stay. Back in his place. The last two years he'd flown high up near the sun but his fakery wings' wax had been melted, and now he was plummeting to sleep in the room with Mikey and Cisco. That was the way it was meant to be.

He pushed the door open, dragged his feet inside, dropped his bag on the floor. The window to the room was left cracked open and he could clearly hear the strum of Mikey's guitar and the rasp of his voice.

Mind just an empty space now, he sat on the edge of the bed. The conversation with Taylor was lost to him. Couldn't even really remember what they'd said. The emotions were gone, too. The emptiness was better than the pain.

When he zipped open his knapsack, a psychic spike lunged through him and the hurt returned. Sitting on the top of his packed things, somehow shuffling its way nearer the mouth, was the pouch of Haribo Gold Bears he'd brought for Taylor. He took it out, crinkled the pack, rubbed his thumbs over the lumpy shapes underneath. He stood up, saw on the dresser the tuna can with the bright green lid, Mikey's lighter resting atop; behind it, a plastic mickey with a few mouthfuls of vodka remaining. He took them all, putting the mickey in his pocket, the Gold Bears and the tuna can together in his left hand.

The crank squeaked as he wound the window open wide on its lever, and he hiked a knee up, set a sneaker out onto the rough asphalt shingles and stepped outside. This room looked down over the fire pit. All his friends were twenty feet below. A good swan dive right now would end everything nicely and extinguish the liquid hurt sloshing around his insides, ready to soon drown his system when he fully comprehended what he lost tonight. But he had a lot to ponder, so he took a step then set himself down on his butt with his legs sticking straight out.

Between his feet he could see the fire below and the ring of faces. Roxie sat on Care Bear's knee; Shelby was near the fire with a metal prong skewered with four marshmallows, an individual s'more kit he'd prepared sitting next to her on the arm of a chair; Mikey strummed; Cisco sat leaning back in his chair as if he might be asleep, legs outstretched, bare feet resting on the rock, soles warmed by the fire; Cookie and Jamie made out; Kelsey Kay and Brady hung out together talking closely, eating s'mores ... It made him smile.

There was no sign of Colt, but he could see Stevie talking with KC, standing just outside the fire's warmth. Taylor had kissed him, held his dick. His *hard* dick. He'd fingered her. His scalp tingled, and he somehow felt a secret commiseration for Taylor's brother, talking obliviously with his friend and teammate who had messed around with his little sister.

From his pocket he fished out the plastic mickey, screwed off the top and took a healthy swig of vodka. Some leaked down his throat, and he ended up squittering a sparkling stream across the shingles. He wiped his mouth with the back of his hand and spat out the remaining taste. Lid screwed back on, he chucked it over his shoulder and back into the bedroom.

Mikey broke into some Bruno Mars and Shelby clapped and said Yay. Harrison pried off the lid of the tuna can, fished around his pocket and found the lighter, flicked a flame, free hand cupping Mikey's joint sticking out of his mouth. It took a few puffs, imitating what he'd seen others do, but he breathed in and he held it. He coughed, snorted, then rubbed at the side of his nose with a knuckle.

Now he breathed deep, looked out down to the beach. The football guys would probably be down there. Pontoon, Rick-Joe, Colt—the guy he hated and who sat on the tailgate of his pickup truck and told him *I'm gonna fuck your girlfriend tonight. Just watch me.* Whatever.

He took another long drag, actually not feeling too bad about this right now. Maybe he wasn't enough fun. Maybe he should be more fun. Responsibility was for assholes. It was the kids who lifted weights and pushed people around who got the girls. Maybe he should lift weights.

He exhaled in a cough, then batted away the smoke lit up in blue from the fire down below. A faint figure headed across the deck. It was dim, but it was Taylor. Long thin legs, drowning in another guy's flannel shirt. She didn't approach the fire, stood facing it on the stairs near the barbecues.

His eyes scanned to the right, and he saw Roxie jump up from Care Bear's knee, looking shocked and alert. Care Bear braced her, putting a huge hand that covered the entirety of her back. She took a few steps forward and tapped Shelby. Shelby looked and saw Taylor standing there. The two of them ran off together, and Harrison lost them for a moment in the dark. But then he could see all three of them, walking up the steps a little toward the barbecues. Taylor had both her hands over her face like she was crying. Shelby rubbed her back, and Roxie stood by looking worried. Then the three of them went away, walking off to the left, toward the woods where he'd had his confrontation with her. Where she told him she didn't do what she actually did. Lied to his face.

Now a sickness came over him. The hurt worked its way up in tangling tense lines. He'd been in that brief moment between when you stub your toe and you think it's not going to hurt. Then it comes at you, and for a moment you wonder if you'll be able to keep it together and you can't imagine a worse pain. His heart began to throb. His heart began to throb and his head began to pound. He chuckled. There was nothing funny. Why would he think something was funny? What was funny? *Don't laugh.* He started to giggle. And the more stupid he thought it was that he was giggling the more he giggled. He had to cover his face with both hands and he lay down on his side. Listening to the music below, soon the ironic urge to giggle dissipated and became soft crying sounds. Quiet sounds, controlled, not braying into his hands and wailing the loss of the love of his life. He just breathed deep and exhaled a soft cry. Breathed deep and exhaled a soft cry. It was meditative. It would keep him alive for a little while longer.

Images came to him in series. The first time he met Taylor. He was *so* nervous. They shared lunch at recess in the public school's playground, the second day of school for him in Saginaw after he moved from Three Rivers. She dropped the foil lid of his chocolate pudding he shared with her right

onto his pant leg. He'd been so tense sitting with a pretty girl that he thought he might blubber, but the way she fawned over him made him feel *so* good. She was so sorry for ruining his pants. She couldn't get over that she'd done that. Put it all on herself, and then it looked like she might be the one to blubber. She was calling herself stupid, stupid, and he said, *You're not stupid, these pants were asking for it.* Then they were both laughing. Then he was eating lunch with her every day. More images. Summer vacation. The time he went to the Brooks with the Brooks to Martha's Vineyard. They went to the Black Dog, to the shipyards. Birthday parties, Six Flags, hanging out at the mall, this fucking lake house ... He could recount every movie they stayed up late to watch. The night they'd blown off the school dance even though Taylor was the most popular girl in his class (she was really sad because her dad had moved out of the house). They stayed at home on a Friday night, ate candies and microwave popcorn, watched the first three *Insidious* movies back-to-back-to-back, and he went to the bathroom and hid. When she came looking for him—she knew it was going to be bad and tittered nervously—he jumped out of a linen closet and she screamed so loud her mother came running down the stairs. Trish had to work the next morning even though it was a Saturday and she made Harrison go home. He lay in his bed and they face-timed till 3 A.M., both of them laughing their asses off. Trish had *totally* lost her shit. That was about a month before they finally told each other how they felt and became a couple. God, every day he'd spent with her he loved her. How could she do this?

WHEN HE WOKE, he blinked and stared, not comprehending that he'd been asleep at all. His hands darted around, frantic, looking for the joint. *Holy shit, imagine if he set the Brooks lake house on fire?* The night their daughter broke up with him? Try and prove you weren't a firebug. Try proving it wasn't arson. He could end up in jail for life.

"Shit, shit, shit," he said, scrambling around in the dark on his hands and knees. "No, no, no ..."

But he found it. Just a tiny ashen stub, no longer even warm. He put it in the tuna can and closed the lid then reached around until he found the crinkling bag of Gold Bears. He fished one out and looked at the fire below. He coughed up the candy.

Taylor was down there.

She wasn't sad anymore. She sat with Colt.

His heart stopped. He literally took his fist and began to beat it against his chest. His eyes were wide and glued on her. She'd gone off into the woods to cry. How long had he been asleep? Twenty minutes? Half an hour? That's how long it took to get over Harrison Wade. Yep. Your best friend, and a boyfriend for two years, that should be an easy twenty minutes of snuffling. He would lament this night forever. His heart was crushed and he would burn forever when he heard the name Taylor Brooks. Taylor Brooks, on the other hand, cried a little on Shelby's arm, sniffled, someone rubbed a circle on her back, she dried her eyes, and she was onto boyfriend number two. Big dick, old-ass Colt.

Sure, honey, spread your legs for that piece of shit. Spread your legs for that bullying asshole. You two are perfect together. Why don't you send me

pictures of the shit you do together. Every day you can text me a new one. The two of you will be a great team.

He gritted his teeth and muttered to himself lines and words of pure hate. Hating Taylor. Hating Colt. Yet he was aroused again. He grabbed his erection through his pants and pushed it down, trying to get it down his short leg so he could sit on it.

Fucking asshole dick. Fuck you, Colt.

He began to cry again. The vision of his girlfriend sitting with another guy getting warbled. He sniffled and wiped the wet away and stared laser beams at them. They were side-by-side. She still wore his shirt. His flannel buttoned up part way now, her legs still bare, her painted toes peeking out the straps of her Birks. They were touching. Hips touching hips.

Roxie was back on Care Bear's knee. Mikey was doing fucking American Pie again. *It was fine the first time, okay, asshole?—this time it's torture.* Colt didn't sing along because Harrison was sure Colt thought it was stupid. Taylor sang along. The song that was theirs for around the fire when they were kids *and* when they were lovers. Young lovers. Stupid ones. His entire past became poisoned in three heartbeats watching this awful display.

His eyes didn't leave her though. Watched every move she made. He watched through three songs. The two of them sitting side-by-side, sometimes he would lean close and say something to her, and she would smile then run her hair behind an ear. Every single time: *whisper, whisper*, and she would do that thing with her hair. It was killing him. When she stood to roast marshmallows, Colt watched her bent over rump. He wouldn't see it under the tail of his shirt that she wore, but he knew what was under it. He'd seen it earlier in her thong bikini. Taylor showing it to *everybody*. And that's what she would do in Santa Cruz. Starting at that beach—Pleasure Points or whatever fucking shit it was—strutting up and down with a dumb surfboard under her arm. She'd fuck some tanned muscular surfer every day. A new one every day. Go through them all and then start over again. Who wouldn't want her? She was beautiful. She was smart. She was *his*. Had been.

A break? Was she kidding? He knew she wasn't—but how could she ask that of him? A break from Harrison. Boring old dopey skinny Harrison. Her unexciting high school boyish boyfriend. She would have sex with Colt. She would have sex with a lot of guys like Colt. Sure, she would come

back to him. After spreading her legs for guys like that, *sure* she would. She'd love to get a little taste of his normal penis. Of his normal body.

He had to squeeze his erection again. It occurred to him though, nobody ever would love her the way he did. Could a girl sense something like that? Could she know there was a difference? Did they all fall for the big muscular guys? Did they all enter into relationships that ended badly, hook up with dudes who treated them like shit, even when good guys were all around? Could it be possible they would survive a break? Could they survive a gap in time where she did all the things she wanted to do and yet they would come together in the end and be restored? *Highly unlikely*. He sighed heavily.

Taylor's marshmallows were roasted, and as she went to sit down, Colt gripped her waist and pulled her to sit in his lap. It got her laughing, and she collapsed, her back falling against his chest and her head on his shoulder. She giggled and looked in his eyes now and Harrison had to press his cheeks. New tears came. She had two marshmallows on the prong, and she took one now, plucked it free from the tine and moved it slowly like a mother sending an airplane to a baby's mouth. Colt opened, and she plopped it in. He ate it. She watched him. She put the fork to her mouth with her perfect teeth, plucked the remaining roasted marshmallow into her mouth.

Colt whispered something in her ear, and Taylor's eyes went wide. She covered her mouth now while she chewed and held his gaze. He whispered something else. She looked around the ring of friends, expression forlorn. She returned, leaned back and cupped her hand to his ear and whispered something to him. He nodded, whispered something to her.

Taylor got off his lap and sat next to him. She poked the metal fork into the ash near the base of the fire, wiped at her face, looked around covertly. Now she stood, walked around behind Cisco, doubled back around behind Care Bear and disappeared into the dark.

Harrison stared after her, looking to see where she went. A minute later he saw a figure moving on the steps again. Last time he'd seen her there she was summoning her friends to help her cry it out, now she was walking with grim determination, moving between the barbecues, then she was gone, disappearing beneath the edge of the roof where he couldn't see her anymore.

When his eyes returned to the fire, he could see Colt looking around surreptitiously, too. He spotted KC, watched him. KC was standing behind Mikey, talking to hand job Stevie. They weren't paying him attention at all.

Colt stretched, looked around again, stood and stepped away from the fire. He went down the slope toward the beach and a minute later he saw Colt heading up the stairs and going into the house, using the same path Taylor had taken.

"Holy shit," he sighed, and gripped the hair above his ears on either side of his head. He pulled, held his tangled locks in his greasy grip, pulled his fists away and beat at his temples again and again.

It was unreal. This night's torture was never going to end. This was never going to be over.

He felt the tears come again, and before he knew it he was up and crouching, moving like Spider-Man—just how he used to think back when he would creep around this roof after reading comic books on the beach and try to spy on Taylor while she undressed. This was old action. This was sneaky Harrison, and he knew exactly what he was doing. In a low, hunkering crawl, he stealthily made his way past the bedroom windows where Riley's room was, past the next room's dormer window, slowing as he came near Taylor's ...

TAYLOR CLOSED the bedroom door behind her, kicked off her Birks. In bare feet, she pranced around her room, trying to be quiet but moving as quick as she could without making noise. She leapt to her dresser, untangled her ponytail, picked up her hairbrush and began stroking at her hair then came bounding right to Harrison watching through the window.

He gulped air, almost fell backward. *Yeah, he could just tumble backward now and die. Go ass over head and fall down splat somewhere below near the barbecues.*

He put a hand up to balance himself. He went lightheaded and dizzy suddenly. She was right directly in front of him but couldn't see him because the window showed only her own reflection to her.

As Taylor grabbed the window's crank and spun it around madly, he shunted to the side. The window scissored outward. If the light that spilled from her window touched him now it would show off that he was there. He waited a long, endless beat before she would spot him and scream, but she didn't even look outside.

Brush still stroking through her hair, she hopped around, grabbed up Harrison's red T-shirt off the floor, tossed the brush away. The shirt was draped carefully over the shade of the bedside lamp. She reached under and flicked it on. The room glowed in bright pink. Then she was prancing again, over to the door and clicking off the room light. Now her room was dim and scarlet and ambient.

Another shirt was snatched off the floor, and she shoved it down the front of her bikini bottoms. She had a thumb hooked in the front of them, giving herself room to wipe at herself. She swiped and swiped, flipped the

shirt over and swiped again. Shirt dropped to the floor, she kicked it under the bed.

She looked expectantly at the door to the room, one more thing occurred to her and she sidestepped quickly; there was a bottle of perfume on the dresser, she took the lid off, spritzed her wrists, set it back down then rubbed circles on her tummy and below her navel. As the door opened, she was fluffing her hair out with raking fingers. Colt was in her room now.

He came in, full of swagger, but looking around, too, a little nervous—aware this could be trouble. This girl had a boyfriend. This girl had a protective older brother. He should not be doing this. *She should not be doing this.* Door closed behind Colt now, Harrison crawled nearer the window and moved around the scissored out glass. The light coming from the table lamp was dim and red, and he held out a hand to see if it would light him. It did, but just barely. Harrison watched from the windowsill as Colt came in Taylor's room and she moved around flirtatiously.

Near the foot of her bed, Colt looked around again, said, "Last time I saw you in here, you didn't have your top on."

She said, "You didn't knock."

"I'm glad I didn't," he said and stepped toward her.

Head falling back, she eyed him through narrow slits. She smiled. His muscular hands came together in the center of her chest and he undid one of the buttons. Harrison clutched his erection through his pants. He didn't even have the right to stop this anymore. They weren't even going out. Were they? Did they even break up? He couldn't even remember what was said—only knew it was *bad*. Only knew she had hurt him more profoundly than anybody ever had. And yet, he *loved* her still. So much. He knew it. That's why he was hard. Because he *loved* her.

Were they on a break? Maybe they *were*. It was all a fast-paced blur. None of it mattered anyway. His girlfriend was willing to have her shirt opened by this handsome older college guy. It was his shirt anyway, wasn't it? She wore it proudly. *Wore it proudly all night right in front of you, you dumbass.*

When Colt had it open, he pulled her close to him, making her head tilt back. She ran a hand through her hair and smiled again.

Then he was peeling the shirt back, going first over one shoulder then the next, letting it fall down her back and onto the floor. He put a big hand

on her waist, starting on her ribs and sliding around, swirling on her lower back and down, grabbing an ass cheek. She bit her lower lip.

“Oh God,” Harrison sighed silently, his hand letting his erection go and clutching at his chest now. It was overwhelming. He hated it and yet he loved it, too. He *wanted* this. He wanted her to do this. It was bewildering. He felt like nothing but he felt like everything at the same time. It was intoxicating.

Colt’s other hand held the back of her neck, tugging lightly at her hair to tilt her chin up. He smiled, letting her wait for his kiss. Taylor wanted it. Her tongue darted out and licked at her lower lip. She smiled again, then the smile faded, and she closed her eyes. Colt kissed her. Pressed his lips to hers, kissed her sweetly at first, then gripped her neck tighter and Taylor ran out her tongue and he took it.

WITH HIS HANDS on her narrow waist, Colt turned Taylor around so her back was to her bed, kissing her lips while he did. He eased her backward, and she stepped until her legs touched the bed. It sat her down on it and his kiss followed her along, their lips never leaving each other's.

Taylor lay back on the bed, finally letting her lips plop free from his. She scooted rearward, and he climbed on to the bed and lay next to her. Now their heads were on the pillow together just underneath Harrison. He could reach in over the sill and stroke her hair. They made out, side-by-side but with Colt's face over top of hers, her hand stroking the bulging muscles of his arm.

When her knee came up overtop his thigh, he stuck his leg in between hers and rolled on top of her. Now he was over her and Taylor's hands went immediately to his ass. She fondled him, tugged at the cotton of his shorts, felt his rump and grabbed at his pockets, tugged at the loops of his belt. They hung low on his waist and Harrison could see the waistband of his underwear.

They ground their pelvises against each other, their lips making popping, smacking noises. Taylor writhed underneath him, and the muscles in his arms bulged and flexed. His hand came up to touch her shoulder. He kissed her, drew away, she smiled, he suckled her mouth again while his fingers slipped under the strap of her bikini bra, slid down to peel the tiny cup back and expose her soft brown nipple. He kissed his way to it, took it in his mouth. The whole while his hips were humping his cock against her. She was humping back against him, too.

As Colt took her hardening bud into his mouth, she moaned and her head tilted back. Harrison could see her mouth open, her white teeth and her pale pink tongue pressing down. Her hands were moving again, down to Colt's narrow waist, squeezing the muscles of his hard ass. Her long, thin brown legs worked slowly up and down, tangled in a scissor with Colt's. Harrison watched her bare feet, saw her coral-painted toes flex to points.

Taylor's hands took the hem of his T-shirt, began to work it upward. She said, "Let me see your body."

Colt raised up, kneeled over top of her and did what he was asked. He peeled his shirt up, the red lamp light casting upward on him, showing all the ripples, ridges, and bulges of his hard body. His chest was broad and his shoulders huge, his biceps were thick and round. Then he was overtop of her as Taylor made cooing sounds, loving what she saw. Her hands went over his bare sides, squeezing on his muscles, his wide lats, touching him. She moaned ecstatically while he suckled her neck then took her lips again.

Harrison watched Taylor's pretty feet as she writhed underneath Colt. Her legs were so long her toes almost touched the footboard. She brought a knee up, hooked an ankle around his waist. Her right hand tugged at his shorts, pulling them down his rump and exposing more of his blue underwear. She pulled on them harder, grabbing his shorts leg and pushing them down. She was so enthusiastic it was driving Harrison mad.

Colt's right hand slipped down her body and cupped her pussy over her bikini bottoms. He squeezed it. She cried out. Her hands were swooping circles over his back, the right hand slipping now underneath his underwear, pushing back the bright blue cotton and exposing one perfectly round, hard ass cheek. Colt pumped his crotch against her pussy, his hand down there, too, and she brought a knee up to let him get better access to her sex.

Colt raised up over top of her on one arm, and she looked his chest and stomach over, said, "You're so fucking sexy."

Colt's hand pushed a middle finger over top of her turquoise bikini bottom and stroked the crease of her pussy and it made Taylor's legs shake. He raised up, kneeling astride one of her legs and began to untie the knot on the hip of her bikini bottom. Then he got between her legs, Taylor moaning and watching his hands work at baring her sex to him, her legs spread out on either side of his hips but her knees pressed together, like she was hiding the sight of her pussy from him.

He took the stringy bikini bottom and pulled it free, slipping it down one of her long legs that she raised up for him and he tossed it to the floor. Taylor did a little sit-up and put her hands behind her back, untied her bikini bra and Colt grabbed it in the middle then flung it free. Now she was totally naked in front of him. He was shirtless with his shorts on. She said, "Let me see it."

He touched his waistband, tugged up where she'd pushed it down, said, "You've been curious, saying that shit in front of your boyfriend. You're bad."

She put her hands over her face as if she was shy. The arches of her feet stroked up and down the bed on the outside of his thighs, her knees still together—though the way she was curled, he must have still been able to see her pussy.

He got off her, stood next to the bed now, one side of his shorts fallen back down. He watched her face as she waited to see what he had between his legs revealed. The zipper was drawn down, the button undone; he let them drop.

The bright blue underpants he wore were humped out, that big thing he had in there straining against the material. Taylor made a funny sigh looking at it. "You're so hot," she whispered.

The guy *was* unbelievably beautiful. Flat stomach with ridged abs, chiseled hips, a thin waist; stacks of muscles that ran up his middle and a broad, rounded chest like a young gymnast; shoulders like cantaloupes, veins running through them and down his arms. It was no wonder she was doing this. If she *could* have this why wouldn't she take it?

COLT TUCKED his fingers into his underpants, pulled down the front and his cock fell out and bounced. He wasn't fully hard, but he was halfway there. It was huge. Under his naval a thin strip of curly hair ran until it bundled in a tangle of thick brownish pubic hair. Underneath that, his huge penis dangled, lifting outward slightly but curving down. The glans was full and flared. His testicles weren't tightened from cold water like they'd seen earlier today and they hung more loosely.

He let Taylor admire it for a moment—her sitting up, looking like she would reach out to touch it—then jumped to join her on the bed, big dick slapping between his legs. He fell over her to land on his back on the side nearest the wall.

Taylor scooted down the bed and he opened his legs. She got in between them, crouching on her knees and examining his manhood up close. It had flopped up to lay on his belly. With the tips of her fingers, she caressed the underside, bringing her finger to touch the tip and run a little circle around his urethra. He groaned and flexed his stomach muscles and she made an appreciative sound.

She kissed at the inside of his thighs; first the left, then the right. She kissed his scrotum. Ran out her tongue and drew slippery circles on his hairy balls. They drew up tight into a big brown bunch. She kissed them, took the tip of her tongue and ran along the underside of his cock, her hand sweeping up his muscular thigh to take it, hold it and run her thumb on it. Then with her eyes on his, she pointed it upward, gripped the base and opened her mouth. She tapped it against her protruding tongue, eyes closed, before she sunk it past her lips and sucked him.

He groaned again, put his head back, the feel of her tongue making him crazy. His hand reached down, huge muscular forearm bulging with blades of muscle, thin leather cords dangling from his wrist. He gripped her hair and caressed the side of her face. She bobbed on him, her hand stroking.

She came off with a wet smack and smiled. "It's so big."

"You like it?"

"It's so big I can't believe it," she said and put two hands on it now. There was still room for a third hand. She stroked two hands together and watched him in her grip, then her mouth was on it again, sucking, breathing heavy through her nose while she went up and down.

The action was hidden from Harrison now, her hair had tumbled forward and blocked the way her mouth wrapped around his cock. Just her head bobbing up and down, her glossy hair billowing in and out, settling in silky chestnut folds against the muscles of his stomach. Colt palmed the back of her head while she sucked him.

It went on for a long time, then she got up on her knees, smiling, grabbing at her hair and tossing it around. Her lips were puffy and her mouth shone wetly with saliva. She stroked him, jerked him, said, "That is the biggest dick ever." He laughed, took her wrist and pulled her forward so she fell face down on elbows and knees next to him with her butt sticking up in the air and he spanked a butt cheek and she laughed.

Taylor straddled him, getting over his hips, completely naked, her nipples like hard bolts. She adjusted herself and Colt sat up, his hand going between her legs, thumb digging into her mound while he stroked fingers across her pussy. Two fingers sunk inside her and began to shake. She cried out and put her chin to the ceiling. When she looked down, she cupped his neck and said it again: "You are so fucking sexy. Your body is unbelievable."

She leaned closer, he suckled on her nipple while still fingering her. She caressed his neck and his shoulder muscles.

Colt's head lay on the pillow right underneath Harrison, cock hard now, up past his belly button, and he put his hands up to pull his hair back from his face while Taylor admired him. She moved a little higher, looking to get the right angle so he could go inside. Then she paused, her expression falling to a troubled look.

He said, "What's wrong?"

She said, "I only have regular size condoms."

“Yeah?”

“Is that okay? Do you need bigger ones?”

“It’s fine,” he said.

She said, “You won’t break the condom or anything?”

He said, “I thought you said you were on the pill?”

She smiled, her eyes moving around as she considered it. Harrison thought *No—not without a condom*. But she was on the pill, she wouldn’t get pregnant. But that was *his* pussy, it was meant only for him ...

She bit her lower lip then said, “You don’t need a condom.”

He said, “You sure?”

“Yeah,” she said, “you can come inside me.”

HARRISON REELED, almost falling backward again. The way she said it was so *sexy*. Shoulders back, breasts thrust out, when she said *You can come inside me* she ran her fingers through her hair and tossed her locks behind her. Then she sat down so her pussy rested on his testicles.

He said, "You want me to come inside you?"

"Yeah," she gasped, a sexy little sound. "Come inside me."

She got over top of him now, her hands and elbows up on the pillow and kissed at his neck. One hand went down and stroked him. She said, "You going to fuck me?"

He said, "I'm going to fuck you so hard."

"I want you to," she said, jerking him.

He said, "Put it in."

She said, "Yeah?"

"You do it."

"You're so big," she said.

"You do it," he said, "sit on it so you're comfortable."

She said, "I've never had anyone but Harrison."

"You'll be okay. I'll be careful."

Her sly smile faded, and she looked serious for a moment. "You don't have to be."

He laughed, said, "I don't?"

She said, "I can take it."

"That's my girl," he said, hands caressing at her waist.

She kissed his neck again, hand hidden between them but her elbow moving in and out as she jerked his big cock. Then she was up, and he

stroked her thighs; she was admiring his masculine body.

Leaning forward over him, her hands went to his chest. She rubbed all over, his nipples moving around as she forcefully kneaded the skin overtop the solid muscle underneath. She sat down on the underside of his cock, her pussy making contact with his hard sex organ. Harrison's heart fluttered. The shaft still poked out, his huge cock head flared and ready for action. She gripped Colt's neck, gasping and sighing, drawing out the moment as Harrison thought he was going to die. There was still a chance she wouldn't do this. Still a chance that she would remain *his*. But then she began to hump and oil herself on him, and Colt bucked her off, pushed her on her back, her head was in the pillows underneath him. Taylor gasped with surprise but surrendered to him, opening her legs as he got over her.

She whispered, "I thought you were going to let me do it."

"You were taking your time and I'm dying for your pussy."

She bit her lower lip, smiled. "I'm nervous."

He said, "I thought you said you could take it ..."

"I can," she said, "give it to me ... give me your cock."

Colt pushed her knees up to her chest, and she straightened her legs out, her toes practically out the window. Harrison resisted the tremendous urge to caress her feet. Taylor stroked the backs of her thighs and watched Colt press her shining pussy with the head of his cock.

She said, "Put it in me. Please, put it all the way in me ..."

He said, "I bet you have a tight pussy."

"The tightest," she sighed and Colt slid himself inside her.

She cried out in pain. A bright sound and Harrison's heart condensed to stone in his chest, a hard beating shape scratching up against his ribs. The sound of her voice as she was penetrated by another man echoed in his head, repeated endlessly, and he knew he'd never forget it.

Colt slowly pushed that huge thing inside her until his hips pressed her ass. It didn't happen quickly. Her nails dug into his thick arms, she gripped handfuls of his tricep muscles as he pushed himself deeper. "Oh my God," she said, "oh my God, it's so big, oh my God ..."

"You okay?" he asked her.

"No," she said, "hold on ..."

He said, "Does it hurt?"

"It's okay," she said.

"Are you sure?"

After a few beats, she said, "Yeah."

"I thought you could take it?"

She gave a little light laugh, said, "I can take it.

"I'll go easy," he said. "Your pussy feels unbelievable."

"Does it?" Taylor's bare chest rose and fell rapidly, her fingers touched at the sides of her legs nervously.

"You feel so good," Colt said and withdrew himself a little. She gasped again. As she tilted her chin up, her face was so close to Harrison he could reach out and touch her lips. He could lean in and kiss her.

AT TIMES LIKE THIS, anxious and perplexed, contact and connection with her true self thinned to jangled wire. Her own voice coming at her with conflicting views a dozen-fold, her eyes darted wildly left and right behind her shut-down lids. But obsessive thought on reproduction—she always pictured the word like it was written in the bold humorless font printed on the cover of her abstinence-heavy sex-ed class handout—could draw her together like lining up iron filaments with a magnet.

It had an effect like being pushed out of a busy room, a bustling mosh pit, into an also noisy but somehow safe side-space of relative quiet, peace from distraction but bringing along its own intense *focus*—but the focus's allure was magnetic, and the more frenetic the external push the stronger that magnet's lure.

But they were relieving thoughts and there was something magical in seeing reproduction as a *whole*, like she could pull a drawer out of the black starry wall of the universe, withdraw the existential truth of reproduction, its tangle of facts connected in a network of struts, braces, pegs, and connectors. An unwieldy construction made up of ragtag parts like something KC would have made when he was ten-years-old, all the parts of dad's ancient erector sets from when he was a boy spread out around KC on the living room floor. She pictured it in a complexity of bouncing arms and bulbs like a chemist's model or maybe like the solar system, which made more sense, because there was a core, a sun, a star around which all else revolved, a central truth, and it was *her*, or more specifically her *uterus*. All the links and connections extended from there, but she was central. She personally, and she universally; the *feminine*. From there extended the

network of biological facts, points, and truths that depended on the uterus's acceptance of seed. The farther you extended from the core, the less relevant the facts might seem, but they were *all* connected. The furthest reaches might just be the cost of daycare, but you could follow its fact's connectors all the way to the core.

And right now in her summertime bed a boy was putting his penis inside her—his '*implement of delivery*' (*and what an implement! The tighter the seal, the greater the success! The deeper the delivery, the more assured is the genetic achievement! Size is success and satisfaction is guaranteed!*).

God, it was crazy to have one-million simultaneous thoughts—hosting such a big party but providing such a narrow door, all the guests jammed their shoulders, wedged the pathway shut.

"You okay?" Colt asked her.

"It's fine. It's uncomfortable. Just go slow."

The discomfort could be a focal point. In fact, it was *perfect*—eyes squinted shut, her mind worried the pain smooth and in only a few beats the dark hurting skies opened and Colt's intrusion warmed to wet pleasure.

Colt noticed. "You're so wet," he whispered.

"You're so hot," she told him. He sure was—probably one of her first heart-crushes; she'd spied on him and KC one afternoon from her parent's bedroom window and tried to figure out why this loud, shirtless boy made her feel so *funny*. Eight years later and he'd only got hotter. His body was *unreal*, and she'd never put her hands on a 'hot' guy before. They were different things altogether. Lust bloomed in her mind now like bacteria in a culture and she smiled, ran her hands over his naked torso, squeezed the hardness of his chest and shoulders, watched the gentle heave of his hard breathing belly as he allowed her to grow accustomed to him. Despite his current care, there was an associated surrendering to him; something else she'd *never* felt before. The sexual disparity was real; Colt versus others, her versus Colt. She'd never been *under* a boy, she'd always been *over*.

"Take me," she whispered.

COLT ROCKED against her again and she cried a high sound, knees up to her collarbone. Her bare feet bounced above his head. He rocked and pushed himself into her, pulled out and pushed in, then let himself sink deep inside her and rolled his hips around in circles and up and down. Now Taylor's face turned to ecstasy rather than pain. She was gasping, mouth opening and closing moaning lightly. She let his arms go and gripped his thighs.

He said, "Okay?"

"Yeah," she sighed, "oh yeah, that's good ..."

He pushed himself deeper and raised his face up. She made a high sound. He wrapped his grip around her neck and dug a thumb into her throat, grunted as he began to rock deeper.

"Oh God," she cried, "mm, oh God ..."

He pulled himself fully out now, and Taylor curled her stomach, her pelvis rotating up, and Harrison could see the size of Colt's cock when it was fully hard. It was huge, and it glistened with her insides. He humped it against her, the belly of that huge thing slipping up and down her parted petals. Taylor liked that. She gasped and sighed, humped her pussy against him.

Now he drew back, pushed his erection downward with his fingertips and shoved it deep inside her again and she shouted out. She grabbed at her own face and covered her mouth, knowing she should be quiet, knowing that the window was open. But now Colt was fucking her. She had her knees up, her legs spread wide, her ankles resting on his thighs as he fucked her. He was upright, holding the backside of her thighs, thrusting in and out.

His stomach muscles rippled, his muscles bulged, and Taylor's head rolled from side to side as he fucked her with his huge penis. She sucked in air, she cried, she bit her lips, she made sounds Harrison had *never* heard from her in bed before.

“Oh God, oh yes ...”

Colt turned her sideways, put her ankle over his neck and rubbed his thumb on her clit as he fucked her.

“Oh my God,” Taylor said, “oh my God, it's so big, so big, I ... mm ... love it, fuck me, Colt, fuck me ...”

Now Taylor's eyes were open and watching Colt. Watching him as he gripped her ankle; she touched his stomach muscles as his hips ran his cock in and out of her. He slapped at her ass. She cried out again. Her foot bobbed over his shoulder ...

AFTER A LONG WHILE of pounding her while his curled-back thumb ran a pressing circle over her clit, Taylor finally came. For real.

It was incredible.

She cried out, she said, “Oh Colt, Colt, Colt, oh my God,” and then she drew in the deepest breath he’d ever heard. Her breasts jiggled on her chest, her nipples extended hard and alveolate. Her ribs pressed the skin out as her lungs expanded her slender frame to its maximum. Harrison had never seen her more beautiful.

While she gathered herself together, Colt let his cock pull free and tapped it on her, making wet sticky noises against her pussy.

She moaned and then made funny chuckling sounds.

He said, “That was good?”

“Yeah,” she whispered, covering her face but watching him.

He lay down next to her, put his thumb against the base of his penis making the huge thing stick straight up in the air.

She said, “You want me to get on top?”

He said, “Yeah,” and when she went to straddle him he made her face away.

“From behind?” she asked. “Is that okay?”

Colt said “It’s perfect,” and she straddled him facing his feet. When she bent over, it showed how narrow her waist was yet how wide her feminine hips swooped despite how thin she seemed. She was a woman and Harrison was painfully being shown.

Her ass was perfect and round and Colt took both her cheeks in his hands, slapped them, squeezed them, pushed her forward, aimed his cock so

it sat in the opening of her membranes and Taylor pushed herself to sit down on it. She made muffled cries as she did, but she slowly took him all the way inside her.

She put her hands down on the bed between his knees, and she did all the work now. Fucking herself against *him*, rolling and bucking her hips with his cock fully embedded inside her. Her hair swung around and it was all about Taylor now.

Colt would alternately put his hands behind his head and watch her, and then reach out to slap her ass, or caress her, too. Taylor made the greatest sex noises he'd ever heard. Like she knew what she was doing, like she knew what she was wanting, and she knew how to get it. She was chasing another orgasm.

Colt was the kind of guy to give her one. *Colt was the guy to give her two. Probably a lot more than two.*

She was upright now, bouncing straight up and down on him as he braced her waist. She still made the gasping, sighing sounds, playing with her hair while she did, trying to look over her shoulder.

She came again, Harrison was sure of it. He could see the bottoms of her feet on either side of Colt's narrow waist. Her toes curled up, dozens of lines formed on the soles of her perfect little feet as she fell forward onto her elbows between his knees. He slapped her ass, and it drew out her sounds of orgasm longer. She made a low moaning sound that reminded him of a cat.

After she came again, she rolled off and fell next to Colt on the bed. Then he was up right away standing at the side of the bed, cock sticking straight out and slightly upward from between his muscular legs. He encouraged Taylor to move, and she knew what he asked, put one foot down on the floor, one knee up on the bed, her hands onto the mattress. Colt angled himself behind her and took her hips. He pushed the head of his cock into her then fucked her from behind.

It went on and on, him banging against her until she collapsed on the bed. He followed on top, never letting his cock fall outside of her. She lay flat on the bed, her head touching the wall and he bucked his hips against her. Sticky sounds came from between them where their sexes were joined, and Harrison watched as his thin, tanned girlfriend was pummeled by this muscular jock, crying out and writhing the whole time, loving every bit of it. Loving every thrust, loving every big inch Colt put up inside her.

She made a sound like she had come again, and now she seemed out of it. Laying flat on her stomach, Colt got both knees up on the bed and put himself deep inside her. He grabbed both her round butt cheeks and push them upward forming a wrinkle across her narrow waist at her tailbone. Hips pounding triple time, his round ass darted in and out, the muscles of his stomach flexing against his skin as he did. Taylor just lay there taking it. Taking that huge thing inside her body. She was lifeless, moaning and groaning as he pounded the shit out of her. The bed rattled against the wall, and Harrison riskily slipped a hand inside, rested his cupped palm over the porcelain globe on the end of a bed post just to feel connected to her in some way. Colt's thrusts into the girl he loved were felt in his palm.

"Hey, come on," Colt said now, and he slapped at her butt. Taylor stirred, made a long draggy moan. He said, "Come on, get up." Harrison withdrew his hand back to the chill of the evening air.

Taylor rose, and Harrison saw how bright red her cheeks had blushed, even over her tan. Her eyes were glassy and out of it. She was in ecstasy, she was on another planet. This was something Harrison could never do.

Colt guided her to lay back on the bed, and she put her hands through her hair and closed her eyes again. Colt put her knees up to her chest, laid his dick along the back of her thighs, drew it back and slipped inside her again. Taylor let out another sound of ecstasy. *Oh God, oh fuck.* She loved when he put that thing inside her.

Now Harrison was looking down Taylor's body as her little breasts jiggled, her feet wobbled on the end of her ankles, both of them together and up over one of Colt's muscular shoulders. He had that huge thing inside her and he ran it in and out, over and over again, not triple-time, but slow and steady. Taylor gasped in pace with his thrusts.

Colt was breathing heavy now, too, his own chest and neck growing red. He grunted, "You sure?"

"Sure what?" Taylor sighed.

"It's okay to come inside you ..."

She said, "Do it, come inside me," as she patted her hands on his thighs.

Now his thrusts came quicker, and he rocked her against the bed. The headboard banged the windowsill again.

Then he was ejaculating inside Taylor. That big thing was squirting his delivery right inside Taylor.

"Oh," she cried, "oh, it's deep, it's so deep ..."

He continued to thrust, and he growled, squeezing her ankles. Then he pulled his cock out and it spurted a thin line of semen onto her belly. He sat back, reaching out and grabbing her wrist. He rolled to lay back with his head at the footboard and pulled Taylor to sit upright. She drew her legs underneath her; she knew what he wanted.

Semen still burbled from his tip, and she got over top of him. Colt lay prostrate on the bed, Taylor at his side, her hand gripped the base of his cock and Harrison could see her mouth slip over the spurting end of him. She stroked him into her mouth, she bobbed her head, Colt caressed the back of her skull as she did. "That's it, that's it," he said, "swallow it, swallow it ... ah, fuck, ah yeah ..."

She grunted and snorted and hummed *uh-huhs* in her throat while she continued to stroke him and suck him. His balls raised up high and when her mouth came off him for a moment, a little more semen jetted out and landed on her cheek and onto his belly. She put her mouth over it, suckled it off his hard stomach muscles. Her hand continued to stroke that thing, going up and down and caressing it. She squeezed his balls, they looked huge in her thin hand.

"Ho fuck, Taylor," Colt said, "oh fuck, you're good."

Taylor laughed and wiped her mouth. She had wet smeared around her cheeks and along her neck. She rested her forehead against his stomach muscles, his huge cock looking so massive next to her fine, pretty face. She still played with his balls. She said "That was *so* unbelievable."

"You're so hot," he said. "You're the hottest fuck I've ever had."

"Am I?"

"Oh my God," he said, "You're so fucking sexy."

She said, "*You're* so fucking sexy," and her hand caressed his stomach muscles and gripped his cock, stroking it again. She kissed it, making three kissing noises on the underside of his shaft. He smiled and caressed his hands over her head. She whispered, "I've never, *ever* had sex like that."

She stroked him again, producing a pearly bulb out of his urethra, put her mouth over his large glans and sucked him. Pulling her lips free and sucking them between her teeth, she smiled. She said, "You're so hot. You're so fucking hot. Your body is unbelievable. I can't believe this thing fit inside me." She wagged his cock and admired it.

"God, that was good," Colt said any laughed, ran both his hands over his hair to smooth it back from his handsome face and collapsed his head

against the bed. Taylor rose up facing him, and the way she kneeled now Harrison could see a thin dangling strand of Colt's semen between her legs.

TAYLOR SENSED the thread of semen dangling and brought up bundled bedsheet between her legs. She gave herself a few swipes, rolled the dirtied sheet in a loose ball and batted it away. Colt lay on his back with his hands behind his head watching her, head propped up on a folded lump of comforter; showing off his body at the same time, letting that huge glistening tool lay up on his hard, ridged belly. It was thick and so impressive, and Colt looked so *good* with Taylor. The sight of him so comfortable with his girlfriend was stabbing Harrison through the heart. They looked *right* together.

Taylor said, "We need to get back down there. You gotta go ..."

"I know, I know," he said.

She laughed a little, dropped over top of him on her hands and knees, her hair falling around his face and chest. He caressed her neck again, and they kissed one more time.

Taylor's bare ass was pointed at Harrison, and he could see her sex had been ravaged by this older guy. Her pussy lips were puckered; she looked *used*. That hard ball in his stomach grew just a little bigger, and he took a long shaky breath.

Colt said to her, "I've been wanting to fuck you all day long." He touched the point of his index finger to the center of her plump lower lip.

She grabbed his finger, wagged it in her fist and said, "I've been wanting to fuck *you* all day, too."

"It was *so* fuckin' worth it," he groaned.

Taylor said, "But we really gotta get back down there before somebody notices we're gone." She put her foot down on the floor and raised off him.

Colt sat up behind her as she stood at the side of the bed. He said, "Hold on," and she stopped and looked over her shoulder at him. He put his hands on her narrow waist, caressed her ass, held her hips and pulled back to bite her ass cheek.

She jumped and laughed, did a little kick to get away from him. Out of his reach, she slapped her own ass, and he reached out and whapped the other cheek. Harrison watched her tight buns jiggle. She wagged her bottom at Colt now a half dozen feet away, safe from his grasp. She said, "You like it?"

He said, "You've been showing it to me all day. I thought I was gonna bust a nut in my pants."

She caressed her own bottom now, looked at him over her shoulder again. Now she walked completely naked to the dresser and Harrison had to shift sideways to see her. There was a small mirror on a stand at the top of the dresser and she watched herself in it, turning her left cheek, turning her right cheek; spotted something.

She said, "Oh shit, you came in my hair ... oh no ..."

Colt laughed, putting a leg through his blue underwear. "Sorry about that."

"Shit," Taylor sighed, frowning sulkily. She turned and squatted down to retrieve her T-shirt again. Back at the mirror, she pulled locks of her shining hair through the bundled up T-shirt. "Shoot. It really got me."

Colt said, "That's what happens when you show that body off all day."

She swatted her bottom again and smiled in the mirror.

While Colt put his shorts on, found his T-shirt and pushed his big muscular arms through it, Taylor opened dresser drawers and pulled a few things out. She tossed a pale pink sweatshirt onto the bed. Cole was fully dressed now, and he came to her and put his arms around her, his chest to her back. He put his chin into the space where her collar met her neck. He breathed her in, and she caressed her hands over his hands laid on her belly. She was still naked. He said, "You got my number?"

"I do," she said.

He kissed her cheek and bit at her ear and she made a girlish, happy sound. Then he slapped her bottom lightly one more time, gave it a squeeze, and kissed her shoulder. "See you downstairs," he said, and turned, walked to her bedroom door and left.

Taylor watched the closed door for a second, and when she turned Harrison could see joy on her face. Her cheeks were bright red, and she smiled so wide her teeth showed. She threw herself on the bed, jumping up on her knees like a little kid. She covered her face and fell with her head on the pillow. “Oh my God,” she breathed into her hands. “Oh my fucking God. Holy shit ...”

It was too much for Harrison. He sat down slowly and quietly, his breaths on the verge of sobs but he was strangely free of sadness. There was something else there in its place, something similar. It was hard and black, and it hurt, but he wasn't *sad*. Was it remorse, or just plain dread? His pant leg felt cold and wet and he gripped his erection over top of the cotton. Sometime when Taylor was coming, riding Colt in reverse cowgirl, he'd ejaculated. Not a huge orgasm, but just a fantastic release into his underwear. It was an odd response that was for sure. He should feel rage right now. He should feel pain. He didn't. Just that lump of stocking coal that must be dread, but really he felt ... *love*. Happiness, too, even. Where did *that* come from? That made no sense.

Despite the lack of sadness, he couldn't deny that tears had streamed his cheeks. He dried his face, inched himself down the scratchy shingled slope, got further from the window, rose to a crouch and began creeping along the roof again.

Their friends still ringed the fire. Cisco was fast asleep. Mikey still strummed, no longer singing, just noodling around. Roxie sat in Care Bear's lap and kissed him. Her head looked tiny against his black-furred face. Her little thin fingers stroked through his hair. KC and Pontoon still talked and drank beer near the fire. Hand Job Stevie joined them and tried to look innocent. Jamie and Cookie made out and April roasted a marshmallow.

Colt emerged from the darkness with a beer in his hand, stepping out of the shadows and slipping back to sit in his chair by the fire. He kicked his flip-flops off and put his bare feet up to warm them by the flames. He looked dozy and satisfied.

The tears came again, wishing he could *be* that guy. Wishing that he was that for his Taylor. Something the most beloved person in his life would *crumble* for. He wished he could make her come the way Colt made her come. Wished when he left the room, she would throw herself on the bed and breathe into her hands *Oh my God, oh my God*. He wiped with his

knuckles, squeezed the tears away, found the open window to the room he belonged in. Not Taylor's room, the *guest boys'* room.

He slipped in the window, stepped down onto the carpeted floor and went to his bag. He rooted through, found fresh underwear and shorts. He pulled the towel out, too, dried up the semen that squirted down his leg while he watched another guy fuck his girlfriend. Marveled at how that was even possible.

"How does this happen?" he said, scrubbing his thigh.

When clean shorts and underwear were on, he sat down heavily on the bed and hung his head. He rubbed circles on his temple with closed fists wondering what on earth he would do now.

THREE QUIET KNOCKS on Taylor's door before he heard her gentle voice from behind saying, "Who is it?"

"It's me," he said.

She didn't answer for a long time. He was ready to turn around and go back to where he belonged before he heard her say, "Come in."

When he opened the door, he saw her on the bed. The bed where he made love to her bare and natural for the first time ever, and where he'd seen her taken properly—taken savagely—by a guy who could *really* make her come. Legs bare, feet bare, she had her knees up and she sat with her phone against her thighs. The room was still lit in red, her T-shirt draped over the lamp. The light of her phone shone from below and only Taylor had a face that could look so beautiful lit that way.

"Hey," he said.

"Hey," she said back. The hold button on her phone was pressed, her screen faded to black. Her legs dropped down to lay flat on the bed. She wore an oversized sweatshirt in pale pink. On the front was a corny painting of a bear in the woods, above it a meandering path; there was also a moose and a sunset beaming through the trees. Below it in script read: Walker City, Michigan. A gem from the WC store.

His gaze wouldn't meet hers and he put his hands in his pockets, stared at the point where the brass legs of her bed's footboard touched the hardwood and left a pale, ghostly reflection even in the dim. A long moment later he said, "I know."

"Know what?" she said softly.

"I know what happened. You and Colt."

“What happened?”

“You had sex with him.”

She softly exhaled, a long, delicate breezy sound. Now it was her looking at the floor. She said, “You can’t tell anyone. KC would kill me. Kill Colt, too.”

He mumbled, “Him I can do without. The world might be a better place.”

“Harrison, please don’t tell anyone.”

“Looks like I’ve got the power,” he said, gaining the courage to look at her face and give her a thin, watery smile.

With her head tilted, she pleaded, “Please, don’t.”

He’d only been joking. He said, “Your secret’s safe with me, Taylor. I’m not telling anyone.”

She regarded him for a long moment, her lips pursing to a thin line, turning down; her eyes went pink and watery while he let her look him over, not saying a thing. She sniffled and wiped at her cheeks suddenly. A tear flashed in the lamplight as it fell from her jaw and disappeared somewhere in that forest on her sweatshirt. “Are you okay?” she said in a thick and warbling voice.

“Yeah,” he said, his voice a little high, a little tight.

“*Are* you?”

Now he inhaled, leaned his back against her wall and closed the door behind him. With his hands in his pockets his eyes went back down to the floor again. He said, “I don’t know.”

“You won’t tell?” she whispered.

He said, “Weren’t you texting all your friends when I came in, letting them all know?”

“Know what?”

“That you had sex with Colt.”

She shook her head, looked at her phone, flipped it over and over against her tanned thigh. She said, “I wouldn’t be too popular.”

“Why not?”

“Sleeping with Colt? That would be cheating on you. They like you.”

“Did you cheat on me?”

“I don’t know. Did I?”

“You slept with him. What does it mean?”

She said, "That's up to you, Harrison. You're the one with all the power."

"Bullshit, Taylor."

She smiled. "I wasn't texting my friends. I was writing you a letter," she said and her face pinched up and blossomed in red as she began to cry. Her fingers darted up to squeeze her sockets, and she sniffled. When she showed him her face again, the smile had returned and looked out of place on a face so twisted with sadness. She asked in constricted voice: "Did we break up?"

"You tell me," he said.

"I didn't break up with you," she said.

He said, "You think we're on a break?"

"I guess we are," she whispered hopefully.

"No, we're not."

Her smile vanished, and the sadness consumed her features again. She pulled the front of her sweatshirt out to wipe her tears. She let out a squeaky, "Okay," and nodded.

He sighed and looked up at the angled ceiling of her bedroom. He said, "We're not on a break and we didn't break up."

Still tearing, she watched him now. The dim red shone on half her face and the wet in her eyes gleamed as she struggled to comprehend him. There was hope there and his breath chugged seeing it. His stomach fluttered, and he fought off his own tears. She wiped her cheeks again with the back of a hand, and mumbled a high, "What?" Her lips stuck together.

"We are not on a break and we did not break up."

"What does that mean?" she whispered.

His head dipped to stare now at the floor. "Go. Go to California and do whatever."

"What do you mean *whatever*?"

"*Whatever*. I'll see you on Thanksgiving and you can come to my house, we'll sit together and we're a couple."

She whispered, "We're a couple?"

Back eased off the wall, hands still in his pockets, he closed the distance between them and stood at the foot of her bed. "I can't be without you," he whispered.

"I can't ... be ... without ... you ..." she struggled to say in chugging inhales.

His knee leaned against the bedpost and it was like a closed electric connection; his heart flooded with warmth for her despite what he'd watched her do right here. "Are you going to fall in love out there?"

She shook her head no.

"Yeah, you are," he sighed.

"I'm not trying to."

"Will you tell me what you do?"

She shrugged, twisted her mouth to the side and looked to the wall.

He said, "Will you tell me *who* you do?"

Now she sucked her lips in and shook her head harder.

He said, "What if I want you to?"

She looked to him, breathed a moment. Her lips were parted, her eyes red. "Tell you if I have sex with someone?"

"Yeah. Would you?"

"Would you want me to tell you, for real?"

"I would. Definitely."

"I would tell you. If that's what you want." She watched him wondrously, her eyes widening with hope again. She brought the front of her sweatshirt up to wipe the wet from her cheeks and sniffed.

Now he nodded, couldn't believe he had actually asked that. Didn't know he would. The thought of her away was bad enough, but he couldn't handle the not-knowing. Not at all. And given the reaction between his legs as he watched her, maybe there was a little he could glean from her action with other guys; it could connect them. He sat down on the end of the bed, far from her, his hip pressing the footboard, took his hands out of his pockets and collected them in his lap. His thumbs caressed each other, and he said, "I watched you, you know."

Taylor nodded, her mouth working around. She made a loud sound of swallowing, touched her throat, said "Excuse me," then eyes turned down to the bed, said, "I hoped you would."

He chuckled, groaning at the scale of his revelation. "No, from the window. When you had sex with Colt. I ... watched."

Taylor said, "Yeah, I know, that's what I mean. I hoped you would."

Their eyes met and her expression was blank. He struggled to understand—was sure he'd misheard. "What—why?"

"I don't know. I thought you might. I opened the window—"

"You opened the ... you *wanted* me to see that? To *hear* that?"

She averted her eyes and nodded.

“Are you crazy?”

She turned to face him, brow lowered. She said, “Are *you* crazy, Harrison?”

Softer now, he said, “You wanted me to watch you?”

“You watched me, didn’t you?”

“Yeah—”

“The whole thing?”

“Yeah,” he admitted and felt his cheeks blaze red.

Eyes lowered again, she whispered, “We’re both crazy.”

The cool of his palms pressing on his warm cheeks, he said, “You thought I would watch you?”

She said, “You used to peep on me.”

“I did not.”

She snorted. “You sure did.”

He chuckled reluctantly, said, “Maybe I did.”

“That’s how I knew to leave my window open. It was there if you wanted it.”

“Looks like I wanted it.”

“I knew you’d come.”

“I came.” *Boy, did he ever.* A welcome but inexplicable smile spread his cheeks. He said, “You know, one time I saw you in your bra I thought I was gonna die.”

She smiled too, let her chin rest on her knees. “And then you saw me without it.”

“Yeah, it took a while, but I finally got your top off. Remember the party at Shelby’s uncle’s?”

She said, “No, I let you see them through my window.”

He said, “I never saw them through the window. Through *this* window?” He pointed to the head of the bed.

She said, “What do you mean you didn’t see them? I showed them to you.”

“The most I ever saw was you in your bra.”

“Are you serious?” She frowned deeply and stared across the room, the corner of her mouth quirking up and setting a dimple in her cheek. “You were outside, and I finally got the nerve to take my bra off and walk around.

My stomach had butterflies when I turned around. I knew you peeped, and I was so nervous to show you. I built up nerve *all* summer.”

HARRISON GAVE her his serious look, the one where he conveyed utmost sincerity. “Taylor, I never saw you naked through this window.”

It made her want to laugh. It was a secret fact in their relationship and it had been a tenet so long she couldn’t comprehend it not being true. The summer of 2013 was when she’d finally built up the nerve, and, wow, it wasn’t easy. She knew he’d spied on her and it turned her on to be so desired that a sweet boy like Harrison would do something so crazy. But it took a whole year before she felt confident enough, and a year of *development*, and by the next summer her legs were shaking waiting for him to show up outside her dormer. Almost chickened out, too, but then, boom, she did it, turned around and let him see for one brief second, then grabbed a shirt and put it on. Then she sat on her bed, shame-faced and on the verge of blubbering. It was the excitement and the adrenalin of the moment that had saved her. *Now it wasn’t true?*

“You didn’t see me?”

“I didn’t.”

“You were out there ...”

He looked over her shoulder to where she pointed behind her. “It must have been someone else.”

“It wasn’t you? I bared myself to ...” *Who had she bared herself to?*

Harrison said, “You had two peeping toms?”

“Oh my God, no,” she laughed to protect herself from a washing shame. She’d flashed someone she hadn’t intended, and doing it for Harrison had almost wrecked her. And look at her now, all these years later. It paled in comparison.

“You never told me before.”

She looked in his eyes, so happy now to see some heaviness lifted from them. “I never wanted to admit I did that ... Isn’t that crazy?”

He nodded.

“And then what I did tonight ...” She looked away again.

“You wanted me to see you naked?”

When she looked back to him, he blessed her with the slightest of smiles. She nodded and gave him a fragile smile back.

He said, “We were just friends back then.”

“I wanted to show myself to you. You made me feel safe, and I knew you watched. I wanted to show *somebody* maybe, anybody, but I knew I could trust you.”

“But it wasn’t me,” he laughed.

“Oh God,” she laughed now, too, and hid her face in her hands.

“I wish it was me,” he said.

“Who do you think was out there?” she whispered.

He shrugged, but his smile faltered. “Am I just safe to you? You wanted to show yourself, but you felt *safe* with me.”

“Is that bad?”

“It’s happening again, isn’t it? I was your *safe* boyfriend, here until you’re ready for better.”

“No way, Harrison. You’re for real.”

He nodded, looked a little sullen and couldn’t hold her gaze for long. He said, “I’m for real. I’ll be here for you when you come back to Michigan.”

She said, “I like that. I couldn’t stand to lose you as a friend.”

He made a soft scoff. “I’m your lover.”

“You’re my lover,” she agreed. “If you’re okay with that.”

His eyes steadied on her. “I am.”

“I’ll always be your friend, Harrison. No matter what.”

He said, “I want more than that.”

“I do, too.”

Harrison said in a shaky voice, “Can I come and sit with you?”

Her sobs came back to threaten her, and she said, “Please, come and sit with me. I need you to, baby, I need you ...”

Harrison scooted up the bed, getting a hand on her knee and she gripped his arms. He said, “Would it be okay if I held you?”

“Of course, Harrison. I want you to hold me.”

Harrison took her in his arms, and she pushed her face into his neck and cried.

THERE WAS no way he thought he would ever recover after the damage done to his heart today, but it was soaring right now and every bit of him tingled with affection and ardor for the fine figure he clutched against him. He couldn't be without her, couldn't bear to not have her in his life. They would work this out somehow. He would do whatever it took to make her happy and to make her *stay*.

She softly cried against his neck and he consoled her, stroked her hair and squeezed her carefully. Her tears made his shirt go damp and warm. Soft lips kissed at the sensitive skin of his neck, just above his collar and he grunted with boundless pleasure.

They just stayed connected. Gentle strumming rode a cool lake breeze through the open window and rustled their hair. Laughter and singing picked up, and they could hear the crackle of the fire; all their friends gathered below. He held her in his arms and stroked her hair, and breathed her in, and soon she stopped crying and they both felt at peace.

Try as he might to push away what she'd done, the images were unshakeable. While he'd held her, he'd been able to suppress them, but what he'd seen—no, what she'd shown him—burned in him now that he thought he had her in his heart again.

Both hands cupping her cheeks he held her face and looked in her eyes. She closed them and parted her lips, thinking he wanted to kiss. He took her mouth and held her lips with his. When they parted he asked her: "Was it really good with him?"

She shook her head no, her fine brow lowered over those glowing gray eyes.

“It wasn’t?” he said, frowning, knowing she was lying. *He watched her.* She said, “No, I mean we’re not doing that, telling you that sort of thing.”

“Yes, we are.”

“No way, Harrison.”

“Yes, Taylor. Why not?”

“I don’t know. To protect you.”

“I don’t need protecting. I watched with my own eyes. You can tell me the truth. The truth is what I need.”

She regarded him almost coldly, said, “Well, you watched it.”

“That’s your answer?”

“What do you want me to say, Harrison?”

“Was he better than me?”

Now she touched his lip with the point of her index finger and he wondered if she picked that up from Colt. The bottom of his stomach fell away and his insides went watery again.

“Was he?” he whispered.

“Yes, Harrison,” she said so quietly only the S sounds were audible.

“That’s okay,” he said, lowering his eyes.

“I don’t want to hurt you,” she said, making him feel very young and left behind.

He challenged her with an adult idea: “It turned me on to watch you.”

They held their gaze and his eyes flitted over hers, wondering how he could take back the statement, or how he might temper it somehow. Taylor worried a canine over her lower lip, and her brows lowered. She asked him: “It did?”

He admitted it. “Yes.”

“Really?”

“It really did. Bad.”

She whispered, “Are you serious?”

“Isn’t that what you wanted? You left the window open for me. Knew I would spy on you. Did you want it to hurt me, or did you want me to watch you and like it?”

“I don’t really know, Harrison. I hoped, I guess, but I didn’t count on it.”

“What if I watched, and it hurt me bad?”

“It’s up to you to watch or look away. I wanted you to see so you would know.”

“Know what?”

She shrugged and made a pained, vacillating expression.

He said, “Know what you’re missing?”

“No, not like that,” she urged in a soft whisper and stroked his cheek.

“That’s how it felt,” he said. “I saw what you were missing.”

“I think I just wanted you to know *me*.”

“I *know* you, Taylor,” he said and squeezed her, hating the thought that she might think there was part of her not shared. “And I saw you together. I saw what you did. It’s not like what *we* do.”

“We’re loving.”

“I know—but I don’t fuck you like that.”

She studied him gravely. “Did it hurt to watch me?”

“More than I can even tell you.”

“It did?”

“I have a lump in my heart,” he said and closed a fist over his chest.

“Oh no, baby, don’t ...” She held his wrist and stroked her thumb over his knuckles.

“Not because of what I watched, but I’m so afraid you’ll *leave* me, so afraid you won’t want me in your life anymore. I’d do anything to be with you ...”

“I want you in my life, I swear I do, Harrison. I love you.”

“Do what you want, Taylor, I want you to, I want you to do it.”

“Am I bad?” she asked him.

“We can figure this out.”

“I don’t want you to hurt. I thought if we were on a break, you wouldn’t hurt.”

“I want you to have whatever you want.”

She paused, asked: “What *are* we?”

“Our relationship?” He took her hand and studied it. Taylor was the only girl for him, and he knew it a long, long time ago. What she wanted wounded him deeply, but it wasn’t unreasonable. She didn’t want to only ever be with one boy. It would have been wonderful for her to know in her heart as he did that there was only one other for her, but not everyone was the same. This was Taylor. And he was in love with Taylor. If this is who

she was, he would accept her, and love her. “What do you call it ...? I guess ‘open.’ Is it an *open* relationship?”

She smiled a little, brought their combined hands closer so she could kiss the heel of his thumb. “At least it has a name.”

“I want you to be fulfilled, Taylor,” he said, “but I need to have you here,” and now he tugged their hands to his chest and laid them over his heart.

She blinked rapidly, and he saw her eyes swell with tears. She swiped them away and smiled.

“You have to do it, too,” she whispered.

He nodded, but felt nothing in his heart for anyone else.

While they lay side by side, their heads on the pillows, hands touching each other, his mind stretched over the coming school year, and it spread him thin knowing she would be with other guys. It turned his mind to paper to think she might be intimate with another boy, intimate in the way she’d been with Colt, but it would have to be that way, and the alternative was depthless destruction. Being physically separated from her would be dreadful, being spiritually separated would be impossible.

Their breaths came loud and slow over the sounds from the campfire beyond the dormer window and he smiled a little and stroked her face, contented knowing for now the pain of separation was staved.

She smiled and rubbed her cheek against his touch. She said, “Tell me how you liked it.”

A flash of shame flickered low in his belly. “Watching you?”

“Yeah ... can you ...?”

“I did. I liked it,” he admitted but looked away from her. He turned away and lay his shoulders on the pillow so he could watch the ceiling and run his hand through his hair protectively.

She whispered, “Did you jerk off?—you can tell me.”

She’d passed it off as a joke, but he knew she wondered. “Ew, no,” he said.

“It would be okay if you did.”

He chuckled and stared at the ceiling. When he turned again to regard her he saw her expression was serious. “What ...?”

“It’s okay,” she said supportively.

“I didn’t touch myself, but ...”

She waited. “But what?”

In his periphery he could see her sweet, tanned face watching him, could sense her curiosity, a certain baseness there, too, lurking, making him think she *wanted* to hear something dirty like that he did touch himself, but most importantly he saw the face of his longtime friend. One to whom he could tell the truth—she may even get a kick out of it; he sure did for some reason.

“I ... uh ... *came* ...”

“Uh-huh ...”

“I ... uh ... well, without touching myself ...”

“You *came*? ...” she asked incredulously.

He’d been excited to say it but once the words were out, he felt his cheeks blaze red. “Maybe ...” he said and scrunched up his nose.

“Oh, shit,” she sighed and gave him an expression that made him believe she liked it.

“I’m so embarrassed,” he said.

“No, don’t be,” she said, a breathlessness in her voice.

The next thing, he’s grunting and buckling as her hand thrust down the front of his shorts and underwear. Her fingers scratched at his penis and testicles and then she gripped them all in a bunch and held them. He groaned and complained. “Ow, oh, careful, Taylor, careful. I cleaned up, changed my underwear and shorts before I came in here—were you checking?”

“You really came?” she asked him, her hand coddling his genitals.

“I did. I hated it, watching you, but I also *didn’t*, I hurt, but ... I don’t know ... you looked incredible.” Now he traced a strand of hair behind her ear.

“Thank you.”

“Are you going to see him again?”

She sucked her lower lip under her front teeth and shrugged.

“Do you like him?”

Still with the lip tucked, she nodded. She let it plop loose and grimaced. “I don’t know if I will. I’m going away, anyway, and ... I’m just a hookup to him.”

The sound of her voice referencing her activity with Colt as a hookup made his stomach flinch, and she noticed, gave his manhood a squeeze. Were hookups something his lovely Taylor would now become more

familiar with? Bouncing from dorm room to dorm room, waking up in some new guy's bed every Saturday morning, hair tousled and naked?

She said, "I've had a crush on him forever."

"I hate that guy."

"I know."

With her eyes on his and her hand in his pants, the pad of her thumb caressed the head of his cock. He grew hard in her grip and she smiled and narrowed her gaze as her thumb continued to stroke at him.

His own smile came but then it faltered. "His penis was really big."

"It was huge," she whispered, then smiled as her words made his cock surge in her grip. She squeezed him.

"Do I feel small now?"

"You feel the same as ever," she said.

"But you've been with ... someone else now ... and he was—"

"Hung?"

"Hung."

She nodded. "Yeah, I was."

"Did you like it?"

Her eyes flicked over his, looking to see if he was truthful about wanting her honesty. "I liked it a lot."

"Oh God," he said with a grimace, then chuckled with a funny slippery pain that wiggled through him.

She said, "It hurt at first and it felt really weird. Like, wrong. I thought Oh, no way, I can't do this, but then, I don't know, his *body* and everything ... I was just so *hot* for him."

He breathed deep. "You were wet."

"I was *so* wet," she whispered. There was no denying he had grown to full hardness in her hand. They could both feel what was happening.

"Jesus, Taylor. You're so bad."

"You like this ... *You're* the one that's bad."

"I *am* bad," he said. "I spied on you while you fucked Colt Briggs."

She whispered, "And I was so hot you came in your pants."

"I came so hard, Taylor." Their smiles grew, their eyes darted over one another, and their chests rose and fell heavily.

"Jesus, Harrison," she said, beginning to writhe against him, her hand went slick on his cock as he squirted pre-come out his tip. When she swooped it on him he moaned out; the pleasure was too enormous.

She laughed, looking in his eyes, her legs rubbing together, and breathlessly asked him, “Are we going to do something here?”

“I think so,” he gasped.

“Holy shit,” she breathed excitedly, “I think so, too.”

“Taylor, oh God, you’re so hot, you’re so bad, and I fucking love you ...”

Now her knee was up on his thigh, just like she’d begun with Colt and he ran his hand up her smooth flawless leg, dipped between her thighs and found she wore no panties. She’d been sitting here naked the whole time under her sweatshirt.

His finger slipped along her slit and he pushed it into her with no resistance, her hungry furnace swallowed him deep.

“Oh fuck,” she sighed, and she closed her eyes and began to hump herself against his hand. Soon her pussy was making slick sounds, and he wondered if this was Colt’s semen making its way back out, or if he had somehow turned her on like this all by himself.

“You’re so fucking wet,” he whispered.

“Get these shorts off,” she hissed and her hands pushed at the waistband.

HE GASPED HOPEFULLY, “You’re still horny?”

“Oh fuck, Harrison, yeah,” she said and there was an excited tremble in her voice.

His shorts were off fast, kicked to the foot of the bed, and he stuck his cock out for her to grab it again. She did, grabbed it hard, and he groaned, put his hand up her sweatshirt and grabbed her breast.

“Was he twice as big as me?” he asked, then kissed her.

She kissed him savagely, gasped wetly, “At least.”

“You came so many times.”

Her hand stroked his slippery shaft, and he got over top of her on all fours. “He fucked me so good, Harrison.”

“I know, baby, I saw, he fucked you so good. You were good, too.”

“Did I look hot?”

“So hot, Taylor,” he said as she jerked him off and he put both his hands up her shirt. His hips worked down, looking to get his cock inside her. “Are you even going to feel me now?”

Her hand stopped stroking and his hips humped the air, desperate to feel his cock inside *something*. “Mm, don’t stop.”

“Harrison ...” she whispered.

His balls ached, his stomach felt hard and hurting. His insides were groaning with profound sexual *need*. “Don’t stop,” he pleaded again.

Her hands came to his neck, and he looked up, having to raise higher up her body. Their eyes met, and she looked deep into him.

“What is it?” he asked her.

Her gray eyes darted back and forth. Her mouth opened, but she didn't say anything. There was a desperation on her face, too.

"What, Taylor?"

She whispered, "Would you go down on me?"

"Go down on you? No, Taylor, he—"

"Please ..."

"Taylor, he's been down there. He came in you ..."

"Please," she said again, and without him answering, she was already pushing on his collar to force his body down hers.

"Taylor," he complained. "I want to have sex again."

Still she pushed on his collar, writhing underneath him, saying, "Go down on me, go down on me first."

"What?" he whined in protest—he was bewildered. He didn't want to. He didn't want to, but he would do it. *Whatever* she wanted.

On his knees, he scooted his butt back to sit on his heels. His kisses went down the front of her sweatshirt, thumbs pushing up the hem and finding the spot below her navel. When he kissed her there her belly fluttered under his lips. She let out a breathy moan. She *really* wanted this. She was the one who wanted this. It was incredible. The closer he got, the more he smelled her funk. The smell of her lubrication was like perfume. She was hot, and she was horny.

He kissed the soft shapes of her shaved mound, kissed along the divots between her sex and her hips. She squirmed underneath him. Then with the tip of his tongue, he drew swooping circles all around her vulva.

"Oh please, Harrison, hurry, please ..."

His heart was pounding now. He didn't want his to touch his tongue down there. Didn't want to put his mouth where another man had been. She been penetrated by another guy. Another guy put his hard manhood inside her. He *came* inside her ...

"Oh wow," he murmured, and his mouth pinched a bundle of her commissure, tongue pushing down on her clit. She hissed above him like a cat, and her hips bucked upward to meet his mouth.

He was all in. He didn't care. Didn't care Colt had put his big dick in her. If this was her thing, it was his thing.

He suckled on her flesh now, fully formed a seal with the ring of his lips around her opening. His tongue slipped up and down, the tip probing,

curling forward, forming a knot that he could press into her button. Her hands grabbed at his hair and she pulled.

“Yes,” she cried, “yes.” He squirmed his head on her, his tongue protruding, his head rolling in circles. He got lower, looked up her body to see her reaction as he did this horrible thing. It was horrible, but fuck, there was no denying the beauty in it. This *was* beautiful. This was a togetherness that no one else could even comprehend. She was opening herself to him, giving herself in a way she couldn’t give herself to anyone else.

“I love you,” he sighed wetly across her sex, but she didn’t even hear him. He was talking to himself, anyway. Taylor was gone. The things he did to her were making her act like he’d never seen.

Hands left his head, went up above her on the pillow, then thrashed down to her sides. She grabbed at the hem of her sweatshirt and pulled it up her body. She wanted to be naked, and he wanted that, too. She pulled the sweatshirt off and did a crunch, rolling her torso forward to toss the sweatshirt aside. When she tightened her core like that it squeezed a liquid spate from her slit and he closed his eyes and kept going. His tongue ran up her belly and around her navel. He made his way between her breasts, and her arms went around his back when he kissed her neck. His penis was rock hard, and he mushed it against the wetness between her legs. Her thighs went around him, he could feel her heels jabbing into his calves. The bad side of him said this was afterglow. This was an aftershock from Earthquake Colt who rocked her world. The good side of him said this was all him. *He* was doing things to her that nobody else could. Nobody else *would*. It took a depth of love. His heart was pounding when he kissed her.

Around the wet sloppiness of her kiss, she blurted, “I’m sorry ... sorry I like that ...”

“Don’t be ... don’t ...” His hips humped the belly of his cock through her sopping sex.

“Why is this ... mm ... so *hot* ...?” her hips humped against him, stroking her own pussy against his male hardness. Her arms clutched him tighter.

“Cause I love you,” he whispered.

“I love you,” she said back.

He took her mouth again, bit her lips and pulled at them. She gave it back, bit his tongue and he let her. Now she *sucked* his tongue, wrapped her lips around it went up and down like it was a small penis.

She pulled back and with horrified eyes, she said, “I feel so crazy right now ... Did you ... did you ...”

“What ...?”

“*Taste* him?” she hissed.

His stomach roiled with her revealed badness. His cock surged harder and he couldn’t wait to put it inside her. He said, “No, but you were, like, *huh*, so *copper* ... did he hurt you?”

“No ...”

“He *stretched* you ...”

“Yes-s,” she cried.

With the hard point of his aching cock pushed into the nest of her needy folds, he whispered, “Taylor ...?”

“Please ...” she urged, flexing her stomach and tilting her pelvis to meet him.

“You have to use condoms,” he whispered.

“I know ...”

“Promise me you’ll use condoms in California ...”

“I promise, Harrison, I’m sorry ...”

“You only take me bare ...”

“Please, baby, oh please,” she wheedled and bucked up, spearing the first few inches of him inside her.

He slipped himself inside fully in one stroke like a hot knife through butter. He said, “Can you even feel that?”

She cried, “I feel it, ah, I feel it ...”

He pushed himself in and out of her; the pleasure was overwhelming. Her hot insides gripped him with a slick tightness. She squeezed her stomach muscles, squeezed on his cock as though she needed more pressure against her walls; he hoped it was his imagination—but Taylor had been with a *man* now.

“Oh fuck, Taylor don’t move. Don’t move. I don’t want to come ...”

“Don’t come yet,” she said, “don’t you dare come. I want to keep doing this. Keep *teasing* me ...”

“I can’t be inside you,” he said.

She wriggled herself away from him, and he withdrew his erection, slithered down her body, running his tongue down along her belly, feeling the wet trails he’d already left there. Kissed at her, suckled on her clit. It wasn’t enough. She needed *more* from him.

He slapped the side of her thigh, lifted a knee toward her chest and made her to turn onto her belly. She did, and he looked at her bare narrow back, saw her long thin hand gather up her hair and pull it down underneath her. He watched the blades of her shoulders work on her tanned back, saw the perfect globes of her ass. He slapped it. Slapped with manufactured confidence in a way he thought Colt might do. He slapped the other cheek, watched her flesh bounce. Then he was kissing her ass. Kissing and biting it. Running his tongue along the seam. With his thumbs, he spread her cheeks and lifted them. Examined her. Smiled at her little butt hole lifted high, the narrow line of her labia. He slipped his tongue from her tailbone down to her anus, scratching on unseen beach sand. Drawing it out, making her anticipate it. His cock throbbed between his legs, the tip pressed hard into his own belly.

“Oh Harrison,” she sighed, and her thighs started to shake.

“Up, up,” he whispered into her ass, and he got her to seesaw her hips and get her knees underneath her. Now her rump was up in the air, and he was over her on his knees. He put his hand on the center of her back and pushed her so her face was in the pillows, ran his tongue down her tailbone and pressed it into her anus and she squealed.

She jumped away suddenly, but he somehow knew by the sounds she made that what he did was accepted. She scrambled to the pillows on her knees, frantically wound the crank to close the window. The room went quiet, and she watched him over her shoulder for a heartbeat, eyes wild, chest heaving. Then she scooted quickly back into position with her ass pushed up.

He spanked her haunch, watched her toes curl. He slipped his tongue up and down again, breathed her in. The smell of her damp sex, the smell of his saliva, the smell of another man. Colt’s smell was everywhere. The smell of *football*. On the bed and between her legs. On her neck, on her mouth. But she was still his. In some way, she was still profoundly *his*.

She quietly whined, “Please, please, are you gonna do it?”

He smiled, and it made his tongue lose its point. Kissed her ass cheek then, focused, brought his tongue to a point once more and ran it into her anus. Her feet kicked underneath him, and he pushed his tongue deeper. His hand shoved underneath between her legs, stroked up her stomach and over a breast. His thumb went across a hard, rubbery nipple. He swooped to the side, found her right hand then grabbed her wrist, pulled it down between

her legs, used his fingers to manipulate the shape of her hand to grab her own sex.

She began to stroke on herself. He gave her room, arched his back so he curled forward. Tongue running in circles and probing inside her, he slapped her ass.

She gasped in excited wonder into her pillow: “I think ... I’m going to come ...”

“You come, you bitch,” he said, and she gasped. She had two fingers inside herself now and his hand came to join. He teased along her perineum, could feel two long graceful fingers slipping inside herself. He grunted, “Three fingers, you slut.”

“Oh,” she cried in a warbling sound, bundled *four* fingers together—his bad girl—and pushed them inside herself.

He said, “Take those four fingers, you beautiful slut, take those four fingers, you whore,” and then his tongue was inside her again. She was rocking back and forth and crying into her sheets.

She screamed, “Going to come, ah, I’m ...”

Her thrusting fingers brought loud popping and sucking noises. He grunted bewilderingly, “Come, you slut, come for me,” and slapped her ass.

“It’s coming, it’s coming, oh God ...”

“Do it, Taylor, do it ...”

“Ah, Harris-ah, oh, mm, fuck, ah, I’m gonna come ...”

“Come you slut, come you fucking crazy, beautiful whore ...”

“Oh shit, baby, oh shit baby, oh Harrison, oh ...”

She rolled on the sheet as she began to orgasm, croaked a long, thin sound, and her body twisted. He pushed his tongue deeper, and with the heel of his hand, pushed her fingers against her pussy. She rolled forward onto a shoulder, and then suddenly *bolted*.

She jumped and kicked, her heel struck him hard in the chest and she cried out. She scampered up the bedsheets, kicking her way up the bed, and he tumbled and fell with his back against the wall to get out of the way.

“What the fuck ...?” he said. Something had gone wrong. He’d hurt her. He’d torn something inside her ... “What’s wrong, Taylor?” he said, and grabbed her knee, looking at her face.

She was shocked and bewildered, staring across the room. He looked to the door, and he jumped, too.

Kelsey Kay and Brady stood at the open archway, Brady with his hand still on the lever. Both of them were stunned. Both of them as bewildered and shocked as Taylor was.

“Holy fuck,” he said, his heart pounding in his chest like a drum beat.

He grabbed a sheet and yanked it to cover his erection. Taylor bundled the comforter around her, bare knees sticking up on either side.

Kelsey Kay didn’t know what to say, and it had to be the first time for that. She still watched the two of them, mouth frozen in the shape it would take if it prepared to pronounce the letter O. Brady had a certain humor to his shocked expression. His eyes were wide; Kelsey’s were wider—three thin lines in the tiny space between her eyebrows and her hairline.

“Holy fucking shit,” she finally said. Then both of them walked backward and left the room.

PART 5

TAYLOR MOANED and made a crying sound as her two hands gathered up some of the comforter and pressed it against her face. A sliver of her ear and jaw and cheek were still showing, and while she made those sad and pained sounds, she was also smiling.

Harrison said, “Did they *watch* that? Oh my God, what did they *see*?” He ran his hand through his hair and exhaled: “Oh shit, what did they *hear*?”

“Oh my God,” she moaned, “we said some *terrible* things.”

“Oh my God,” he said, “well ... shit.”

Taylor’s body began to shake with a quiet laugh, and with the comforter still bundled against her face, she fell to lean against him. He kissed her bare upper arm and rubbed her shoulder. She groaned, “Oh my God, I can’t believe they saw that.”

Harrison had a singular, unshakeable thought: “Did you come?”

She nodded into her comforter.

“Did you really?”

“I came,” she said.

“Well, fucking shit,” he sighed to himself. *He* did that. Maybe it just took a guy like Colt to get her started, but Harrison could finish the job. Tumbling opportunities in his future fell from a high closet shelf and lay at his feet. Did he like this? The answer was yes. This togetherness with her right now was amazing. If he had a role in Taylor’s life he would take it. If *this* was the role, he would cherish it.

“What do we do?” he said.

She said, “I don’t know. I guess, I should go talk to them.”

“You *want* to do that?”

“Can you go do it?”

He said no.

She said, “You go do it.”

“What—go talk to them? But ...” He said it reluctantly, but he was already getting off the bed. He pulled his shorts toward him, slipped his legs through and zipped up. He hadn’t come yet and his cock pushed the front of his shorts out. With both hands gestured between his legs he said, “I’m gonna go talk to her?”

She said, “Put on a baggy shirt.”

He groaned and rolled his eyes, looked around for his shirt. Once he’d pulled it on he saw that it would cover okay, and he went to the door. He said, “What do I say?”

“I don’t know, just make it okay.”

So simple. “Yeah, yeah,” he said, opened the door and peeped out into the hall. Kelsey Kay and Brady stood at the top of the stairs huddled close together in the dark. They were holding hands and facing each other and they were laughing. He said, “Hey, I know, very funny. You guys okay?”

“Are *we* okay?” Kelsey Kay said. “What the shit, Harrison ...”

“Sorry,” he said sheepishly and darted a look back in the room to see Taylor still sitting on the bed watching him hopefully, just pulling her hair out of the neck hole of her pink sweatshirt she’d shrugged back on. He gave her a nod to show it was going okay.

He said to Kelsey Kay, “You can come in.”

She said, “Do you need a few minutes?”

He’d like to take a few more minutes, he had unfinished business, but it wasn’t probably going to happen right now, anyway. He said, “Did you need something in here?”

She came closer holding Brady’s hand, said, “We were going to bed.”

Brady looked at him and said, “Dude.”

He said, “Don’t be afraid, don’t be scared off, you can come in.”

“You two can keep it down?”

“Yeah, yeah. Nobody knocks around here?”

“We really thought you guys were down at the beach,” Kelsey Kay said, coming near him now, her arms folded across her chest, Brady walking behind her with his hand on her shoulder. When she came near the light, he

could see her cheeks had gone rosy. He didn't know Kelsey Kay could be embarrassed.

He said again, "Sorry."

"It's all right," she said as she brushed past him to get into the room. She hopped across the space between the two beds and jumped on the one opposite Taylor's. There was only a six foot distance between the two. Brady came in and gave Harrison's elbow a tap as he walked by. He followed to Kelsey and sat down on the bed next to her.

Taylor looked at them then hid her face again. She said, "I'm sorry, guys."

Kelsey Kay said, "It's okay. Harrison's right, we should've knocked."

Taylor moaned, "You didn't hear us through the door?"

She said, "We were talking. We weren't even thinking. Really, we thought you guys were down at the beach."

Taylor said again, "I'm so embarrassed."

"You're embarrassed?—so am I. Look at this, my hands are shaking." Kelsey Kay held out her hands and showed them a slight tremor. She said, "Not that I ever pictured you two, you know, *together*, but that was not what I expected."

"For real," Brady echoed.

Kelsey Kay—who Harrison would have thought was unshakable—had been really affected by what she walked in on. It made him feel bad, not wanting to upset somebody, but as he narrowed his eyes on her, noting the rosy quarters that bloomed on her cheeks he thought of what she'd seen. She'd come in and seen her best friend with her butt up in the air, her other good friend with his tongue right in there and the two of them were dirty-talking like out of a porn. His legs began to slither on the bed and he drew his knees up. Embarrassed, but also *aroused*. Kelsey Kay had seen his erection. She'd seen him totally naked. Seen his naked penis. Seen him at his most sexual. And it was *dirty*. He felt exposed, but somehow the effect that exposition had on his friend illuminated a certain *power*. Mouthy, bossy, in-control Kelsey Kay had swooned by something she witnessed Harrison doing. No one had ever put a tongue in Kay that way before, he knew it.

He started to smile and had to cover his two hands over his face before he burst out chuckling. He breathed loudly into his hands, and Taylor watched him. They knew each other long enough she knew he was

laughing. She poked him with her toes under the comforter, scolding him, but not able to hide her own smirk either.

Taylor said, “Kelsey, I’m so sorry. Come here.”

Though it may look like Taylor was dressed, Harrison knew she wore no panties underneath that baggy sweatshirt. And despite that, Taylor stayed with her legs crossed and her crotch exposed, even though it was hidden under the comforter.

Kelsey Kay came across the room now and Harrison could see wet in her eyes. They’d really shocked her. She came over and Taylor held her arms out and they hugged, Kelsey Kay staying standing and bending over the bed to put her arms around her friend. It got the mood lightened, and Kelsey Kay began to laugh. Now she sat down on the bed with her butt touching Harrison’s shin and faced Taylor. She wiped at her cheeks, her face looking like she would blubber, but she was chuckling, too. “What the hell? ...” she sighed.

Taylor said in an apologizing tone: “I know, I’m sorry. It’s our last weekend before school.”

Kelsey was laughing again, saying now, “*That’s* what you do before you go off to different schools?”

Taylor said, “I don’t know—I guess so,” and put her hands to her face and laughed into them.

HARRISON WATCHED his two good female friends looking at each other, seeing something communicated between them, their eyes locked on one another; some message being transmitted without their faces even moving. Taylor shook her head no almost imperceptibly.

Harrison watched the love of his life as her gray eyes darted over Kelsey Kay's, wondering what was being said. Kelsey Kay apparently knew more about Taylor than he did.

Kay's instructions to him on the dock: *Keep your head up. Don't let her run you down.*

Gaze drifting across the room now, he saw Brady sitting by himself on the other bed. There was space for four on Taylor's, but not much, and he slapped the spot near the edge of the bed by his knee and said, "Look at Brady so lonely over there."

There was a spark in Brady's eyes, and Harrison felt it, too. The moment when they'd been caught had been intense, and emotional, and so sexual, and they were all young and eager. All of them thinking they were so experienced, but really just an accumulation of *nothing* behind them. Bunch of days at school, chatty gossip, fights, heartbreaks, homework, and parties. A lot of *big talk*.

"Come on over, man, don't worry, I'm wearing shorts."

He knew he was afraid. Knew he was afraid to be without Taylor. Knew he was afraid to be without all the people who he'd known for the last eight years. Kelsey Kay would be with him at Michigan State. So would some of the others. But it wasn't the same, and it scared the shit out of him. Tonight was different. Tonight was the culmination of their past; a distinct point of

transition—of transformation. This was the night when it all changed. And the decisions he'd made this evening made him feel like he was finally ready for it. He *could* be big. He could be there for his friends. He wouldn't let them down. He would never let Taylor down because he couldn't love anybody more. When he began to smile again, he wondered what the hell was in that thing from Mikey's tuna can. Maybe he'd wake up tomorrow and this would be an evening of regrettable actions. But as Brady stood up and took a step toward the bed, he patted it again as if he knew what he was doing.

Now four of them were sitting on the bed, Princess Taylor at the head, of course, bundled up in her pink sweatshirt sitting on the pillows, Kelsey Kay at her feet and touching her ankle. Behind Kay was Brady, resting a hand on Kay's back. And Harrison had his back against the wall, knees up as if to ward everyone off. But he felt warm and happy, and despite the horror of this afternoon and the absolute torture of what he'd seen through the window, he felt loved and warm, too. He let his legs straighten till his feet hung over the edge of the bed.

He said, "We were just warming up."

Kelsey Kay said, "Gross," and she sniffed with a laugh.

He said, "I thought you guys were coming in to challenge us tonight."

Brady said, "Oh yeah ..."

Harrison nudged his butt with a knee, and Brady laughed.

Kelsey Kay said, "What's that mean?"

He said, "You were going to drown us out with *your* sounds tonight. How'd that turn out?"

Kelsey Kay laughed again and covered her face. Taylor stroked Kay's silver hair and smiled.

He reached over, getting bold, stroked the knuckle of his index finger over the top of Kelsey's calf and said, "You gave me some advice today and I took it."

She said, "You told me to fuck off."

He smiled. "It hurt going in, but once it was it there stuck with me."

Now it was Brady's turn: "Gross."

Taylor laughed brightly, her chin going up, hair tossing over her shoulder. It made his stomach flinch. She knew what it was like when it hurt going in now. She didn't this morning. He tented his fingers against his side, pushed a thumb into his rib cage to avoid wincing noticeably. There

was something just so exciting about it. Something so exciting about her. He could do this.

“No, really ...” he said.

Taylor asked, “What did she tell you?”

“Bunch of stuff,” he said. “Mostly to keep my head up. And to be cool.”

Kelsey looked at him with an almost dreamy smile, appreciating his tender words. She said, “You cool?”

He said, “I think I can be.”

Kelsey stayed with his gaze and said, “Or at least act like you are.”

“Exactly,” he said.

Brady said, “It’s pretty cool—what you two do when you’re sending each other off to separate schools. Makes me wish I went to one.”

Kelsey was still looking at Harrison, hearing Brady’s words. Brady who was at the end of his rope. Cute, hunky Brady who would be spending his last time at the lake house, for sure. Maybe it was the last time for all of them. Brady was a fling. Kelsey Kay using him for his hot body. All the girls were like that, weren’t they? He’d just never wanted to see it. They were no different from the guys. When you get too attractive and you can get anything you want, you get *everything* you want. But when you weren’t blessed with a body like Colt’s or sport sex equipment like his, you had to find your value elsewhere. You had to establish it; you had to make it known. He’d always made it known to Taylor, and she never forgot. When she went away to school, she could do the things she needed to do. He’d trust that no one could ever love her like he did and that she *knew* it. He’d trust that anything that happened in her dorm room bed was just for fun. He’d stick with her. And he could prove it.

KELSEY KAY'S eyes had never left his, even when he went distant, lost in a dark sliver of woods in his own head. They'd stared at each other the whole time, but she came into focus again.

He made a funny sort of smile at her like she had just read his mind and he felt vulnerable and exposed. Her smile grew wider. Then, she rolled forward on her knees, went close to Taylor, hands on her shoulders. Taylor put her hands on Kelsey Kay's waist. For a second, he thought they were going to kiss, and his heart did a funny drum line like it was at a comedy show and someone had just landed a punch line. His hand went over his heart. But they didn't kiss; Kelsey Kay whispered into Taylor's ear through two cupped hands. Two adult women now who looked so much like the teenage girls he'd always known. The mannerisms were the same, but their minds and bodies were advancing rapidly. Faster than he could keep up. His heart began to race again.

There was a multitude of possible things Kelsey was whispering; from the sweet and heartfelt to the horribly, disgustingly profane. An absolute certain honesty: anything that was whispered was welcome. It was beautiful to him no matter how kind or perverse it might be. The sight of them like that made him smile again. This was their last night together like this.

Without even thinking, he let his hand fall to grip Kelsey's ankle, thumb resting on the back of her black converse. She didn't even flinch or kick him away. He felt new and changed, and there was that other thing he wasn't used to: power. Value beyond being kind.

Taylor was nodding, and she had something to whisper as well. Brady watched them, too, and their two male minds synced up. It was all over

Brady's face that he was fixated on the *possibility* here.

Kelsey Kay sat back down on her heels and he removed his hand before he was offered scorn.

He said, "What's with all the secrets?"

"What secrets?" Taylor whispered as she was looking at Kelsey.

He offered up, "Wondering if I'm *cool* or not?"

"Kind of," Kelsey Kay said, still looking at Taylor.

He let his hand fall and hold Kelsey's ankle again, and said, "I'm cool, don't worry."

Now she looked at him, but turned away. Just before he thought this had all been a misunderstanding and she would return to the other side of the room, she pivoted and touched Brady's T-shirt, tugged it upward. Brady watched her hand and sat back farther.

Harrison said, "Take your shirt off." He looked to Taylor and her eyes were wide. "You want to, don't you?"

She shook her head no but her eyes returned to watch Kelsey and Brady. She didn't *want* to—but some twisted little part of his sweet girlfriend *did*. And he would nurture it because it wasn't as ugly as she thought it was. There was nothing ugly about any of this if it was done with love. She loved him and he loved her.

Brady kissed Kelsey, sucking on her mouth, then began pulling his shirt up. He wasn't a football player, he wasn't as yoked as Colt was, his shoulders not big, round globes. But the guy was on his way. He'd competed one time already in some bodybuilding thing; he wasn't huge but his body was packed with slender muscle and he was what the girls would describe as *cut*.

Brady slung his shirt off and let it drop to the floor, his hands went to touch Kelsey, began stroking her arms while they kissed. Harrison caught Taylor's attention, and she looked at him, her eyes still wide; almost horrified. He nodded to her; whatever she was thinking was okay. Whether she'd just like to watch, partake, whatever it was he was willing to listen. He respected whatever lust beat in that perfect heart of hers.

He scooted sideways so he could hold her hand. He put his fingers through hers and rubbed his thumb over one of her fine knuckles.

"What are you doing?" she asked him.

"What are *you* doing?" he asked her.

"Nothing," she said, eyes still glued.

He said, "What were you whispering to Kay?"

"Nothing. Just stuff."

"You didn't ask for this?"

She shook her head no. Then her head jerked rapidly to face his, and she said, "Ask for *what*?"

He said, "Whatever happens."

"What's going to happen, Harrison?" she said now, her voice getting a little pinched and high.

He said, "I have no idea."

"Okay," she sighed, worry and tension in her voice.

The hand he held wasn't loose, her grip not relaxed. The tension in her had her fingers squeezing like scissors against his, and he put his other hand over top to soothe her, saying, "Easy, easy ..."

Now it was Brady's turn to look in Kelsey Kay's eyes—trying to communicate without speaking. But he was sure that Brady had zero telepathic ability. You had to know someone for a long time and really care about them to be able to do that. His eyes just dumbly rolled around Kelsey Kay's face, and she looked at him blankly, though her mouth hung open in a worried slack.

Harrison would have to be the ringleader. Harrison, the guy who cried buckets of tears today over his girlfriend's behavior would have to be the one in charge. He said, "Get up on the bed," to Brady, patting the spot now to the right of him.

He let Taylor's hand go and indicated where he'd been sitting and scooted back to the foot of the bed. Brady's brow furrowed, and he watched Kelsey's eyes. She didn't know either. She wasn't saying no. She wasn't in love with this guy. This was this guy's last night, anyway. And of important note: Kelsey Kay had a reputation to live up to. If there was anybody in their group of friends who might engage in what he thought was about to happen, he figured it would've been Kelsey Kay to have done it.

She was breathing heavy now, and she ran her front teeth over the curl of her pouting bottom lip. Then she nodded very slightly. Brady didn't need more encouragement. He put one hand down on the bed and hoisted himself up to sit next to Harrison right between him and Taylor. He still held Kelsey Kay's hand, but he was looking at Taylor now.

Harrison said to Taylor, "Go ahead."

She was tentative, fearful. Brady didn't encourage her either, just staring at Harrison's beautiful girlfriend. But Harrison could see the guy's pulse in a neck vein that ran up from his collar. His heart was beating as fast as Harrison's.

Harrison said to him, "Taylor really likes your body."

Taylor made a scolding face meant for Harrison but still watched Brady.

Brady didn't know what to say; Mr. Cool Dude with that hot body didn't know how to act right now. He said dumbly: "Yeah?"

Harrison said to Taylor again, "Go ahead."

Now he looked to Kelsey Kay to make sure he was right about this. She was watching just as pie-eyed as the others. *It was going to happen.*

Taylor pivoted where she sat, closed her legs up now, suddenly her nudity concerning her mind when it wasn't before. She put her knees together, pinching the quilt, and she flipped them sideways, leaned forward nearer to Brady. Her hand was tentative when it came up and Harrison could see it shaking. They looked like they would kiss, but he didn't think Taylor was turned on in the same way she was with Colt. She didn't commit to putting her lips to his, but their faces got close. Her hand rested on Brady's chest, right above his nipple, her thumb stroking at his hard, muscular shoulder. She moved around softly, over to the other side then down his trim stomach. The way he sat, his abs weren't visible, the skin bunched up in thin folds down to his low-hanging shorts. She moved her hand lower, and Harrison began to stiffen to steel watching her.

It wasn't *terrible*. He was jealous as shit, sure, but he loved her so much this was nothing but beautiful. She was faithful with her heart, not with her hands.

Brady did that weird thing where he sat stiffly, started to flex for her in the places she touched—and it made Harrison instantly aware why Kelsey Kay was going to dump this guy.

Brady moved in now to kiss her but Taylor hid her lips from him. He persisted and settled on suckling her long, thin neck. Taylor made a sighing sound and ran her nails over Brady's body. She tilted her head forward, began to kiss and bite at his collar.

It was really happening, and it was powerful. Steam-driven freight trains thundered through his central nervous system. His head began to shudder while he watched like it rattled on tracks, his heart roared in his chest and the sounds of their kissing mouths were drowned out by his own

pulse in his eardrums. He refrained from blurting out *Oh God!* but couldn't help himself from flexing and tensing his body, kicking his legs and moving farther away. It wasn't like he was reproachful, it was just his body's autonomous function facing fight or flight. His insides told him *Get in there! Protect your woman!* and his brain said *She's not yours to keep! She's only yours to love!* His body responded with a strange mechanism of 'retreat', but fought with 'fight' in some interior purgatory.

The distance between them now, though small, was enough to quell the rising storm lashing through his insides. His heart still raced, but it was endorphins now. It was pleasure and excitement. Even smiled a little and looked to Kelsey Kay. His fifteen-year-old mind leapt forward and said: *Give her a high five and shout, Who's the cool cucumber now, bitch?* But he wasn't a kid anymore. Oh no, sir. He was *not* a kid. He was an adult and he sure as shit liked being an adult even though it was frightening.

Kelsey Kay watched and Harrison rotated to sit almost beside her. Space on the bed was cramped, and any time they moved they were touching one another, so moving their pieces around the bed was like one of those sliding tile puzzles.

Taylor's suckling mouth came off Brady's collar, and she moved back, tucked her hands inside the cuffs of her sweatshirt, folded her knees up between them protectively. She was watching Brady though and biting on her lower lip.

She looked around at him and Kelsey and said, "What are we doing here?"

Harrison said, "I don't know."

Taylor worked her mouth around, stared a long moment with Kay, then nudged her chin toward Harrison but her eyes still on Kelsey's. Kelsey looked alarmed. She shook her head no. Taylor was insistent, jabbing her chin again toward Harrison, indicating *they* should do something together. Kelsey Kay shook her head no again. A small measure of discomfort worked through him now.

Taylor looked to Brady now and said, "Is that okay?"

Brady looked to Kelsey, and they stared at each other blankly, no psychic connection between them at all. He shrugged his shoulders.

Kelsey Kay said, "You guys keep going." Her voice was hesitant and shaky.

KELSEY KAY WAS LOOKING at him now, and he could see what she was thinking. He didn't know what to say, didn't know how to explain it. *Didn't know if his explanation was true.* He said, "We're ... going to be ... open."

Kay said, "Really?"

Taylor said, "While we're apart. We're going to have an open relationship."

Harrison added, "We're in love."

Taylor said, "We are."

And he couldn't help himself. Heaving forward from his cross-legged position, he walked on his hands between Kelsey and Brady, and Taylor leaned forward to kiss him. He was light and careful, and Taylor touched his cheeks with her fingertips. She looked in his eyes then and said, "You're okay? Really okay?"

He was. And this was how he would show her.

He said, "Of course," and as he withdrew to the footboard, kept her gaze and showed her a pretty decent smile.

Brady said, "Open? That's crazy."

"No, it's not," Kelsey said. Though her face didn't show her real judgment, he could see something troubled her.

"It's not crazy," Taylor said smiling back at him.

"It's not crazy," Harrison said to her.

"No, it's not," Kelsey said, and scooted herself a little closer to him. His shin pressed against her hip and he had to lift his leg. When he did, she scooted even closer.

Brady amended his position, "It's wild is what it is."

Taylor was looking at Brady again. Brady's nervousness had subsided. Now he knew what was up, he was getting more confident.

Taylor made the first move, and their faces came closer together but she wouldn't meet Brady's eyes, so instead looked at his lips. Brady was handsome, with a long face but a strong chin and pouting, almost feminine lips. Taylor was wondering what it would be like to kiss those lips and Harrison knew it.

They came together finally, and just as she'd touched Harrison's face when she kissed him, now she touched Brady's face. It all came back to him: the staggering pain, the hurt, the jealousy ...

He couldn't do this.

He couldn't but he *had* to.

Face gone tight as a mask, his mouth turned down.

Kelsey Kay wasn't watching the action anymore, her face had turned toward his and she eyed him suspiciously.

Then Taylor said, "You, too."

They both turned to see her cupping Brady's neck. Brady didn't look at them, his eyes were on Taylor. Taylor's eyes were on Kelsey. Kelsey looked at her, Taylor nodded her chin toward Harrison again.

Kelsey nodded but made no move. Then Brady was leaning toward Taylor, rolling her onto her back and letting her head rest on the pillow. The comforter was between her legs, but her bare, tanned knees poked straight up. If Brady put his hand down underneath that comforter, he would find Taylor wasn't wearing panties.

The first reaction he had to that thought was anger, but it was squashed by pounding excitement that surprised him. All those horrible feelings had returned, all that awfulness wrapped in swirling, shiny pleasure he felt when he'd spied on her and Colt from the window. Watching Taylor like this was so exciting. And the endorphins that raced through him right now reassured him: *You can do this, Harrison.*

Only a foot away, another guy made out with his girlfriend. A guy with a great body. A guy Kelsey had always told Taylor had a *great* body. And Taylor agreed, knew all about it—probably *wanted* it.

Harrison liked seeing Taylor get what she wanted.

Brady was over her, shifting and aligning to get between her legs, still on his knees with his hands on the bed on either side of Taylor's head.

Slowly, they kissed each other, their mouths making wet noises and soft clicking sounds. Taylor's hands caressed Brady's muscle. One hand strumming up the ridges of his muscular side, the other stroking the back of his neck.

Underneath him, she moved gently, legs slowly working up and down. When she began a soft, repetitive moaning sound, his heart thudded harder. Kelsey Kay moved herself a little closer, pushing in between the footboard and him so she was at the foot of the bed, furthest removed from the action. She got right next to him, and it felt so awkward. How could he do anything with Kay? It was weird. She said nothing, simply let her shoulder touch his and watched across his body as her soon-to-be ex-boyfriend made out with her best friend. He said, "I assumed you were okay with this."

"Yeah, I know. It's fine. It's weird, but it's fine."

"You sure?"

She shrugged then nodded. "Are *we* supposed to do something?"

He said, "You know we are."

"When I made that face before it's not because I didn't want to ..."

"It's okay."

"It's just ... you're *Harrison*."

He agreed. "You're Kelsey Kay."

"Right?"

He looked away from her, saw Taylor's knees as they lifted a little, coming up Brady's hips. Brady's butt was sawing from side to side, his loose shorts sliding down a little and showing off he wore sexy and masculine underwear much like Colt's, but his was a bright red color.

Back to Kelsey Kay now, he looked in her eyes. He let his head drift toward her and she didn't shy away. Kay's eyes lowered to his mouth as they got closer. He pressed his lips against hers and they held them together for a few heartbeats. When they came apart, both their faces looked like they would burst out in the giggles.

"That's so fucking weird," Kelsey Kay said.

"Thanks," he said. Laughing but feeling hurt, too.

She said, "You're *Harrison*."

Then she wiped at her lips, pulled them away from her teeth and made a funny face.

"What?"

She said, "When I came in here ..."

He laughed and said, "Should I go brush my teeth?"

She shook her head no, said, "I don't want to kiss you."

"That's okay," he said, and as he turned to Taylor again, Kelsey rested her hand just over his sternum. He looked down and saw her familiar digits, her familiar pewter rings, and a flutter began in his stomach.

He looked in her eyes again and she looked back with a strange expression. "If there was going to be a foursome, you don't want to be the one that chickened out," he said.

She said, "You got me."

"I got you," he said.

Now his creaky arm came up, rotated to cross his chest. He rested his hand on her thigh, the insides of his fingers curling toward the seam between her legs. His hand was so close to her privates, and it was so overwhelmingly odd. Both of them were hesitant, both of them licking their lips and considering ways to get out of this. But they wouldn't.

NEXT to them on the bed, Brady pulled Taylor's sweatshirt upward. He had strong, bulging forearms, and they flexed and moved as he took grip of the cotton and slid it up her body. It revealed her tight tummy past the edge of the comforter bundled between her legs.

"Holy shit," Harrison sighed.

Kay said, "I can't believe you're cool with this."

"I can't either."

Brady's hips swayed, and he pushed the sweatshirt right up over her head and Taylor raised her arms to let him. The pink cotton scrolled up her face, and Brady left Taylor's arms bundled above her head inside the material. Pretty breasts exposed to him, he took both in his hands and pressed them together to suckle on her nipples.

Harrison grimaced and groaned. Kay's hand drifted a little lower. She said, "We should do something."

"I know," he said but kept his eyes on Taylor.

Brady continued using his mouth on her breasts and Taylor squirmed underneath, liking it. She let her arms stay bound above her head, liking the way she submitted to him.

He suspected she was a closet extrovert. Taylor liked them all watching. It wasn't something she'd ever talked about, fantasized about, or even attempted. But all he'd seen of her today made sense. The string bikini, the flirting. This right now. Taylor was coming into her own, finding herself, discovering what made her heart *pound*; she had a whole host of dirty thoughts in her mind, and Harrison thought they were *all* thrilling.

Her knees came up a little higher, touching the backs of Brady's shoulders, and one of Brady's hands abandoned a perfect Taylor breast, slid down her tummy and disappeared under the comforter. Brady would soon discover Taylor didn't have time to put on panties after what they witnessed when they came in without knocking. He would soon find out Taylor was *bare* under the comforter.

Taylor hissed when she was touched between her legs, and Harrison saw the hand above her head turn to a fist and shake. She arched her back, let out a mewling sound. Brady must've put a finger inside her because she gasped out suddenly.

"Oh my God," Harrison sighed.

"I can't believe you can watch this," Kelsey Kay said.

He exhaled shakily.

Kelsey's hand drifted a little lower and touched the top button of his hastily thrown-on shorts. He'd never totally lost his erection, and it was back with a vengeance now, bowing out the front of his shorts. The baggy T-shirt he wore came down to rest and cover it partially, but Kay would see it if she looked. The edge of her pinky finger was about to touch the tip.

The crazy unreality of the present took over his thoughts: Taylor lay on the bed next to him—his best friend and lover—kissing and playing with another guy, and *he* was touching another girl. They were going to be *open*. They were going to be together, but *open*. Could he really commit to this? Could he allow Brady to take Taylor, and could he be *sexual* with his friend?

Taylor wouldn't want to be the only one who was open, now would she? It occurred to him it might make her feel self-conscious. That would be something Harrison would do: Agree they would be open, but not do anything about it. Let her be the bad one, and she would know that while Harrison was okay with it for now, soon *it* would be coming. He would build a case against her, and when they got in the courtroom, he'd slam down a file folder thick as the Bible. *Well, Your Honor, my girlfriend was terrible. I was good, and she was terrible. We agreed to be open, Your Honor, I'll admit, but Taylor was really, really open, yet I was honest and devoted and pure.* And then when they finally blew up this relationship it would be *her* fault. Taylor would expect that from him. And shit, it *was* something he would do, too. He knew himself. Open had to be open.

He gave Kelsey Kay's thigh a squeeze, let his hand curl over its soft curve, pushed his fingers between her thighs and Kay let her legs part. It reminded him of the first time he'd been with Taylor. The first time he'd put his hand between her legs, she'd parted them just like this.

She wouldn't want his lips on hers, but he let his head come down, and he put his nose underneath her ear and smelled a sweet fragrance in that silvery hair. He never thought of her sexually. Well, maybe once, a long time ago. He remembered jerking off in the bathroom one time thinking about Kay. But it was just one time after a pool party for Shelby's birthday. He'd glimpsed something Kelsey Kay didn't realize she'd revealed. A simple, quick slip of a bikini bottom, but he saw her ass crack and soft, bare cheeks for a half-second and he would never forget it. He laughed into her neck.

She hunched up her shoulder and bumped his chin, said, "What's funny?"

"Nothing," he whispered, getting serious again, putting his nose under her ear and then kissing her there again, pressing his lips against the tendon of her neck. She didn't mind that, even lifted her chin a little.

Her hand slid an inch lower and now her knuckle bumped against the point of his aching erection. His hand moved in compensation, slipping a little higher up the seam of her thighs until the knuckle of his index finger rested against the crotch of her shorts. He couldn't help smiling again, had to force his face further under her hair to hide himself. She was shaking a little, and he could tell she was laughing. At least she saw the kookiness in this, too.

Brady's foot bumped him, making him turn from Kelsey's neck to see this guy going down Taylor's body a little, pulling the comforter. That most intimate part of Taylor was about to be revealed. Taylor wanted it. She looked down her own body and squirmed. Her knees were pulled up and her feet pointed, and she knew they were all watching, too. Knew three people were about to look between her legs.

Brady pulled the comforter away and Taylor let out a thin, warbling note, and her eyebrows wriggled as she was bared to them all. Kelsey was watching, too, looking at her best friend's sex. She'd probably seen it before in the showers, but not like *this*. Not with Taylor's knees up and her legs parted. Not when what ran between her legs was engorged and aroused and wet.

Kelsey Kay looked away quickly and kissed at Harrison's neck now, and seeing that side of his own girlfriend so submissive like that underneath another guy, seeing her most secret part exposed while lips touched his neck made him shiver all over and his right leg kicked out spontaneously.

Kelsey Kay's hand slipped up over the end of his cock poking against the fly of his shorts, and she rested it over the middle of its curve. She gave him a little squeeze, and it was like he would almost pass out.

THE FEEL of Kay's hand was so foreign; disjointed from his known experience. Taylor had been the only other person than himself to ever touch his erection. It was familiar to have fingers squeezing against it, but he knew this was *Kelsey*.

He turned shakily toward her and looked in her eyes. She was waiting to receive his gaze, and she returned it. The hand on his bulge squeezed again, she even rubbed it up and down, and he wanted to kiss her. He let his head come closer, and this time she tilted her chin up and let him touch her lips with his.

A lot different from their first kiss, this one was still tentative but with the impending excitement there were no giggles present. Kay had his heart racing. While they softly and tenderly kissed each other's lips, his hand pressed between her legs harder. Through her shorts he could feel a damp heat. She didn't moan, but she exhaled into his kiss, and his heart did a flip-flop. It was stunning. Incredible. He'd never been intimate with anyone but Taylor. He never wanted to be.

Doing this with Kelsey was like finalizing a ritual, signing your name on a pact. *We are going to be open.*

That brought him back to the reality in the room. His kiss broke, and as their faces drifted farther apart again, he licked his lips and so did she. Her eyes were on his again, lowering then to watch his mouth. It was all too much. His good friend Kelsey Kay with her hand over his erection, him with his hand between her legs, feeling her sexual heat ...

Taylor writhed next to them and he couldn't help but look.

Brady still crouched over top of Taylor, and she still caressed his body. Her hands touched his strong shoulders, and he kissed at her stomach.

Now Harrison drew his knees up, wincing; knowing what would happen. Brady was going to put his mouth between Taylor's legs.

Kelsey gave him another squeeze on his erection to get his attention. She whispered, "You okay?"

He nodded in a short, rapid motion, trying to convince himself more than Kay. They both watched as Brady lowered himself beyond Taylor's reach. She'd thrown her sweatshirt off somewhere along the way, and now she was completely naked. While Brady flicked his tongue below her navel, she squeezed her own breasts. It was so hot and yet so *wrong*. He wanted to stop her but knew that he wouldn't.

Was he the only one hurting here? He was, wasn't he? Taylor was into this. Already knew she wouldn't be faithful. Wanted to experiment in college, probably. Kelsey Kay didn't like Brady that much, really. What Brady did to Taylor right now was what he was good for as far as Kay was concerned. Harrison was the only one getting beat up here, and yet somehow despite the discomfort, despite the tumbling disquiet rolling through him in hot waves there was a part of him deep down that liked it. Liked it because it was *Taylor*. And he *loved* her. His was a depthless love, and what he did now proved it.

So he let his legs go down again, and Kelsey—maybe sensing the turmoil in him, the possibility of him bailing on this act—had her fingers trying to undo the button of his shorts. He put his hand over top of hers to stop her. An automatic reaction. The reaction of someone who had a girlfriend. And he did, but it wasn't like that anymore.

Kay looked in his eyes again and he could see what she was thinking.

I'm not going to blow it, Kelsey.

He let her hand go and let her work the button through the hole.

Brady had his mouth on Taylor's pussy now. She'd brought her knees up high again and stroked the soles of her bare feet along the guy's wide lat muscles. Soft moans came from her throat, and her head rocked in the pillow.

He turned away to face Kelsey, and together they worked each other's buttons and zippers. Her shorts were tight and he wouldn't be able to get them off. His would go easily, so he sat back and pushed his thumbs into his waistband and shoved them down to his knees. The shirt still covered his

arousal, and he grew hesitant again. He'd never been with another girl. Kelsey had been with a few guys. He knew he didn't have what Colt had between his legs—and he knew his body wasn't like that. And Kelsey had been with *Brady*. Beautiful Brady with his delts and biceps and abs. But in Kelsey's eye he saw something tender, and he sat back against the wall again.

The T-shirt slid up from his testicles and over the hump of his erection, revealing it to Kay. Her hand slipped up his thin thigh and his stomach tightened. She looked at what he had between his legs and made no reaction only watched her own hand take a gentle grip on it. He closed his eyes and his head fell back against the wall.

Kelsey's mouth was on his neck, and her hand began to work him. It was explosive to his insides; his chest felt like it would expand to bursting proportion; his head went light and airy and felt like a balloon on a string. It was the single most tender yet visceral moment he'd ever felt without Taylor. And then as quickly as the wave washed over him he was left in the exciting trough on the other side, and he leaned forward and turned, put his back to what Brady did to his girlfriend, touched Kelsey's tummy, slipped his hand into her shorts and underneath her panties.

Where Taylor was thin and taut, Kelsey was soft and smooth and he appreciated it just the same; the feel of her skin under his hand was how he expected her to feel and it was congruous with her personality and how he comprehended her.

"Oh God," he mumbled as he kissed at her neck again.

His hand slipped along the soft shapes of her vulva. Kelsey wasn't fully shaved and the fact that he knew this about his friend made his eyes snap open. It was wild and *wrong*. He *shouldn't* know these things about her. She shouldn't know what his erection feels like in her hand either.

They'd known each other too long as friends to be doing this ...

FINGERS SLIPPING A LITTLE LOWER, he worked through a scratch of narrow-trimmed pubic hair. In his mind's eye for some reason he pictured a silver and pink little pelt that matched the hair on her head.

"Wow," he groaned into her neck, and he felt her pant against him too, a tiny laugh whisking through her exhale.

And then he touched her in her most feminine space. The space where he would never consider in his life he would ever touch. *She was allowing him.*

Now the trouble began in his head again. The conflict. Was she doing this for her best friend Taylor? What was it she whispered to Taylor? Did Taylor say I want to sleep with Brady, and Kay said I'll take one for the team and occupy your bf? But that was crazy. Kay wouldn't even do that ...

As soon as the thought came to him that Kelsey not only didn't *mind* him, but possibly had thought of him in this way before, he forced it away. This was just being open. This wasn't anything more. He hooked his middle finger, curled it through Kay's hot folds, shocked to find her damp and inviting.

She moaned a little, and he felt that blackness trying to slip its hood over him again. He leaned closer to her, wanting to hug her, and it pushed out a spate of pre-come into Kelsey's grip.

He hitched his breath, expecting her to jump back and squeal *Ew, gross ... What is wrong with you?* furiously wiping her hand on her shorts. Instead her grip went liquid on him, her stroke careful and tender, swirling the palm of her hand over his tip and giving him short, sweet strokes. She was the

one seeking a kiss this time, working along his jaw until she could put her mouth on his.

She kissed him a while, her hand slowing its movement between his legs then she whispered in his ear, "I have to take my shorts off."

"You do," he panted, and their eyes met again. There was something surprisingly intense there.

She got to her knees, and he put his hands on her waist underneath her shirt. He felt her soft, feminine body, put his hands down her shorts and pushed them while she seesawed her hips. The fit was tight, but when they went over her rump, they fell to her thin knees pressed together beside him on the mattress. Her panties were still on, but they'd been tugged low, laced crooked across the tops of her thighs. That thatch of pubic hair showed, and he could see it wasn't silver at all. Tufts of mousy hair just a little darker than her natural hair color.

His hand came up without his command, ran two fingers through her scratchy pad. She bit her lip, used her toes to pry off both her sneakers, and they thumped to the floor next to the bed. Now she was bottomless, she came back and lay next to him just in a shirt and some crooked panties.

They both chanced a look to the left and could see Brady still at work, his head rolling around between Taylor's legs. She had her thighs clamped around his ears, both hands tugging his thick head of hair. She was quiet, making soft breathy sounds, her puckered and pouting lips working open and closed. Brady had no knowledge of the things that had transpired between Taylor's legs earlier, but had to know Harrison had been in there, and it gave him a weird jealous feeling that he was meant to be the lone soul who did the depraved things for her.

Brady's feet were touching his, and he and Kay had been pushed to the very end of the bed. He said to Kelsey, "We should go to the other bed."

She shook her head no. She said, "Stay here," and he was already settling down next to her again, hand slipping up her thigh and underneath her shirt. She did the same, bypassing his erection this time and coming up to touch his bare stomach. She was used to Brad. She wasn't always into jocks, but she was a beautiful girl and they came to her. Sometimes, if they were the right ones, she would date them for a little while. She'd been with the artistic types, skinny guys with eyeliner. But she'd been known to get down with guys like Brady before. He supposed though, while he wasn't

built like Brady, he probably wasn't much different from some of those artfuckers she'd dated.

So he tried to push out of his mind all the things that he *wasn't* under the feel of her fingertips. He was just in the moment. He had a lot to learn, but he was a good student and he was doing it all for Taylor.

While she caressed his skin, hand moving underneath the emblem in the center of his cotton shirt, nails lightly scratching his chest, he did the same underneath hers. Coming up to slip two fingers between her ample bosom pressed together in a stretchy bra.

She whispered, "Take my bra off," and she leaned toward him to expose her back.

His hand went around and twisted the snap and he could feel the heft of her breasts sag forward. He'd never touched other breasts. One time in Grade 9, but it was over a sweatshirt and hardly counted.

Now his hand came around to the front, went up underneath the bra to push it away. He could feel the hardness of her nipple against his palm.

The fact that she could be aroused by him was astounding. But he supposed it was the moment that was arousing. Kelsey Kay had some experience behind her, but he didn't think she'd ever done anything like *this* before. And this was crazy, and crazy was good.

Toes pressed against him, and it made him inch closer to Kelsey whose back was pressed against the footboard now.

The toes pressed again, but there was nowhere for them to go so he ignored them. The toes took a little grip on the side of his thigh and pinched his flesh. He looked around to see that it was Taylor touching him, stroking her foot on him, and his mind did that flip-flop thing again.

He put his hand down, stroked her ankle, came up to rub a thumb on her arch. The whole while, he kissed Kelsey's mouth, and she played her hand over his chest and collar under his shirt.

But now the foot was insistent, trying to get his attention. He let Kelsey go for a moment, shifted where he sat to look over at Taylor again. Brady was between her legs still, kissing a little higher now, working his way upward toward her bellybutton. Taylor still caressed her fingers through the guy's thick hair but she made eye contact with Harrison. She wanted something.

His mind stuttered for a second, his eyelashes fluttering. Had she had another orgasm? Had Brady done that to her with his mouth? His cock

surged harder inexplicably.

Taylor whisper to him, “Can you get me a condom?”

THAT REQUEST FOR A CONDOM—AND the way her perfect lips had formed it—would be forever etched into his memory. The most erotic and lubricious statement he'd ever heard. So wrong and so taboo, so anger-invoking, and yet it did nothing to the honey-coating of love around his heart for her. The last time she'd whispered a request for a condom it was for him and her. But now she intended it for another guy. And she was going to do it right in front of him. Right next to him. Their feet practically touching. He went statue-stiff, and Taylor must've realized how awful it was to ask him that—her eyebrows tented and she took a look of sadness. Yet she persisted. "Please ...?"

"Yeah," he grunted, still a little shellshocked. He stood up, naked except for his T-shirt, the hang of it draped on either side of his erection which struck almost straight up. The arousal was intense. Taylor and Kelsey watching made him self-conscious, and he covered it with his hand. Both of them were familiar with it, and he didn't know why he did that.

Now he was up, he realized he didn't even know where the condoms were. *He wouldn't give Brady one of his own.* He said, "Where?" in a bewildered, crazy professor way. He could feel his hair sticking up in clumps and shaking with his movements, knew his cheeks would be red and his eyes wide but vacant.

Kelsey said, "In my purse. There," and pointed toward the head of her bed with her toes.

Kay's canvas bag opened on her bed, he rifled through it till he found a plain white plastic bag from the WC. He stuck his hand in, pulled out the box of condoms and had a horrible fear that he'd been mistaken the whole

time and when he would look at the box, it would say XXL on it. But it didn't, just a plain old box of regular condoms, and he tugged open the folded end and fished in two fingers to pull out a strip of four condoms.

His hands shook so badly the foil wrappers rattled. He tore one off, doing it so clumsily he broke open the second wrapper and its rolled latex edge peeked out at him. That was okay, that one would be for him—*shee-it, him and Kelsey*. Oh boy, here were those two kidnappers sneaking up behind him again and putting that hood over his head. The room went dim and his knees went weak.

It was momentary, thankfully, and he found he'd made the two steps to the bed while he was semi-conscious. Taylor extended a hand waiting for the condom. He gave her the intact packet, the one that hadn't been accidentally torn, and she took it and thanked him, but when he moved his hand away, he found she had hooked two fingers around his last two fingers and gripped him tight. Their hands tugged, and the grip tightened like a knot. It was hard for his eyes to focus, but when he found hers they were staring at him. She squeezed his fingers, and he squeezed hers back. The condom Brady was going to put on his dick so he could fuck her made a crackling sound in her hand. *This was so crazy*. He nodded to her, and she asked in a soft whisper, "Okay?"

"Okay," he said. And her submission to him, her kindness in this moment made him rage at her even more for fucking Colt without even asking him.

He would have to figure this all out later, right now he was trying to keep the tracks nice and smooth and well-greased so the train wouldn't jostle off, plunge violently through a town of sleeping villagers and leave a smoking devastation and the lamentation of the survivors. "Okay," he said again, and she let his fingers go.

Taylor kept his eyes for a moment longer, set the condom packet down on her bare chest where it shimmered and winked at him under the red light from her lamp. Brady kissed at her throat again and she put her hands on his neck and kissed his mouth. Her hands spread over his collar, down his chest, disappeared between them and showed up again at his waist, undoing the button on his shorts.

Brady reached a muscular arm back and pushed his shorts down his hips. Taylor tugged down the front of his red underwear and his penis poked out. One of her hands slipped into his underwear and cupped his testicles,

her knuckles sliding against the red cotton, her other hand gripped him and stroked. Their mouths still sucked on each other, Taylor's eyes closed. Brady's penis was engorged but not hard enough for sex yet. He looked big. Not even fully erect he was still more impressive than what was between his own legs.

Kay got his attention, her pale hands fluttering in his periphery as she waved him to rejoin her.

WHEN HE RETURNED to kneel on the bed next to her, Kay took the condom out of his hand and set it by her bare thigh. He plopped down beside her, shoulder to shoulder again, his head angled to watch Taylor. He had a great view of Brady's bare, muscular bottom and hairy butt crack. Taylor's elbow moved in and out, and it was driving him crazy knowing that his girlfriend was stroking this guy's cock.

Then Kelsey Kay's hands were on him again, lifting up his T-shirt and exposing his erection to the chilly air. She stroked him. Two of his good high school friends all grown up now, both girls being seen in ways that he'd never seen them before. Was that a selfish thought? Wouldn't they see him in a different way, too? Why would he think he was so removed from the action? He turned, put his hand down on Kelsey's thigh again and their lips found each other. He kissed her once, and she chuckled briefly against his cheek.

"What?"

"It's so weird," she whispered. It was. Her hand was on his penis. His finger was stroking her labia. They were kissing.

"That's okay, right?" he asked her.

She bit her lower lip, the corners of her cute mouth turning up a little. She let her lip plop free and said, "I think so." Her hand still worked him and she watched it now in her grip.

"If it's not okay ..."

She said, "No, it's okay, Harrison. It's just so *weird*."

"I know it's weird. It's weird for me, too." And with that he chanced another look over at Taylor.

Brady fell to one side, flopping next to her onto his back. In one motion, his hands were in his shorts and pushing them down, his knees were up high because there wasn't much room on the bed for four people but he got them off and they lay bundled against Harrison's hip. Taylor was eager, shifting to the side to allow Brady some room, but her hand instantly going over the hard muscles of his chest and slipping down his tight stomach. He let his legs fall open like a butterfly. He exposed his genitals clearly to Harrison and Kay. He was harder. Still not ready. And knowing that, it instantly occurred to him what was about to happen: Taylor's hand came down and cupped his hairy testicles and she scooted closer, her mouth forming a pouting O shape before it slipped over the end of his cock. Brady sighed, "Oh my God." He rested a hand on the back of her neck as she began to suck on him. "Oh my God, oh my God ..."

Taylor's face bobbed up and down, just taking in the first third of Brad's pretty big erection. He wasn't Colt, but he wasn't small. Not small at all. As Brady grew stiffer in Taylor's mouth, Harrison gaged he was at least an inch longer and a little thicker than what he had. Taylor *liked* what Brady had; she used her fingernails to scratch lightly at his scrotum while she sucked him.

Brady ran his hand over her hair, pulling it away so Kay and him could see what Taylor did with her mouth. The two of them were exhibitionists. Of course Brady would be, what kind of bodybuilder doesn't want to be looked at? And he did look *good*. He looked *right* with Taylor. Her long, thin, and pretty body next to his muscle. The veins stood out on his forearm, hand resting on the crown of Taylor's skull, riding it up and down as she sucked on him.

She came up occasionally, touching her own cheek, pulling away stray strands of hair, running the curl of her tongue along the shape of Brady's cock head. Then she pouted her lips, formed a seal around the glans and rocked her head on him. Brady's head went back again, sighing, "Oh God, oh God."

Harrison had completely forgotten Kay, frozen watching this. He didn't realize Kelsey Kay had shifted herself downward until her face was going toward his own erection. She pinched an OK sign around the base of his cock and angled it outward. He watched the top of her silver head as he felt her cool, wet mouth plunge over his cock. His head went back hard against the wall and he closed his eyes.

As he lay there with his head turned to the ceiling but his eyes closed, Brady said to Taylor, “You want to get fucked?”

Taylor gave a squeaky *Uh-huh*.

Taylor continued to suck on Brady’s cock, her hand still playing with his sack, and Brady’s eyes met Harrison’s now. Kelsey bobbed between his legs and her mouth felt incredible stroking up and down on him. He could picture it, knew her mouth so well. Knew the way it worked when she talked, knew the shapes it took as it formed vowels. He could picture that mouth now wrapped around his most private thing. And it was a stunning thought. It was *incredibly* intimate.

Brady’s eye contact was unnerving. It was too bro-like. As Brady watched him—that handsome face leveled on his, that thick shock of messy brown hair curled back and up off his forehead, jittering as the bed was rocked with their actions—he thought of that statement out front of the WC. How Brady *used to fuck this chick* over in Traverse City. How Kelsey Kay was just a chick that he *fucked*. And Taylor was just another chick that he will have fucked. But these two girls meant *so* much to Harrison. They were such a big part of his life. They weren’t just chicks. They were human beings that he loved. But he supposed both girls had agency. Both girls knew what was up. None of them were being taken advantage of. It was Brady really that was being taken advantage of. Kelsey Kay wanted him for one thing. Was dating him for one thing. Not his mind, not his personality. Nope, the girl right now who had her mouth around his own cock, who he’d grown up with, just liked having Brady around for sex.

Brady’s hands moved around, his attention down to the right as Taylor continued to work up and down, her pretty mouth stretched to a ring around his cock. Then he had the condom, holding it above the back of her head while he tore the packet open. Taylor heard the sound (was very familiar with that sound), and she let her lips plop off with a soft smack. She jerked him rapidly and smiled. His balls bounced around, and they both watched his hands remove the rubber and toss the foil away.

Taylor, up on her knees, running her hair off her face, watched as Brady’s masculine hands pushed the rubber down the length of his shaft.

It was killing Harrison the way she was biting her lip, eager for what would come next. He wanted to see more trepidation in her. But if there was trepidation then maybe what they were doing wasn’t right.

HE DID THE SAME NOW, looking around behind Kelsey and finding the packet he'd already accidentally torn. He pulled out the rubber, his hands still shaking. Kelsey heard it as well, and like Taylor, moved away so he could put it on.

As he pushed the rubber down his shaft, he saw Brady getting off the bed and guiding Taylor up toward the pillows. He was going to do her from behind and it made Harrison inhale sharply at the badness. Taylor knew what he wanted, and he didn't know how his girlfriend would be so good at sex. But there she was, getting her knees up in the pillows and putting her elbows over top of the headboard's brass rail, looking over her shoulder while Brady got back on the bed.

Harrison watched from behind now, sitting there with his condom-covered dick sticking straight up, Kelsey stroking his thigh. Watched as Brady angled his cock between Taylor's legs. She had her knees wide, and he and Kay could see her little sex angled up ready to receive him.

He slid himself inside her and she made a moaning gasp. Then it was on; they watched Brady's back muscles bulge and flex as he started to hump against her. He slipped inside her deeply and easily, and it made Harrison wince knowing that this was the second time his girlfriend had been fucked tonight. Wait—the third? She was loose and ready and eager. A steady whomp-whomp came as his muscular hips bounced against her bottom. Her thin thighs shook and jiggled with his thrusts. Taylor grabbed hold of her own breasts between her arms, flicked her hair around to look over the opposite shoulder. Harrison could see her face, see the blush coming out in a ragged broadcast across her cheeks.

“God, that ass is so nice,” Brady said and slapped her haunch. Taylor liked it. Harrison saw her toes curl.

Harrison was the worst lover in the world because all he cared about was what happened next to him. It startled him when Kelsey’s Kay’s thighs went around his own. She got on top of him now, trying to sit on him. He wasn’t long enough, and he had to shimmy down the bed. Kelsey bundled up the shorts she’d removed and tucked them behind his head to make him comfortable. She angled his cock upright, and when their eyes made contact, a funny tremor passed through both of them. Both of them shocked, knowing what was about to happen. Eye contact was a terrible idea, and he looked away immediately. But with his eyes closed he felt the tip of his penis touch his good friend between her legs. Felt her heat against his cock. Felt himself slide inside her as she slowly sank her hips down on top of him. She went all the way, right down until their pubic bones ground together. He was fully inside her.

Sinking his hard manhood into his friend—his girlfriend’s best friend—pushed instant distance between him and Taylor and it made his eyes tear. There was already a growing distance between them, one he would do anything to assuage, including the dirty events right now on this bed, but this action right now with Kay could never be undone. It was to help keep the straining threads of their relationship together, to prevent it from being torn completely, but how could this help?

Now he looked over, wanting to touch her, wanting to reach out and hold his girlfriend in this crazy moment—the wildest thing he could ever possibly do in his whole life. They changed positions. Brady was out of the way so she could move, she was curling herself to lay in in a fetal position. It was perfect timing, and he rested his hand on her ankle. Taylor gathered her two hands up together around her face and her expression twisted in ecstasy.

Brady was saying, “Show me that pussy,” and he pushed one leg a little higher, her two thighs together but scissoring apart and Harrison could see her reddened sex. The pounding she’d taken had put the same blush across her ass cheeks she had on her face. She was making soft warbling grunts now in anticipation, and Brady gripped her haunch, held the base of his cock, teased her opening with that tip.

Taylor said, “Yeah, do it, give it to me. Give me that big dick.”

He could feel himself stiffen inside Kay, and she did as well, giving a nice appreciative gasp. He wanted to look at her, but he wanted to watch Taylor, too.

Brady thrust himself inside her, pushed deep inside Taylor and she made a crying sound, her head rolling on the pillows in a nest of her tangled hair. She looked up at Brady, their eyes met, and she gritted her teeth in a snarl as he started to fuck her. Her breasts bounced around, her nipple drawing circles toward the ceiling. Taylor put a hand up and scratched her nails down his masculine chest. As he fucked her, Harrison saw the nail marks she'd already run all over Brady's back. Taylor had drawn lines in swoops and crescents over his lats and shoulders.

The ankle that Harrison held lifted up now, wanting Brady to have better access to her pussy.

"Fuck me," she said, "fuck me with that big dick," and now she caressed his neck.

Harrison winced and grimaced, looked back at Kelsey who was above him, her eyes were closed as well. She had to prompt everything, and she reached down now and took his wrists and slipped them up underneath her shirt to grab her breasts. He squeezed them and coddled them, head drifting to the right now, seeing Brady back himself out of her, saw a horrible moment as Taylor's pussy was left slightly gaping in an almond shape like an eye. But she shifted, and Brady was getting over top of her do her missionary. She put her knees up to her shoulders to receive him.

Her hands came down and grabbed Brady's buttocks as he got his cock between her thighs. Brady's narrow, round ass was hard and firm, no real softness for Taylor's fingertips to sink into. Brady pounded her now. Pounded her hard. She squawked and wailed and moaned. Her feet wagged around on her ankles.

“HEY, pay attention to *me*, you idiot, look at me.” Kay’s hand squeezed his cheeks between thumb and fingers, making his lips pout. His face was turned forcefully to see Kelsey Kay’s just above.

She was having sex with him. Whatever was happening with her, whatever she wanted from this, she was taking it, and right now his penis was inside her. It was profound and wonderful but his mind was conflicted and torn, leaving him detached from her.

She squeezed his cheeks harder, and a smile began to work on her face. His hands caressed at her hips and her soft stomach. He ran the pad of his thumb around the cup of her navel.

That smile of hers spread wider, and now her hand shoved his face away as she started to laugh. “No, *don’t* look at me. *Don’t* look at me,” she chuckled then buried her face in his collar with one more guffaw.

The two of them laughing together while their sexual equipment was conjoined felt incredible. She was warm and slippery and tight and the way they moved on each other had small slipping increments of pleasure zipping from the tip of his penis then racing orbits around his pounding heart. He caressed her back and sides, and she put her hands on his chest. “I can’t believe we’re doing this,” he whispered.

“Stop talking about it and just do it.”

“I *am* doing it. We *are* doing it.”

“You feel pretty good,” she whispered.

Hearing her say that, seemed so exciting. Taylor was out of his league but they’d been best friends for so long that their union made sense. But Kelsey Kay was the kind of girl who would laugh at him. If they weren’t

good friends, she would scare the shit out of him. Kay was bold and intimidating, cynical, smart. To hear her say she enjoyed his sexuality was wonderful. He said to her, “You feel so good.”

“Don’t ...” she gasped and chuckled again.

“You do, you do ...” His hands went up to her shoulders and squeezed at her collar, felt the silky, silver hair brush on the back of his wrists and hands. She had a warm and soft and surprisingly loving body. Her breasts were pressed against his chest and he could feel the hardness of her nipples. “You do, you feel so good ...”

“Just do it. Let’s just do it,” she whispered now, and her hips began to swivel. She squashed herself down in his lap. He was no porn star, there would be no bouncing, but this was good and this was real. Not fantasy but reality.

Now he held her waist and felt the movements underneath her skin as her swaying hips rocked faster and faster. Side to side, forward and back, then becoming an elliptical pattern. Then she *did* start to bounce. Not right up his length—he would pop out—but just enough to create the most incredible sense of pleasure down his shaft. Kay was getting off on it, too. Hands came up and squeezed his neck. She had no more words and no more laughs, just a soft repetitive gasping in his ear in time with her bouncing.

“Ah, wow,” he mumbled.

“Just do it,” she urged, “Let it happen.”

“I’m doing it, I am.”

“You going to come?”

He didn’t want to answer. It didn’t seem like long enough had passed. But, yeah, he was going to. “You want me to?”

“Just do it, Harrison,” she said, and he could sense her body flinching when she used his name. It broke the spell, and soon they were both laughing again.

He sighed lustily in her hair, “Oh Kelsey ...”

She snorted into his neck. “Oh Harrison,” she replied, her voice breaking up with laughter.

“I was so close.”

“Sorry.”

“You’re wonderful,” he whispered, and it brought another flinch. Her hands moved tentatively on his neck, and he smiled and didn’t bumble that

compliment with an apology, just enjoyed the feel of her underneath his hands.

BRADY HAD Taylor on her side again. He was on his side as well, spooned behind her, and his butt muscles flexed as he pushed himself in and out. Taylor's foot was draped over his knee. Harrison could see the top curve of her hip and where Brady had wrapped his hand over it. The point of her elbow stuck up from the pillows and a tangle of her hair tumbled across a pillow. Her voice came in clear, chirping gasps in time with Brady's fucking.

Then he had her slipping off the bed, pushing with his legs to get her feet onto the floor. He held her wrist and her waist, and she looked over her shoulder to see what he wanted to do now. He slipped behind her and sat on the edge of the bed, leaning back, body parallel to Harrison now. He pushed his cock to point upright—*it was definitely longer than his*—and Taylor backed herself toward him with her rump turned up.

He pressed the point of his erection into her sleek, ruffled membranes, and Taylor sat down on him.

"Look at that ass," Brady said and spanked her as she sunk him deep inside.

Taylor's long fingers curled over his thighs, her head dipped forward and her hair swung. Brady found an easy pace at first, making sure she was comfortable, but then he went suddenly wild—his hips stuttered and thundered into her. The whole bed shook, the headboard rattled on the sill, and the footboard banged on the wall like a woodpecker. The guy's sweaty abs glistened and flexed while he did. The staccato pounding made Taylor cry out long and high. She *liked* it. Brady couldn't keep the pace for long though, slowing again, making Taylor's head nod forward.

“God, that body,” Brady said and ran his hands all over her narrow back.

Taylor wasn’t comfortable standing at the side of the bed for too long and now she motioned for Brady to move back. Their eyes locked on each other, Brady stroked himself as he scooted against the back wall and brought his knees up again so his feet wouldn’t touch Harrison. Taylor thumped herself on the bed, bouncing once, lifting her knees up and rolling to lay down. She liked it on her back. Another whomp in Harrison’s stomach. She knew how to get her pleasure, and for some reason it bothered him. *You have to get used to that because that’s what he wanted for her.* He wanted her to know the pleasure she craved. Why would he keep it from her? He should be happy that she knew the things that would please herself and the angles required to do it. It didn’t look anything like sex between him and her though. That’s what hurt the most. Taylor seemed far more sexually advanced in the last two hours than she had in their whole time together. Did she watch porn, too? Or was she a natural? She probably didn’t watch more than him, so why was she so good and comfortable at it?

Brady bounced himself on top of her and Taylor’s knees poked up on either side of his waist. She raised them higher, Brady pushed himself back inside her pussy. Harrison watched the tight, creamy, latex ring near the base of his cock as it inched deeper inside Taylor. She moaned, and it wasn’t long before they had the bed bouncing again.

Kelsey watched, too, and he caught her. Watching her soon-to-be ex-boyfriend’s cock slide inside her best friend. When he looked to her, she looked away.

He kissed her cheek, and one of his hands that circled on the low of her back went down her rump. He felt the curve of her ass, felt that supple, dancing shape as they rocked and rolled on each other. He knew what he would do, couldn’t believe he would do it—slipped his middle finger down, probed until he found their connection. Tapped on the underside of his erection and admired his own hardness. Now he touched Kelsey Kay, slipping along the seam where her membranes clung to his shaft. Gathered some of their produced lubrication, moved his hand upward, drawing a finger along her perineum until he found soft weakness, winking and squirmed with her swaying hips. He prodded at it, and Kelsey slowed. The nails she ran on his neck stopped and they dug in. He didn’t ask permission. *Cool cucumber.* His cock throbbed harder inside her. Knowing what he

would do was producing an intensity in him, and he hoped in her as well. She had every opportunity to stop him but she didn't. So he let his finger press against that winking hole and slid his finger to the second knuckle inside her rectum. It sounded like Kelsey swallowed her tongue and inhaled at the same time. She caressed his neck again, then squeezed the back of it. She rocked her hips faster again, finding that old tempo she liked. She got herself moving in circles faster and faster, and her breath panted in his ear.

He couldn't be harder. She liked this. He did something she liked. Maybe not the first guy to do it, but Harrison Wade just put his finger in Kelsey Kay Miller's ass while they were fucking. *Oh, the stories ...*

Brady's grunts and groans were building to a crescendo. Harrison listened for a while as he felt Kelsey's beautiful body, two parts of him embedded inside it for pleasure. Taylor was gasping and squawking as well, the way she was being fucked making her breath come quicker.

Brady said, "I'm gonna come ..."

Taylor squeaked, "Yeah ..."

"Yeah, I'm gonna come," he grunted.

"Yes, do it, do it ..."

That set Harrison's trigger off. Hearing her want another guy to come sent him over. The contents of his testicles simmered past the boil, and he felt all the tubes and vesicles tangled around them begin to flood. Now *he* was gasping into Kay's neck. She sensed it, probably heard Brady and Taylor, and knew why. Her gasps in his ear were laced with a whine now—Kay somehow finding her own excitement in all this. He wiggled his finger inside her. Shook it and flexed his hips, too. She clung to him wetly, their skin like stickers.

Brady came first. A rampaging animal's bellow, then hissing air through clenched teeth.

Harrison didn't want to look, but he did. He could see Brady driving deep inside Taylor, and Taylor's hands caressing his hips. She gasped, "Are you coming?" and Brady just roared. Then Taylor was pushing Brady, digging a knee into his side, making him flop onto his back. His dick popped out of her and slapped up against his hard, muscled stomach. Taylor scooted up to kneel at his side. At first, Harrison thought Taylor realized how wrong this was, and didn't want this other guy coming inside her even if he wore a condom. But Taylor instead seized the rubber, squeezed it upward with the reservoir tip pinched between two fingers, and snatched

the condom right off Brady. He was still ejaculating, and it bubbled from his tip. Taylor grabbed his cock and jerked it frantically, pointing it upward toward his chest. She hissed, "Come on your abs, come on your abs ..."

Harrison reeled.

Vain Brady knew what Taylor wanted. He curled himself into a crunch with his hands up behind his head now, shoulders on the pillows with his flexed abs formed in hard muscular plates. Taylor's jerking spattered jags and drops of his pearly semen onto the muscle. Taylor whispered, "Oh my God, that's so hot, oh, that's so, so hot ..." And Harrison lost it inside *his* condom.

He bumped and jolted against Kelsey, and she gasped in his ear. His chest shot forward, his back coming off the wall, and Kay's hand slipped around to hug him. Her feet clamped against his thighs as she hugged herself to him while he came inside her. She squawked and cried as he pulsed stream after stream inside the latex.

WITH KAY on top of him—riding the swell of his heaving breaths, draped on his chest with her arm still around him—they watched Taylor together. Brady still lay on the bed with his knees up, grinning, hands behind his head bodybuilder body shimmering wet and sweaty in the red light from the lamp.

While Taylor held his gaze, he couldn't help but drift to watch her hands. She held the condom Brady had used. It swung heavily with the load he'd shot into it. She tied a knot in the end and tossed it onto the night table where it stuck. She squeezed herself down below Brady's knees, sitting on his feet, her hot sticky shoulder touching Harrison's hot sticky shoulder. Kelsey's head drew away, resting in the cup of his collar on the other side. Taylor smiled sweetly at them, but he saw a thunderstorm on her horizon, storm clouds rolling in behind those eyes and that sweet smile faded. Her eyes turned sad in the moment before she leaned forward and kissed his shoulder.

He moved his hand to touch her, but she was gone—getting out from next to him, crawling on her hands and knees to lay up beside Brady. He turned to her, and she caressed his chest. There were drops of semen on his belly, and she moved her fingers down to trace lines through them. His fading erection swelled inside Kelsey again. How could Taylor be so bad and he never knew? How could she be this way and keep it secret? The terrible things she'd done tonight were enormous in scale when compared to the way he'd considered her only yesterday. Only this *morning*. Was this the way she wanted to be?

Taylor made an enormous decision today. She would break up with him to save him. Save him from the badness she knew was coming. She *loved* him. Loved him enough to do that but not enough to be faithful. It must really be what she wanted. Thoughts of her laying on her back and masturbating came to him unbidden. Fear that he had never been enough to satisfy her. Times when they were together, and he wasn't enough for her would she pleasure herself when she'd gone home? Sickness worked through him again, and he guided Kelsey Kay off him. She did, and when he saw her face he felt a brand new connection. Her eyes were glossy, her cheeks rosy and her cute button nose had gone pink. It matched her hair perfectly. She was beautiful, and he touched her chin but she laughed and pushed his hand away.

"Don't, you pervert," she chuckled, then she was backing off, not able to make eye contact with any of them. She turned and snatched her T-shirt, threw it over her head and walked to the other bed. He felt distant from her, but was happy for her to have the space she wanted. He'd like to sit with her and laugh again soon. What they'd done was not something you could simply talk through, was it? Way too weird.

Now Kelsey sat on the opposite bed, cross-legged with the hem of her shirt pushed down between her legs so nobody saw. She rubbed at her face, then pounded at her pillow, flopped down.

Taylor rolled over and seeing Kelsey Kay on the opposite bed knew this was done. She sat up now, too, put her feet on the floor. She motioned for Brady to make some space. He did, scooting out between Harrison and Taylor, getting onto the floor with his glistening half-hard dick wagging around. He grabbed his T-shirt and scrubbed the semen off his stomach then squeezed his dick into the shirt.

He mumbled to Kelsey, "Want me to take a shower?"

She shook her head no, lay back and put her head on the pillow.

TAYLOR WATCHED him and he didn't know what to say. He could see the fear in her eyes and knew that she would see it in his, too. What had they done? And worse—how much of it was him and how much of it was Taylor this time?

Still not saying anything, she averted her eyes now, looked down and gathered up the quilt, brought it between her legs and bunched it around her middle. Her nipples were still aroused.

Into the bedding, she softly said, “Are you going to lay with me?”

“Yeah,” he said, “of course.”

His own condom needed to be dealt with, but he didn't want her to even see it on him. Didn't want her to see that he'd filled the reservoir tip with something meant for her. So he grabbed the bottom corner of the quilt and pulled it over his naked waist and slid up the bed. Their bare legs touched each other as he slid in place and put his head on the pillow next to hers. They both stared at the ceiling.

He had a million things to say, and this was his best friend and the love of his life, but he was speechless. Everything he wanted to say was all standing around waiting for one of the others to take the first step. The longer it was quiet the stranger the moment became and all the things that needed to be said and were waiting grew more and more frightened. His hands went under the sheets. He pinched the condom's base and slid it up his shaft as quietly as he could. There was soft latex clicking sounds under the sheet and he knew she heard it and knew what he was doing. But instead of being sad or forlorn, she put out her hand in waiting, expecting him to put his used condom in it. He tied a knot in the end but couldn't pass

it to her. He curled over her body and tossed it to the nightstand next to the one Brady had used on her. His insides grew dark again.

Taylor's hands caressed his sides as he hovered over her, and when he lay down, she kept stroking his chest. She looked in his eyes but now all he could do was see over her shoulder at the two slick discarded snakeskins on the night table. His mouth worked around again but still nothing came out. He said, "I'm going to take those to the trash," and pointed to them with his chin.

She said, "Just leave them."

"I don't want to look at them."

She had nothing to say to that. She chewed at the inside corner of her lip and watched him, but he avoided her gaze.

She asked, "You okay?"

He said "Uh-huh."

Then he was up, moving over her again and putting a foot on the floor, getting out of bed. He said, "I just don't ... I don't want them in here ..." It was a hard thing to explain, to put into words, especially when you were so emotional and in fear of being overwhelmed by the emotion.

Taylor seemed to understand, and her timid face had gone grim but she nodded to him. He was just in his T-shirt with his half-hard dick sticking straight out, and he reached around on the bed to find his shorts, put his legs through them while she watched. Then he turned, gathered up the condoms, Brady's in his right hand, his in the left.

She said, "Don't flush them."

Riley had flushed a boyfriend's condom down the toilet in the house in Saginaw back when Mr. Brooks was still living there and it clogged the pipe. Riley was way too young. The episode had been ugly.

"I won't. No, I know ..." he said, then walked to the door, halfway there turning over his shoulder to say, "I'll be right back."

As he left, closing the door behind him, he saw Brady and Kay in bed together, half a foot apart, both of them looking at the ceiling; Taylor watched him expectantly, her grim expression becoming sad. He closed the door.

Down the hall to the big guest bathroom on the eastern wing of the second floor, he tiptoed quietly in case there were people around who would catch him creeping with two used condoms, one in each hand. Enclosed in the bathroom, he lay the condoms on the bathroom sink and flicked the

light on. Now he stood at the sink and looked at his reflection in the mirror. This was the right thing. One hundred percent the right thing. But it was *so* crazy. It was unbelievable. If he loved her so much, how could he share her? And the scariest thought—the one that he was dreading to face—bubbled up with chilling effervescence.

You know you liked it, right?

“No, I didn’t,” he said to his reflection.

Yeah, you did. You know you did.

He closed his eyes and bowed his head. On the counter, the two condoms lay, one in a slightly S-shape the other in a curved C. He held them up by their knots now. Brady’s was slightly longer, and he winced seeing the load swinging heavy in the reservoir tip. Bigger than his load. And for some reason, as much that tightened his insides he couldn’t help deny that it did powerful things to him, terrible things he should hate—but didn’t. Not entirely. He liked that Taylor experienced Brady. He knew she loved that guy’s body. Knew that as timid as she’d been at first, her hands had enjoyed stroking that guy’s muscular body. Just like she did Colt’s.

He tossed his used condom onto the countertop and rubbed his hand over his shirt to feel the meager body underneath. This was what she was accustomed to. This was most likely all she had ever felt intimately. She’d only ever been made love to by Harrison. At least up till today. Taylor deserved pleasure. Didn’t she? Why was that okay? It had to be because he loved her. It’s not like he didn’t care, it’s not like he was saying go fuck whoever—I don’t care. It was a hundred and eighty degrees the opposite. *Do it because I love you.*

He sniffled now, held up Brady’s condom again and could feel lubrication beneath his fingertips. With his free hand, he cradled the swinging load and his fingers traveled up the length of the condom’s body. It was slick and oily with lubrication but most importantly: Taylor’s insides. Brady had put this over his big hard dick to fuck Taylor. It had been swelled to large and hard proportion this condom and stroked in and out of Taylor’s sweet pussy. He caressed the condom. Felt its warmth. It was Taylor on the outside, Brady tied safely off on the inside. Taylor had made all sorts of noises as she was fucked. They were beautiful sounds. He could hear them now, lusty echoes in his mind. He loved to see her getting off like that. He loved to see her with so much pleasure. His cock was growing harder. It was inexplicable.

“Whatever,” he said, avoiding his reflection.

At the toilet, he gathered up handfuls of toilet paper tugged from the roll and bundled up each condom separately, shoved them to the bottom of the waste basket. He peed. Flushed. With soap and warm water he stood at the sink and scrubbed his genitals. He washed his hands and even as he ran them under the water he could smell Kelsey’s sex smell wafting up in humid waves. *He had sex with Kelsey Kay Miller. Holy shit.*

He dried himself with a hand towel, and out of respect for his friends, threw it in the laundry basket. Light clicked off, he left the door ajar behind him and padded down the hall back to the bedroom.

IN THE HALLWAY powder room just inside the front door into the lake house, Kelsey Kay closed the door behind her and Taylor rested her hands on the edge of the countertop, her face toward the mirror but dipped down because she didn't want to see herself.

She whispered, "What did we do?"

The door closed now, Kelsey Kay leaned her shoulder on it, and Taylor sensed being watched in the mirror. She raised her eyes to see Kelsey's pallid face just over her shoulder in the reflection. She asked again, "What did we do, Kay?"

"It's okay," she said softly.

Taylor turned now, took a few steps backward to put some distance between them. On the left-hand side was the pale blue toilet. Now she remembered the day five years ago, the end of summer bash of 2013, where twelve-year-old Kelsey and twelve-year-old Taylor took a twelve-year-old Ashley Gray into this very bathroom and Taylor flipped up this toilet seat making way for Kelsey Kay to shove Ashley's face in the water. Kelsey Kay had been convinced that Ashley had taken ten dollars out of her iPhone case. The girl *had* stolen it.

Now it was *all* she could think about.

She hunched a little forward and ran her hands over the sides of her face until she felt the silk of her hair between her fingers. Then her hands went over her ears to block out the ghost-sounds of Ashley's protests, Ashley's gurgling, Ashley's cries. She thumped her butt down onto the toilet seat trying to trap those sounds like they still emanated from the bowl, five years past. *Stay in the bowl!*

“Hey, don’t freak out,” Kelsey said, and then her hand was on her shoulder.

She opened her eyes, saw Kelsey Kay’s bare feet with her black-painted toenails next to her own bare feet. The absence of her toe ring squeezed at her heart again. Her heart that was *pounding*. Now, with the sound of ghostly Ashley Gray’s proclamation that she didn’t steal the ten dollars—though she definitely did—she could see Kelsey Kay’s feet in her mind’s eye as they were curled up against Harrison’s thighs as she had sex with him. She squinted her eyes shut.

Kay soothed her: “Come on now, come on ...”

“I had sex with Brady,” she said coldly and flatly, no emotion at all.

“You wanted to,” Kelsey Kay said, and she kneeled down so she could look Taylor in the eye. Taylor pressed her forehead to Kelsey’s and Kelsey ran her hand up underneath her hair and stroked at her neck. “It’s okay. Don’t freak out.”

“Are you mad at me?”

Kelsey Kay said, “Am I mad at you? For sleeping with Brady ...?”

“What did we *do*?” she said again.

“It was Harrison. I think he wanted to prove something.”

“Why did I *do* it?”

“Don’t regret it.”

“My God. He wants to be *open*.”

“I can’t believe Harrison wants to be open. *He* said it? What the heck happened?”

She couldn’t tell her about Colt—*God, the astounding shame of it*. “I don’t know. He knew I was going to break up with him,” she lied. “He knew and ... he said he would support me.”

“Did he?”

“He did.” Taylor looked up and into Kelsey’s eyes now. “He said we would be open. He said we could stay together and I could date when I was in California. And he would still be here for me.”

“Are you okay with that?”

“I don’t know.”

“You don’t *know*?”

“I thought I should just break up with him. I thought it would hurt him if I didn’t.”

“I think it would hurt him way more if you did. He’s so crazy for you.”

“We can’t do this. Can we?”

“I think you guys just did.”

“I can’t believe it,” she sighed, then started to cry. “You slept with him,” she blurted to Kay in a sobbing mumble as the retaining wall around her emotions crumbled. “My Harrison ...”

“Hey, hey, hey, come on ... you knew I would ...” Kelsey Kay was rubbing her back again.

“I can’t believe you slept with him,” she said, wanting to go after Kelsey now.

“I’m sorry, I’m sorry, I thought—”

“I watched you two together,” she cried.

“You were with Brady,” Kelsey Kay said with sadness in her own voice, too. “You told me to ...”

“What did I do?” she moaned again, and flashes of her naked best friend riding the kindest, most beloved boy she ever knew came after her again. Pale, pretty, pink Kelsey. Confident Kelsey. Kelsey who didn’t stress about her looks, didn’t worry about what other people thought. Carefree, cocksure, *tough* Kelsey. She thought of all the things that Kelsey was and she wasn’t. All the things that Harrison would *see* in her. He had been *inside* her. “I can’t believe he slept with you ... I can’t believe he did that ...”

She’d been jealous of Kay. Jealous of her and her *hot* boyfriend. *But Kay didn’t even care about him ...*

“Hey. Don’t—Harrison did it for you.”

“I know, I know ... what’s wrong with me?” The trembling of her own hands frightened her and she held them back from her temples to look at her palms. She could see them shaking, could see stains of tears on the insides of her index fingers. She wiped them dry with the pads of her thumb. This wasn’t right. It wasn’t Kelsey’s fault. It wasn’t Harrison’s, either. It was her. Once again, you could lay the blame entirely on her shoulders. There was nobody more responsible for the badness in her life than her. But she wouldn’t cry over it, not in front of Kelsey. Underneath her came more muffled crying from one sad little poor girl who was so happy to get an invitation to rich Taylor Brooks’ house. *I didn’t do it, blub, blub, I didn’t take the moneeeey ...*

She sniffed heavily, snorting, making her eyes go wide like she had smelling salts in front of her. She shook her hands out when she was done, dabbed at her eyes.

Kelsey laughed. "There's my tough Taylor. Buck up, kiddo. Buck up, you California bitch."

"I am," she said, and set her mouth grim and firm.

"You are. You're my hero."

"I'm your hero?" She said the last word breaking up with a bit of overwhelming emotion.

"You're totally my hero, Taylor. You know you are."

"You're *my* hero. I wish I was you."

"Are you kidding? You don't know what goes on in this little coconut," she said and rapped on her own head. They hugged and squeezed each other's necks and pressed cheeks together. And she couldn't help it, she started to cry again. She would never get the sight out of her mind: Harrison having sex with Kelsey. She would never, ever lose the vision of the boy she loved having sex with another girl. Didn't she deserve it? This *was* a fitting punishment. *You deserve this because you're bad. You're a piece of nothing. What you did to him tonight, he did back, so take that.* With a tough grunt, she dug the thumb of her fist in between her breasts.

Harrison was hers alone, and that was gone now forever and it hurt *so* bad. *How could he have watched her with Colt?*

"You okay?" Kay asked her.

"It hurts."

"You can do this."

"I don't think I can."

"You can. You totally can. Don't you love him?"

"I love him so much."

"Do it, then. But, Taylor, don't hurt him."

"I don't want to hurt him. But won't me being with other guys hurt him?"

"He did this to show you it wouldn't hurt hm. That's how much he wants to be with you."

"It hurt me to see him with you."

"It hurt Harrison, too, he's just trying to pretend it didn't. He's doing it all to be with you, Taylor. You always get what you want."

"No, I don't."

"You kind of do, baby, and that's okay. Just be careful with Harrison, promise me."

"I love him, I don't want to hurt him."

“Be honest with him.”

They held each other for a long moment, Taylor still seated on the closed toilet, Kay standing beside.

Taylor whispered, “Please, don’t ...”

“What ...?”

“When I’m away ...”

“What is it?”

“Please, promise me ... when I go away, promise me on your heart that you won’t sleep with Harrison again ...”

“I won’t, Taylor. I’ll watch over him.”

“I can’t be without him, Kay, I can’t be without him. I need him. I need him so bad. It would be like not having you in my life.”

Kelsey Kay looked down on her with a warm smile. Her forearms rested across Taylor’s shoulders and her fingers played through her hair. Her face dipped toward hers, and she could see Kelsey’s pouting pink lips part and knew she was about to be kissed. She closed her eyes and let Kelsey take her mouth. Kelsey’s hands caressed her neck now and inhaled her deeply. Her friend’s lips were soft and cool and slightly damp. It was a nice kiss, maybe the softest and kindest she’d ever felt. She held the kiss and gave it back, her hands caressing the small of Kelsey’s back. She breathed Kelsey in. Inhaled deeply as her friend had just done. She could smell Harrison on her. Could smell Harrison’s deodorant on her skin. But under it was her familiar friend’s talcum powder and sugar. The kiss was soft and gentle and it was exactly what she needed right now. Kelsey didn’t let it linger, let their lips part and the sound of their smacking lips made Taylor’s skin snap to goose flesh. Her nipples grew hard, and she tucked her elbows in protectively.

Kelsey kept her gaze and licked her lower lip, pulled it under her front teeth then let it slide back out again. She said, “I wanted to do that so bad when I watched you with Brady. I really wanted to, but I didn’t want to make it into a thing for the boys to enjoy.”

Taylor nodded.

Kelsey said, “That was just for you and me.”

Taylor nodded again and now she licked her own lips and her tongue felt the ghostly trail left by the softest kiss she’d ever felt.

“Oh, Kay,” she sighed and she let her head dip forward until her forehead rested just under Kay’s breasts. She turned her cheek and rubbed it

into the softness of her friend's tummy. Kay caressed the back of her head.

It was like it was all a dream. She'd worried so much about this weekend all summer long. Just before the end of the school year, before they were high school graduates, she and Kay had a sleepover at Kay's house. They stayed up all night watching YouTube videos and making their own, and when it was dark and very late and they should both be sleeping, they lay in her dad's home theater on the real live bear skin Kay's dad killed himself hunting in Canada—*I tell you, Taylor, one shot, honey, right through the heart, this mean old guy didn't feel a thing, don't shed a tear*—staring up at the dim halogen lights in the ceiling. She'd concocted a plan and outlined it for Kay. Divulged to her lifelong best friend forever how when she went away to school she couldn't be with Harrison anymore. Told her that she couldn't break up with him. Told her the things that it did to her insides.

God, it hurt so much because she truly loved him. And she was so terrible at responsibility. It was a fantastical phantasmagoric odd evening of delightful plotting, and they babbled and giggled like they used to when they were nine-year-olds and sleeping over.

In the end they left it as if it was concrete. The party at Wolf Lake would culminate with a foursome. Taylor would sleep with Brady. Kelsey would sleep with Harrison. And they would do it together, and it would be about love and fun. Kay said they would squirm around on the bed like a naked litter of newborn pups. That got her giggling so hard she couldn't breathe. It was a tender but exciting thought. And she could see how it would work. Could see how it was so much easier than telling Harrison the truth. She was terrible at that. Not honesty, just facing honesty's responsibility.

So she figured once they'd all done rolling around in the bed it would be *fait accompli*. They were now (drum roll, please) on a break. Harrison had slept with someone else and she had slept with someone else. They were going to be 2400 miles apart. She still hadn't figured out the part where she would use real words and explain it to him face-to-face. She kind of figured the session of the four of them in bed would be all the explaining necessary.

By the end of the school year she kinda forgot the plan though it didn't disappear from her mind totally. They'd just been joking, hadn't they? It was silly; they were each only trying to make the other laugh, surely it

wasn't real. Come June, she remembered it again and laughed. Wondered how serious they had been. By early July she found out Kay was serious. Kay was saying she couldn't wait for August because she was dying to get rid of Brady, then adding: at least he's good in the sack. Taylor realized Kelsey was just staying attached to this guy so they could use him at the end of summer party. Early August she almost had a meltdown.

After work one day at the municipality, still covered in grass clippings—from the sharp line where her ankle socks ended above her work boots, right up to the height of her short-shorts—she lay on the living room couch a frozen immobile wreck. Trish had come in, slapping her hands, *Oh my God, look at the couch, Taylor you're filthy. Get up! Get up!* But Taylor couldn't even move, stayed curled and practically comatose staring at the TV set that wasn't even on.

The next day she told Kay there was no way she could do it. Cool Kay shrugged her shoulders and said Whatever. But then she never broke up with Brady. Then Brady was coming to the Wolf Lake party and the only reason Brady was coming to the Wolf Lake party was for the foursome, right? And by the time they picked him up with Kay on Saturday morning, she thought Shit, maybe I *could* do this. The emergency stop at the WC had been to buy condoms for Brady to use on Taylor. Kelsey Kay and Brady didn't use condoms, they got blood tests, proclaimed exclusivity to each other and Kay had been on the pill since she was fifteen. *Taylor, can't he just use the condoms Harrison thinks he still needs? I'm not asking Harrison to lend your boyfriend one of his condoms so he can have sex with me, Kay!* But even with the condoms in that bag, Trish in Myrtle Beach, and the knowledge the evening may end up laying in bed she didn't think it would *actually* happen. Didn't think it would really come to this. But then again, the path into a bed was a lot easier than the path to uttering a communication to Harrison. Maybe she was a shower rather than a teller.

And then once she decided that she might actually be able to sleep with Kay's hot boy-toy—thank God Harrison had taken her real virginity early this morning—it all started coming apart. KC showed up. KC who might not even come. Shows up with a batch of some of the hottest dudes she'd *ever* seen. And then she knew in her heart of hearts it was practically done between her and Harrison. By the end of the day they would be on a break. And she couldn't miss the opportunity now ... *Of course she could.* But sometimes Taylor didn't see things that way until it was too late.

She was compelled to Colt. Compelled to Stevie. And deep down she knew there was nothing stopping her except for some bureaucratic technicalities. By tomorrow morning she and Harrison would be on a break and it would be fine. So what's the matter with doing it a couple hours early? Deep down she knew a lot was wrong with it, and that was why her life was a hastily packed suitcase full of nuclear-tipped regrets. Things she had done wrong. Things that would curse her forever. Bad decisions made; horrible, regretful things said; unacceptable behavior; but most profoundly: an unflappable ability to let down the people that loved her.

"Hey, I thought we stopped crying," Kay said soothingly.

"I'm not crying," she sniffed, a sob in her voice.

They held each other's gaze again; Taylor looked into the depths of her best-friend-forever's bottomless blue eyes. It was like a never ending well of care and support. The person who'd always been there for her, never begged anything of her. And she looked below those beautiful eyes and saw her equally beautiful mouth and had to have it, her thighs flexing and her knees activating before her brain had time to give permission. She raised off the toilet to stand, and she gave back to Kelsey a passionate kiss just like the one Kay offered her. Standing face-to-face and holding her best friend's neck, she caressed her ears and cheeks with her thumbs and took her mouth. Kay's knees dipped and now Taylor's face was over hers and she held the back of Kay's neck. This time when she let the kiss part she wanted to show Kay the strength that she'd given her. She smiled confidently, but gave her a blast of warm and caring eyes. She said, "I love you, you know."

Kay said, "I love you, too."

IT WAS a long and uncomfortable time laying in bed and looking up at the ceiling knowing Brady was in the bed on the other side of the room. They said nothing together and Harrison hoped Brady had fallen asleep. Everything now seemed like a mistake with Taylor gone—just him and the guy that had sex with her quietly breathing. It crushed his heart to return and find her bed empty.

This room had seemed like such a perfect place before. A place where his Taylor had grown up and slept in back when she would spend some of her summer here. Times when she would come with just her family, waterskiing with her dad; the times they would *all* come together in late August. It had always been a happy place. Earlier today—God, yesterday now—it had been the place they *truly* consummated their relationship with their bare bodies together. It was supposed to be a place of beauty and now this room frightened him. It was the place where it all began to come apart.

He lay in Taylor's bed, head on the pillow where she'd lay hers while Brady had sex with her. Where Colt had fucked her. The bed smelled sweaty. It smelled like sex. His lips began to wriggle, and he fought back tears. Footsteps came, and he wiped his cheeks before he got caught.

The latch clicked, and the door opened quietly. Kelsey came in first. She looked briefly at him with no expression then away quickly, tiptoeing across the room and climbing into bed with Brady. Brady had been awake the whole time, and Harrison saw him open his arms to receive Kay into the bed. Taylor was next, coming in sheepishly, looking at him just as briefly before looking away, turning her back to him and closing the door behind

her. She hesitated a few heartbeats like that, holding the door lever, her head touching it.

In that brief flash he'd seen her face, he could tell she'd been crying. It was like a rug had been tugged from underneath him, his already wobbly legs stumbling again. Everything had seemed so perfect. Everything for so long had been so wonderful and now it was all shit. He waited for her patiently, afraid to speak her name because she would hear the sadness in his voice. So we watched her, wiped his eyes again.

Finally, she turned, and seemed collected. Gone was that sadness, and in its place, Taylor looked happy again. She smiled brightly but her eyes still shone with the remaining wet of tears. Like Brady, he opened his arms to her now, scooted himself to the far side of the bed. She trotted on long prancing legs and jumped into bed, slipping underneath the covers he held up for her.

"Are you okay?" he asked her. "When I came back, you weren't in here and I was worried ..."

"You always worry," she said and touched her finger to his lips.

"I do. I do worry about you. I worry about everything."

"Don't. Just be *happy*."

"I'm always happy. When I'm with you."

She exhaled a grunt, half-rolled her eyes. "Can we just have fun?"

"We can do whatever you want."

"Don't worry about me. Kelsey and I just had to talk."

"I guess you did."

Taylor nodded and smiled. But despite the meager humor on her face he could see a hurt deep in her gray eyes. He said, "I'm sorry. I'm sorry I did that. With Kay."

"Don't, Harrison," she said to him. "We'll work it out. If you want to do this, we'll work it out. You can't be like this. It can't be full of sadness and regret."

"I just worry that it hurt you."

"Of course it did. I love you, Harrison. I've loved you for the longest time."

It seized him up, and he fought back the urge to say *Then why can't you just be faithful?* If he did, it would ruin it all, bring them back to step one and next time Taylor might not take step two. And without step two he would be alone and without her. So he kept his mouth shut. Whatever love

meant to Taylor, he still wanted it for himself. If she could love him, he wouldn't push it away and he would squeeze from it whatever he could.

"Okay," he said. "I love you, too. I've always loved you." Interiorly he added, *And no one else.*

She said, "We have to be honest with each other. If this is going to work, we have to be honest."

"You're right. You're so right, Taylor. That's what I want. We could've worked this out today. But what hurt more than the things that happened was the *betrayal*."

He watched as her face bloomed in sudden red, and a tear squeezed out of her eye and rolled over the bridge of her nose. She let out a soft whining cry and a hoarse sob. He hugged her, and whispered, "Don't cry, don't cry ..."

"I didn't want to betray you," she sobbed. "I just want to be me. Everything is so huge and hard and sometimes I can't *take* it. I just want to get away but then I don't want to go away. I'm so messed up ..."

"You're not messed up," he said. "I face it too sometimes," though he didn't suspect he did. "But I'll be here for you. I'll be here when you need me, and I can hold you when you want it and I'll leave you alone when you don't want it. But you always have to tell me the truth."

"I do," she softly cried near his ear. "I do, I really do. I will, Harrison."

A gentle shushing came from across the room. Polite, but hoarse and masculine still. Brady indicating for them to keep it down because he and Kay were trying to sleep.

He whispered to her, "I want to talk to you. I want to talk all night."

Taylor said, "Take me out to the roof."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah. I've never been out there ..."

HARRISON BROUGHT HIS KNEES UP, got upright and bent over the headboard, opening the window wider using the ratchet, then gestured an open hand to help her. Always the gentleman. She gave her hand; he helped her to her knees, then she hiked a leg out over the headboard, Harrison bracing her from behind with a hand on her butt and on her waist.

The night air was cool and gentle, and it was *beautiful* out—the spreading black was full of stars and the smell of smoke. Gentle waves lapped at the beach down below. She was a little afraid of heights, but she made her way warily from the dormer window, bare feet on the asphalt shingle. She peeped down over the edge of the roof as she got closer and could see the dwindling fire. Mikey and Cisco were still up. Mikey noodled on his guitar quietly and Cisco listened drowsily. No one else was out, all her friends had retired. She wondered what they thought about the things they'd actually seen tonight. But she didn't want to dwell on it and bit her lip, turned back for Harrison. Harrison always made her feel safe.

And he was coming out of the dormer window now, getting his feet down on the asphalt, tossing pillows on the shingle and dragging out the rose-printed quilt she'd had since she first graduated to her own summertime room when she was eight. He walked on his hands and heels like a crab down toward her. She rose a little higher into a squat, peeked back into her bedroom. Her Harrison had stood in this very spot and watched her do those horrible things. Her beloved boy stood and stayed for the whole thing, poor heart twisting while he watched her be an awful person. As he watched her do some of the awful things she always knew she was capable of. Sometimes she was no good. She closed her hand in a loose

fist and bumped it over her forehead, trying to erase the images she made up in her mind of what it looked like when she spread her legs and Colt got between them and put his thing inside her. It had been a horrible thing to do to Harrison. How did she ever think she could get away with that? But then again, she had, hadn't she? Just like Kay said to her in the bathroom, her casual words laced with a much deeper truer meaning: *You always get what you want, Taylor.*

Well, she sure had tonight, hadn't she? She wanted Colt. Wanted to have sex with him bad. The moment that door burst open, and she was naked and he looked at her and smiled she knew she wanted to have sex with him. He didn't jump back bashfully and babble apologies, he just pointed at her and said *Hey, titties* or whatever. What Kelsey always called BDE, or Big Dick Energy. And she knew already because she'd *seen* it. Spied on Colt in her own pool cabana. He didn't give her the time of day back then even though she'd flounced around a little. It was nothing. Just curiosity. She was a stupid, annoying kid. KC's dumb little sister. She didn't know a thing about sex back then other than the boy put his penis in your vagina and you would get a baby—*so don't you ever dare, Taylor.* But somehow seeing him this weekend brought all that back to her, and she felt like she *deserved* to have him. Deserved to have him? What an entitled piece of shit she was. But it was true. That little blip in her past when she was a little girl, and she had a crush on a hot guy and flash forward to today and times sure had changed. *Try and ignore me now, Colt.* And what with the stress of school, the stress of the impending departure from her home, from her state, leaving her friends and leaving everybody she knew to go away to a place she'd never been before looming over top of her, she thought she *could* do it.

Now she caught Harrison smiling at her, patting shape into the pillows and setting up a makeshift bed for them under the stars. She *had* done it. She'd done it and got *away* with it. She'd done it and kept the boy she loved. She cupped a hand over her mouth to stifle a bursting giggle and dropped onto her butt and scooted close to him. She put his arms around him and he put his arm around her waist with gathered sex-stinking quilt and held her.

She said, "I really do love you so much, Harrison. I can't believe you want to do this."

He said, "I do. I want to do it. But you know that I want to do it because I wanted to make us stronger. Not weaker. Okay?"

“I know,” she whispered. “I know. It will.”

He said, “I think it will.”

There was hope in his voice but his words brought dread to her. It might not. She couldn't not have her boy in her life.

When she drew back to look in his eyes, she saw trouble there and she whispered, “What?”

He hesitated, then said, “After Colt ... why did you want me to go down on you?”

TAYLOR'S BROW wrinkled as she paused to comprehend him. She averted her eyes for a moment, the red from her table lamp glowing along one of her fine cheekbones. She said, "I don't know."

"You liked it?"

"Oh boy, Harrison, don't ..."

"We have to be honest."

"I liked it, what do you want me to say? Am I gross?"

"It's not that at all."

"It's hot. I think it's hot ..."

"You're not gross, Taylor. I'll do anything for you."

"I knew you would."

"I would do anything you asked me."

"That's what's hot. I knew I could make you."

"Make me?"

"Yeah. I know you would do anything I ask, and that is *so* crazy hot."

He nodded, trying to understand her better. This was what he wanted—to know her better, wasn't it? The things he was discovering were things he shouldn't like, but he still found them arousing. He said, "Promise me if we're going to do this you won't humiliate me."

"Harrison, I won't. Why would I do that? Do you think I want that? Was it humiliating?"

"Not if you don't mean it to be."

Eyes on his, she shook her head. "I didn't."

"I don't want to be your puppy dog."

"Last thing you are is my puppy dog, Harrison. You're my angel."

With that she let her face drift towards his with her eyes lowered, and he met her eagerly for a kiss. Softly their lips pressed together and he felt their damp softness.

She cupped his cheek. "I would never humiliate you."

"On purpose."

"Did I do it accidentally?"

"You had sex with four guys tonight. What's that mean when you go to ___"

"I did not," she said stridently.

"You did, Taylor."

"No," she said weakly, and now her eyes drifted a notch upward and darted back and forth as she did the math.

He said, "You're not including me, *are* you?—*thanks*. And don't forget Stevie."

Her placid face broke in a downward curve and he regretted bringing it up. She realized it *was* four, though technically she didn't have sex with Stevie, only had tried to use her hand on him.

In a soft crying, she said, "It's not like that Harrison, it's not. I'm not ... *like* that."

"No, I know—"

"What do you think I am?—don't say it. I did this with *you*. It was *us* together. You wanted it, I didn't make it happen. Brady was *your* idea ..."

"I know, shh-sh, I'm sorry, you're right. I don't think you're bad or anything, Taylor, I'm sorry ..."

He guided her now to lay her back against the cold shingles, but brought the quilt around to warm them. They rested their heads on the pillows and watched each other.

She sniffled, said, "Don't sleep with Kay ever again."

"I won't," he said, "I won't," and stroked her cheek.

"Promise me," she whispered softer.

"I promise."

"You know her, and you'll be together at State without me. It'll hurt me."

"I'm sorry."

"I hated to see you with her."

"Why are we doing this then?"

“It’s the way it’s going to be. I thought it would be all right because it was Kay, but it was worse. You two kept laughing.”

“Because it was weird.”

“You were having fun,” she broke into a sob.

“No, Taylor, it was just nervous laughter. It was awkward ...”

Taylor whispered, “Was she good in bed? Did you like it with her?”

“No, Taylor, it wasn’t you. I love you, I wanted to be with you.”

Her mouth went firm, and she nodded her head, her eyes looking through him now. “We can make this work. I love you so much, Harrison. So, *so* much. You’re everything to me.”

His hand swept under the quilt, moving over her hip and down the outside of her thigh, U-turning and making its way up the inside of her thigh. He touched her panties, and she flinched, made a soft sort of grunt. He stroked the cleft overtop her cotton.

She said, “I’m a little sore.”

“Does it hurt?”

“I’m closed for the night, I think. I’m sorry. It doesn’t hurt, it’s just not comfortable. Do you want me to use my hand on you?”

He felt the pain of refusal but hid it. He shook his head no.

“My mouth?”

He shook his head no again, but knew if she tried without asking him he would have loved it.

“We’ll do it again before I leave for California, I promise.”

“Maybe in the morning,” he said.

“Maybe,” she said. “Would you cuddle with me?”

“I’d love to,” he said, and lifted an arm. She flipped over and scurried her back against him. When she felt the point of his erection push her rump, she wiggled and made a breathy snort. He closed her in the quilt and squeezed her light body against his.

As trying as it all was, as awful as his day had been, he was content with her like this. The alternative was her fucking Colt, dumping him, going to Santa Cruz, and he’d hardly hear from her ever again. Stasis was better than expulsion; at least he thought so. He sighed heavily, and she squirmed tighter against him. He said, “Earlier tonight, I thought I could see myself hanging out with your dad on his balcony at his divorced dude’s apartment, sitting on one of those cheap lawn chairs, drinking beers and lamenting the Brooks’ women together.”

She snickered.

He said, "I'm glad you want to try this. I think it's possible if we work at it."

Now she nodded and gathered quilt up under her chin.

She said, "It wasn't like that with my dad. It wasn't him. It was both of them."

"They both cheated?"

"It's complicated. It was ..." she sighed heavily, "... they were in emotional relationships. With co-workers."

"Both of them?"

"I don't want to talk about it, Harrison," she said petulantly and wormed against him.

"Okay, okay."

"Just hold me ..."

PART 6

GRAY MORNING LIGHT woke him and he was back in Taylor's room, alone in the bed.

The events over the last twelve hours drained him and left him empty and powerless. Couldn't tell you how long he'd slept, but he had psychic knowledge that he was the last one in the house to wake. There were voices down below, and the clatter of people moving around knocking cups and glasses and pans in the kitchen. Raucous laughter, too, and boastful braying.

He licked his sleep-dry lips, stared at the sloping ceiling above Taylor's summertime bed. No waves lapped golden light on the cedar paneling up there today. It was dull and gray and lifeless, and it was exactly how he felt.

When his eyes had fluttered open, his first instinct was a shooting hand off to the side searching for his Taylor. She was gone. It was just a simple absence but instantly felt more profound. When he rolled to his side, he saw the sheets and covers torn down in a messy triangular fold across the empty bed where Kay and Brady had slept. Somehow they'd *all* woken and managed to file themselves out of the bedroom without waking poor Harrison. He wondered if they knew he needed to sleep—but he also wondered if he just didn't matter enough to them. It was one of those early morning dreadful paranoid thoughts that hopefully would burn away as the sun grew higher in the sky. But he craned his neck in the pillow to look up above and out the window and could see nothing but dull gray morning sky. No sun today.

He gathered himself, pulled his body from the bed and found clean clothes. Began then to fold and tidy and put away some of his things in the knapsack. Today's schedule would be the same as every end of summer

weekend: wake up, shoot the shit, someone would make breakfast (wouldn't be Trish, it would probably be him again today), then gradually, as late morning became noon, guests would begin their departure. In previous years it was no big deal, you go home and you see your friends on Tuesday, the first day of school. Last year would be the last time they were all going to the same school again. No more would the Brooks' Lakeside Party be just a turning page. It was like the end of the book.

Once he was dressed, he headed out of the bedroom and stood at the top of the stairs to listen to the voices. This could be the last time for this as well. He came quietly down the steps to hear Cisco complaining, Mikey said something in a gravelly blues voice, and Cookie gave her bright syncopated laughter always punctuated with a comically horse-like sound.

At the bottom of the stairs he could hear two voices on his left, the speakers hidden and trying not to be heard, separated from the group. Two familiar girls talking with each other in purposely hushed tones. He stopped and leaned against the wall. It was Shelby and Roxie and they'd gathered in the narrow hall that ran to the pantry talking closely about secret things that made him want to listen in. He could see Shelby's shoulder and arm, and sometimes could see Roxie's hand gesturing beyond her.

His scalp tingled as he listened, and his heart raced at the terribleness of his eavesdropping, but instead of fleeing he grew quieter and more still.

Roxie whispered, "She said they went into the bedroom and Harrison had, like—" now her voice got even quieter and he had to strain to hear what was said, "—he had Taylor like face down with her butt up in the air and he was ... he had his tongue, like, up her butt hole."

"No way," Shelby laughed.

"And like Taylor was fingering herself and they were saying like all kinds of kinky shit and he was spanking her ..."

Shelby hunched forward and laughed so hard she blew raspberries.

"She said it was the dirtiest things she'd ever heard. Like *You slut*, and *Take it in your cunt, you whore*, and Taylor was practically *cuh-rying* ..."

Shelby waved her off like she couldn't hear any more until she caught her breath.

Roxie laughed too, saying, "I know, right?"

"You'd just never know looking at him."

"Crazy, huh? And he's such a nice guy. She better watch him at State."

Harrison couldn't hold back a growing smile despite the fear he would be imminently caught. He clamped his lower lip with his teeth.

Roxie said, "She'll have Kelsey Kay on him like a hawk."

"Shit, you imagine he ends up with his tongue up *her* butt hole?"

They both laughed heartily.

Shelby said, "Taylor would *kill* him. *And* her."

"Who's gonna watch her though?"

"Tell me about it."

"I guess she didn't break up with him."

The smile faded from his face and a morning-gray sadness returned, seeping into his dark corners and showing his hiding spots.

"Kay said she didn't."

"I thought she said she was going to."

"She did. But I guess she didn't do it. Yet."

"I guess."

They paused for a moment, and Shelby turned her face so he could see her profile and he felt a wave of embarrassment at the oncoming discovery. They would be embarrassed and he would be ashamed.

She looked back to Roxie and joked: "Would *you* break up with a guy who put his tongue up your butt hole?"

They both laughed in quiet snickers.

Roxie said, "Gross. You ever have a guy do that?"

"No way."

"Would you let them?"

"No way."

There was silence for a long moment then more snickering. "You would, you totally would."

"Gross. No way. If some dude put his tongue in my pooper, I would karate chop his head off."

Roxie said, "You'd like it. You're a pervert." They both laughed in loud uproarious cackles now and he had to get the hell out of here before he got caught.

But Shelby said, "Hey, good for her. Harrison's a good guy."

He paused again, taking one step back, worried now someone would come from the kitchen and see him, call out to him and give him away. Mikey was singing again and someone opened a pop can. Or a beer. *What if they needed something from the pantry?*

“He is,” Roxie agreed.

Then more quietly, Shelby asked Roxie: “Did you sleep with Care Bear?”

They got close and he couldn’t hear what was said.

They moved apart again, and Shelby said, “That guy is *huge*.”

Roxie said, “He was done in like two minutes and then he fell asleep on me. I thought I was gonna suffocate.”

So the Bear had fucked her. An inexplicable sadness returned.

Shelby chuckled. “No tongues in your asshole?”

They laughed and guffawed, and Roxie pushed Shelby. If she turned her cheek, she would have seen him watching. His stomach fluttered and his asshole puckered. Shelby lunged forward and was hidden again.

Roxie laughed, “Sounds like I should’ve gone to bed with Harrison.”

They chuckled low together.

“Mm, he is kinda cute.”

Now with great but frightened stealth he stepped himself backward, glad he had bare feet. He moved and moved until he couldn’t see Shelby’s elbow anymore. They still talked and Shelby said something that had them folded in cachinnation and he ached to know what it was—laughing at him?—but he’d heard enough and tried his luck too far already. He’d heard enough to make him smile, and on this gloomy day he felt the first warm light fall on him.

Taylor had intended to break up with him. He was right. They were done as a couple if he didn’t propose what they agreed to. But they weren’t out of the woods yet.

Heart growing heavy, his heels found the top of the stairs leading to the basement. He turned and descended. Each step down, his heart felt heavier.

She could tell him later this morning: I changed my mind, we’re crazy to be open. She could tell him on the ride home. She could tell him when she kissed him goodbye this afternoon. She could call him before she left for Santa Cruz. Or she could call him *from* Santa Cruz. *I’ve met someone. I’ve met someone special and I just can’t be what you want me to be.* Blood began to thud heavily through his heart.

He took the cooler from the back window by the basement door, walked it out into the surprisingly chilly morning. He upturned it and left it open in an upside down V so it would dry out for the ride home. Smoke still drifted in weak, aimless circles from the excellent fire he’d built. Chairs were

overturned and the ring around the fire pit was littered with empty glasses and empty bottles.

The lake was silent. No one out there hooting and hollering or racing around on jet skis. The air felt heavy, but cold and strangely humid. Without even realizing he began descending the steps, his heart sinking lower and lower but an enlightening thought revealing itself to him. *Her toe ring*. What would it mean if he could find it? He wanted to see her face when he presented it to her.

When he hit the beach, he found he wasn't alone ...

ON THE LEFT-HAND side of the beach where Harrison wouldn't have seen as he descended the steps, a muscular young man was bent over raking his fingers through the sand. It was Colt. Harrison's shoulders drooped because he was positive Colt was already down here looking for Taylor's toe ring.

I bet I can find it.

He didn't forget. He fucked her, but he didn't forget her. Wouldn't it be better if he just did? Wouldn't it be better if he fucked Taylor then went down to the fire, kicked off his flip-flops, had a beer and never thought about her again?

His cheeks were hot now and the cold of the lake air stung. He wiped and rubbed at his eyes, watching Colt walking backward now, dragging his fingers along in undulating crescents, trying to kick up Taylor's toe ring.

Harrison turned right and put his back to Colt, headed to the opposite side of the beach until he was in a straight line ninety-degrees from the swimming dock. That was where he'd seen her last night after he'd come to shore looking for her in the boathouse and then swept through the house trying to find her, she was here and this was where she lied to him. And Roxie did, too.

We were out swimming, we must've missed you.

He shook the thought away, bent over and imitated Colt's action, pushing his fingers into the sand and then wagging them through. He found a bottle cap.

He worked for a quarter of an hour before they finally acknowledged each other. They'd grown closer in their search, and Colt stood now, one

hand on his hip and watching Harrison with no expression, ball cap on backward, wearing a baggy undershirt that showed off the muscles of his shoulders and arms. Harrison stared back. Nothing was said, but he knew it was communicated.

I told you I'd fuck her. I told her told you I'd fuck your girlfriend.

Did Colt know? Did he know that Harrison knew it had actually happened? Did he know that he just humiliated a verified nice guy who didn't deserve it? He *was* the nice guy, the hero in the story. How had it come to this? How did this awful human being manage to take something of such great value from him? And worse: that thing of great value to him was an independent being that he always thought would know better. Maybe she didn't.

Or maybe he was wrong. Maybe he *wasn't* the hero in the story. Maybe this guy staring at him grimly right now was the real hero. The guy that would come into Taylor's life and rock her world. Make her jump out of bed in the morning, grab her phone to see if he'd texted. Make her chatter to all her friends and swoon about how *hot* her boyfriend is.

Without saying anything to Colt, he lowered his gaze, started to kick through the sand again looking for a flash of gold that might bring a happy smile to lovely Taylor's face.

THE FRENCH DOORS up by the barbecues slammed. There was a commotion.

Now he could see KC with his back toward the beach facing someone at the house. It was Kay and Taylor. Kay had her finger pointing; she looked red-faced. Taylor's arms were folded as well; she looked upset. KC shouted something before wheeling around and stomping down the stairs.

Harrison could feel his testicles beginning to shrink in his shorts, climbing up inside his body before KC kicked him between the legs and crushed them to dust. *You're going to be open? You piece of shit ... Don't you respect my sister?* And then *wham* he would punch him right in the face. *Taylor deserves a man!* he would say, hands clenched in fists at his sides, knowing that skinny, weak-willed Harrison couldn't take more than two punches, and he didn't want to go to jail for accidentally murdering the lowlife who wasn't enough for his little sister.

But as KC stomped down the steps, he wasn't looking at Harrison. KC was mad and his face was red. He was shirtless, his muscular bulk jumped and bounced as he came down the steps in just a pair of cargo shorts. He pointed at Harrison with the last three fingers of his right hand and said, "Harrison, get out of here."

He said, "What? Why?"

KC was adamant. "Harrison, get the fuck out of here," he repeated, but he had no time for any more niceties because now he was crossing the sand and closing the distance between him and Colt. Colt watched him coming, stood upright with his hands up by his chest ready to block the punch. KC said, "Colt, fuckin' tell me you didn't."

“Didn’t what?” Colt said defiantly.

“Tell me you didn’t fuck my sister.”

Colt was confident and casual, but there was a stiffness in his neck and Harrison new Colt felt the oncoming trouble. He said, “What are you talking about? I didn’t fuck your sister. Who? You mean Riley?”

KC was undeterred, still mad. “Taylor. Tell me you didn’t.”

Colt stared and acted incredulous, like he couldn’t believe the question was being asked of him. He looked briefly to his left and caught Harrison’s eye then abruptly turned away. The connection there had been intense but brief.

Now Harrison’s heart was racing. Who had told? Would everybody know now?

Taylor and Kelsey were trotting down the stairs, and now Roxie and Riley were coming out from the French doors as well. A whole gaggle of defenders.

Colt said, “Taylor? Your little sister?”

“If I fuckin’ find out you did, I’m going to fuckin’ kill you,” KC said, jabbing a finger in Colt’s face.

The veins bulged in KC’s hefty arms. He was racing with adrenaline and while a big part of Harrison wanted to see KC knock Colt into the afterlife, he didn’t want trouble. He looked to Taylor coming down the steps, his beautiful girlfriend and her vulgarities out on display for everybody to know now. Her eyes were wet, her cheeks red, and she met his gaze with a mournful look. She trotted down the steps with her arms folded. Kelsey Kay’s eyes darted around, smart Kelsey trying to figure out what she could say.

Harrison said, “That’s impossible.”

KC looked at him and said, “Harrison, I told you to go up to the house.”

He said, “I’m going. But that’s impossible what you’re saying.”

KC was listening, still mad, still intending to cause damage to Colt. Taylor came down now and stood an arm’s length away from Harrison and stopped. He extended a hand to her, and she whipped hers out and clutched his. Her nails pinched into the backside of his fingers. He said to KC, “When would that have happened? She was with me all night.”

KC said, “No, she wasn’t. You know she wasn’t.”

“Sure she was. I was up in the bedroom but I saw her walking around. She came up and saw me a few times. We went to bed together early.”

The first seed of doubt was planted—but a disappointment welled up within him. It would be so easy right now to say Yeah, your piece-of-shit friend fucked your little sister. Your twenty-two-year-old friend fucked your nineteen-year-old sister. Fucked her pretty good. Are you going to stand for that? Colt was strong and tough probably, but KC was defending his sister and had about twenty pounds on Colt.

But he didn't want KC to get hurt. He didn't want to see KC break a finger on Colt's face, cost him games, or a chance at a future in football. As much as he wanted Colt's face to be broken, he would hate to see KC hurt. Or KC get in trouble with the police. Not for this. Not for Taylor. Taylor was Harrison's problem now. He would assume her protection.

He squeezed Taylor's hand and said, "Come on, KC. Taylor? She was with me, dude. I mean it. And she wouldn't do that." That was a nice little dig at Taylor, and he hoped she felt that shot crease her bow. It was a warning shot. But it was also love. Because ultimately it was Taylor he did this for.

Riley had joined them, arms folded, her posture genetically exact to Taylor's. Two long skinny bodies, Riley's pinched brow like her sister's, too. He saw Riley's eyes flick to Taylor's; saw communication there. Maybe he didn't have it yet—that psychic link that her and her friends and sister had—but it was like he could hack into their lines and know what was being said. Riley's eyes were asking Taylor's eyes: *Did you sleep with Colt?* Taylor's eyes told her sister that she did because Riley stepped forward now and held KC's wrist. She whispered, "KC, don't do this. It was me."

KC tugged his hand away but Riley kept her grip on him and he didn't struggle out of it. He watched her face, and she gave her brother a deceptive look of honesty. Lying with her expression and saying, "It wasn't Taylor. It was me. Don't tell anybody."

That was it, Riley. Make your brother embarrassed to make a scene. Make him feel guilty for embarrassing you even though you're lying. Even though you know your sister *did* sleep with Colt.

For a brief moment there was a flickering warning like the time a week after he paid his mom for the Subaru and he was driving on the highway he saw a bright flash on his dashboard and for two seconds he swore it was the engine light. His mom was a hard-ass and she would tell him it was the buyer's bad luck—she offered no warranty. His flickering warning light right now was the message: *The Brooks girls are bad news! The Brooks*

girls eat men alive! But Taylor wasn't Riley. Or at least he thought she wasn't.

The warning light on the Soob wasn't the engine. It was a flickering parking brake light from a slightly too-tight cable. His foot had touched the pedal, and that's all it was. His mind had cascaded with unnecessary worry.

He stepped forward, said, "Come on, KC. It's okay. She was with me," and he nodded at Riley who gave him a puzzled look—Taylor's sister trying to comprehend whether Harrison knew the truth or not. He'd prefer Riley to think he didn't.

KC, still mad, turned back to Colt. The anger had softened, but hadn't left him yet. He said, "Dude. Seriously. I know you. If you did, I will fucking end you."

Colt say, "I didn't. Everybody's telling you I didn't. Come on, man."

No hand was offered in friendship, and KC made a weird grimace then turned and yanked his arm out of Riley's grip.

To Taylor, he pointed and said, "Don't turn into Mom."

Taylor looked wounded.

KC wheeled and left, pounded up the steps, muscles in his back bulging and flexing as he went. The back of his neck was hot red with anger.

The girls looked to Colt, and he quickly got the picture. He flicked his head to the left, and ran his tongue through the inside of his cheek, smirked a little, then put his hands in his pockets, walked past them and followed KC's trail back up to the house.

Kelsey Kay stroked Taylor's upper arm and Taylor blubbered: "I didn't, I didn't do it, I don't even know ..."

Kelsey Kay said, "I know you didn't, baby. It's okay ..."

Riley took her in her arms and held her sister. Taylor hugged Riley back but couldn't thank her. Thanking her would be admitting to Kelsey Kay that she had slept with Colt. And while Taylor had told him she didn't regret her decision, she wanted to keep it a secret because she *knew* how bad it was.

Kelsey Kay stepped back and stood next to him and their shoulders touched. She rubbed his arm now, too. There was an electric spark at her touch because until this moment he'd forgotten what they did last night. They had a much stranger but deeper connection and he didn't know how to make sense of that. But one thing was clear: the men had left. KC had stormed off, and the girls glowered at Colt until he scarpered as well. But Harrison was allowed in this trusting circle and while he should be happy,

he couldn't help but feel like *one of the girls*. And that was not the place where he wanted to be. He wanted to be the one that was glowered at and told to leave; whose lustrous presence was *dangerous*. But he would take what he could get, and he would claw from Taylor what he wanted, what she would allow. The only wish he had right now was to be able to get down on his knees before her and slip a toe ring on her just to watch that pretty face beam and to feel its glow in his heart.

FOR HALF AN HOUR she avoided her friends. Didn't think she would be able to keep up the façade when she was so emotional.

One little thing that KC overheard, and he interpreted it as the truth. Just a casual statement from Roxie where she asked Taylor how Colt was in bed. KC overheard. Roxie was *joking*.

Roxie had seen how she and Colt were behaving last night and knew that Taylor was going to break up with Harrison. She would never suspect that her good and decent friend Taylor would *actually* sleep with Colt while Harrison was in the house. *It was a joke, KC.*

But it *was* the truth.

And that was a little scary. The fact that her own brother thought she *might* do that. Thought she *might* be capable of that. She would like to think that he would overhear Roxie and just roll his eyes and know it was a joke right away. But he didn't. *Don't turn into Mom.* What did that mean? What did he think of Mom?

So while she dealt with those horrible thoughts, she'd stayed away from her friends. Stayed away from Harrison now, too. Her decent boy. Holding her hand and lying to KC who he practically adored, telling her brother She was with me all night. There was no time she could've been with Colt. This poor guy she tortured, had sex with Colt while he watched. *Suspected* he was watching. And right now that good guy, that best friend, that Taylor-cheerleader was in the kitchen making breakfast for everyone. He had some spine on him. It was impressive. The thing she'd done last night should break someone. *She* couldn't survive it. Had it been done to her she would've left, broken and wounded. But he stayed. Maybe he was a little

chicken to get those guys to move his car but still he stayed. She watched him, too, with Kay. She deserved it. Watched her best friend roll her feminine hips while knowing her boyfriend's penis was inside her. Meanwhile another guy, a hot guy that she kind of had a bit of a crush on, was inside *her*. Were they lying to themselves that they could do this? The thing they'd done—all four of them in the bed together—was just demonstration for each other. *See, we could do this. We're so sure we can do it, we can do it right in front of each other.* It was a nice thought; she sure would like for it to be true. But boy did it come with pain. Harrison had been her life since she was ten. He had this face that made you instantly want to go up and talk to him. Wanted to see him do that cute little smile, show off his boyish charm. For almost ten years now they'd been pretty much inseparable. But all good things came to an end.

Why *couldn't* she just end it?

It was clear: ending it would end *them*. End their friendship. And there was *no* way they could do that. So being open was the way it was going to be. She just couldn't dwell on it. Just push away the thoughts of him with another girl. She already knew what *she* was going to do. Already knew that she was going to meet guys in California, knew she wouldn't be faithful to Harrison. It was clear enough she'd been ready to break up with him.

Kelsey had her trapped at the end of the pantry hall, the two of them gathered together and leaning against the rarely used back door that led to a small balcony where her mom would come back in the days when she used to smoke.

They weren't saying anything, both of them with their arms folded and not looking at each other, shoulders up against the door, their gaze watched out over the gray lake. Colt was down there on the beach again and KC was with him and they were talking. There were no punches being thrown, and that was a good thing. The rumor would get around. *I think Taylor slept with Colt. She says she didn't, but boy did KC want to beat the shit out of Colt.* Would they believe she didn't? Nice Taylor. Would nice Taylor do something so terrible to such a good guy like Harrison? It would be terrible if they believed it. Maybe it was only KC who got to know the real Taylor. Maybe he was the only one who knew she really *could* do something that terrible. Maybe she had her friends fooled.

Kelsey sighed now, ran the tip of her tongue over her upper lip. "Did you? Sleep with him?"

Boy. Just come right out and ask. Roxie had done the answering for her, saying, *I know there's no way you could do that, Taylor*. But Kelsey Kay had been her close friend and confidant for too long. Knew there *was* a possibility. Hadn't they planned a similar dirty event together?

"No," she said softly.

"You can tell me if you did."

"I wouldn't do that."

Kelsey tilted her head to the side and her eyes rolled up. There was an unsaid interjection there and Taylor heard it even though it wasn't uttered. *You might. You might do that, Taylor*.

"I wouldn't hurt Harrison."

"Did he tell you you could?"

"Sleep with Colt? He hates that guy."

"Most people do."

"He wouldn't want me to be with Colt."

"He thought it was okay with Brady."

"I guess. He likes you. Harrison does. If you were with Brady, it was like a seal of approval. Plus he doesn't *know* the guy."

Kelsey nodded, sighed.

Now a loneliness swept through her again and she felt too distant from her friend. Her hand went out to hold Kelsey's wrist. "I'm going to be so alone," she said

"That's your choice."

"It is my choice. But now I'm afraid."

"You'll do okay out there. I'll talk to you every day. I'm sure Harrison will, too."

"He wants me to—" She stopped. Maybe it was too personal.

"Wants you to do what?" Kelsey lay her hand over Taylor's where it held her wrist.

She said, "He wants me to tell him if I meet anybody."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah, like ... He wants me to tell him if I *do* anything, too."

Kelsey nodded. It was a lot. It seemed like just yesterday they were all just dumb high school kids, now the world was getting very adult very fast. Harrison seemed the most levelheaded of all of them. He was nice, and he was kind and generous and he would do anything for you. He was the last guy you would think might have a weird kinky thing going on in his brain.

But it was what might make them work, it was what might keep her sane when she was away. With Harrison she could have it all.

Kelsey said, "Are you going to?"

"You said it. *Be honest with him*. The last thing I want to do is hurt Harrison."

"I don't know. Some guys are into that."

"The hurt?"

"No," she said, rolling her eyes, "Seeing their girl fuck other guys. You remember Ashley Gray ...? Remember her?—she went to Hazelton with us, but ended up at Mitchell High ..."

She nodded. "I know," she murmured. *Blurb, blurb ...*

"Her boyfriend is on the Mitchell hockey team and she let one of his teammates bang her while he watched."

"That was a rumor—"

Kay shook her head no.

"Some dudes ..." Kay shrugged as though describing the depravity of boys escaped her.

"You make it sound so—"

"It is."

"What ...?—do you think I'm bad?"

"No, baby, I get it," she said, stroking her hair, "I told you I do. I did the Brady thing with you because I get it. And I like Harrison."

"He's so good he makes me feel bad."

"But you're getting exactly what you want."

"I feel so guilty. Can you believe he would *support* me like this?"

"He's getting something from it."

Now she scoffed. Maybe it was really true. The image of Harrison pleadingly telling her he wanted to be open then secretly getting off on it seemed so ridiculous. But the signs were there. "Can you believe it? Can you believe it with *Harrison*?"

Kelsey shrugged, said, "Hey, we've all got some crazy thoughts in our heads that we hide from each other."

She smiled a little. "What's yours?"

Kelsey smiled, too. "No way, sister."

She reached out now and put her bare foot over Kelsey's bare foot, felt the warm skin connect. "You can tell me."

“No, Taylor. It’s nothing. I just mean I feel for Harrison. He must be hurting.”

“I couldn’t have him out of my life. I couldn’t have him hurting either. If he wants to be open, we’ll be open.”

“Does he want to watch you?”

“What do you mean?” she said, and her scalp tingled. Kelsey Kay getting right into the heart of this new relationship between her and her boyfriend.

“Does he want to watch you, like, with other guys?”

“I think he would,” she whispered.

“Did he say it to you?”

“Say it to me? You watched him watch me.”

“I know. That’s why I’m asking. I think he really ... I don’t know ...” She sighed now, looked away again.

“Got off on it?”

Kelsey still looked out the window. “Yeah. Got off on it. I don’t want to say too much, but you know he couldn’t keep his eyes off you and Brady.”

“Yeah. I don’t know what to tell you. That’s Harrison’s business.”

“Well I’m not asking him.”

She laughed. “It’s *so* kinky.”

They both giggled a little, and hearing each other’s laughter brought the chuckles stronger.

It was crazy. The thought that nice guy Harrison wanted something so kinky was crazy. But there was something also kind of hot about it. He was a nice guy. Supportive. So it made sense. He also had a weird matronly-slash-patronly thing that he would do sometimes. Maybe it became more pronounced after her dad left, or maybe she was just too sensitive and that’s why it felt that way, but in the last few years he seemed more mature than her, and when he saw disappointment in some of her actions, he wanted to nurture her. Maybe she had a daddy thing because the idea that she would go to California and do whatever she wanted, and Harrison might watch her from the shadows and like it—and offer guidance—was strangely *thrilling*.

Kelsey said, “Did you ever think you would find yourself in such a weird relationship with Harrison?” They were still laughing, and it took her a few breaths to get the question out.

She rubbed her forehead and sighed a long, lamenting sound. “No. We’ll make it work, but yeah, I never saw this coming.”

“We didn’t plan for this at all.”

“Who would have figured?”

“I guess it’s better than breaking up.”

There was applause from the kitchen, and they knew breakfast was being served. The smells had grown stronger and more intense; Good Guy Harrison was at work again, at command central in her summertime kitchen. He’d been in there beating eggs, dipping bread in the mixture and making French toast. He had coffee on for the coffee drinkers and helped Cisco cook four trays of bacon in the oven. She needed to see him *right* now.

She took Kelsey’s hand, and they walked together down the long pantry hall that emerged in the kitchen and she saw all her friends there. That dull gray light seeped in from the lakeside windows and filled the kitchen with that ghostly glow, flooding the room, erasing dramatic shadows, removing any illusory hue. All their young faces were shown as blankly and starkly and as truthfully as possible. Her sister with her shocking black hair, the tail of a black scorpion visible on her shoulder—she’d changed in the last two years; KC, patron saint of the family now since dad was gone, troubled in his own way but always enduring—there was a lot of Harrison in him even though he was twice the size and had bouts of abject meanness; Shelby and Roxie her best friends—this might be the last time she’d see them until Christmas. Even when she came back at Thanksgiving, she probably wouldn’t meet up with them. They would talk for sure, she would text them, but they were going away. Not to Michigan, going south. Both of them together at Georgia. They would grow separate soon, find new friends, the two of them in a different state. And every time they would meet from here on, it would get farther and farther apart. Cookie, Cisco, Mikey, Jamie, April, all familiar faces that would grow dim and pale. None of them would be in California. She didn’t see them after high school. Would there ever be another Brooks’ lakeside bash? If not, this could be the last time she would feel them as friends.

She breathed, watched them all with a sad sort of ardor.

Then the faces of dread. KC’s teammates. Beastly Care Bear who was apparently a guaranteed NFL draft. Pontoon and Rick-Joe, KC’s college friends. She’d have to put up with them all in some way in their future; probably KC’s wedding. Handsome Stevie. Her brother’s friend who lured her out for a secret swim and who she was quick to put her lips against and

slink her hand inside his shorts. And Colt. Her childish crush brought to lurid and satisfying life. Her mistake. Sex with Colt would mean trouble, and though she didn't know how yet, she could feel something looming.

Before she came to tears, she moved her back to the photos on the wall on the north side of the kitchen. If she put her eyes there it would be *over*. Photos of Mom, Dad, young Riley, young KC, young Taylor; happy times, prize bass caught, waterskiing trophies won, face painting at the fair, learning to swim, young thin mom, Dad (with all his hair) tossing the ball with KC, never knowing that young blonde-haired boy with the knobby knees would make it to one of the best football programs in the country one day. The tears came and when her eyes fell on her love, she couldn't stop them.

Her Harrison, her forever-boy at home in her home, her fucking anchor, smiling, giving her that cute crescent she loved so much the first day she met him she *knew* he needed to be in her life. She staggered through blurry tears and embraced him as he served French toast to all their friends. He fell against the counter and she squeezed him tight. Warm, appreciative murmuring from the crowd filled her ears, and she cried into his chest and hid her face from them all. Harrison's arms circled her and held her tight, his soft hand running a circle on the center of her back.

IF ANYONE WAS GOING to cry at the end of what could be the last Brooks' summer bash, he'd figured it would be him. Taylor's breakdown in the kitchen had saved him. Seeing her succumb to the nostalgia—to the fucking finality—of this weekend bolstered him unexpectedly. When Taylor was weak, he would be strong.

With everyone watching he held her and rubbed her back and a smile grew on her face. She knew who to come to. She knew where to find love and strength. Then the moment overwhelmed the others. Kay, Roxie, Shelby, Mikey, Cisco, Cookie, Riley, April, and even KC joined in for the dopest (yet sweetest) group hug he'd ever been a part of. There were a lot of tears; there was laughter. And the best part?—it was the official goodbye. It came unexpectedly, and it salved the tension. They broke apart and clapped backs, shook hands and then they fucking *feasted*. No worry of farewells hung over their head, and the breakfast was only filled with cheer. KC offered his crew to stay and do the cleaning, everyone else could go. The football guys would stay another day. They'd already been at school for three weeks getting in their training, but they had three days off this weekend and they planned to take advantage.

Riley was the first to leave, Cisco tagging along. Then Cookie and Jamie and April went shortly after. No more tears, no sad farewells, just *We'll see yas*. Taylor said bye to her brother in secret, up in his bedroom, but she came down buoyantly and gathered in the driveway with Roxie, Shelby, and Mikey. This was a little more tender and Taylor shed some tears with her girlfriends, made promises of contact amidst one more girl-only group hug.

Then they were gathering at the doors of the Soob. Brady said to him, This is going to be awkward. Yeah, four people alone in the Subaru who'd got naked last night and fucked around in the same bed, he got it. He winked at Brady and said, Just be cool. Kay overheard and cackled before slipping into the back seat.

At the end of the driveway, he went left and behind them Roxie's Mustang turned right, tooting their horn. Taylor made him go clockwise around Wolf Lake and they ended up at the WC but she wouldn't tell him why.

TAYLOR AND KAY slept most of the way to Whittemore, even when he pulled into the Citgo to gas up. Brady played games on his phone, but put it on pause when they pulled up to the pump.

As Harrison got the Soob in park, Brady tapped his shoulder on the window side and he looked to see a credit card held between two fingers.

“Hey man, on me,” he said.

“Seriously? Thanks, Brady,” he said and took the card. A kind gesture, but of course, Brady figured this guy was kind enough to let him fuck his smoking hot girlfriend, how about a tank of gas for the gift.

Taylor still slept in his passenger seat; world’s worst navigator. Tanned legs together, drawn up, Birks slipped off and kicked to the depths of the footwell; she’d bundled up in a plaid flannel, her own today, but it made him wonder if she’d given Colt’s back. Had she said bye to Colt and Stevie? Not while he watched at least. A thud hit below his belly again, less powerful than the hurt from yesterday, and he even smiled while watching her sleep. Her plain white WC bag was clutched to her chest like a teddy bear. He touched her arm, and she stirred.

“Where are we?” she asked, sliding upright and looking out at the highway, then over to the doors to the gas station and the convenience store, a big hand-painted sign in the window proclaiming they sold the best homemade pizza on Highway 65.

“Stopped to get gas,” he said quietly because Kay still slept.

“Mm,” she moaned sleepily and settled back in the leather again.

He pumped and listened to the hiss of highway traffic. Tank filled, paid at the pump with Brady’s card, he went in to get the key for the can.

Bladder drained, he flushed then stood at the hazy mirror and looked at his reflection while he washed his hands. Someone knocked on the door.

"In a minute," he said, rolling his eyes. Sign on the door said you had to get the key from the desk.

The knock came again and this time he didn't answer, just whisked scratchy paper towel from the dispenser and dried his hands.

The knock came again, then dissipated to a tapping and scratching.

"I'll be out in a minute," he said.

"Harrison," Taylor whispered on the other side.

He laughed and opened the door, but startled to see her looking quite frantic.

"What is it? What's wrong?" he asked her.

She hustled in, closed the door behind her and locked it.

"What's wrong?" he asked again.

She turned to face him and her hands were stroking his chest and stomach.

"Nothing, nothing," she said, pushing on him till he was backed up against the sink.

Her hands shook and he could see a tremble in her jaw.

"You okay?"

"We didn't make love," she said, eyes too wide and wild. "You wanted to last night, and I told you no."

"I understand," he said soothingly.

"What if I don't see you? What if I don't see you before I leave? What if—my plane leaves on Wednesday, and I have to go with my mom, and your mom will be all over—"

"It's okay, Taylor," he said soothingly, "don't worry, I'll come and see you ..."

"I want you right now," she said and kissed him hard, her hand holding the back of his neck with surprising strength.

When his rump hit the edge, he knew despite the awful redolence of overwhelming disinfectant and what it might be masking, he would have no problem performing. Taylor's hand roughly grabbed between his legs and squeezed over his shorts, discovering that he was half-hard already.

"We have to be quick," he said, breaking their kiss and undoing the button of his shorts.

“Yeah,” she said, undoing her own shorts and stepping back, that unsettling wildness still in her eyes. But she smiled, and it brought one out of him, too.

“You’re crazy,” he said and pushed his shorts and underpants down.

Taylor danced around him, got her back to the sink and jumped up to sit, her Birks clattering to the floor. Her shorts and panties were run across her perfect thighs just above her knees and he pulled them off.

They came together in a warm kiss and she slipped her hands underneath his shirt so she could touch his bare skin. He reeled at the dancing scratches of her long pretty nails against his skin.

“Go slow,” she whispered near his ear and between soft, tender kisses.

His cock probed between her legs and he could feel her warmth and slipperiness against the underside of his shaft.

“You sore?”

“I got *fucked* yesterday, Daddy,” she said, her eyes searching his, gaging his reaction.

He didn’t know how to respond, but his eyes focused deep on hers and he could see the effect those dirty words had on her. Her breaths came sudden and hard once she’d said it, looking for acceptance, looking for love and approval.

She grimaced suddenly, looked sad. She whispered, “I don’t like it ...”

“Then don’t say it ...”

“Harrison, do you hate me?”

“I’ll never hate you, Taylor, I told you a million times how much I love you ...”

Her pupils flitted over his and his own pulse surged suddenly. He took her kiss hard, got his hand between his legs to angle his cock, pushed with his hips and slowly, agonizingly sunk everything he had inside her. She hitched soft squeaking breaths the deeper he sunk and her nails dug his flesh. Taylor’s insides burned him. She was hot and gripping; their kiss grew hazy and haphazard and Taylor’s head swayed away from him, her eyes closing.

Fully seated inside her, he kissed her neck and she stroked his hair. He fucked her gently, hips rocking against hers, Taylor trembling.

“Look in my eyes, Harrison,” she said, and he did.

Her grays bored into him, and he’d never felt more emotion from her. It took him by surprise.

She said, "Make love to me and look in my eyes."

He nodded and worked himself in and out of her, unblinking gaze locked on hers.

She said, "We're going to do this, you hear me? We're going to do this so good. I love you, Harrison Wade, I love you so much."

"I love you, baby, I love you," he said, and his own jaw began a tremble.

"I'm going to tell you *everything*," she promised him.

"Tell me ..."

"I'm going to tell you *anything* you want to hear ..."

"I love you ..."

"Oh, I love you," she sobbed and then hugged his head and cried.

He pounded her harder; she was wet, and she humped her hips against his thrusts eagerly. Then he had her throat in his grip and he eased her away. Taylor curled back, her head resting just below the mirror, both her hands gripping his forearm, faucet pressing into the small of her back, smiling and watching him through lowered brows. Between their legs his cock went in and out of her tight pink slit and they both watched, Taylor's mouth hanging open lustily, ecstatic over the garish but beautiful sight of their biological connection.

He said, "You wear condoms with other boys ..."

"I will, I'll always use condoms, *Daddy* ..."

"Oh God, don't," he said, and laughed. He wanted to like it, but it was too powerful, too loaded.

"I'll be good at college," she whispered and stroked his cheek.

"Ah fuck," he groaned and hissed now.

"You're the one I love, Harrison, you're the only one I don't use condoms with ..."

"Mm" he grunted and squinted, had to shut his eyes for a moment. When he opened them again, she smiled at him lustily.

She said, "Please come inside me ..."

"Oh God, Taylor," he sighed, a tenderness tumbling over him now, his neck thickening with the pulse of love pounding in his heart.

"No more Colt," he said.

"Why?"

"I won't be with Kelsey. You won't be with Colt, okay?"

"Why not?"

“I forbid it,” he said and thrust deeply.

She inhaled and arched her back, made a sneering face.

“I won’t,” she sighed, “I swear I won’t ...”

“I don’t approve of him,” he said patronly and that strange flood washed through him again.

“I swear I’ll be good,” she cried, “oh, come, please, come inside me ...”

Now he took her neck with his lips and kissed and bit his way to her mouth. She met him hungrily, and they locked each other tight; hips pounding against each other’s, arms clutching, hands grabbing and scratching, tongues slipping and tangling.

When he came inside her, she knew it immediately and she howled out and locked her legs on his hips.

“Deeper,” she cried, “all the way, all the way,” and they fell back on the sink until it made a frightening crack. He filled her with hot pulsing *gallons* of his love, and she kicked and swiveled and moaned and cried underneath him.

They stayed clutched together in the stinking bathroom, heaving and breathing, panting and whining, both of them feeling ashamed but bound with tight togetherness.

When he inched his penis out, she bucked forward and grabbed his ass.

“Hold on,” she whispered.

“I love you,” he said, feeling sheepish over their dirty talk.

“I’m going to miss you,” she said and burrowed her head into his collar.

He helped her forward and rubbed her back. “I’m here for you, Taylor. I’m always here for you.”

“I know, I know,” she sighed and slowly sat up and separated from him, letting his neck go so she could wipe her cheeks.

When he tried to withdraw again, she grabbed his hips. “Look in my eyes, okay, look in my eyes ...”

Both of them watched the other, Taylor’s mouth hanging open, her soft pink tongue pressed down behind the perfect white and even line of her lower teeth. With her hands on his waist guiding his pace, he slowly inched his still-hard cock out of her tightness. Their connection made sticky wet sounds, and they were loud in the small concrete space of the gas station bathroom. The further he withdrew the more her chin tilted upright and the narrower her eyes grew. When he plopped free, cock hard enough to spring upward she gasped.

“Taylor, you’re unbelievable,” he said, and she laughed and put her hands between her legs.

She said, “I feel better we did that.”

“Me, too,” he laughed, implying just the sex, but he could see the bigger meaning. He tugged off some more rough towels and presented them to her, getting between her thighs and helping her clean.

Soon their breaths slowed and Taylor grew shy from what they’d said and done. He helped her get her shorts up, slipped her Birkenstocks onto her pretty feet, touched the second toe of the right foot longingly, sorry she had lost her treasure. When she hopped down, she hugged him again.

“I just freaked out that I might not see you before I go.”

“I’ll see you, Taylor, don’t worry.”

Stepping back now, she said, “Give me the key, go back to the Soob before they come looking for us ...”

“You okay?”

“Yeah,” she laughed then put her knees together, “I just gotta pee ...”

IN THE CAR, Kay and Brady were sitting up, each of them on their phones and facing forward. He got behind the wheel and passed Brady's card back and thanked him again.

Without looking up, Kay said, "You smell like a dude who just fucked in a gas station bathroom."

He started the Soob and turned up the stereo. "I don't know what you're talking about."

"You smell exactly like that, Harrison," Brady said.

He smiled, but it was tempered with the thought that Brady knew Taylor's pussy smell very well; had it spread balls deep up his shaft last night.

Kay's phone dinged a half second before his own.

Group text from Taylor.

Taylor: Pops? My treat. Ask Brady

Harrison looked out the side to see Taylor waving and heading into the gas station with the key's wooden fob dangling.

Kay said to Brady: "You want a pop or anything?"

Brady grunted a negator. Harrison sent Taylor a text saying he was fine.

In the footwell of the passenger side, he saw the plastic bag from the WC. Taylor was in the store, heading down to the coolers, and using the rearview he spied Kay and Brady who were phone-occupied. Still watching his girlfriend as she moved around behind the windows, getting herself an R

n' R, he leaned over and peeped inside, poking the bag's mouth open with a curious index finger. It was a shirt or something, folded over; red cotton with black somethings on it.

Taylor was at the counter, paying.

He tugged at the item, unfolded a corner and saw a small sleeve. It was a baby onesie with bears and moose printed on it.

BRADY WAS DROPPED off at his apartment he shared with two other guys in the Emperor Arms, and Harrison wondered what he would tell the guys about Taylor. What would those guys think of Taylor if they ever met her now?

Kay got out of the Soob to say goodbye, standing under a low apple tree in the parking area of the apartment complex and giving Brady a kiss. Brady waved to them, turned and walked with his bag over his shoulder, headed down a pathway to his townhouse.

They all watched him go, Taylor, too, and Harrison felt pretty confident that would be the last time he saw Brady. Taylor turned back, caught his eye, and he wondered what she thought. She'd had sex with that guy. Casual sex even though she was in a committed relationship. But how would a girl feel afterward? That guy had entered her body, shared intimacy with her. Did it mean anything?

Taylor looked away, and he put the car in drive and headed out to State Street.

Five minutes later, they were entering her treed and landscaped neighborhood and a sadness began to grip him. She was leaving him. She was going to be thousands of miles away. These familiar streets they drove where he used to ride ten-speeds with her would soon be irrelevant and lost, and she would make new memories with new people without him and all the way in California. His breaths came shaky and whiny but he gritted his teeth and held it together.

He brought the Soob around Taylor's sweeping concrete crescent driveway to stop at her garage door. The front door was ahead, but the

Brooks' kids all used the garage because Trish kept the front entrance formal and never wanted shoes and coats in there cluttering the place up.

Taylor looked straight ahead, and he caught her in his periphery as her eyes welled up and her tightly held mouth moved around.

He wished the day wouldn't end. Wished they could stay together this afternoon. His mom was on his ass over being ready for university; didn't even think he should go to Wolf Lake this weekend, but thankfully knew how much it meant to him and acquiesced. But she wanted him home Sunday afternoon, no question.

He stopped outside the first bay door, painted white and set with Xs, and parked.

"This is it," Taylor said, voice constricted.

Kay shot forward between the seats and kissed Taylor's ear. Taylor reached over her shoulder and they held hands.

Kay said, "I'll see you tomorrow."

"Okay," Taylor said, blinking tears.

"I'll take you to the airport and pick up your mom."

Taylor nodded. "Mr. Sanders is bringing her home."

"We'll chill, then," Kay said and stroked her arm.

"And I'll see you tomorrow night," Harrison said.

She nodded again, sniffed. "I'm fine. I'll see you both before I go," she said, brightening and showing them a strained expression of happiness.

When he unbuckled his seatbelt, she stopped him.

"No, Harrison. I'll get my own stuff. You stay here. This isn't goodbye, okay. It's not goodbye." She put a closed hand over his heart and she leaned into the driver's side and kissed him.

Their faces came away, and they both smiled weakly. She kissed Kay's hand.

"I'll see you tomorrow?"

Kay and he said in unison: "I'll see you tomorrow."

Taylor got out then and he popped the hatch. She opened the back, slid her bags out and whomped his door closed, and rapped twice on his window.

The garage door opened on its rails and retracted, Taylor using her remote fob. She'd be alone tonight. Mom in Myrtle Beach, Dad in Lansing, Riley with her friends who knows where these days, brother in Wolf Lake. So many good memories in this house and around its property, but they

were already fading. Taylor carried her things into the garage bay and she turned and waved. The garage door closed as he and Kay waved back. Slowly the white barrier came down, closing off her sad but smiling face, her long brown legs ...

“Well,” Harrison said, looking for something profound to say but not finding it. Kay fell back to sit in her seat.

He said, “You’re not sitting in the back, Kay, I’m not an Uber.”

She rolled her eyes at him, but pulled forward, a hand on both front seats and stepped through, her Converse scuffing the lid of his console.

“Hey,” he scolded, but she’d already plopped down in Taylor’s seat. She said, “Take me to Denny’s?”

“My mom will ream me if I’m not home—shit, ten minutes ago,” he said, checking the Soob’s clock.

“Home then, Jeeves,” she said, and pointed her ringed finger out ahead.

When he put the car in drive, she put her hand on the shifter and slid it up to park.

He looked at her, saw her regarding him seriously. “What?”

Kay asked, “Did she sleep with Colt?”

It took him aback. He shook his head no, but he couldn’t lose his grim expression. Kay looked in his eyes and he thought she could read his mind. She nodded once and looked away.

Facing out the Brooks driveway, Kay said, “She told me she did, Harrison.”

He watched her profile, stunned. But he knew her too well. He said, “She did? When? She *slept* with him ...? Kay ...?”

She turned to regard him now, her serious expression softening. “No. She didn’t. She didn’t tell me that at all.”

“Why would you say that?”

She shrugged, looked down. “I’m sorry.”

Kay was crafty and smart and he could trust her until he couldn’t. Everyone knew that about Kay. But she had a kindness under the hard shell. She looked at her own hands gathered in her lap, and he could see a sadness on her expression. She would be losing her best friend this week, too.

They sat uncomfortably silent for a while. He said, “Is she going to fall in love in California.”

“She probably will, Harrison.”

“Can she love two people at once?”

She looked up and around, sighed. "I don't know."

Now he wished he hadn't asked, and his stomach hurt. Tears came quick at the thought of her looking at another boy the way she looked at him. He stayed quiet but covered his face with his hands.

She said, "Be strong, Harrison, you got yourself into this. Don't let her crush you, you're too good to get splatted by a girl like her."

"I love her so much."

"Hey, dickhead," she said and pulled one of his hands away, "she doesn't like criers."

It got him laughing, and he wiped at his face.

She said, "Buddy. You can cry on my shoulder if you want."

"No, you're right, I can't get myself into this and then cry every day about it."

"There's the other option ..."

He shook his head no.

"You could. You could break up with her and move on."

"I can't do that."

"It's an option."

"I love her too much. I can't let her go. She's my best friend."

"Then commit to it, Harrison."

"I know."

"Be a man. Impress the shit out of her with how well you can do this."

He nodded.

Soob back in drive, they headed out of her street, out to Midland so they could cut around and get into Kay's, which backed onto Taylor's. At the stop sign, she said, "You know, Colt would be a perfect fuck-toy."

"For you?"

She shrugged. "For anyone. I'm just saying. He's not as dumb as a bag of rocks but they do their homework together. That body he has, holy shit, right? And you saw his dick. But there's not a lot of heart in a guy like that, you know? Not much to fall for."

"You think he's good for one thing?"

"I bet he is."

On Midland now, he said, "I hate that guy."

"Hey," she said. "Your call."

"My call?" he said, feigning misunderstanding. Had she talked to Taylor? What had Taylor told her friends? Kay was talking about Colt for

Taylor. Recommending Colt for her, pointing out that she was unlikely to fall in love with that guy, if love was what Harrison worried about. But he hated seeing her with him, and if she ever did fall for Colt, it would be unbearable.

On Kay's street now she sighed and said, "You're not careful, she's going to use you up till you're empty and dry as dust, Harrison. She won't even realize she's doing it, and she won't notice when it's done and too late. She's doing it to me, too."

"Some friend you are, talking shit about her behind her back."

"You're my friend, you should hear the shit I say about you behind your back."

He stopped at the end of her long driveway on purpose.

She said, "Ha ha. You're not going to take me to my door?"

He said, "Taylor ever talk shit about me behind my back?"

"No, Harrison, she doesn't. She honest-to-God does love you."

"She does. I know she does."

"She just stresses, dude," Kay sighed.

"I know she does."

"Don't put it on her. She could break."

"I wouldn't want that, Kay."

"Sometimes, I think you use her up, too, and you don't even realize you're doing it."

He shook his head, looked up at her house, back at her. "Really?"

"You're a good guy, Harrison, but you're demanding."

"Hmnh. Not anymore, now, am I?"

"It's your one and only shot, being open. Well played. You got big balls."

She flashed a wily look between his legs and he laughed out loud and it surprised him how good it felt. He said, "You're such a bitch."

She stayed serious. "You tell her you couldn't be her friend if she wasn't your lover?"

"Why?"

"You did right?—that's like emotional extortion."

"No, it's not."

"Think about it, Harrison. Sound like something Colt might say?"

"What does that mean? She doesn't like Colt."

“I don’t want to argue with you, I’m just saying. Be strong with her. Confident. You know she stresses. You know she loves you. You put that emotional pressure on her, she can’t take it. Be the man she needs.”

“I really do want to be open,” he said, but he was truthfully unsure. This had become the darkest, scariest fairytale woods to get lost in, and he’d left no breadcrumbs at all. He did want to be open, didn’t he?

Kay said, “You better be for real. You better not just leverage it all against her next month or something.”

“I won’t,” he murmured.

“If she hurts you, I’ll be upset, and I’ll be mad at her. You hurt her, I’ll come after you.”

He nodded solemnly.

Now she poked his arm.

“What?” he said, looking up again.

“It was fun this weekend,” she said, that guileful look returning.

He said, “We’re not supposed to have sex again.”

Kay raised one haughty brow. “Did you think we were going to?”

“Hey, I’m just saying.”

“I know. She told me already. So much for us being MSU fuck buddies,” she said dryly.

“*Were* we going to be fuck buddies?”

“You might do in a pinch.”

“Gee, thanks.”

“Aw, come on, Harrison. What, we had sex one time and now I can’t bust your chops ‘cause I might hurt your feelings?”

“It was okay with me?”

“Rule one, Harrison. Don’t ask shit like that. It’s annoying.”

“Is it?”

“So annoying.”

“It’s good to talk, I thought.”

She scooted over to his side of the car and pressed against him with surprising brusqueness. Breathlessly, she said, “Were my breasts okay? Tell me they were fine. Tell me you don’t think about other girls’ breasts. Oh Harrison, was I good in bed, did I please you? Oh be careful, my feelings are very fragile ...”

“All right already.”

“See? Tell me that’s not annoying. God. Cloying motherfuckers out there. But sex with you was good. It’s just weird ‘cause it was you.”

“And you, too.”

“You’re my friend.”

He put the Soob in drive again and headed up the driveway to her dark brick, Gothic-looking home. “You regret it?”

She shook her head. “Hey, I had a foursome. I can cross that off my list now.”

In front of her house, at the foot of the wide stone stairs that led to her portico she opened her door and put a foot out but he stopped her. He said, “You told Roxie what you saw? Me and Taylor ...”

She looked shiftily from side to side; caught and guilty. “Yeah.”

“Why?”

“We’re going to make fun of Taylor till we’re in our fifties, dude.”

“That’s so mean.”

She chuckled and closed her eyes. “You didn’t see what I saw. *Oh shit, baby, oh shit, baby, I’m gonna come, Harrison, oh ...* and you and your face ...” Now she waved her hands back and forth in a horizontal slice like she declared a runner safe, laughing quietly but so hard she couldn’t breathe.

He scoffed. “Your hands were shaking.”

She shrugged like it was nothing, but he’d seen the way her body reacted to the shocking sight she’d walked in on.

“You didn’t tell them *anything* else?”

“No way. Never. Probably never.”

“Good.”

A smile whipped across her face like she’d been holding it back. “Ah, who am I kidding. Sometime I will.”

He shook his head and laughed and she punched his arm, laughing with him.

When it petered out they eyed each other amiably. She said, “All right, Booby. You going to orientation on Wednesday?”

“Yeah.”

“Come with me? I’m looking for a new best friend.”

“I’ll be your best friend,” he said and laughed.

She kissed his lips, and he jolted.

“Yeah,” she said, looking in his eyes and stroking his cheeks with her thumbs, “you and I will be good for each other.”

She held eyes a moment longer and licked her lips. It made his insides squirm like excited twisting snakes. She backed herself out of his car, reefed his hatch open and pulled her shit out. Door slammed she strode to those mansion steps giving him a long-lasting peace sign and blew him a kiss. She ran up the steps, bag bouncing on her shoulder, then disappeared through the tall front doors of her home.

It took a minute to gather himself, sitting and rubbing his eyes. When he had it together, he headed back out the driveway and stopped to merge with the street.

Coming along from his right were two kids riding bikes in their swimsuits. Bare feet on the pedals, they rode in wobbly undulating lines, trying to get a bead on one another with neon squirt guns supplied with comically large reservoirs of water along their tops. A boy and a girl, soaked head to toe, laughing and yelling on this their last day of summer. The girl was missing her two front teeth, the boy had a transfer tattoo of a Transformer on his shoulder.

Times sure changed fast. There were days not that long ago when he'd bike up and down these streets in his trunks, Taylor by his side, coming to see Kay, and he thought that was all life would be.

As the two kids grew distant, letting their bikes drift farther so they could sprinkle each other good with their super-soakers, he smiled.

One day, before you know it, those little kids you were biking with were growing up, and shit, you were, too, and crazy unsuspecting things would happen; you might just fall in love; you might get hurt and your heart might break; it will all happen so fucking fast, and maybe, just maybe, for fear of letting everything you breathe for slip from your grasp, you might just let the little girl you once loved be with another guy, you might sleep with her best friend to prove who fucking knows what, you might do *anything* to keep her with you. And you might like it.

But you sure as shit would never see it coming.

AFTERWORD

If you've enjoyed this story about Harrison and Taylor, I'd like to recommend my complete and finished Maggie series. It's a complicated college-age love quadrangle between a young graduating woman, her fiancé, their best man, and a boy she never should have got involved with.

It begins here: [Tempting Maggie](#)

Sign up for my newsletter on my blog to get the latest info, sneak peeks at upcoming stories, and even a free story or two down the road!

[Visit my blog!](#)